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# FORM IN HIP-HOP MUSIC:
# SECTIONS, SONGS, AND HISTORY

by

STEPHEN GOMEZ-PECK

A dissertation submitted to the Graduate Faculty in Music in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy, The City University of New York

2023

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APPROVAL

Form in Hip-Hop Music: Sections, Songs, and History

by

Stephen Gomez-Peck

This manuscript has been read and accepted for the Graduate Faculty in Music in satisfaction of the dissertation requirement for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy.

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ABSTRACT

Form in Hip-Hop Music: Sections, Songs, and History

by

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This dissertation explores musical form in recorded hip-hop music from 1979–present. Form, defined as the large-scale organization of songs, is a parameter that artists consider in the creative process and fans experience while listening. Hip-hop's historical foundation as a live, improvised, party-oriented genre influenced formal functions and patterning from the earliest days of its popular recorded life, beginning with the Sugar Hill Gang's "Rapper's Delight" in 1979. While many of the section and song form labels used by scholars of pop-rock music are transferable to the analysis of hip-hop, the latter genre conveys a unique sense of time rooted in looped grooves and improvisatory orality. The Introduction reviews previous scholarship on form in hip-hop and pop-rock and describes this dissertation's methodology as well as my scholarly positionality. Chapter 1 presents a typology of basic formal functions and sections. Chapter 2 discusses how these small- and medium-scale units combine to create full songs forms; four categories of song forms are posited. Chapter 3, the first of two case studies, features analyses of two of Salt-N-Pepa's cover versions from 1988: "Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang (It's Your Thing)," arguing that the rap versions present form more clearly than the originals. Chapter 4 introduces the idea of inter-rotational form in recent trap-influenced hip-hop and concludes by considering the achievements and limitations of the dissertation as a whole.

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# INTRODUCTION

In a 2012 interview with then-host Kurt Alexander (a.k.a. Big Boy) on KPWR "Power" 106 FM, one of Los Angeles's premier hip-hop radio stations, Kendrick Lamar gave the following advice to listeners of his recently released album, *good kid, m.A.A.d city*: "If you listen to it from top to bottom you'll get the whole aspect and concept."[1] With this statement, Lamar is playing the role of shrewd self-promoter, withholding specifics in order to fan the flames of mystique surrounding the album. There is some unstated and apparently unifying "aspect" or "concept" that he invites his fans to go discover for themselves by listening to the work in its entirety. With regards to taking advantage of the opportunity presented by this interview to plug his album on a widely listened to radio talk show broadcasting in one of North America's commuter meccas, Lamar has hit a bull's-eye. But more substantively, K-Dot also hints at part of what helped his major-label debut go on to be one of the most commercially successful and critically acclaimed albums in the history of popular music: its large-scale musical organization, i.e., its *form*, mattered and was well-executed.[2]

Lamar is arguably the preeminent concept album artist in hip-hop history, but he is far from the only one who considers large-scale organization carefully in the production process.[3] Every musician to have released a hip-hop record has had to make decisions about the construction of songs, from choosing samples and adding the right textural layers over the course of a verse to selecting the perfect guest artist for a collaborative project or placing a song's constituent sections in a specific order. These variables and many more matter to varying degrees, depending on the artist and era of hip-hop in which they were/are working. Lamar has a reputation as a perfectionist when it comes to creating albums. He experiments endlessly with each parameter until he is satisfied with

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[1] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=x6wE_jc5mQY.
[2] Justin Tinsley (2019) of *The Undefeated* makes a case for *good kid m.A.A.d city* being the album of the decade. https://theundefeated.com/features/album-of-the-decade-kendrick-lamars-good-kid-m-a-a-d-city/.
[3] Lamar won the Pulitzer Prize in music for his 2017 album *DAMN.*, becoming the first artist outside of classical or jazz to receive the award.

the artistic integrity of the product. An old school artist like Kurtis Blow, on the other hand, would have been focused less on crafting lean, cerebral songs and more on getting recordings to transmit the original, non-recorded function of hip-hop as dance party music.[4] Regardless of which artist or era one is discussing, the form of hip-hop songs is something that is experienced by every listener; it affects their relationship with the music whether they realize it or not. Fans at an Atlanta concert feel an increasing sense of excitement as they get ready to shout the lyrics of their favorite hook when it approaches. Listeners driving around Los Angeles with the windows rolled down and their speakers turned up nod their heads emphatically when the beat drops midway through a song's intro. Graduate students working in a New York City coffee shop become distracted when they notice that Eminem has kept the same rhyme going for sixteen bars. Each of these not-so-hypothetical scenarios involves hip-hop's capacity to shape our experience of time by setting up expectations and fulfilling or thwarting those expectations. In other words, they demonstrate that musical form is a powerful compositional resource in hip-hop.

Hip-hop theory and analysis has recently become an established sub-discipline within the academic music theory community, but the study of form has still received scant attention.[5] Scholars have focused primarily on flow in their theoretical and analytical work. This is understandable because, ostensibly, hip-hop music is distinguished by two features: rapping and sampling. Without implying that scholars have said everything there is to be said about flow, this dissertation sets aside this thoroughly discussed parameter and puts form under the microscope. The central questions I seek to answer include: How are hip-hop songs organized at medium and large scales? How do

---

[4] Assigning credit for the various components of a hip-hop song's genesis is a thorny issue, as it is in the study of most popular genres. Blow was not involved in the production of his songs nearly to the extent that Lamar has been over his career. Therefore, the above reference to "an old school artist like Kurtis Blow" is really a reference to him and his producers, who, in his early releases, were J.B. Moore and Robert Ford Jr.

[5] The Society for Music Theory Hip-Hop and Rap Interest Group was founded just under a year ago at the 2022 annual meeting of the SMT in New Orleans. Extant publications that take form as a central object of study will be discussed below.

repetition and change at these scales influence our perception of songs? In what ways have hip-hop artists used formal strategies familiar from pop-rock music and in what ways have they departed from these strategies? Have norms of formal design changed over time within hip-hop and, if so, how? This introduction contextualizes the four core chapters that follow with a literature review, a discussion of methodology, and a summary of the chapters.

Overview: Theory and Analysis of Form in Hip-Hop

Music theory and analysis of hip-hop is a relatively young subdiscipline within the broader musicological project in North America and Europe.[6] Popular music studies broke into the mainstream in North America following Susan McClary's formative *Feminine Endings: Music, Gender, and Sexuality* (1991)—particularly with her chapter on Madonna. McClary broke new ground not only in that she helped to make gender a topic of importance for music scholars, but also in that she changed the course of the field such that scholars could build careers researching and teaching about popular music. Historical musicologists and ethnomusicologists began discussing hip-hop before music theorists. Because hip-hop has always been a deeply social and political music, it has presented those scholars with important questions about how artists, fans, and capitalist enterprises have made, consumed, and used it. These two disciplines legitimized the study of hip-hop in the academic world but generally shied away from close readings of individual songs. The first articles that look and smell like music theory began to appear in the mid-1990s with the work of Robert Walser and Cheryl Keyes, and Adam Krims' 2000 monograph *Rap Music and the Poetics of Identity* set the stage for a new millennium in which rap theory and analysis has continued to grow.

In what follows, I trace some of the major publications within this subfield in the last twenty years in an effort to summarize the state of research on hip-hop theory and analysis. Three major trends will hopefully become apparent from this survey. First, hip-hop music theorists have done

[6] The following discussion is limited by my own fluency in just one language: English. Luckily, it does seem that the main non-US country to have produced hip-hop scholarship is England.

more than most within the broader field of music theory to engage social and political context, even if their overall emphasis has been on the sounds themselves. I view this as a positive state of affairs, an appropriate—if not requisite—approach to perhaps the most politically- and socially-oriented music of our age. Second, the musical parameter of form in hip-hop has received little attention. I am aware of just one published scholarly theory of form in hip-hop music (Duinker 2021a), one article in which form is the central topic of analysis (Bungert 2019b), and one conference paper presenting a theory of form in hip-hop (Bungert 2019a). Berry (2018, 3 ff.) also provides a brief but useful overview of formal terminology and techniques. Usually, when the subject does come up, it appears in passing and is not discussed critically. This is not because music theorists are lazy or unobservant. To the contrary, the emphasis most publications on hip-hop to date have put on rhythm, flow, and sampling is an indication of music theorists' sensitivity to which musical parameters are most important to hip-hop's practitioners and consumers. But the important role form plays in the creation and perception of hip-hop suggests a need for more academic engagement with this musical element. And third, music theorists use two broad and often stratified categories to analyze form in popular music: lyrics and musical parameters.

Before beginning my survey, I would like to explain my reasoning for choosing the literature that I have included. This involves tackling the question "what is music theory?," far too big of an inquiry to answer comprehensively in the current context. In short, I construe music theory quite broadly. The disciplinary divide between music theory and historical musicology, largely endemic to the U.S., is a split that I methodologically try to avoid. Vincent Duckles' and Jann Pasler's *Grove Music* definition of musicology as "the scholarly study of music" (2001) fits my personal conception of what a music theorist does. Even the definition of musicology presented in an early article of the *Journal of the American Musicological Society* aligns with my approach: "A field of knowledge having as its object the investigation of music as a physical, psychological, aesthetic, and cultural

phenomenon" (1955, 153).[7] Music theory does not necessarily have to be something that involves transcription, diagrams, mathematics, or other things traditionally associated with this brand of scholarship. These happen to be the tools that I emphasize in my work and in this literature review because they are effective at capturing and modeling the sonic patterns of music in a relatively precise way. But understanding music stops neither with the singular text, nor with the sonic information alone. An analysis of a popular song is incomplete if one's data set is nothing but the sound waves emanating from time stamp 0:00 to 2:54.[8] In summary, I aim to explore form in hip-hop as one feature situated within a network of other musical parameters as well as social, economic, political, racial, and gendered situations and dynamics. To that end, the literature I include in this dissertation crosses disciplinary boundaries.

Another aspect of the survey that follows worth commenting on is that I briefly touch on literature treating pop-rock music. While some might disagree with my move to incorporate literature that deals with a repertoire distinct from the one that is the main focus of my work, I defend it for at least the following two reasons. First, hip-hop is a close cousin in many ways to pop-rock music.[9] Numerous examples of hip-hop artists collaborating with rock artists might be cited, including Blondie's "Rapture" (1981) and Run-D.M.C. and Aerosmith's "Walk This Way" (1986), among others. Tricia Rose notes that rock has been part of hip-hop culture from its very earliest days, with founding DJs like Kool Herc "drawing on, among others, New Orleans jazz, Isaac Hayes, Bob James, and Rare Earth … [while] Afrika Bambaataa, DJ and founder of the Zulu Nation, would

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[7] This definition is taking from the "Report of the Committee on Graduate Studies" section of the minutes from the 1954 Annual Meeting of the American Musicological Society. While no author is given for the minutes as a whole, Archibald T. Davidson is listed as the chairperson of this committee.

[8] This is not to say that an analysis of just the notes themselves is valueless. Such a piece of scholarship constitutes one part of what would hopefully be a multitude of perspectives published about a song, artist, or genre that add up to a more comprehensive picture.

[9] Most scholars exclude hip-hop under the umbrella term "pop-rock music." One of the most common reasons is a perceived lack of melody and directional harmony in much of the hip-hop repertoire. Temperley's description is representative: he excludes rap within the domain of "rock" because of "the absence of vocal melody in rap, and frequently of harmony as well" (2018, 6).

also use beats from European disco bands such as Kraftwerk, rock, and soul in his performances" (1994, 51). Countless rap songs have used samples from the pop-rock world. Snippets as short as milliseconds in duration that have been spliced into rap songs have caused the timbres and the harmonic palettes of rock to loom large within the hip-hop repertoire. Even when hip-hop artists do not sample directly from pop-rock, they often structure looped beats the same way pop-rock artists do, as Kyle Adams has observed: "hip-hop uses the same looped repetitions as pop and rock music" (2020, §2.4). Finally, rock and roll and hip-hop are both outgrowths of African American musical and cultural practices. Rock developed from the blues while hip-hop's roots can be traced to Afro-Caribbean and African American traditions like gospel, toasting, and spoken word poetry. In light of this, it is not surprising that rock and hip-hop share some formal characteristics, even though they represent parallel generic streams that have not always overlapped overtly. The second reason that I include literature theorizing and analyzing pop-rock within a dissertation on hip-hop is more practical. As previously mentioned, the literature focusing on form in hip-hop is limited, so I view pop-rock theory as a good launch pad for approaching form in hip-hop.

Most mentions of the topic of form in hip-hop scholarship are fleeting observations made in support of broader arguments focusing on other parameters (usually rhythm, flow, and/or lyrical meaning). Robert Walser begins his early (1995) analysis of Public Enemy's "Fight the Power" by describing how "the two-measure groove that begins 'Fight the Power' … underpins the entire song, except for the choruses, which switch to a different tonal center and use a somewhat different beat, and a few sections at the end that strip down and chop up the fundamental groove" (200). Walser does not define what he means by a chorus, which is not surprising since his emphasis is almost entirely on the rhythms of the song's beat and Chuck D's flow. Significantly, however, Walser acknowledges a teleological effect of the song's form: "Because the groove itself is non-teleological, it situates the listener in a complex present, one containing enough energy and richness that progress seems moot. *Form and direction* are imposed on the song by the rapper through rhetorical fiat, by

means of rhythmic patterns, rhyme schemes, the ideas and exhortations of the lyrics, *and the verse/chorus alternation*" (204, emphasis added). The most specific way in which Walser engages notions of large-scale organization are his comparisons between the characteristics of Chuck D's flow in each verse. For example, in both verse one and three, the rapper sets up expectations for the arrival of rhymes on certain metrical locations then quickly subverts those expectations. Although Walser refers to a "formal trajectory" (207), he is true to his word that he views "the complex interrelationships of rhythm and timbre [as] paramount" (203). Walser's goal of demonstrating the relationships between the sonic structures of the music and the social context and political meanings of rap is supported only tangentially by form.

Further examples of passing mentions of form in hip-hop theory analyses can be found in the work of Tricia Rose and Kyle Adams. Rose's foundational monograph *Black Noise: Rap Music and Black Culture in Contemporary America* (1994) studies rap mainly from the perspectives of Afrodiasporic history, sociology, and gender studies. Some of Rose's observations about aesthetic preferences in hip-hop culture are relevant here, particularly her discussion of "rupture" and "flow": "In hip hop, visual, physical, musical, and lyrical lines are set in motion, broken abruptly with sharp angular breaks, yet they sustain motion and energy through fluidity and flow" (38). Rose argues that highlighting instead of concealing discontinuities in rap music is not a trivial choice. Rather, "these effects at the level of style and aesthetics suggest affirmative ways in which profound social dislocation and rupture can be managed and perhaps contested in the cultural arena. Let us imagine these hip hop principles as a blueprint for social resistance and affirmation" (39). I read this as Rose connecting the social, political, and economic realities of marginalized groups with creative choices as heard in live and recorded hip-hop. For example, the threat of disruption that many people of color faced in New York City in the 1970s and 80s manifested itself in hip-hop music as an aesthetic preference for rupture and disjunction to be craftily navigated rather than avoided. Hip-hop styles have diversified and changed dramatically in the three decades since Rose's publication of *Black*

*Noise*, but her ideas about the social meaning of hip-hop's organization remain important for hip-hop scholars today.

In the vein of a more traditional music theory publication, Adams (2008) analyzes the chorus of Big Boi's song "Tomb of the Boom," demonstrating that rhythmic aspects of Big Boi's flow cooperate with the beat to emphasize a formal articulation—the beginning of the chorus. Again, "chorus" is not explicitly defined, but—as in Walser's analysis of "Fight the Power"—is presumably meant to correspond with generally-accepted understandings of chorus in popular music as the section of a song that repeats verbatim multiple times, might contain the title lyric, and alternates with more lyrically varied sections called verses. Furthermore, Adams (like Walser) draws inter-verse connections when he observes that Big Boi uses a rhythmic motive "to integrate with the other verses" (§36) in Outkast's "The Rooster." Adams's 2009 article, "On the Metrical Techniques of Flow in Rap Music," engages more extensively in a discussion of form in rap. In his analysis of "Blazing Arrow" by Blackalicious, Adams notes how rapper Timothy "Parker's [Gift of Gab] flow helps define the form of the song" (§14). As shown in Example 0.1 (a reproduction of Adams's Example 2b), the end rhymes in lines 1–2 and lines 11–12 match ("arrow," "-eiro," "-maro," and "arrow"), while all of the end rhymes in lines 3–10 match (all rhyming with "major way"). This

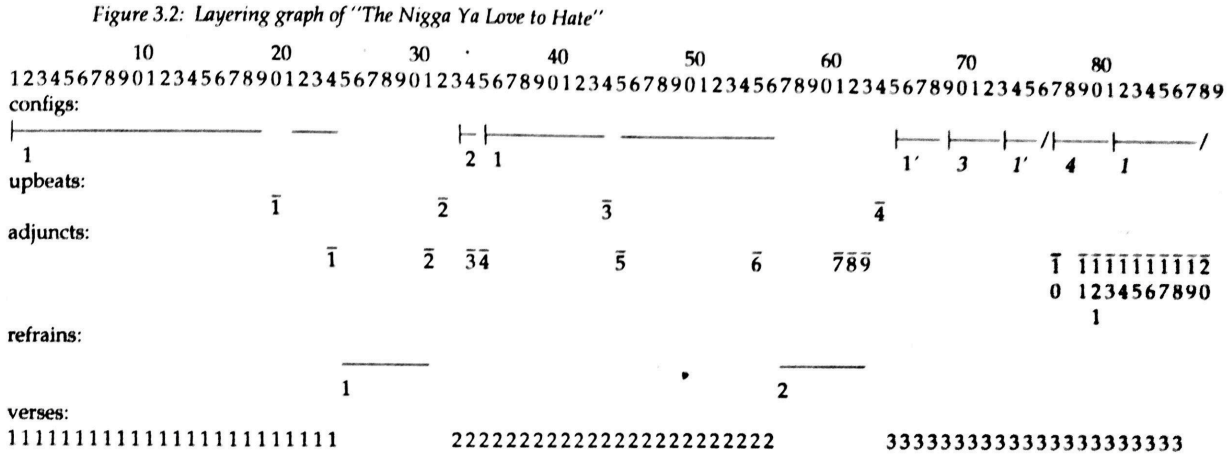
**Example 0.1:** "Blazing Arrow" by Blackalicious, verse 1 (Example 2b in Adams [2009])

| | 1 | x | y | z | 2 | x | y | z | 3 | x | y | z | 4 | x | y | z |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | A- |
| 1 | ma- | zin' | phase | your | days | your | ha- | zy | ways | my | bla- | zing | ar- | row | | The |
| 2 | rays | that | range | from | A- | sia | way | to | Ri- | o | de | Jan- | eir- | o | | A |
| 3 | craze | you | crave? | but | work | to- | day's | the | day | that | in | a | ma- | jor | way | I'll |
| 4 | make | you | say | oh | look | he | saved | the | day | and | al- | so | paved | the | way | (hoo- |
| 5 | ray!) | Rock- | in | my | crew | like | ra- | zor | blades | to- | day | and | days | a- | way | from |
| 6 | now | o- | kay, | o- | kay | I'm | like | a | la- | ser | ray | keep- | in' | the | stage | a- |
| 7 | blaze | and | dan- | g'rous | ways | drop- | pin' | the | phrase | that | pays | all | things | just | ain't | a |
| 8 | phase | but | age- | less | ways | a | cage- | y | great | dis- | plays | yo | hey, | this | ain't | a |
| 9 | game | so | stays | a- | wake | 'cause | if | you | came | to | play | you'll | all | be- | have | in- |
| 10 | sane | af- | ter | we | change | the | game | it | won't | re- | main | the | same | (I'll | fade | a- |
| 11 | way!) | So | make | your | disc | and | play | this | tape | in | your | Ca- | ma- | ro | | A- |
| 12 | ma- | zin' | phase | your | days | your | ha- | zy | ways | my | bla- | zing | ar- | row | | |

bookending created by the rhyme scheme helps to signal the beginning and end of Parker's verse, engaging with the listener's sense of time and metaphorical sense of location within the song. The rhyme pattern in Parker's flow not only displays control and mastery over rhythm, words, pitch, and humor, but also interacts with the song's form. Adams's suggestive analyses show some of the ways in which form is generated by smaller-scale parameters like the rhythm and rhyme of flow.

Krims (2000) also describes form but does not take it as a central focus. Example 0.2 shows what Krims calls a "layering graph" of Ice Cube's 1990 classic "The N***a Ya Love to Hate." This might be the first published visual that captures aspects of the large-scale organization of a rap song in its entirety. Krims' engagement in extended analyses of individual rap tracks validated this type

**Example 0.2:** Layering graph of "The N***a Ya Love to Hate" (Figure 3.2 in Krims [2000])




of work to the music theory community, opening the door for subsequent scholars to go further. But some terminology in Example 0.2 is cumbersome. Krims refers to one of the layers as a "refrain." In doing so, a term normally used to describe a formal section is used instead to describe the texture and sonic content of the beat. The beat in the verses of "The N***a Ya Love to Hate" are called configurations and in refrains they are called refrains. While Krims gets away with it to

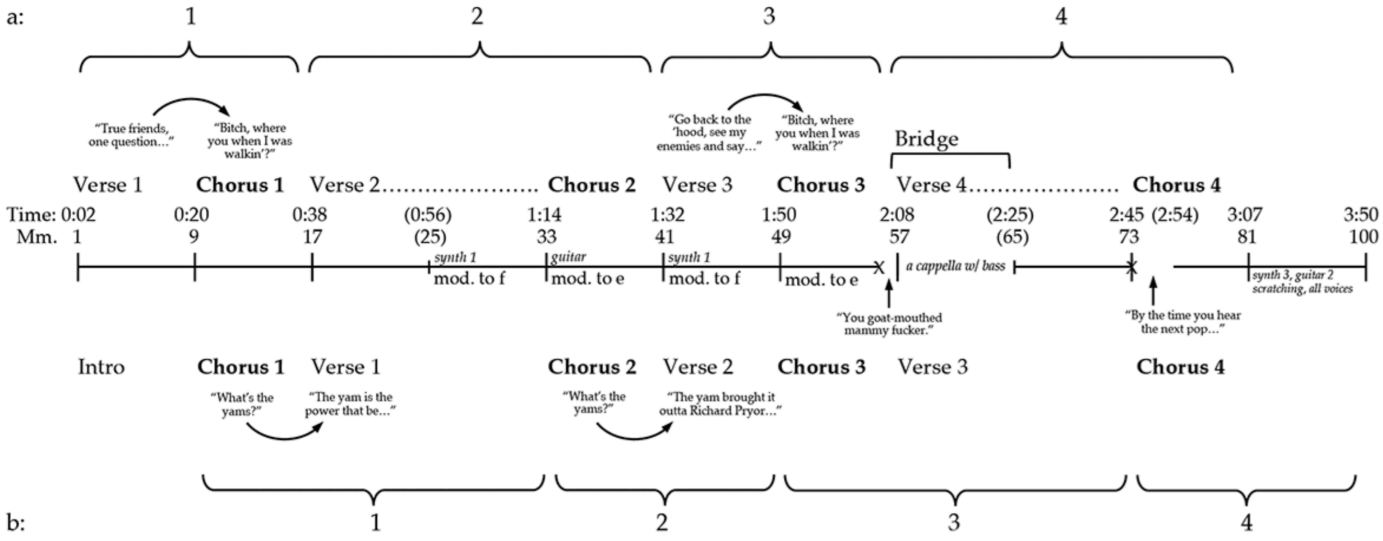
some extent in this song because the beats in each of the song's refrains are entirely sonically distinct from the beats within the verses, there are countless rap songs in which the beat stays the same between verses and choruses. It would seem counterintuitive, for instance, to refer to the beat in the verses and hooks of Run-D.M.C.'s "My Adidas" using completely different terms because the instrumentals are essentially identical. Formally, the verses and hooks are differentiated by lyrical content, but the beat is the same.

Krims draws out several large-scale patterns in his analysis of "The N***a Ya Love to Hate." For example, "there is a steady increase in both (overall attack) density and pitched material from the beginning of the song, climaxing in configuration 1'" (111). After configuration 1', the texture and attack density thins, allowing Ice Cube's lyrical punch line, namely his critique of the use of hip-hop solely as a form of entertainment, to shine through. Furthermore, Krims (like Walser and Adams) compares content across verses, focusing more on the literal meaning of lyrics than the flow style. A final observation of Krims' that I find useful is his statement that "quite a few rap verses begin with a sung style [of flow] and then proceed gradually to a speech-effusive style. This kind of 'rhythmic acceleration' … belongs to the basic repertoire of rhythmic techniques for quite a few MCs" (52). Here Krims notes a musical trait that might help listeners understand why verses sound verse-like, an issue I address at length in Chapter 1. Although Krims does not put form at the center of his discussions, his analyses and general observations show that rappers carefully craft the large-scale organization of their songs to expressive effect.

James Bungert's 2019 article—"'I've got a bone to pick': Formal Ambivalence and Double Consciousness in Kendrick Lamar's 'King Kunta'"—offers the most extensive and detailed analysis of a single hip-hop song's formal design to date. In an effort to inspire theorists to avoid ignoring lyrical meaning—and, by extension, sociopolitical meaning and context—Bungert explores "a symbiotic relationship between structural and lyrical content in rap" (§1.4). Bungert's primary path of exploration is the form of "King Kunta." Example 0.3 reproduces his diagram, which overlays

competing interpretations of the overall formal design of the song. What sets Bungert's diagram apart from previous hip-hop scholarship is the detail and consistency with which it conveys information about segmentation and formal functions. Another important aspect of this article is that Bungert states the criteria that led him to call the interval 0:20–0:38 and the corresponding sections "the choruses": "the chorus functions as such primarily because it appears four times with an internal repetition of lyrics … and it includes the song's name" (n. 4). Bungert's reasoning is not surprising, since chorus function is marked by lyrical repetition and title lyrics in popular songs from a wide variety of genres and styles, but the explicit statement of his reasoning is still noteworthy.

**Example 0.3:** Formal diagram of "King Kunta" by Kendrick Lamar (Example 3 in Bungert [2019b])




The connection he draws between the ambiguous form of "King Kunta" and Afrodiasporic aesthetic preferences and sociopolitical ontology is a sophisticated marriage of sounds and meaning. Bungert situates the formal ambiguity in "King Kunta" within a larger network of African American expression and experience, invoking W.E.B. DuBois's idea of double consciousness as well as Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s "Signifyin(g)." While theories of form in classical and pop-rock music are often

valued for clarity, perhaps ambiguity and/or multiple meanings *should* be a central feature of a theory of form in hip-hop.

In an unpublished conference paper, Bungert has also proposed a formal paradigm describing the large-scale structure of early recorded hip-hop: prime-verse form. In prime-verse form, the chorus-oriented teleology of the better-known verse-chorus form is flipped: "The *verse* carries the song's primary musical and narrative content, thus forming the primary module, and the other modules, including the chorus, are secondary" (2019a, 2). Bungert observes a general trend in hip-hop's formal organization over the genre's history, namely that prime-verse form gradually became less common over time: "Throughout the Golden Age and into the 90s, I speculate that the forms of increasingly commercial songs pushed away from ballad and strophic prime-forms toward pop-oriented chorus-driven verse-chorus forms, leaving prime-verse in the past" (3). This highly suggestive remark aligns with one of Ben Duinker's (2021a) central theses, to be discussed below. Bungert emphasizes the non-teleological ontology of prime-verse form. Because hip-hop started as a dance party genre, I posit that its early recorded history naturally carried over the feeling of getting lost into the verses. Prime-verse form will be adopted and adapted in Chapter 2 as one of four song form types.

There seems to be a recent wave of interest in small- to medium-scale formal theory and analysis, i.e., investigations into what a phrase is in hip-hop. In Adams's recent article, "Harmonic, Syntactic, and Motivic Parameters of Phrase in Hip-Hop," he posits that, while "'phrase,' a term and concept taken from European art music, is an imperfect fit for repertoires that are tangential to that tradition" (2020, §1.14), phrase-like entities still exist in hip-hop and it is worth exploring how they are generated. Three musical elements interact to generate phrases: harmonies, lyrical syntax, and melodic and rhythmic motives. While Adams does not consider the large-scale organization of songs, this article is an important step forward in hip-hop scholarship in terms of diversifying the musical parameters valued and theorized. Ben Duinker similarly presents a theory of phrase in hip-

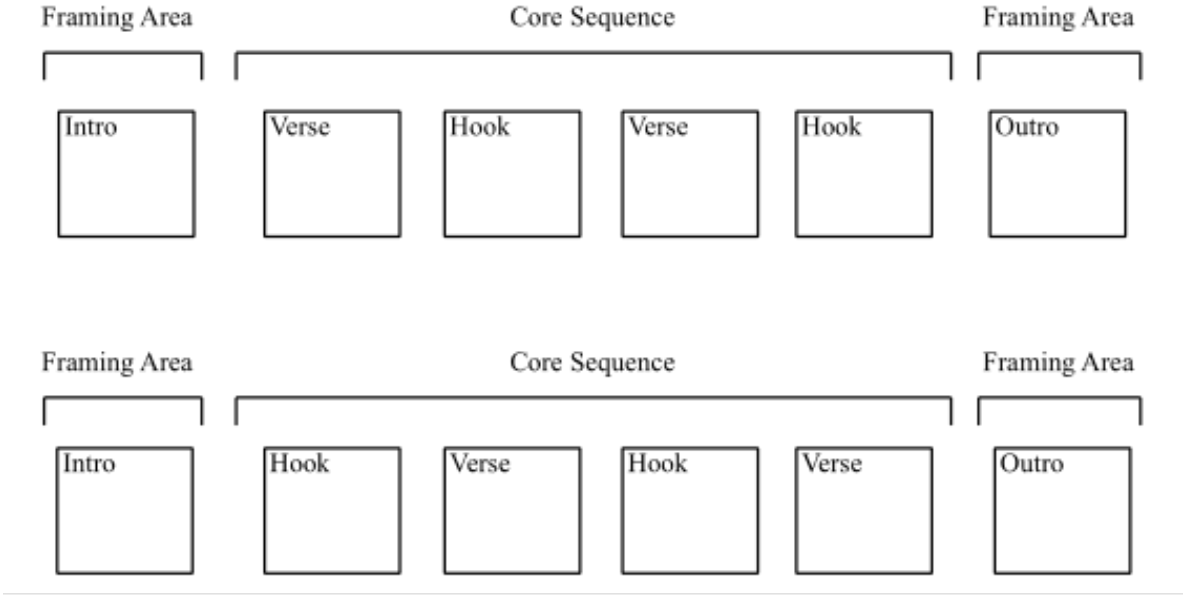
hop in "Segmentation, Phrasing, and Meter in Hip-Hop Music" (2021b). This article differs from Adams' in that Duinker "stratifies flow and beat, with the former being 'segmented into phrases' and the latter 'express[ing] hypermetrical units such as measures'" (Adams 2020, §2.1).

Duinker's "Song Form and Mainstreaming in Hip-Hop Music" (2021a) is the first publication of a full-fledged theory of form in hip-hop. Like I aim to do in this dissertation, Duinker uses pop-rock terminology and conceptions of form as a starting point for describing hip-hop, but adapts the ideas with sensitivity to the latter music's history, various social functions, and the actual sonic processes heard in recorded hip-hop. Duinker presents a taxonomy of four formal functions: verses, hooks, instrumentals, and looser-organized vocal sections. These section types are most commonly combined and arranged to generate one of three formal paradigms: strophic form (simply consisting of multiple verses or verses alternating with instrumental sections), verse-hook form—featuring cycles through verse-hook pairs, not dissimilar from "the verse-chorus paradigm referenced by Covach (2004), Temperley (2018), Ensign (2015), and others" (13)—and long-verse form. Example 0.4a provides a sample of how Duinker represents one of these schemas—verse-hook form—and Example 0.4b shows a formal analysis of a specific song. Duinker does not equate his "framing areas" with intros and outros, but it seems that they usually manifest as such from his analyses and descriptions of the musical characteristics of framing areas. From his formal theory, Duiker observes historical changes in hip-hop artists' uses of various formal schemata. Hip-hop has seen "a gradual increase in prevalence of verse-hook songs, an increase in sung hooks, hooks appearing sooner in songs' formal sequence, and the proportion of a song's total length taken up by hooks" (20).[10]

Popular music scholars have already done a great deal of work to explore the topic of form in the pop-rock repertoire. Pop-rock formal theory cannot and should not be mapped directly onto

[10] The only other scholar I am aware of to make connections between formal design and specific style trends in hip-hop is Justin Williams, who posits that one feature of "G-funk, … largely pioneered in rap music by Dr. Dre and his collaborators," is simple verse-chorus form (2013, 100).

**Example 0.4a:** Generic diagram representing verse-hook form schema (Example 5 in Duinker [2021a])




**Example 0.4b:** Formal analysis of "99 Problems" by Jay-Z (Example 6a in Duinker [2021a])

| *Formal Region* | *Section Type* | *Elapsed Time* | *Duration (s)* | *Notes* |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| framing area | hk | 0:00 | 6 | features hook lyrics |
| core sequence | vs1 | 0:06 | 40 | |
| | hk | 0:46 | 11 | shorter than other hook sections in the song |
| | vs2 | 0:57 | 62 | |
| | hk | 1:59 | 20 | |
| | vs3 | 2:19 | 52 | |
| | hk | 3:11 | 21 | |
| framing area | inst / voc | 3:32 | 23 | hype vocals |

hip-hop music without careful consideration, but it provides a useful starting place since a large portion of hip-hop music shares some of the basic formal procedures as pop-rock (e.g., the verse-chorus and verse-hook cycles referenced in Duinker [2021a] above). Mark Spicer (2004)—referenced by Bungert in his analysis of "King Kunta"—discusses accumulative processes as a form-shaping device in pop-rock music. John Covach (2005) presents a concise summary of the most common

formal types and procedures. Trevor de Clercq (2017)—while using much of the same terminology as Covach and others—offers a slightly different perspective by "embracing ambiguity" in the analysis of form. David Temperley (2018) takes on more of a textbook perspective of form, and Nobile (2020) has offered something of a Caplin-and-Schenker-meet-popular-music account of the role that harmony plays in shaping the understanding of form in pop-rock music. These varied and intersecting perspectives provide a useful network of interpretations of hip-hop's closest cousin and are referenced throughout this dissertation.

Methodology and Positionality

This dissertation is written from two perspectives that are at times in sync and at other times at odds with each other, but generally form a complementary relationship. On one hand, it is written from my perspective, that of a classically trained band kid turned academic whose primary engagement with hip-hop is best described as that of serious fan. On the other hand, it is written from the perspective of hip-hop practitioners, or, more accurately, my most honest attempt to relay their perspectives through quotation, accompanying prose, and historical accounts of their careers and personal dynamics. It is fortunate that hip-hop is perhaps the most well-documented musical genre in history because it allows music theorists to supplement traditional tools like transcription and analysis with digital ethnography. Written and video interviews, live concerts, music videos, unreleased music like freestyles, and much more are available online. I view these as crucial resources in attempting to mitigate one of the most palpable tensions at play in this dissertation, a tension on the minds of most contemporary music scholars in North America: music theory's white racial frame. A concept adapted by Philip Ewell from sociologist Joe Feagin, the white racial frame is a set of systemically enforced values that privilege white people, perspectives, ideas, histories, aesthetics, and things. Example 0.5 reproduces Ewell's list of the core beliefs of music theory's white racial frame. Choosing an African American music as a topic of study does not exempt me or any author from confronting the issues Ewell raises. At times I have felt that studying hip-hop is worse

**Example 0.5:** Beliefs of music theory's white racial frame, as formulated by Phillip Ewell (2020, §2.4)

> 1. The music and music theories of white persons represents the best, and in certain cases the only, framework for music theory.
>
> 2. Among these white persons, the music and music theories of whites from German-speaking lands of the eighteenth, nineteenth, and early-twentieth centuries represent the pinnacle of music-theoretical thought.
>
> 3. The institutions and structures of music theory have little or nothing to do with race or whiteness, and that to critically examine race and whiteness in music theory would be inappropriate or unfair.
>
> 4. The best scholarship in music theory rises to the top of the field in meritocratic fashion, irrespective of the author's race.
>
> 5. The language of "diversity" and "inclusivity" and the actions it effects will rectify racial disparities, and therefore racial injustices, in music theory.

than writing about Beethoven or the Beatles since, done without awareness of one's positionality, it may constitute a form of intellectual colonialism. Ultimately, where I think this dissertation is guilty as regards Ewell's core beliefs is its heavy dependence on the "music theories of white persons" (Belief #1), and its infrequent discussions of race (Belief #3).

I do not have an excuse or solution to this situation; it is simply a limitation of my work. However, clarifying the extent and nature of my claims as well as including digital ethnography throughout the chapters that follow may help assuage concerns about this document's relationship with the West's centuries-old tradition of racism and colonialism. Thankfully, white scholars have been considering this issue for decades. Adam Krims' description of his position in relation to hip-hop is exemplary:

> Being a white, middle-class academic exacerbates the tangle of objective situational impossibility. Examining vernacular culture, I risk appropriation of a culture that is in no way "mine," and many of whose participants pay a price I have never paid for partaking in that culture … Any claim I could make to hip-hop authenticity would be

> preposterous. So I do not make it. My connection to rap music and hip-hop culture is that of an ardent fan. (2000, 6–7)

Like Krims, I can not and do not claim any status as a hip-hop insider. My methodology relies mostly on tools foreign to hip-hop, especially transcription using Western music notation and the vocabulary I use to describe harmonies.[11] I do not use transcription or harmonic analysis because it legitimizes the music I study. Hip-hop needs no help gaining traction as a cultural movement. What hip-hop does need is more attention and space within colleges and universities. I use transcription because it facilitates more detailed and precise descriptions of salient musical features than prose alone. Along with this, it may make hip-hop more accessible to academic musicians who are experts in reading music but do not have experience working with drum machines, analog or digital samplers, or digital audio workstations (DAWs). What I hope this dissertation offers is a way of understanding hip-hop based on my own experience listening to hundreds of songs for thousands of hours in dialogue with scholarship on all kinds of popular music, including hip-hop itself as well as its ancestors and siblings. Finally, since form in hip-hop has only been minimally discussed in the scholarly literature, this work pushes against the threat of uncritically slapping the same formal labels we use for pop-rock music onto hip-hop. Such a trend would diminish hip-hop's autonomy. Instead, the framework outlined in Chapters 1 and 2 theorizes hip-hop on its own terms.

Speaking of pop-rock, I make comparisons fairly regularly throughout this dissertation between hip-hop and pop-rock. These comparisons are necessarily made using broad strokes because, in reality, neither term denotes a monolithic style, genre, or set of musical practices. I use the term pop-rock in a conventional way—to the extent that a "conventional" understanding of pop-rock can be said to exist—to refer to a collection of popular styles and sub-styles including blues, rock & roll, R&B, funk, disco, punk, progressive, metal etc.[12] Hip-hop and rap are not

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[11] That being said, many artists involved in hip-hop have had classical training or at least a working familiarity with one or more traditions of music theory (e.g., jazz theory).

[12] Spicer (2011a, xi–xiv), details many of the issues that are perennially contested in defining the boundaries of popular music, rock music, and pop-rock music.

included in most authors' lists of genres under the pop-rock umbrella, a delineation I maintain. The very question "to what extent is it useful/productive to make comparisons between such broad and slippery categories?" could inspire an entire dissertation in and of itself, and thus my justification here will likely leave some readers unsatisfied. In spite of rap-rock crossovers dating back at least as far as Blondie's "Rapture," hip-hop and pop-rock artists have generally been devoted to distinct musical and aesthetic preferences. Hip-hop distinguishes itself from pop-rock in its use of rapping, intertextual saturation, and the use of technology like the DAW. Pop-rock distinguishes itself from hip-hop in its use of directional harmony, singing, and live instruments. Even these are generalizations that can be easily complicated with counterexamples, but the point is that pop-rock and hip-hop are associated strongly enough in the scholarly imagination with specific traits that comparison between them remains a useful and meaningful exercise. Hip-hop can be better understood next to something that it is not. Pop-rock music serves as such a foil throughout this dissertation.

The musical parameter taken as the focus of this dissertation, form, can be an equally complicated concept to define. When musicians discuss form, they use spatial metaphors: "keep the bass line simple *in* the chorus."[13] A song's chorus, of course, is not a physical thing that one can step in and out of. In the most literal sense, the only spatial dimension to music is its existence as vibrations in the air and electric pulses in human brains. Despite this, performers and theorists alike depend on formal terminology, i.e., spatial metaphors, to understand and communicate about music. A likely reason we depend on these constructs is because music is a temporal art. William Caplin's theory of formal functions in classical music rests on the listener's experience of musical time:

---

[13] Although I invoke it here, metaphor theory and embodiment are topics that will not be pursued in any detail in this dissertation. I take it as an assumption that spatial metaphors are non-problematic and even necessary ways for humans to understand and discuss time. Arnie Cox's *Music and Embodied Cognition: Listening, Moving, Feeling, and Thinking* (2016) thoroughly treats the use of metaphors in discussing and understanding music.

> Central to our experience of time in general is our ability to perceive that something is beginning, that we are in the middle of something, and that something has ended. To these general temporal functions, we can add the framing functions of something occurring before-the-beginning or after-the-end. Musical form directly engages our temporal experience of a work inasmuch as its constituent time-spans have the capacity to express their own location within musical time. (Caplin 2009, 23)

My investigation of form in hip-hop does not emphasize nearly to the extent that Caplin does the beginning, middle, and ending functions that music can convey. This has to do with hip-hop's relation to groove-based genres like funk and disco, which convey a different sense of time than the teleological one Caplin describes. However, I draw from Caplin here because he gets at what I consider to be the core question theories of musical form seek to answer, no matter the repertoire under consideration: how does what I am listening to shape my awareness of time?

The gift and the curse of studying form is that its perception is shaped by every aspect of a song. As Trevor de Clercq writes, "More so than any other aspect of music, form allows for a wide variety of approaches because theories of form inherently engage with every possible musical parameter" (2012, 1). For a scholar of classical music, the strongest cues to the study of form lie in pitch-based structures like melody, harmony, and counterpoint, with tonal rhythm and meter coming in a close second. The study of form in hip-hop should surely take pitch-based entities into account, but elements that are privileged in this music are rhythm, texture, timbre, and lyrics. These aspects, therefore, have floated to the top and are mentioned more frequently in my analyses than others, but I do not discount any particular parameter from playing a role in influencing a song's expression of form.

A brief comment is in order regarding how I chose songs as examples throughout this dissertation. The primary place I went when choosing repertoire was prior scholarship, especially corpus-based work. Corpus studies make a great starting point for studying a large body of music because their populations are selected under strict conditions. Duinker and Martin's (2017) corpus,

for example, consists of 100 songs from the Golden Age of Hip-Hop (defined by the authors as the period from 1986 to 1996). Duinker and Martin consulted eight online "best-of" song lists in constructing this corpus; songs that appeared in two or more of these lists were included in their corpus. Analyzing the songs in this and other corpuses is a useful form of scholarly dialectic.[14] The current trend in the field of studying popular music via corpus analysis is supplemented by this dissertation's non-corpus approach. While corpus studies offer breadth and hard data, they tend to neglect the richness of close readings. Corpus studies also engage in a canonization process by reinscribing the popularity and success of songs in written scholarly format. While I certainly include songs and artists that are already in the hip-hop hall-of-fame, so to speak, I have also intentionally included songs that may be less well-known. In order to do this, I would select a song from a previous corpus study, go to that song's album on Spotify, and listen not just to the single song but to the album in its entirety. While it would be impossible to discuss every song I listened to in the context of this dissertation (or any single scholarly work for that matter), this approach helped to contextualize the overall artistic vision and aesthetic of the song in question. In several cases, another song or two from the album makes its way into this dissertation because it is a good example of a topic being discussed.

Finally, historical scope is an important aspect of this study. In selecting songs and making claims about form, I have not limited myself to any single time period. However, there is a strong emphasis in Chapter 1 on the Golden Age of Hip-Hop, a period that has been defined and chronologically circumscribed in a variety of ways. As mentioned above, Duinker and Martin (2017) consider the eleven-year period 1986–96 to be the Golden Age of Hip-Hop. The former date marks the beginning of hip-hop's long-term commercial success with the release of Run-D.M.C. *Raising Hell* and the latter is the year Tupac Shakur died (the Notorious B.I.G. would die months later in

[14] Other corpus studies on hip-hop include Ohriner (2016), Condit-Schultz (2016), and Duinker (2020).

early 1997). Duinker and Martin cite contrasting definitions: in a review of Slick Rick's *Behind Bars*, Cheo H. Coker mentions that "the song ['Sittin' in My Car"] invokes memories of rap's '86–'89 golden age, when it seemed that every new single reinvented the genre" (Coker 1995). Meanwhile, "Keyes (2002) makes no explicit reference to the Golden Age, but writes a chapter chronicling rap music's explosion into the musical mainstream, therein focusing on the period from 1985–1989" (Duinker and Martin 2017, 81). Schloss notes that the increased use of digital samplers and their sophisticated and streamlined artistic affordances "led to the late 1980s being called the 'golden era' of hip-hop" (2004, 39). In a parenthetical, Kyle Adams identifies the range ca. 1988–95 as delineating the Golden Age (2016, §8.1).

There is little agreement as to the exact date range of the Golden Era. However, when describing the defining musical and creative features of the Golden Age, most scholars discuss the prolific use of sampling, stylistic eccentricity, seemingly constant groundbreaking releases, and hip-hop's ever-growing popularity and commercial success. Several trends also serve as landmarks signaling the end of the Golden Age. One is the increase in copyright lawsuits against artists and record companies like *Grand Upright v. Warner Brothers*. Such cases set a precedent for record companies to want to clear their artists' samples, which made sample-based hip-hop prohibitively expensive for many. Another is the rise of West Coast gangsta rap with albums like *The Chronic* by Dr. Dre (1992) and *Doggystyle* by Snoop Dogg (1993), whose sonic palette and subject matter took hip-hop in a new direction. As is the case with most musical trends, limiting the Golden Age to a strict beginning and end point is ultimately leads to over simplification. Artists that produced outside of the Golden Age date range can still be considered to have created hip-hop in the spirit of the Golden Age (the late Daniel Dumile is an example). I argue that the Golden Age is better understood as being characterized by a particular approach to creating music, one full of the freedom and sonic experimentation afforded by digital sampling technology. However, for the sake of clarifying a specific date range, I define the Golden Age as beginning in 1986 with the release of

Run-D.M.C.'s *Raising Hell* and ending in 1994, a year that was post-Dr. Dre and Snoop Dogg but saw the release of many albums that are strongly Golden Age in aesthetic and spirit (e.g., Nas' *Illmatic*, Outkast's *Southernplayalisticadillacmuzik*, and Digable Planets' *Blowout Comb*).

Overview of Chapters

This dissertation is organized into four core chapters that group into two halves. Chapters 1 and 2 present typologies of basic formal functions and song forms, respectively. These chapters build a framework for approaching form in hip-hop, starting with building blocks at the level of the section in Chapter 1 and broadening to the level of the song in Chapter 2. The nine formal functions/section types presented in Chapter 1 are verse, hook, chorus, refrain, intro, outro, instrumental, bridge, link, and skit. The literature review offered in this introduction is continued and expanded in Chapter 1 in an effort to thoroughly consider how perspectives on pop-rock music can cross over to the analysis of form in hip-hop. Chapter 2 presents four categories of song forms: prime-verse form, verse-chorus form, AABA form, and compound song form. The smaller-scale sections identified in Chapter 1 group together in various patterns to form the full song forms identified in Chapter 2, which stand as formal schemas in their own right. Whereas the formal functions in Chapter 1 are presented without much reference to history or style, Chapter 2's typology is historically situated: as will be discussed in detail, prime-verse form is the *modus operandi* of old-school and Golden Age hip-hop while verse-chorus form and compound song form are more strongly associated with post-millennial hip-hop.

Continuing the trend of increased historical specificity, Chapters 3 and 4 are case studies of form in hip-hop during relatively narrow periods. Chapter 3 compares two hip-hop cover versions by Salt-N-Pepa to their originals: "Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang (It's Your Thing)." In addition to discussing how these songs are part of Salt-N-Pepa's stance of female empowerment, the analyses in this chapter show that the form of their versions is clearer, i.e., less ambiguous, than in the originals. Finally, Chapter 4 identifies an approach to formal organization in trap-influenced

hip-hop since about 2013 that I call inter-rotational form. Inter-rotational form results from a confluence of multiple factors, including the infusion of singing into verses, a freestyle-based approach to recent recorded hip-hop, and streaming, the world's newest mode of mass music consumption.

# CHAPTER 1: BASIC FORMAL FUNCTIONS AND SECTIONS

## Verses

### *From Block Party to Recording Studio*

Verses are the expressive locus of rap music. They constitute the space in which the feature of hip-hop that most obviously distinguishes it from other popular genres—and some would say is the very point of rap music, generally speaking—takes place: an individual delivering lyrics rhythmically, usually minimizing the use of discrete pitches and almost always over a looping beat. Verses are so important to rap music that in his construction of a corpus, Mitchell Ohriner did not count the number of *songs* in his population, but rather the number of *verses* (2019, 34–39).[1] Musical reputations and careers are made and broken within the verse, but flow was not always what hip-hop fans flocked to hear. The early development of hip-hop from a live, unrecorded dance party genre to a commercial, recorded one caused rapping to replace DJing as the music's most important element and sheds light on the sources of the some of the musical characteristics of verses. During hip-hop's first (mostly unrecorded) decade, MCs "were onstage at the discretion of the DJ, the king of the party" (Chang 2005, 132). New York City block party and disco attendees in the late 1970s and early 80s hailed the DJ who could provide beats that kept the party going and respond effectively to the mood and wishes of the crowd. The MC was there to pump up the crowd and make announcements, but the DJ was in the driver's seat. It was the translation of hip-hop music into recorded song format that caused rappers to become the primary musical icons, with DJs (who became known as producers in the commercial recording industry) generally taking more of a backseat role.[2]

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[1] Similarly, the Musical Corpus of Flow (Condit-Schultz, 2016) contains transcriptions only from the verses of the 124-song population.

[2] Loren Kajikawa (2015, ch. 1) has recounted in detail the impact that "Rapper's Delight" (1979), the first commercially successful recorded hip-hop song, had on the dynamic between MCs and DJs. DJs/producers, of course, can be and are MCs/rappers, as is true for Prince Paul, Lauryn Hill, and Jay-Z, to name just three major figures.

Rapping as it came to be known in recorded hip-hop began with the MC (master of ceremonies) taking on a gradually more prominent role at parties.[3] Instead of introducing DJs and hyping up the crowd, they would flesh out their vocal exclamations into catchy rhythmic verses, treating their own voices partially as percussion instruments layered on top of the records being spun by the DJ. In an interview with Davey D, Kool Herc (one of hip-hop's founding DJs *and* MCs) recounts that rapping began with lyrics as simple as "hailing my friends that I knew out there in the party." More interesting lyrics followed when Herc played records with "lyrics that was saying something" and wanted to "say something [him]self with a meaningful message to it" (1989). Rapping is also one manifestation in a long history of African American lyrical practices. Alice Price-Styles argues that "to chart the history of modern spoken word and rap, it is crucial to recognize the age-old traditions of oral performance and storytelling in African culture. From oral folk tales to traveling griots, oral forms have long been an integral element of communication within African communities" (2015, 11). Cheryl Keyes details these and other African and African-American antecedents to rap, including West African bardic traditions and American and Caribbean practices like toasting, the blues, and sermons (2002, 17–38). Immediately preceding hip-hop, live performances and recordings by Civil Rights activists like the Last Poets and Gil Scott-Heron influenced the vocal delivery styles and, in some cases, the lyrical content of MCs.

As rapping took on a life of its own, two freestyle formats developed that would impact verses and therefore form in recorded hip-hop: the cipher and the rap battle. In a cipher, MCs gather in a circle and take turns freestyling, keeping rhymes going as long as possible (Keyes 2002, 124–5). With the goal of continuing a lyrical groove ad infinitum, the cipher influenced recorded rap's formally by setting a norm of lengthy verses, a topic to be discussed in more detail below. Competition is not just a component of rap battles but also of DJing, break-dancing, and graffiti,

[3] Because MCs were usually the ones rapping in early hip-hop parties, the terms "MC" and "rapper" are used interchangeably in this dissertation. Recording artists throughout hip-hop's history have used the title "MC" in their stage name (e.g., MC Shan, MC Lyte, and MC Eiht).

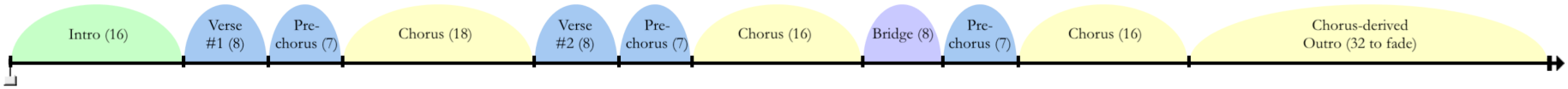
the other three elements of hip-hop. DJ battles pit two turntablists against each other, sometimes being evaluated for their skills and taste by a crowd and sometimes by judges.[4] An original use of graffiti was "tagging," a way for street gangs to mark their territory. Keyes notes that "during the formative years of rap music, it was not unusual for an MC to verbally challenge an opponent through freestlyin, the extemporaneous recitation of rhyming couplets. Many of these verbal battles (e.g., Busy Bee versus Kool Moe Dee) were live, unrehearsed performances, but as rap grew into a commercial music industry, verbal battles ensued on record" (2002, 137). Both ciphers and battles served as a forge in which virtuosity and style of vocal delivery were developed. The rap battle incentivizes the development of crafty ways of dissing (disrespecting) one's opponent and, depending on the taste of the crowd, impressive rhythms and rhymes. The cipher requires quick thinking and improvisatory endurance to keep help keep the group's flow going.

Elements of the early dance party format and Afro-diasporic poetic roots of rapping have spilled over to mold the musical traits of verses throughout hip-hop's recorded history. Primary among these is the verse's open-ended format. Verses in hip-hop music tend to be the formal unit occupying the largest percentage of a song and demonstrate the most amount of variance in length over the course of a track. Paul Edwards notes in his handbook on rapping that "a verse is usually longer than a chorus" (2009, 193) and verses made up more than half of the duration of the songs released between 1979 and about 1990 in Ben Duinker's corpus study (2021a, 26). Examples 1.1a–e show the proportions of formal units across five full songs in order to compare the length of representative verses, both among hip-hop songs and relative to chart-topping pop-rock songs released near the beginning ("I Wanna Dance With Somebody") and end ("The Sign") of hip-hop's Golden Age. Pete Rock and C.L. Smooth's "One In A Million" (Example 1.1c) is indicative of the freedom rappers have for determining the length of verses. The first, second, and third verses,

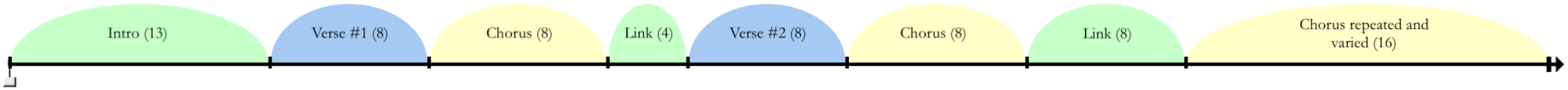
[4] See Johnson (2015, ) and Hansen (2015, 44) for descriptions of significant hip-hop dance and DJ battles.

**Example 1.1:** Section proportions in five songs

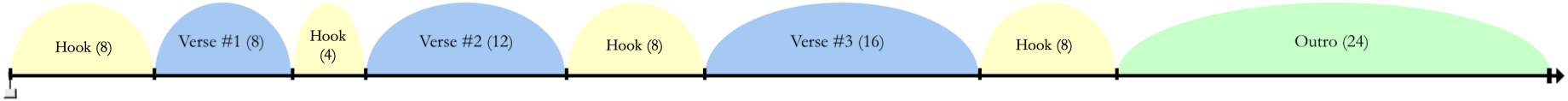
**a. Whitney Houston-"I Wanna Dance with Somebody" (1987)**



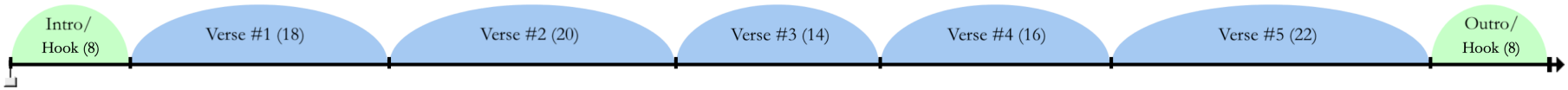

**b. Ace of Base-"The Sign" (1993)**



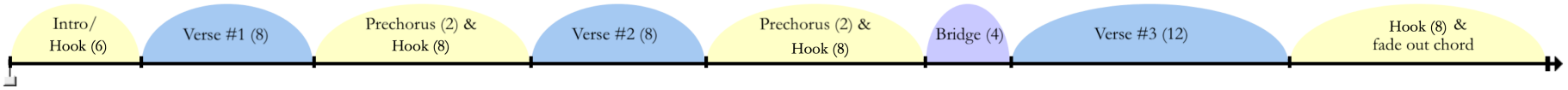

**c. Pete Rock and C.L. Smooth-"One In A Million" (1993)**




**d. A Tribe Called Quest-"Scenario" (1991)**




**e. Nicki Minaj feat. Ariana Grande-"Bed" (2018)**



length from verse to verse is not a high priority among rappers and producers. Verses are thought of more as an open-ended space in which a rapper is free to tell their story, however long that takes.[5]

The overall length of rap songs also evinces the influence of block party DJing, at least if we look at the beginning of rap's recorded history. A DJ knew he or she was doing well when the crowd did not want a certain break beat to stop repeating, so these musicians were incentivized to perform long "songs," even if they did not think of their musical creations in such terms. During the first years hip-hop went vinyl, song lengths were surprisingly long relative to popular music standards. Within the corpus analyzed by Condit-Schultz the length of recorded rap songs prior to 1985 was significantly longer (six to fifteen minutes) than the average pop song (three to six) (2016, 144), but Chuck D is quoted as having been surprised at how *short* "Rapper's Delight" (1979) was.[6] Two other seminal releases from this era with notable lengths are Kurtis Blow's 1980 "The Breaks" (1980) and Grandmaster Flash & The Furious Five's "The Message" (1982), both clocking in at over seven minutes. After 1985, the average song length in Condit-Schultz's corpus is on par with most pop-rock songs. That recorded rap took on the format (at least in terms of sheer length) of most Anglo-American popular music after just a few years shows that producers, artists, and label owners were aware of what would sell and what would not. It also supports the idea that rap has been commercialized (Rose 2018) or mainstreamed (Bungert (2019a) and Duinker (2021a)) over time.

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[5] Duinker (2021a, 4–6) has described a number of factors that influence the length of verses in hip-hop, citing the examples of Roxanne Shanté's "Roxanne's Revenge" (1984) and Nas's "NY State of Mind" (1994) as tracks with long and irregular verse lengths resulting from a freestyle verse recorded all in one take in the case of the former, and two verses with the words written down but no planned rhythms prior to recording in one take in the case of the latter. The in-studio circumstances were unique in the production of these songs and I would argue that they are both related to early live hip-hop practices like rap battles.

[6] "I did not think it was conceivable that there would be such thing as a hip-hop record. I could not see it. I'm like, record? Fuck, how you gon' put hip-hop onto a record? 'Cause it was a whole gig, you know? How you gon' put three hours on a record? Bam! They made 'Rapper's Delight.' And the ironic twist is not how long that record was, but how short it was. I'm thinking, "Man, they cut that shit down to fifteen minutes?" It was a miracle." (Chang 2005, 130).

A final aspect of block-party DJing that has influenced the musical landscape of recorded hip-hop verses and entire hip-hop songs is the use of the looped breakbeat. The famous "merry-go-round" technique first used by DJ Kool Herc (Clive Campbell) is usually cited as the musical act that gave birth to hip-hop. Jeff Chang recounts the big bang moment, quoting Herc himself:

> Herc carefully studied the dancers. "I was smoking cigarettes and I was waiting for the record to finish. And I noticed people was waiting for certain parts of the record," he says … The moment when the dancers really got wild was in a song's short instrumental break, when the band would drop out and the rhythm section would get elemental … In a technique he called "the Merry-Go-Round," Herc began to work two copies of the same record, back-cueing a record to the beginning of the break as the other reached the end, extending a five-second breakdown into a five-minute loop of fury, a makeshift *version* excursion." (Chang 2005, 77–78)

Herc's extension of the crowd's favorite part of classic funk and disco records—usually a two- or four-measure instrumental break featuring only percussion—became the backdrop over which recording hip-hop artists would deliver their lyrics.[7] That a looped beat sampled from a funk or disco song with rapping layered on top is the basic format of recorded hip-hop is demonstrated by countless examples. A humorous but telling quote from De La Soul founding member Prince Paul (Paul Huston) also underscores the importance of this textural setup: "You put anything over a beat and it's hip-hop. Anything!" (2019, 1:27:04–12). The highly repetitive nature and concomitant incessant quality of hip-hop's beats was one of the sources of early criticism of hip-hop as not music but rather "noise," a term whose racial and gendered tone has been discussed by Rose (1994) and Cheng (2018). Yet the looped beat remains a central feature of rap to this day, and while there are countless examples of songs that simply loop a one-, two-, or four-measure beat throughout, the significance of textural fluctuation is understudied in music-theoretical literature, especially as it relates to form. Strategies for designing rap songs via textural variation and undulation will be

[7] This is not to say that beats are simply a blank canvas whose specific features are trivial. Joseph Schloss's (2004) ethnographic study of hip-hop DJing practices documents the intense care that goes into musical and aesthetic decision-making in the production of hip-hop beats, and Kyle Adams (2008) has argued that beats have a significant influence on rappers' flow.

further discussed throughout this dissertation. For now, suffice it to say that one can expect to be hearing a looped beat during a hip-hop verse but this element of the musical fabric alone generally does not help to differentiate verses from other formal units.

*Flow: Lyrical Repetition and Rhythm*

As I noted in the Introduction, lyrics are one of the two broad categories of parameters that scholars have used to theorize and analyze form in popular music. Lyrical analysis can do a great deal of work to help understand what makes hip-hop verses verse-like as well to differentiate them from other formal functions. Ben Duinker has noted the lyrical similarities between rap and pop-rock verses: "As in popular music, hip-hop verses are usually 'lyrically variant but musically invariant' (Ensign 2015, 27), meaning that each successive verse utilizes new lyrics and flow rhythms over the same beat" (2021a, 4). Similarly, "the defining characteristic of verses" for Michael Berry is that "each appearance of it tends to have the same music but different lyrics" (2018, 3). These descriptions depend on knowledge of a song in its entirety, or at least information from more than one verse. It is impossible to know whether lyrics within a given formal unit are the same or different across multiple cycles through that unit without having listened to most of a song. Although not stated explicitly, these descriptions probably also rely on a relational understanding of verses, i.e., an understanding of the verse based on how it is similar and/or different from other formal units like hooks or outros. In these senses, lyrical variance as an essential feature of verse function requires rehearsed hearing. To what extent can the hip-hop verse be defined based solely on internal criteria?

One answer to this question lies in the non-repetition of lyrics within individual verses. Lyrical topics and syntax in verses cover a wide range, from weaving a coherent narrative to stream of consciousness flow that emphasizes a rapper's rhythms, rhymes, timbres, and melodic elements rather than specific stories or arguments. But whether an MC is rapping in complete sentences or stringing together words that simply sound good, verses tend to contain minimal internal lyrical

repetition. This often results from the difficulty of telling a story without using at least a fairly large variety of words. Another more general reason for lyrical non-repetition is the value placed on demonstrating skill through one's flow: it is easier to repeat a word (especially at the end of a line to complete a rhymed couplet) than it is to think of a new one, suggesting that rappers are incentivized to repeat as few words as possible. Edwards notes that exact lyrical repetition used to be frowned upon in the rap community: "Today, perfect rhyme includes rhyming by repeating the same word or phrase. This technique was not always considered valid, but it has become more widely accepted" (2009, 83). One of Edwards's interviewees, rapper Yukmouth (Jerold Dwight Ellis III), further supports this claim when he says, "Back in the day it used to be wack for you to say the same shit, but now you can say the same phrase over. Like you can say, 'Yo, I went to the store and I copped that *coke*, / And I came back on the block, now I got that *coke*' —saying the same word. It used to be corny to say the same shit over and over again, but now it's hot, so hip-hop has definitely changed" (83–84).[8] Even though repetition of lyrics within verses has become more common over the course of rap's history, lyrical *non*-repetition remains perhaps the most immediate internal signifier of this formal function.[9]

Degrees of lyrical repetition can also be understood in relational terms. Theories of pop-rock music once again map well onto rap here. Trevor de Clercq writes, for example, "the lyrics to a typical chorus repeat *more than* the lyrics to a typical verse" (2012, 43, italics in original), which is also to say that lyrics repeat less in verses than in choruses. A Tribe Called Quest's "Buggin' Out" demonstrates this relationship between verse and hook: the minimal lyrical repetition that does exist within and across the song's four verses (0:08–53, 0:53–1:33, 1:53–2:33 and 2:33–3:13) can be described as incidental or trivial while the two iterations of the hook (1:33–53 and 3:13–33) are

[8] Hip-hop fads change very quickly, especially in the post-millennial environment of streaming. Yukmouth's observation, therefore, is likely out of date over a decade removed from publication.
[9] An example of a recent song that features more lyrical repetition than usual in verses is Drake's "God's Plan" (2018) in which every line in the first verse ends with the word "me."

highly repetitive, featuring only the line "Buggin' out, buggin' out, buggin' out, you're buggin' out" repeated eight times.[10] In summary, rap verses feature minimal lyrical repetition both within individual verses (although this type of repetition has increased slightly over the genre's history) and across all the verses in a song, and far less lyrical repetition than hooks.

Another internal characteristic of verses—a musical parameter more than a lyrical one—is the number of musicians active: verses tend to feature one rapper delivering lyrics. This may seem like an obvious observation, so self-evident that we might be tempted to posit that the single characteristic shared by all verses is that they involve "an *individual* delivering lyrics," to reprise my description from the beginning of this chapter. The common method of describing verses as belonging to a certain rapper (e.g., "Monie Love's verse on the song 'Ladies First'") is indicative of how natural it is to assume that one person will be rapping in such a formal unit. But enough verses exist that defy this expectation to warrant a degree of caution in strictly defining verse function in this way.[11] For example, in two passages from A Tribe Called Quest's "Check the Rhime" (0:24–54 and 2:04–33), rappers Q-Tip and Phife Dawg trade lines enough to make it difficult and perhaps even irrelevant to determine whose verse is being delivered. As Example 1.2 shows, in the twelve measures that make up the first of these passages, Q-Tip's lines occupy approximately seven measures while Phife's take up five. The rappers have fairly equal weight in this passage, both in terms of time heard and in terms of guiding the narrative, making it reasonable to simply state that we are hearing a shared verse.[12] An excellent example that further problematizes the assumption that verses necessarily feature one rapper is Lil Dicky's "Professional Rapper." In this humorous

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[10] For reasons that will be explored in detail in section later in this chapter, the present theory of form in hip-hop will use the term "hook" instead of "chorus" in most cases. In considering how scholarship on pop-rock is applicable to the current context of rap, I have generally treated choruses in the former and hooks in the latter as analogous.

[11] The Beastie Boys are an extreme example of this; most of their verses are shared by two, if not all three of the group's members.

[12] Robert Komaniecki (2017) cites A Tribe Called Quest as an early rap group whose MCs would share verses resulting in "unified flow," i.e., flow from disparate rappers that shares characteristics of rhyme, rhythm, accent, and pitch.

**Example 1.2:** A Tribe Called Quest, "Check the Rhime" (1991), 0:24–54; Q-Tip in white boxes, Phife Dawg in grey

| 1 | e | & | a | 2 | e | & | a | 3 | e | & | a | 4 | e | & | a |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Back | | in | the | days | | on | the | boul- | e- | vard | 'o | Lin- | den | | we |
| used | to | kick | rou- | tines | | and | the | pre- | scence | was | | fitt- | in' | it | was |
| I | | | the | Ab- | stract | | and | me | the | five | | foot- | er | | I |
| kicks | the | mad | | style | | so | step | off | the | frank- | | furt- | er | yo | |
| Phife | | you | re- | mem- | ber | that | | rou- | | tine | | | | that | we |
| used | to | make | | spiff- | y | like | | Mis- | ter | Clean | | | | um | |
| | um | | a | tid | bit | | | um | | | a | smidg- | eon | | I |
| don't | | get | the | mess- | age | so | you | gots | to | run | the | pidg- | eon/you | on | on |
| point | | Phife | | | | all | the | time | | Tip | | | you | on | |
| point | | Phife | | | | all | the | time | | Tip | | | you | on | |
| point | | Phife | | | | all | the | time | | Tip | | | well | then | |
| grab | the | mic- | ro- | phone | | | and | let | your | words | | rip | (now | here's | a) |

**Example 1.3:** Lil Dicky and Snoop Dogg, "Professional Rapper" (2015), 0:29–1:28; Snoop Dogg in white, Lil Dicky in grey

| 1 | e | & | a | 2 | e | & | a | 3 | e | & | a | 4 | e | & | a |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | | | | Grab | | a | | seat | | | |
| thanks | | I'm | | Dave | | ver- | y | nice | | to | meet | | | | |
| Dave | | what | it | do | | you | can | call | | me | Dogg | | | | |
| le- | mme | just | | check | | your | sheet | | | no | | prob- | | lem | |
| sir | | le- | mme | just | | say | | | | I'm | a | big | | fan | |
| of | the | shit | that | y'all | | make | | | I | cant | | lie | | I've | been |
| think- | in' | bout | this | all | | day | | | | all | | good | | there's | a |
| rea- | son | that | we | called | | Dave | | | | le- | mme | start | | with | your |
| back- | | ground | | where'd | you | come | | from | | sure | | I | was | un- | der- |
| grad | | down | | there | in | Rich- | | mond | be- | fore | | that | | oh | you |
| talk- | in' | bout | my | home- | | town | | yeah | | I | was | born | | outt- | a |
| Phill- | y | grew | up | in | a | litt- | le | silli | y | old | | town | | called | |
| Chelt- | | en- | ham | | it's | in | the | sub- | | urbs | | upp- | er | midd- | le |
| wealth | | a- | round | | so | real | | shit | | you | ain't | ev- | er | had | to |
| stru- | ggle | for | much | | I | would- | n't | say | it | like | | that | | | |
| we | just | had | a | diff' | rent | kind | of | trap | | | e- | lab- | | or- | ate |
| | | well | | I | ain't | ev- | er | had | | a | tool | | | but | I |
| had | to | be | the | man | | at | school | | like | I | was | do- | in' | shit | I |
| had | | to | do | | so | when | I | fin- | ished | un- | der- | grad | | I'm | cool |
| | and | I | can | get | what- | ev- | er | job | | I | | want- | ed | but | the |
| job | | you | | want- | ed | was- | n't | all | | that | | bump- | in' | yeah | |
| and | I | saw | | quick | | all | the | flaws | | that | be | com- | in' | when | you |
| grow | up | like | | that | | | | when | you've | | been | rac- | in' | | them |
| rats | | | | you | ain't | | been | mak- | in' | | them | raps | | boo- | |
| hoo | | what | a | hard- | | ship | | | but | how | you | pay | to | get | the |
| rap | | shit | | start- | ed | man | | | my | Bar | | Mit- | | zvah | mon- |
| ey | but | don't | | dis | | me | budd- | y | I | was- | n't | one | of | those | young- |
| ins | up | on | the | block | | who | had | noth- | in' | to | lose | | I | must- | 've |
| want- | ed | this | a | lot | | I | had | some- | thin' | to | choose | | | ha! | |
| look | at | that | | I | can | see | there's | some- | thin' | to | prove | | up | in | your |
| ass | | yeah | I | guess | that's | | e- | ough | of | | the | past | | | |
| what | makes | | you | wann- | | a | do | rap | | oh | my | | god | it's | the… |

portrayal of an aspiring young rapper (Lil Dicky) being interviewed by one of the legends of hip-hop (Snoop Dogg), there is near constant lyrical back and forth, as shown in Example 1.3. The rapping that takes place in this song is essentially a conversation set rhythmically with rhymes. Even though the expectation that one person will be rapping is not fulfilled, this passage meets many

other criteria for verse function: a story is being told, there is very little to no lyrical repetition, the rhythms and some of the rhymes are fairly complicated and hard to remember, and the sections in which Lil Dicky and Snoop Dogg are in dialogue take up the bulk of the song. The effect of this shared verse format is a heightened sense of urgency, partially resulting from the way that this song is reminiscent of rap battle, and perhaps meant to put the listener in Lil Dicky's nervous shoes.[13]

Another reliable music-lyrical aspect of verses that helps one identify function—one that can be viewed both as an internal characteristic and in relational terms to other formal units—has to do with rhythm. The rhythms of a rapper's flow in the verse tend to be dense and complex, especially when compared to those of a song's hook. Even in verses featuring relatively simple flow styles—e.g., Krims's "sung style" (2000)—the likelihood is very high that syllabic density, i.e., the number of syllables per unit time, will be higher than in other formal units. Example 1.4 summarizes the syllabic density in the verses and hooks of three songs. In these examples, the rhythm of the lyrics in the verses is denser than in the hooks. Segments of hooks are often just as rhythmically dense as verses, but the overall lyrical busyness is lower because of a tendency to add more space ("rests") between lyrics during these formal units, a topic to be discussed further in section below. Like most other descriptions in this dissertation, the difference in syllabic density between verse and hook is not a hard and fast rule that should be blindly depended upon for interpreting formal function. Numerous examples of songs that run counter to my general description could be given, like Missy Elliott's "She's a Bitch" (1999) whose hooks have similar syllabic density to the verses. Plus, denser sampling, vocal layering, and call-and-response lyrics as in Queen Latifah's "U.N.I.T.Y" (1993) often makes counting the actual number of syllables in hooks a less than straightforward task. Are we to count only the syllables delivered by the primary voice in the texture or take into account any hype

[13] If forced to make an analytical decision, I would say this is Lil Dicky's verse. Dave is the subject of the interview and so has something to prove. Our attention is further placed on him because we empathize with his stressful situation whereas Snoop Dogg's presence takes on more of the role of a cameo appearance. The interviewee also has more lines and switches between different flow styles with a range of rhythmic and rhyme complexity.

**Example 1.4:** Comparison of syllabic density (measured in syllables per measure) between verses and hooks in three classic hip-hop songs

| Song | Verse measures | Verse syllables | Verse syllabic density | Hook measures | Hook syllables | Hook syllabic density |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| "Basketball" by Kurtis Blow (1984) | 40 | 379 | 9.5 | 88 | 264 | 3 |
| "Can I Kick It?" by A Tribe Called Quest (1990) | 34 | 330 | 9.7 | 16 | 110 | 6.9 |
| "Joy" by Missy Elliott feat. Mike Jones (2005) | 44 | 511 | 11.6 | 16 | 134 | 8.4 |

men/women that respond to the primary vocalist?[14] Should words heard in a passage that are clearly sampled be counted? How should we count syllables that are repeated via studio production techniques like scratching? These problems notwithstanding, verses in rap music tend to be wordier and rhythmically denser than hooks.

Complexity is an aspect of flow that is difficult to quantify. Mitchell Ohriner's recent definition of complexity is based on "the extent to which a groove places accents on positions that do not usually carry accents in rap music" (2019, 137). A vocal groove (Ohriner's primary tool for describing flow based on repeating sequences of inter-accent-intervals) with accents on the second sixteenth note slot of one or more beats would be considered fairly complex. The justification for Ohriner's definition has to do with the way in which statistics from his corpus reflect listener

[14] Several theorists (e.g., Temperley 2018, 160) have observed that choruses in pop-rock music tend to feature more backing vocals. This is usually considered a textural phenomenon, meaning that the lead vocals are analyzed apart from backup or responding vocals when analyzing "the lyrics" of a chorus. While there are some cases in hip-hop that fall into a grey area (especially because of the extensive use of samples woven into already-dense textures), I tend to follow this analytical practice.

expectations. Groove classes with accents just after one or more of the four beats in a four-beat measure are rare and therefore ostensibly harder for listeners to process because they are much more used to hearing accents coinciding with the beats or in the third sixteenth note slots of each beat.[15] What I mean by complexity here has less to do with the location of accents within a groove class—although this is undoubtedly a metric for quantifying complexity that provides great analytical and interpretive traction—but rather relies more on the amount of switches in groove class and rhyme scheme over a given span. Verses can be said to be more complex than hooks because in the former, rappers tend to pack in a wider variety of rhythmic motives and rhyme patterns while in the latter, very often a single rhythmic motive and line of text (not just a single rhyme scheme) will be repeated several times verbatim, as in the lyrics in the hook from "Check the Rhime," mentioned above. Flow also varies more from verse to verse than from hook to hook, as Berry notes: "In contrast to more melodic popular music, it's important to note that rappers might vary their flow in each verse" (2018, 3). Except for this inter-verse trend, rhythmic density and complexity signify verse function similarly in both hip-hop and pop-rock music. Ken Stephenson, for instance, states, "choruses in rock … have a tendency toward slower vocal rhythms than do verses" (2002, 129). Similarly, de Clercq identifies the "simplified rhythmic structure" (2012, 46) in the chorus of Bruno Mars's "Just the Way You Are" (2010) as a normal feature of pop-rock choruses. And, in a formulation that closely reflects the data presented in Example 1.4, Temperley posits that "choruses tend to have fewer *syllables* (per unit time) and thus fewer notes—a lower syllabic density, one might say" (2018, 161).

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[15] A groove class, as Ohriner defines it, is "one of seven duration segments made up of only 2s and 3s, summing to 16" (2019, 213). Groove classes, like pitch class sets, are intervallic abstractions. Whereas pitch class sets denote intervals of pitch height, groove classes capture time intervals based on accent in Ohriner's theory. Groove classes may begin at any part of a measure, unless there is an internal repetition like in the groove class <332_332>. A flow with groove class <332_2222>, for instance, might begin on the downbeat of a measure, then have another accented syllable three sixteenth notes later, then three sixteenths after that, then two, and so on.

*Refrains*

Another typical lyrical characteristic of rap verses is that they very often begin or end with refrains. Refrains have been widely theorized and analyzed in the pop-rock literature and have been defined in fairly contrasting ways by different authors. Some, especially in slightly older scholarship, use the term "refrain" in a related but truly different way than is typical today, essentially using it interchangeably with "chorus."[16] In this conception, a refrain is understood as a section in and of itself. Definitions of refrains today are more commonly made in distinction to the chorus and are usually based the recurrence of a set of lyrics, although two questions are not as uniformly agreed-upon: 1) to what extent does a refrain constitute an independent section? and 2) where in a song may a refrain occur? Walter Everett offers one of the stricter definitions: "an optional final line of a song's verse, consisting of a lyric (usually containing the title) that does not vary from verse to verse" (2001, 365). For Everett, a refrain only occurs in the verse, at the end of the verse, and the lyrics that make up the refrain must be invariant. Everett is not explicit about the degree of autonomy a refrain has as a section, but one can glean that he does not consider them to be independent because the word "optional" in his description implies that refrains are like decorations, something to be added to something more substantial for artistic effect. The advantage of such a restrictive definition is that it creates a bright line between refrains and non-refrains. On the other hand, we are in danger of losing some of the richness of specific musical context if we are too quick to analyze examples containing ambiguous traits in a black and white fashion. Ken Stephenson explicitly defines refrains not as independent sections in and of themselves, but unlike Everett allows for them to appear virtually anywhere in a song: "Not a complete section, a refrain consists of one or two textual lines that recur periodically. A refrain normally ends a verse, as in [The Beatles'] 'I Want To Hold Your

[16] Examples of this usage can be found in Harrison (1997) and Pollack (2001). Adam Krims (2000) and Robert Komaniecki (2018) are two hip-hop scholars who have used "refrain" in this way; obviously, Komaniecki's dissertation is very recent, but his focus was not on musical form. A useful summary of the differences between refrains and choruses can be found in Nobile (2020, 61).

Hand,' or begins a chorus, as in the Lovin' Spoonful's 'Do You Believe in Magic.' … Again, the refrain is not a complete section but rather a specially designated part of the verse, bridge, or chorus in which it appears" (2002, 135). De Clercq similarly allows for refrains to occur in a wide range of contexts, but—in what is largely a nuanced reframing of Everett's definition—does describe the most common circumstances that give rise to refrain function: "the strongest and clearest sense of refrain occurs at the end of a section as the cadential material of the final 4-bar hypermeasure. Moreover, the clearest cases also have a specific melodic phrase structure and a corresponding cadential location" (2012, 62). De Clercq's description of refrains is particularly attractive because it captures musical characteristics surrounding refrains in addition to their lyrical basis. Finally, Temperley is one of the few modern scholars to theorize refrains as standalone sections in and of themselves. Although for Temperley a chorus constitutes "a sizable section in its own right" (2018, 153) unlike refrains, he is clear to segment them apart from verses that precede them in his form diagrams. In strong accordance with Everett, "a short passage with unchanging text at the end of the main repeating section of a song" is treated as a refrain in Temperley's theory.

Within the scholarly literature on hip-hop, I am aware of two theoretical definitions of refrains. One comes from James Bungert, who describes a refrain as as "the small bit of lyric invariant text that ends each strophe" (2019a, 3). Bungert also notes that the refrain provides closure to verses in strophic form songs, resonating with de Clercq's observation that refrains most often participate in or even serve as cadences. Bungert's is a relatively strict definition that is most similar to those of Everett and Temperley. Michael Berry offers the other scholarly definition of refrains in hip-hop amid his description of "When The Revolution Comes" (1970) by the pre-hip-hop group The Last Poets: "The poem uses the refrain (a short, repeated phrase of text) 'When the revolution comes' as its backbone" (2018, 67). Although this definition has the advantage of being broad enough to be applied to the multifarious lyrical strategies found throughout hip-hop's history, it verges on being too all encompassing. The hook sections of many rap songs consist of nothing but

"a short, repeated phrase of text," but this text is not always found in isolation elsewhere in the song, a condition most authors at least implicitly agree is part of refrain function. Apart from these two theories of refrains in hip-hop, several theorists have also used the term and provided some guidelines as to what they mean by it. Ben Duinker, for instance, states, "I allow for refrain lyrics to be part of the verse or hook, depending on context" (2021a, n. 21). He also analyzes the final lines from each verse of Mez's (Morris Ricks II) song "Morris" (2014) as a refrain, an uncontroversial interpretation since each iteration of them is the same and they come at the very end of each of the song's three verses. These scholars provide a useful foundation for theorizing refrains in hip-hop, but there are many questions left unanswered. It is not clear in Bungert's formulation, for example, whether refrains can occur in songs using formal types other than strophic. Additionally, none of these authors indicates that a refrain can take place at the beginning of a verse even though "head refrains," as they have been referred to, have been widely observed in pop-rock scholarship.

What is common throughout all these writings is that refrain function comes about through lyrical repetition, in most cases exact repetition. My own one-line definition of refrains is also based on this core feature: a refrain is a short phrase of text repeated exactly or with slight variation, usually heard in an emphasized delivery at important formal locations in order to add a sense of cohesion to a song. This formulation is general enough to include a range of lyrical strategies that yield refrain function yet specific enough to differentiate refrains from hooks and to capture what I consider to be the function shared by all types of refrains, namely creating cohesion. It does not specify that refrains must participate in closing function, although this is true for verse-ending refrains. The use of the word "phrase" also implies that refrains are sections in that they are usually substantial enough to be a segmented span. But to be clear, I do not understand refrains to be independent sections. Rather, I agree with de Clercq that a refrain is better understood as "a subsection—only part of a larger, standalone unit" (2012, 57).

Within verses, refrains can either serve a launching function as in the case of head refrains, discussed below, or, more commonly, provide a sense of closure as is true for verse-ending refrains. A song that provides a nice example a verse-ending refrain and its function within the context of a rap verse is "Ladies First" by Queen Latifah with guest artist Monie Love.[17] As Examples 1.5a–e show, each verse ends with the words "ladies first" or a close variant thereof.[18] These verse-ending refrains occur mostly within the second measure of a rhymed couplet that takes place over two measures. Note that in Example 1.5a, Monie Love adds an extra word ("yes") to the end of her first verse in order to complete a rhyme with the end of the preceding line. This lyrical manipulation *in favor* of completing a rhymed couplet runs counter to Drew Nobile's observation about pop-rock music that "a common lyrical technique is for the refrain line *not* to rhyme with other lines in the verse, thus emphasizing it by setting it apart from the rest of the verse" (2020, 59, emphasis added). The remaining iterations of the verse-ending refrain are all set up by words that rhyme with "first" ("birth," "reverse," "verse," and "worst") but the end of Monie Love's first verse demonstrates one common manipulation of verse-ending refrains made in concession to the strong preference throughout rap's history for rhymed couplets. Not all verse-ending refrains are contained within just one measure, as discussed below in the context of Nas's "NY State of Mind," but in the common situation in which they are, their completion of a rhymed couplet means they take place in a hypermetrically weak measure.[19] In order to add emphasis, rappers will sometimes set up their

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[17] Other examples of songs featuring verse-ending refrains include Salt-n-Pepa's "Hyped On The Mic," De La Soul's "Me Myself And I," Public Enemy's "Night of the Living Baseheads," L.L. Cool J's "Illegal Search," Lauryn Hill's "Lost Ones," and Blackilicious's "Blazing Arrow." Literally hundreds more songs featuring this common approach to large-scale organization in hip-hop could be cited.

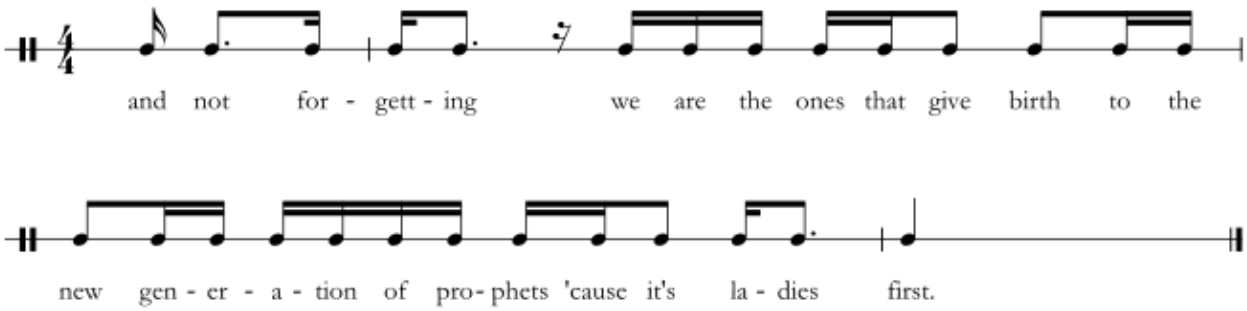
[18] Although not shown in Example 1.5 (which is an analysis of the album version of the song), the radio version of "Ladies First," discussed by Duinker (2021a, 14–15 and 21–22) included another verse by Queen Latifah that also ends with the titular verse-ending refrain.

[19] Hypermeter in rap music is virtually unstudied. The assertion that the first measure of two containing a rhymed couplet is stronger than the second is based on Lerdahl and Jackendoff's (1983) Metrical Preference Rule 2, which stipulates a weak preference for metrical structures in which strong beats come earlier than weak beats.

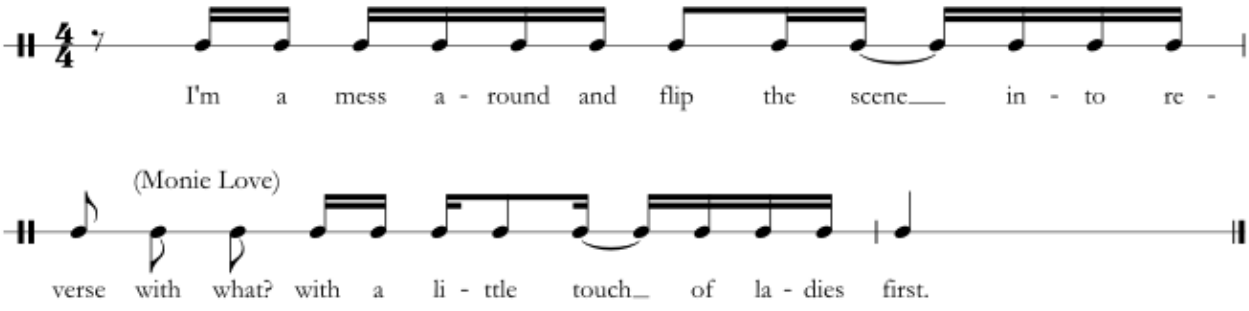
**Example 1.5:** Verse-ending refrains in Queen Latifah and Monie Love's "Ladies First" (1989)

a. End of Monie Love's first verse (0:44–50)

b. End of Monie Love's second verse (1:07–12)




c. End of Queen Latifah's second verse (1:25–30)




d. End of Monie Love's third verse (2:54–59)

e. End of Queen Latifah's fourth verse (3:12–17)

delivery of the refrain so that it elides with the beginning next formal unit, as is true in Examples 1.5b, c, and e. This manipulation serves both to connect the verse to the subsequent formal unit (usually the hook) and to bolster the musical support of the refrain text by displacing the rhyme from a metrically weak position (usually beat four of a hypermetrically weak measure of $\frac{4}{4}$) to a metrically strong one (the downbeat of a hypermetrically strong measure).[20]

As is true of most verse-ending refrains, the line "ladies first" gains strength in providing closing function over the course of the song. Unless one is aware of the song's title before listening, the primary source of closure at the first verse-ending refrain is the dropping out of the beat for one measure (i.e., in the second full measure of Example 1.5a; see the discussion of textural fluctuations in verses in below). It is also possible that a listener who attends closely to lyrics would notice that the second word of the song (albeit rapped by Queen Latifah, not Monie Love who delivers the first verse-ending refrain) is "ladies," thus imbuing this word with some sense of importance from the outset and creating a lyrical bookending effect over the first two verses.[21] However, once we have heard the refrain at the end of a verse whose closure is articulated by a fluctuation in musical texture, it is likely that the reuse of this line as a refrain later on will be within our range of expectations as to how the rest of the song will unfold. Indeed, the next iteration of the refrain is stronger in that its last syllable pairs with the penultimate line of the verse. And as Example 1.5c shows, the refrain is even further strengthened upon its third appearance because Queen Latifah places the rhyming syllables "-verse" of "reverse" and "first" of "ladies first" in analogous metrical positions (directly on the downbeat), as opposed to disparate metrical locations as in Monie Love's "birth" and "first."

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[20] In addition to "Ladies First," this technique can be heard in Erik B. & Rakim's "I Ain't No Joke" and "Paid in Full" (1987), as well as in numerous other hip-hop songs.

[21] Adams (2009) notes that rapper Gift of Gab (Timothy Parker) articulates the beginning and end of his first verse on the song "Blazing Arrow" (2002) in a similar bookending fashion, using both rhyme *and* repeated words ("blazing arrow") to frame the verse. In the radio edit of "Ladies First," one does not have to strain to hear the words "ladies first" early in the song because it opens with a sung hook consisting solely of the title lyrics.

Unlike most theorists, I have posited that refrains can include some lyrical variation from iteration to iteration. Expecting verse-ending refrains (and any type of refrain, for that matter) to always contain the identical text is problematic for two reasons. First, rappers will often add slight variation to the word, phrase, line, or lines that function as a verse-ending refrain. This is true of one of the most famous verse-ending refrains in all of hip-hop history, from Nas's "N.Y. State of Mind," in which the two verses end as follows:

- Verse 1 (2:04–15): It drops deep as it does in my breath / I never sleep, 'cause sleep is the cousin of death / Beyond the walls of intelligence, life is defined / I think of crime when I'm in a New York state of mind
- Verse 2 (3:58–4:09): Inhale deep like the words of my breath / I never sleep, 'cause sleep is the cousin of death / I lay puzzled as I backtrack to earlier times / Nothing's equivalent to the New York state of mind

These two moments are clearly parallel in that they share many words (including the same rhyming words) and come at the end of Nas's verses, functioning as verse-ending refrains. Yet only one line out of four is the exact same: "I never sleep, 'cause sleep is the cousin of death," which might explain why these words, not the title lyrics stated in the last line of the verse-ending refrains, are often shouted by crowds at live shows.[22] "NY State of Mind" highlights the analytical issue of segmentation in identifying verse-ending refrains. What exactly is the verse-ending refrain here? Is it the entire final four lines of each verse? Is it the title lyric only (i.e., the last five words of each verse)? Is it possible to interpret just "I never sleep, 'cause sleep is the cousin of death" as the verse-ending refrain? In this case, I consider the entire four lines to be the verse-ending refrain because they are so similar in lyrical content and rhythm and because these four lines feel relatively short

[22] See for example Nas's live performances of "NY State of Mind" at South by Southwest 2012 in Austin, Texas (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q81lInyFZfE) or at the Keswick Theater in Philadelphia in October 2013 (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SlLW45sq54A). Another reason "I never sleep, 'cause sleep is the cousin of death" may well be interpreted as the refrain in this song is Nas's intertextual use of it during the hook of "The Message," released on *It Was Written* two years after *Illmatic*.

compared to Nas's lengthy verses.[23] Second, there exist examples of verse-ending phrases in the recorded rap repertoire that meet many typical characteristics of refrain function, yet are not repeated at the end of any other verse. An example of this is Dr. Dre's verse on "Deep Cover" (1992). At the end of this verse, Dre states the lyric "deep cover" very emphatically, providing a sense of closure, but the title lyric never returns. There is the problem of whether a listener who does not know the name of the song would perceive this as a refrain, but it helps that Dre stated the same words ("deep cover") near the beginning of the verse, creating the same bookending effect mentioned above in the context of the first verse-ending refrain in "Ladies First." "Deep Cover" flies in the face of what many theorists consider the defining feature of a refrain, i.e., the repetition of text at the end of each verse, but it is hard not to hear at least traces of refrain function at the end of the song's first verse. "NY State of Mind" and "Deep Cover" serve as healthy reminders that we should take a flexible approach to defining, analyzing, and hearing verse-ending refrains.

Some rap verses begin with what has been called a head refrain in pop-rock music (de Clercq 2012, 64 ff.). Such refrains come at the outset of verses, usually such that they constitute the very first words of the verse. Like verse-ending refrains, the actual words are often the song's title or, if not, they relate to a central theme of the song. Unlike verse-ending refrains, however, head refrains set the stage for what is to follow; they have beginning or initiating function instead of closing function. Additionally, head refrains tend to be organized more loosely then verse-ending refrains. For example, it is much more likely for a head refrain to occur in some but not all of a song's verses, as in N.W.A.'s "Fuck Tha Police" (1988). As an example of a song using a head refrain in a fairly straightforward manner, Examples 1.6a–c present passages from Kendrick Lamar's "These Walls." In all three of the song's rapped verses, Kendrick begins with the words "if these walls could talk" (Examples 1.6a–b) or the close variant "if your walls could talk" (1.6c). The rhythmic setting of the

[23] Additionally, the first of the four lines in each refrain is rhythmically identical and places the analogous words "breath" and "death" in the same metric positions. Thanks to Kyle Adams for pointing out this detail to me.

head refrain is the exact same in each iteration within the verses but the line is set differently (starting on the downbeat as shown in Example 1.6d) when it appears in the intro and hooks. Note also that the rhymes in each verse's opening couplet are different: good/would, deep/see, and late/fate. This is another feature of head refrains in hip-hop that differentiates them from verse-ending refrains. Whereas we saw the text of the verse-ending refrain determining the rhyme scheme above in "Ladies First," head refrains generally do not determine rhyme scheme. Rappers can achieve a balance of repetition and variety through head refrains by starting verses in the same way but taking

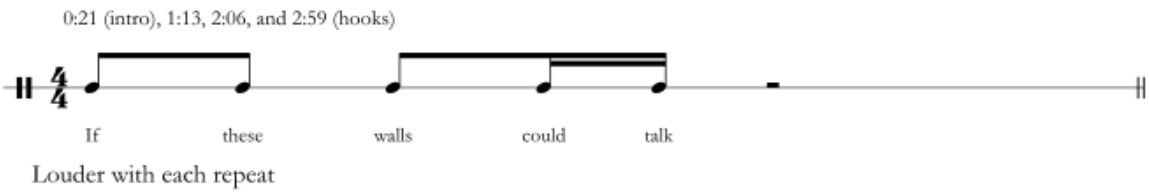
**Example 1.6:** Head refrains in Kendrick Lamar's "These Walls" (2015)

a. Beginning of first verse (1:30–35)

b. Beginning of second verse (2:23–28)

c. Beginning of third verse (3:34–39)

d. Head refrain as used in intro and hooks



the listener in a different direction both topically and in terms of rhythm and rhyme scheme. In the case of "These Walls," Kendrick's use of a head refrain binds the song together by thematically linking the intro and hooks to the verses and by giving the verses a rotational feeling. Each time a verse begins, it seems like Kendrick is taking us on another pass through the subject at hand: walls that metaphorically invoke an aspect of female anatomy, religious symbolism, systemic oppression of black people, and actual jail cells. Yet Kendrick is able to keep listeners on their toes by ending the first line of each verse differently, ushering the narrative forward and avoiding any sense of tedious predictability.[24]

Both verse-ending refrains and head refrains are particularly useful strategies for MCs to identify or show solidarity with each other when multiple rappers are featured on the same track, values that have been discussed in detail by Robert Komaniecki (2017). Like many other aspects of recorded rap music, it is possible that both types of refrains derive from informal/unrecorded settings common throughout hip-hop's history: freestyling, rap battles, and ciphers. In each of these contexts, rappers deliver bars that are made up on the spot.[25] Head refrains are especially likely to have been derived from these non-recorded hip-hop practices because in live settings, a topic or several topics will be given at the start of or during a session in order to structure the rap, provide a specific challenge, or help a rapper who is running out of ideas. Some rappers ask their audience or DJ to throw ideas to them, as can be seen during Juice WRLD's (Jarad Anthony Higgins) freestyle on Charlie Sloth's (Charlie Rouillon) radio show Fire in the Booth.[26] The head refrain may very well

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[24] Verse-ending refrains and head refrains have been the focus of this discussion, but further research is needed to exhaustively account for refrain types. In Digable Planets' "Where I'm From" (1993), for instance, the title lyric is repeated as a refrain frequently and unpredictably.

[25] There is no clean distinction between rapping "off the top," i.e., through pure improvisation, and using prepared lyrics. Many rappers quote passages of their own recorded lyrics or composed verses-in-progress when they run out of improvised material in freestyle settings. Conversely, performances of a single verse from a recorded song at live shows can vary quite notably. For purposes of the present discussion, however, it will suffice to assume that in freestyle, rap battle, and cipher settings, rappers engage their improvisatory capabilities more than their prepared material.

[26] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TGb4PEZ6HEE&t=353s. Juice WRLD asks Charlie for topics starting at 6:15.

be a recorded remnant of rappers' practice of restating the topic that was just given to them to get their flow going in these improvised contexts. A number of African-American practices that precede hip-hop chronologically may be sources for head refrains, including sermons in black churches and spoken word poetry. The Last Poets' "When the Revolution Comes" is an example of a recorded poem that begins with the refrain. "Music and Politics" (1992) by the Disposable Heroes of Hiphoprisy is an example that might more properly be called a hip-hop recording that evinces the influence of spoken-word poetry via non-quantized rhythms.

*Beats*

Like the above discussion of flow, the present exposition of the general characteristics of beats in verses will not be exhaustive.[27] This topic has been widely covered in the literature and has been the subject of numerous monographs. Given the specific focus of this dissertation, however, it is worth considering how beats influence the perception of verse function and how artists use beats within verses. There is no golden rule as to what a hip-hop beat must be comprised of (see again the remark by Prince Paul above on page 4). Numerous tracks from experimental hip-hop group clipping.'s 2020 album *Visions of Bodies Being Burned*, for example, seriously throw into question how we should define a hip-hop beat. Music theorists have categorized the basic elements of popular music beats in a number of ways, perhaps reflecting the complicated musical reality of beat construction. Krims's layering graph method captures the formal function of various textures over an entire song more than the role of specific sounds within the instrumental swath of a track. Adjuncts are the only element in Krims's layering charts that are purely beat-functional instead of form-functional.[28] Allan Moore posits four basic textural layers typically found in in most rock

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[27] The word "beat" is here used to refer to all the elements of the musical texture in a rap song other than the rapper's voice. It is also sometimes used to refer to the regular succession of pulses (e.g., "the fast beat") or a specific metrical location within a succession of regularly spaced pulses (e.g., "the third beat of the measure"), but the former meaning is the primary topic of discussion.

[28] Adjuncts refer to "one or more tracks superimposed either to configurations or to refrains" (Krims 2000, 98). Adjuncts are samples that are added to hip-hop textures to provide color or punctuations and, unlike drum, bass, and harmonic layers, tend not to occur in regular patterns.

music: the explicit beat layer, the functional bass layer, the melodic layer, and the harmonic filler layer (2012, 20–21). Moore's focus is pop-rock music, but his taxonomy is applicable to a great deal of rap music as well, so much so that Duinker and Martin used it as the basis for their own categorization of beat layers for analyzing their corpus of rap songs.[29] As Duinker and Martin explain, "In hip-hop music, these four layers are normally present in some combination, but where the melodic layer in other popular genres might be occupied by a singing voice, in hip-hop this does not always occur. Therefore, the melodic layer was defined purely by melodic instruments, reserving the analysis of vocals for a separate parameter category" (2017, 84). To account for hip-hop's idiosyncratic sampling and beat production practices, Duinker and Martin add a fifth beat layer "to account for any sound effects that do not fit into Moore's four categories" (ibid.); this layer type is simply called sound effects.

While the modification of Moore's layering scheme theoretically provides good traction for the analysis of hip-hop, Duinker and Martin's application of the sound effects layer category is worth considering closely. Example 1.7a reproduces their Figure 3, a transcription of the beat from Dr. Dre and Snoop Dogg's "Nuthin' But a G Thang" with each layer labeled using the five layer scheme. The sound effect layer consists of synthesizer punctuations emphasizing beat two in each bar of the two-measure loop. These backbeat stabs may be less integral to the texture than, say, the chords in Duinker and Martin's harmonic filler layer, but they do participate in the harmonic oscillation of the loop. Example 1.7b simplifies the texture, collapsing the B and A of the sound effect layer into the chord progression, and provides an interpretation of the harmonies via Roman numerals.[30] The B is a chord tone in the initial minor tonic harmony. During the second chord, no

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[29] Adams's description of the basic elements of the beat in "Sofa King" by Danger Doom (2005) also very closely reflects Moore's scheme: "In 'Sofa King,' we can identify the fundamental configuration as: (1) the melodic figure in mm. 1–2, initially played by the violin; (2) the bass line 1–4–2–5; (3) the harmonic progression i–iv–II$^7$–V; and (4) a backbeat rhythm in the drums" (2018, §2.8).

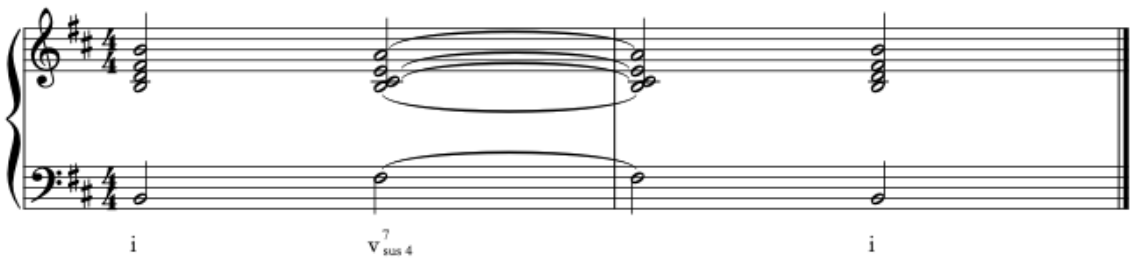
[30] These are the same Roman numerals Duinker and Martin decided upon.

leading tone (A♯) is heard throughout the texture; rather, the melodic layer passes through A♮, the subtonic.[31] The second chord of the loop can thus be understood as a minor or modal dominant, a common harmony that leads back to tonic in popular music, making the sound effect

**Example 1.7:** Transcription and analyses of main beat from Dr. Dre and Snoop Dogg's "Nuthin' But a G Thang" (1992)

a. Figure 3 from Duinker and Martin (2017): transcription of beat with layering scheme based on Moore (2012)

b. Reduction of beat's harmonic progression




[31] The subtonic scale degree is heard rather than the leading tone both in the melodic phrase transcribed in Example 1.7a and in the other famous melody heard first at 0:04. See Kajikawa (2015, 105) for a transcription and discussion of both melodies.

layer's A♮ a chord tone as well. The backbeat stabs are perhaps the most sound-effect-like thing in the texture of "Nuthin' But a G Thang," but that does not mean they are sound effects. I propose that the sound effects layer be thought of more like a catchall category for elements that do not fit well into any of the others. They can include sampled vocal exclamations or non-musical sounds like police sirens and occur less regularly than the other layers. In these ways they align most closely with what Krims called adjuncts. A clear example of a sound effect along these lines is the scream heard from 2:07–10 in the Beastie Boys's "Egg Man" (1989). This tweak of Duinker and Martin's layering classification system does not smooth over all problems,[32] but it provides a useful framework for analyzing a satisfactorily large number of beats from the hip-hop repertoire.

The explicit beat layer—usually featuring alternation between bass drum on beats one and three and snare drum on beats two and four—is the only element of this classification scheme that is sure to engender a surprised response from listeners if missing from the texture. Probably the second most common layer throughout hip-hop's history is the functional bass layer.[33] Beyond that, production practices are so widely varied in hip-hop from artist to artist, region to region, and year to year that it is difficult to posit a normal textural state for beats during verses. Classic East Coast rap in the style of the Bomb Squad and Public Enemy tends to feature noisy beats in which sound effects are more common while West Coast gangsta rap à la Dr. Dre's *The Chronic* (1992) foregrounds melodic layers (Kajikawa 2015, 103–4). Because verse beats do not demonstrate widely generalizable internal characteristics, we have to depend on relational aspects to understand how

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[32] For example, should non-musical sounds that recur regularly be considered part of the sound effect or the explicit beat layer? I would tend to say the latter in order to emphasize the function of the sound (i.e., participating in keeping time with the drums) instead of its sonic quality.

[33] In some sub-genres of rap, the term "functional" in this category might be questionable. One of the characteristic features of trap (and trap-influenced mainstream rap, which has become extremely popular in the 2010s), for example, is a deep, rumbling bass whose pitch can be hard to identify. The point of the bass in trap is probably less about supporting harmonic progressions or even harmonic pedals and more about filling out the low end of the frequency spectrum, providing listeners with a unique, dark feeling.

beats help to signify verse function. One such relational characteristic is of primary importance: beats tend to go through more textural fluctuation in verses than they do in hooks.

Textural fluctuation—the addition and/or subtraction of layers in the beat—is used to achieve one of two goals: to create a sense of direction or even teleology over the course of a verse or to punctuate moments of beginning or closure. An example of the latter goal, creating beginning and ending punctuations, is given in Example 1.8, a passage from A Tribe Called Quest's "Buggin' Out."[34] Throughout most of the song, the beat simply consists of an explicit beat layer and a functional bass layer, the textural state in the first three measures of Example 1.8. As Q-Tip starts the second line of a rhymed couplet ("listen to the mission…"), the drums drop out and the bass is the only instrument heard. The textural fluctuation is made more dramatic in this case because the bass is softer in the mix than the drums and harder to hear in the first place because of its low register. Not only does the textural fluctuation align with the second bar of a rhymed couplet, it also coincides with the fourth bar of a hypermeasure initiated by the cymbal crash noted in the musical example over the word "best."[35] The return of the full beat on the downbeat of the next measure ("as I crack the…") is made to feel like a very strong beginning because the two-measure loop has repeated so many times thus far in the track that a listener may have come to expect it to recur over that period. The dropping out of the beat threatened the expectation that the loop would repeat on schedule and so its return is satisfying and, again, made to feel like a strong new beginning. The result is that two relatively small hierarchical units of the verse have been punctuated by a textural

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[34] Adams (2020) and Duinker (2021b) have recently offered theories of phrase and segmentation in hip-hop, privileging the beat layer and the flow layer, respectively, in the perception of phrases/segments. The present discussion is not meant to advance a theory of phrase and only minimally presents a framework for what constitutes a segment in rap. Indeed, I remain agnostic for the moment as to whether a beat or flow more strongly influences the perception of phrase. The musical objects that are punctuated by textural fluctuation in this discussion are basically rhymed couplets and two- and four-bar hypermeasures.

[35] That a four-bar hypermeasure begins here is also a justifiable interpretation because the word "best" aligns with the start of the fifth bar of Q-Tip's verse. The entry of a new rapper suggests a new hypermeasure and the "best" measure is the start of that rapper's second four-bar hypermeasure.

**Example 1.8:** Textural fluctuation as punctuation in A Tribe Called Quest's "Buggin' Out" (1991), 1:03–15

fluctuation in the beat. Although this type of fluctuation subverts hip-hop norms, within "Buggin' Out," it is normalized by its appearance in three out of four verses. Another small-scale segment is created by shorter disappearances of the drums during the third verse on Phife Dawg's words "action" and "satisfaction." Example 1.9 provides a number of other examples of similar types of textural fluctuation within verses. Although all of the examples given feature beats that thin out at the end of small units, this is not the only textural fluctuation that can add punctuation to verses. Beats sometimes become more active or have slightly thicker textures at similar formal junctions. One notable instance of textural fluctuation between verses in "Buggin' Out" is the addition of a ride cymbal to the beat only during Q-Tip's verses. Both the case of the beat-thinning and the beat-

**Example 1.9:** Examples of textural fluctuation (thinning) punctuating endings in rap verses

| Song | Artist | Time Stamps | Comments |
|---|---|---|---|
| "Buggin' Out" | A Tribe Called Quest | 0:26–28, 1:02–03, 1:55–58, 2:50–53, 2:59–3:03 | |
| "I Know You Got Soul" | Erik B. & Rakim | 0:24–27, 2:52–55 | Many two- and four-bar segments in this song are punctuated by textural intensifications in the form of a drum fill |
| "Express Yourself" (1988) | N.W.A. | 0:45–50 | Beat drops out for two measures, which is the length of one entire cycle through the looped groove in this case; Dr. Dre's lyrics during this passage include "Even if [DJ] Yella makes it *a capella*" |
| "C.R.E.A.M." (1993) | Wu-Tang Clan | 1:17–20 | |
| "Fuck Tha Police" | N.W.A. | 0:34–36, 0:58–1:00, 1:27–30, 1:46–49, 2:25–28, 2:35–38, 2:54–57, 3:14–17, 3:33–36, 4:17–19, 5:01–03 | |
| "Gangsta Gangsta" | N.W.A. | 0:48–51, 0:59–1:01, 1:08–10, 1:47–49, 2:07–09, 2:26–29, 3:05–08, 3:15–17, 3:44–46, 4:24–26, 4:34–36, 4:43–46 | Some, but not all, of these beat dropouts end with a drum fill leading to the next downbeat |
| "Ladies First" (1989) | Queen Latifah feat. Monie Love | 0:25–27 | The beat completely drops out for most of the fourth bar of a hypermeasure; a short drum fill breaks the silence and serves as a pickup to the next measure |
| "Hard Piano" (2018) | Pusha T | 0:27–29 | |

intensifying fluctuation techniques are reminiscent of the live funk and jazz drumming practice of adding fills at the end of four-bar hypermeasures or other small-scale units.[36]

Another aspect of beats crucial to their musical construction that was understudied until very recently is harmony. Numerous authors have analyzed harmonic phenomena in rap music but tend to show a slight hesitancy toward diving fully into this parameter for a number of reasons.[37] One is that most of the tools theorists have for harmonic analysis are rooted in the tradition of European common practice era music. The ethical issue of colonialism thus manifests itself when one begins to study harmony in hip-hop. Another problem is that harmony is simply not considered the most important parameter in hip-hop. For most artists, scholars, and fans, flow and its rhythms, rhymes, accents, and meanings have been and remain paramount. Additionally, most hip-hop songs consist largely of unchanging loops, preventing harmony from creating any sense of tension and release beyond very local levels. Hip-hop's repetitive chord patterns were a source of criticism in the music's early days, even giving some critics fodder for dismissing it as not music at all. In a review of a 1981 performance by the Sugar Hill Gang, Grandmaster Flash and the Furious Five, and the Funky 4 Plus 1, Robert Palmer wrote, "basically, the Funky 4 Plus 1 provide a kind of rhythm noise. Melody and harmony have no place in their music, which rides on an irrestible [sic] dance beat and various cross rhythms" (1981). Palmer's account is sympathetic relative to many early reactions to rap, yet he still emphasizes that pitch-based parameters play no role. Finally, the very notion of what harmony is in hip-hop presents serious challenges that have not yet been addressed. Hip-hop producers are concerned with creating musical products that are interesting and aesthetically pleasing to them, their friends and co-artists, and their fans, and this sometimes means piling up layers that create what theorists of common practice era music would call a highly dissonant environment.

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[36] Duinker notes that drum fills can suggest hypermetric boundaries, as in "the beat for 'I Know You Got Soul' (Eric B and Rakim, 1987)" (2021b, 19).

[37] Temperley (2018, 256), for instance, analyzes the second harmony in the beat to Usher's "Yeah!" (2004) as "♭VI?," suggesting a degree of caution in unequivocally identifying the chord.

Gangsta rap—especially music produced by the Bomb Squad—very often features "radically dissonant pitch combinations" that Krims argues contributes to a musical aesthetic of "hardness" (2000, 72). Producers have also shown that they are not beholden to the twelve-tone equal-tempered tuning system.[38] Are we to include, for example, the wailing trumpet that slides through several half steps in Public Enemy's "Rebel Without A Pause" (1988) in a harmonic analysis? It is even unclear which layers should be analyzed as part of the harmony in consonant environments, as the above discussion of "Nuthin' But a G Thang" shows.

Despite—and perhaps because of—these problems, harmony is still worth studying in hip-hop. No musical theory can claim to artistically validate the repertoire that it addresses, and the present study is no different. It is sometimes difficult to separate harmonic analysis from the ideological residue of hegemonic notions of organicism and coherence leftover from the Austro-German Romantic movement. This is a crucial history to remain aware of because traditional tools of harmonic analysis like Roman numerals still have much to offer in aiding intersubjective dialogue about hip-hop despite the cultural baggage they carry with them. Claiming an analysis using these tools proves a song's artistic worthiness or constitutes an explanation of what "the artist was really thinking" crosses an ethical boundary by devaluing the perspectives of the actual artists and evaluating rap on musical grounds that were never important to most hip-hop musicians in the first place. But harmony *is* an important part of hearing and understanding hip-hop. The vast majority of the pitch-based material heard in hip-hop songs fits within the twelve-tone equal temperament tuning system and many of the musical genres that serve as source material for hip-hop's samples like jazz, rock, and funk have histories of cross-influence with classical harmony. Plus, many hip-hop

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[38] Krims specifically notes that many of the layers in gangsta rap exist outside the realm of twelve-tone equal temperament: "The hip-hop sublime is a product of dense combinations of musical layers. All of them reinforce the four-beat meter, but in the domain of pitch they comprise a sharply dissonant combination, even by the standards of jazz, or soul, harmony. In fact, layers tend not even to be 'in tune,' so to speak: they are separated by intervals that can only be measured in terms of fractions of well-tempered semitones" (2000, 73).

artists participated in public school and college music programs or have collaborated with jazz, rock, funk, or even classical musicians during their careers, making it completely reasonable to think that some of them have training in or knowledge of traditional music theory. In light of all this, the following discussion adopts Kyle Adams's recent treatment of harmony in hip-hop beats—which uses the vocabulary of diatonic harmonic theory including Roman numerals—in an effort to outline some of the music's most common patterns.

Adams (2020) identifies three aspects of beats as regards their "pitched elements," i.e., harmonic content, that most prominently influence the perception of phrase: length, number of harmonies, and directionality. The present discussion will take up the first two of these parameters. Unsurprisingly, Adams posits that "loops of one, two, or four measures" are most common (2020, §2.6). In terms of the number of harmonies, there are three usual types of beats: repetitive, oscillating, and expansional beats. Repetitive beats contain just one harmony, as represented in Example 1.10a.[39] Such beats can be thought of as being based on a harmonic pedal, a static expression of a single chord or, more rarely, a single note that merely implies a chord. Oscillating beats "alternate between two different bass notes or harmonies, whose roots will necessarily either be a second, third, or fourth apart" (§2.11); three iterations of oscillating beats are shown in Examples 1.10b–c.[40] This beat type is very similar to what Philip Tagg calls a chord shuttle, an "oscillation between two chords" (2014, 482), in his study of pop-rock tonality. Unlike Adams, Tagg includes under the umbrella of chord shuttles vamps that have subordinate harmonies, in a Schenkerian sense, whose function is to embellish the section's single harmony. Adams's analyses

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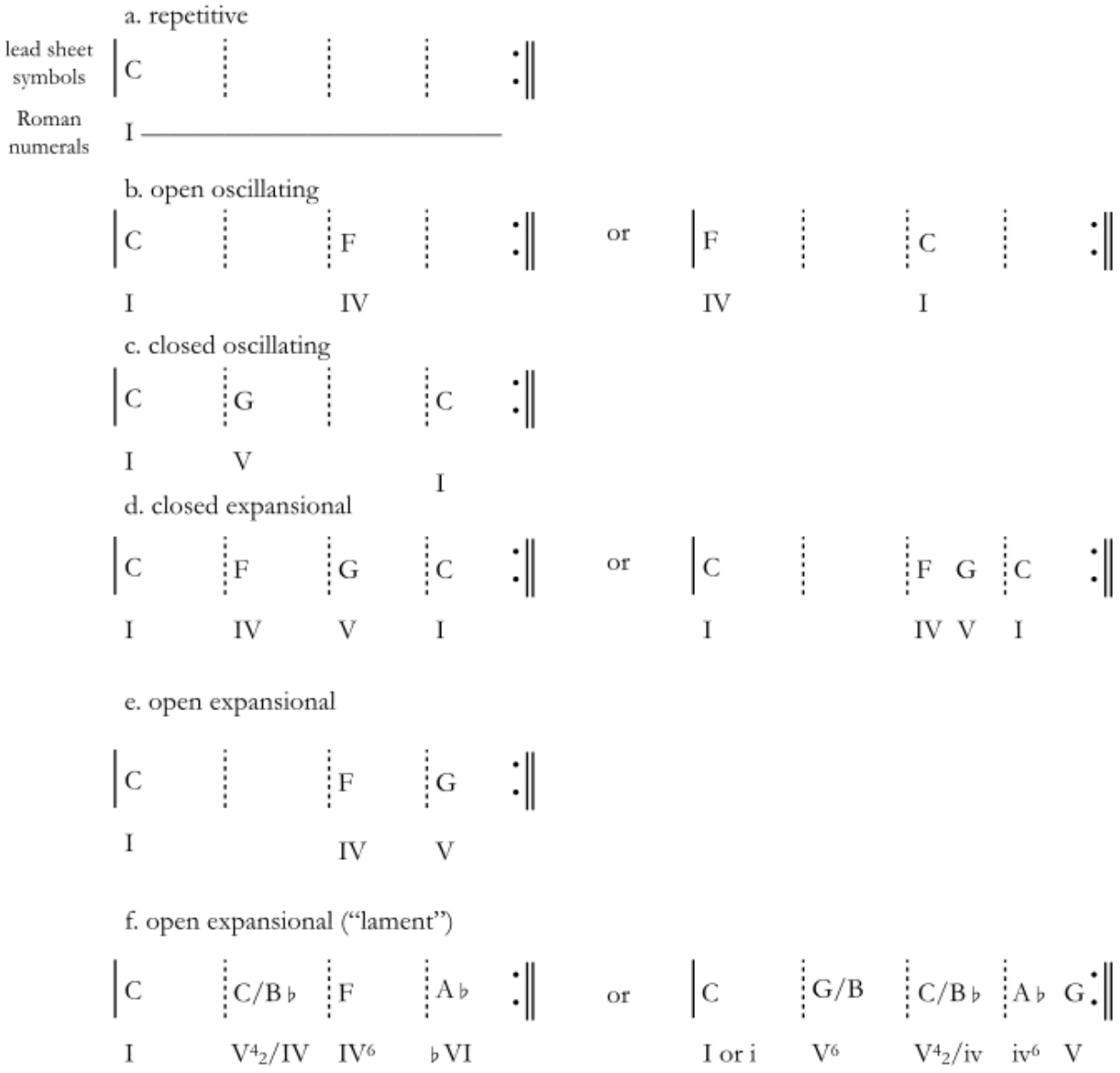
[39] The dotted barlines throughout Example 1.10 represent generic metrical locations, not necessarily barlines per se. Example 1.10a is meant to show that a repetitive beat may repeat every measure (in which case the dotted barlines represent beats), two measures (each dotted barline is a half note), or four measures (each dotted barline is an actual barline).

[40] Adams makes a distinction between two-chord beats and many-chord (expansional) beats because the former seems to be a special and particularly common format, a point that I wholeheartedly agree with. In my own listening and study of hip-hop music, I have found dozens of songs with oscillating loops; Adams offers an additional five songs that were not part of my list before I encountered his article.

indicate that not every single chord in a beat necessarily needs to be counted in a tally, but Tagg's "one-chord shuttles" would likely be included within Adams's repetitive beat category.[41]

Although hip-hop producers have used a wide variety of harmonies to bounce back and forth between in oscillating beats, one of the most common is the plagal progression I–IV (i–iv in minor);

**Example 1.10:** Generic harmonic schemas in hip-hop beats after Adams (2020)




[41] Nobile (2020, 14–17) offers a more detailed discussion of chord shuttles from a neo-Schenkerian perspective.

sometimes the perceived tonic chord comes second (i.e., IV–I or iv–i).[42] Examples include De La Soul's "The Magic Number" (1989), Gang Starr's "Just To Get A Rep" (1991), A Tribe Called Quest's "Check the Rhime," Dr. Dre's "Xxxplosive" and "Bang Bang" (1999), the former features the iv chord first rather than the tonic), and Sean Price's "Lord Have Mercy" (2017), not to mention two of the oscillating beats presented by Adams. Note that in Example 1.10c, there are two unique harmonies but actually three total chords per loop. I refer to this as an oscillating beat type because the effect of the harmonies is the same back and forth of a two-chord progression. This closed oscillating beat is a rotation of the open oscillating beat—each chord has been shifted one metrical location earlier.

Finally, expansional beats feature more than two harmonies (Examples 1.10d–f). This beat type is hardest to model because of the higher number of possible harmonies and chord orderings. Although hip-hop beats can and do contain any number of harmonies, it seems that three or four are the most common numbers if they have more than two. Three of Adams's four initial examples of expansional beats have four chords. This may be a result of producers' desire to create a sense of variety and direction in one-, two-, and four-measure beats without distracting from the main act, the rapper, by creating too busy a chord progression. Additionally, the simplest way to create a functional harmonic circuit—"a complete statement of the syntactical functions T–PD–D–T" (Nobile 2016, 158 quoted in Adams 2020, §2.16)—is to use one chord for each function. There will be four chords in a beat whose circuit is completed and three chords in one that ends on dominant function (or gives an illusion of being completed via the return to tonic upon its repeat). Many open expansional beat types common to a number of hip-hop songs contain bass lines that resemble the common practice era's lament bass in that the functional bass layer descends from $\hat{1}$ through one or more chromatic pitches and ends on $\hat{5}$, as in the hooks to Kanye West's "Stronger" (2007). A variant

[42] Tagg (2014, 375–77) expands on the commonness of plagal shuttles in pop-rock music.

is to end the progression on $\hat{6}$ or $\flat\hat{6}$ before snapping back to $\hat{1}$; the verse beat from Eminem's "Drug Ballad" (2000) cycles through the bass notes $|\hat{1}\ |\hat{7}\ |\flat\hat{7}\ |\hat{6}\ :||$ harmonized by |i |$V^6$ |$V^4{}_2$/IV |$IV^6$ :||. The bass line patterns are more consistent than the harmonizations that take place above the bass in these beats, thus the two schemas shown in Example 1.10f show just two possible manifestations of the lament expansional beat.[43]

Harmonic activity in beats can be further understood in terms of whether the loop ends stably or unstably, closed or open, on-tonic or off-tonic. This distinction is invoked by Adams, who observes that open progressions "seem, by far, to be the majority of expansional beats in hip-hop" (2020, §2.17). Closed beats in hip-hop are not precluded from creating momentum back toward their own beginnings through musical parameters like flow, drums fills, textural fluctuation, or melodic elements, but the harmonies alone do not suggest repetition. Open beats more strongly lead back to their own beginning, especially if the first chord in the loop was tonic. Can repetitive and oscillating beats be categorizes as open or closed? It might seem like an obvious and even redundant statement to say that repetitive beats are harmonically closed. Indeed this is almost always true: repetitive beats are the epitome of stability, never even creating the possibility of an open ending because they remain on a single harmony for their entirety. But one can imagine a repetitive beat whose single chord does not express tonic function but rather, for example, dominant function. In this case, we would be dealing with what Mark Spicer has called an absent tonic in the context of rock music (2017). The only example of an absent tonic I am aware of in hip-hop is in Hieroglyphics' "Classic" (2003), in which a clear V harmony in the sample source (the third movement of Franz Joseph Haydn's trumpet concerto) is looped for the entirety of the beat.[44] Oscillating beats are most often harmonically open. This is true for most of the examples of oscillating beats mentioned above

[43] Other examples of the lament beat ending on include Snoop Dogg's "Who Am I (What's My Name?)" (1993), Chance the Rapper's "14,400 Minutes" (2012) and A Boogie Wit da Hoodie's "Drowning" (2017). A lament bass ending on $\flat\hat{6}$ can be heard in 2Pac's "Tradin War Stories" (1996).
[44] Many thanks to Kyle Adams for bringing this interesting song to my attention.

because the final measure of the beat contains the chord that is not tonic. Oscillating beats whose final chord is the tonic chord are closed, which evinces the privilege given to endings in harmonic theory and analysis.

A related way of categorizing hip-hop beats can be taken from Tim Hughes's distinction between autotelic and exotelic grooves. In his analysis of Stevie Wonder's "Living for the City," Hughes notes that the opening two-measure groove (reproduce in Example 1.11) "progresses

**Example 1.11:** Primary groove from Stevie Wonder's "Living for the City"

strongly toward *its own beginning*. As a result, it is well-suited for extensive repetition and even implies infinite repetition, like a figure eight or the Midgard Serpent swallowing its own tail" (2008, 242). This groove is autotelic because it suggests its own repetition in three ways: harmonically, rhythmically, and registrally. The downbeat of the first measure is the most harmonically stable. The right hand chord changes become slightly more dissonant relative to the static bass with a passing G♯ minor triad and an A major triad. The return of the root-position F♯ major chord at the (re)start of the groove makes its beginning feel like a point of arrival. Similarly, the right hand is rhythmically in phase with the left hand at the downbeat of the first measure, but the two are syncopated from the latter part of the first bar until the second beat of the second bar. Finally, the pitch height of the right hand's top voice (F♯4) has registral gravity. As rhythmic misalignment and harmonic instability

increases over the course of the first measure, so the top voice ascends registrally; as the syncopation ends and the passing G♯ minor chord returns on the progression's way back to F♯ major, the top voice descends.

Some harmonically open beats—especially of the expansional variety—may be additionally described as autotelic. When a loop begins on tonic and ends on some other harmony, the return to stability upon its repetition imbues the final chord with a sense of tension. This tension heightens the expectation that the loop will snap back and restart. But Hughes is clear to describe the autotelic/exotelic dichotomy in terms of multiple musical parameters, not just harmony. A harmonically repetitive beat may be exotelic, i.e., it may *not* suggest its own beginning, because the lack of harmonic motion away from stability obviates the need for a restart.[45] However, another layer of the beat may suggest an autotelic interpretation. For example, if the melodic layer of a two-measure beat has a descending scale ($\hat{5}$–$\hat{4}$–$\hat{3}$–$\hat{2}$) in the last four eighth notes of the second measure, an arrival on $\hat{1}$ on the downbeat of the next measure is strongly implied. If the melodic layer delivers $\hat{1}$ at this metric location on any repetition of the loop, then it is at least somewhat autotelic. The same quality can be achieved by rhythmic elements like a drum fill leading to a cymbal crash on the first downbeat of a loop.

Because beats in hip-hop are most often repeated throughout the entirety of a song's core formal sequence (a string of verses or a series of verse-hook alternations), the above description of harmony in verses can generally be said to apply to hooks as well. Covach's term for rock songs containing the same harmonic progression in the verses and the choruses, "simple verse-chorus form," is thus applicable to a great deal of the hip-hop corpus (2005, 73). Much more will be said regarding the relationship between verses and hooks below in this chapter and in Chapter 2, but for now, this observation serves as a reminder that Adams's typology of harmonic progressions and the schemas in Example 1.10 do not just apply to verses.

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[45] "Repetitive" is here used in the sense outlined by Adams (2020) and in the above discussion.

## Hooks

### *Untangling Terminology*

In a pop-rock song that begins with a verse, a chorus is likely to occur after some period of time. This expectation is conditioned to some degree by chronology and genre. Songs from rock's early history (roughly before 1960) and those written in the folk tradition often feature verse-ending refrains within strophic verse forms like the 12-bar blues and no chorus. But the vast majority of rock and roll, R&B, punk, and modern country songs are structured on verse-chorus cycles, or what Temperley calls a verse-chorus unit (2018, 155). There are formal units in hip-hop that parallel the pop-rock chorus in their alternation with verses, but they demonstrate three key differentiating characteristics. First, these sections are usually not focal in hip-hop, verses are. Second, most if not all elements of the beat heard in the verse usually remain the same upon arrival of these sections, making their perception and analytical identification much more dependent on the lyrics, rhythms, timbres, and pitches of any vocals present as well as more subtle changes in texture. And third, there is far less agreement on what these sections should be called. Hip-hop artists, critics, and fans alike for the most part use the terms "hook" and "chorus" interchangeably. This situation is evinced by numerous online sources that present beginner guides to the hip-hop songwriting process:

- Cole Mize's website *How to Rap*—"The hook aka the chorus is typically the busiest part of the song"[46]
- Flocabulary.com—"Nearly every rap song consists of three basic parts: intros, hooks (choruses) and verses"[47]
- Rhymemakers.com—A section header is titled "The Chorus Or Rap Hook"[48]

Scholarly publications have also used these terms interchangeably, as the following sampling shows:

- Edwards (2009, 187)—A section header is given as "Choruses (Hooks)" and contains the following: "Choruses are short sets of lyrics that are repeated more than once in a song. They're also known as *hooks*, because they're designed to 'hook' the listeners and to stay in their heads."

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[46] https://colemizestudios.com/how-to-rap-song-structure/.
[47] https://www.flocabulary.com/warp/hip-hop-songwriting/.
[48] https://rhymemakers.com/rap-song-structure/.

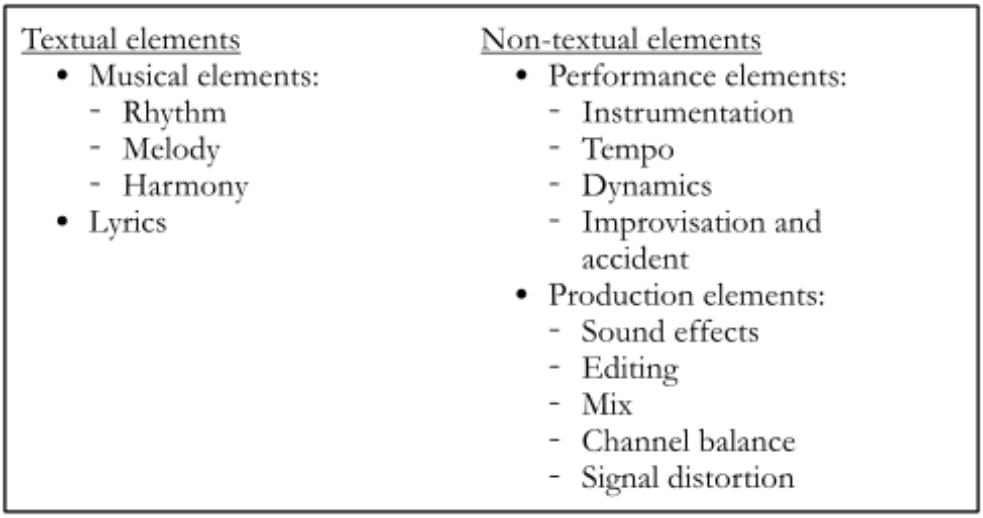
- Berry (2018, 3)—"The chorus or hook of a song is typically what listeners remember, what they find themselves singing or reciting after the song is over…"

This section reviews other uses of these terms in an effort to show that there exist some generalizable differences between them and in order to argue for keeping them distinct in theoretical and analytical practice.

Unlike the descriptions of hooks listed above, Gary Burns formulates hooks primarily in terms of what the word means itself: "The word 'hook' connotes being caught or trapped, as when a fish is hooked, and also addiction, as when one is hooked on a drug" (1987, 1). Any element of a pop song that affects a listener in this way can thus be considered a hook. In one sense, hooks for Burns are remarkable in that they are unshakeable, such a powerful part of a song that a listener can not help but be drawn in and possibly spend the rest of the day with the hook or hooks stuck in their head. On the other hand, Burns construes hooks as utterly normal because any element of a song—big or small—can amount to a hook and because there can be many hooks in one song. Example 1.12 reproduces Burns' summary of the elements of music manipulated by popular artists "through use of repetition, variation and modulation to produce hooks" (2).[49] Textual elements include those aspects of a song that are unchanged from performance to performance. Rhythm, melody, harmony, and lyrics are textual in the sense that they contribute to the identity of a song as a musical text. Slight or even significant variations can occur in non-textual elements between live performances or different versions of a song, yet the song retains its identity if the textual aspects remain intact. The differences between each version of a song come from changes in Burns' non-textual elements. For example, most musicians would not reproduce dynamics with exact precision from performance to performance, but differences in dynamics between performances would hardly

[49] Burns uses the term "modulation" as a diametric opposite to "repetition," rather than in the more common musical sense of the word that refers to a key change. Repetition is stasis; its opposite, major change, is modulation.

**Example 1.12:** Burns' organization of structural elements used for hooks in popular music



Textual elements
- Musical elements:
  - Rhythm
  - Melody
  - Harmony
- Lyrics

Non-textual elements
- Performance elements:
  - Instrumentation
  - Tempo
  - Dynamics
  - Improvisation and accident
- Production elements:
  - Sound effects
  - Editing
  - Mix
  - Channel balance
  - Signal distortion

come close to making a song unrecognizable. Whereas the composer or songwriter controls textual elements, performers and producers determine non-textual elements (sometimes intentionally, sometimes not).

As the list of hook types sketched in Example 1.12 suggests, just about any aspect of a song can be a hook in Burns' theory. How is one to distinguish hooks from non-hooks given this broad formulation? Even though it is probably impossible to draw a distinct line between these two types of musical entities, a musical element's memorability and distinctiveness are of utmost importance. Given the broadness of this definition of a hook, Burns likely understands popular songs as consisting of a tapestry of hooks, and would probably argue that a higher quantity of hooks exist in a given song than most analysts. Although I do not embrace Burns' all-encompassing view of hooks, his argument sets into relief an important way of understanding hooks that will shape the theory and analyses that follow, i.e., *hook-as-function* instead of *hook-as-section*. Put another way, the word hook can be used as an adjective or a noun. In its adjectival sense, I agree with Burns that almost any element of a song can have hook function. For instance, catchy guitar riffs are commonly used at the beginning of rock songs. Numerous of these (Burns cites "Sunshine of Your Love" by Cream;

another example is Deep Purple's "Smoke on the Water") undoubtedly have hook function because they are so memorable and usually repeated many times, adding to their aural infectiousness. While these types of musical elements are hook-like and can be reasonably referred to as hooks, *the* hook of a hip-hop song has a special meaning that will be reserved in this dissertation to refer to a memorable *section*. A hook section has hook function and can consist of riffs, rhythms, lyrical refrains, etc. that have hook function themselves. Indeed, the hook is often made up of hooks.

The most common observable difference between how "hook" and "chorus" have been used is that the former is more closely linked to words and the latter with denoting a formal unit. In *Listening to Rap*, for instance, Berry describes the passage from 1:39–2:00 in Eminem's "Lose Yourself" (2002) as follows: "Hook—The music in the chorus is strengthened with the addition of the synthesizer playing on strong beats (1 & 3). The hook consists of four lines of text repeated once" (2018, 4). The use of the word "chorus" refers to the section because of the preposition "in," which implies that the chorus is a space. Further, the point of that sentence is to highlight the overall increase in intensity that takes place starting at 1:39, a boundary line between the chorus (one section) and another section that precedes that time point. The word "hook," on the other hand, is explicitly described in terms of textual content. Covach uses "hook" to refer to the combination of a specific set of lyrics and a harmonic progression in the Ronettes' "Be My Baby" (1963): "the variously repeated 'be my baby' lyrics set to the conventional I–vi–IV–V harmonic pattern combine to form the song's 'hook'—that part of a song meant to catch the ear of the listener" (2005, 71). The chorus and the hook are identical in this analysis. But while Covach's general definition of a hook—"that part of a song meant to catch the ear of the listener"—could theoretically be applied to any memorable section, it does seem that he is most concerned with the lyrics for creating something that gets stuck in listeners' heads. The doo-wop progression used in the chorus of "Be My Baby" is catchy but also not special given how common of a progression it was in the 1950s and 60s. In discussing the characteristics of dance choruses, a term coined by Alyssa Barna (2020), Kyle

Adams notes "they contain fewer lyrics, repeating most prominently the hook and/or the titular lyric" (2019, 36). In this use of the term, a hook refers fairly explicitly to a short phrase of text.

In contrast to these words-based understandings of hooks, Ben Duinker and Denis Martin offer section-based definitions, an approach that the present theory of form will ultimately align itself with. In Duinker and Martin (2017), a hook is presented as a section type with three subcategories: refrain hooks, extended refrain hooks, and chorus hooks. A refrain hook is the least substantial and the one that is most text-based. It verges on not being a section at all given that the authors' definition resembles a description of a verse-ending refrain: "a brief, recurring lyrical entity that typically appears at the end of a verse" (85). Extended refrains are "largely similar to the refrain [hook] but with more substantial lyrics." Finally, a chorus hook, "the most substantially lyrical and autonomous hook type," is the most similar to a pop-rock chorus. A common but not necessary feature of this hook type is sung vocals. The example given by Duinker and Martin for this category is the hook from "Shook Ones Pt. II" by Mobb Deep (1995), which features rapped lyrics. In cases similar to "Shook Ones," the chorus hook is minimally differentiated from verses, at least in terms of the rapping layer. More recently, Duinker (2021a) has offered a more concise theory of hooks as sections. In this article, the primary criteria for identifying a section as a hook is that it "contains intelligible vocals—either sampled, rapped, or sung," and "remains musically and lyrically invariant throughout the song" (7). These are features that I retain in their entirety in my own conception of hooks. Instrumental sections can also take hook-like function, underscoring the flexibility of function that sections other than verses can take on in rap music.

Duinker also gives an explanation for his use of the term hook instead of chorus. Hooks may be parallel to pop-rock choruses but their high "level of lyrical repetition and fragmentation" is extremely rare in genres other than hip-hop. Additionally, the pitch-based changes that take place between the verse and chorus of a pop-rock song—e.g., moving from a harmonic state of tonic prolongation to one of cadential motion—are usually absent in hip-hop hooks. There are instances

where musical characteristics so strongly align with theories of the pop-rock chorus that "hook" feels forced. I include chorus in my typology of sections types to account for such songs. Examples include Eminem's "Lose Yourself" Jay-Z and Alicia Keys's "Empire State of Mind." Chorus is defined here as it is in pop-rock scholarship; while any number of definitions could be cited, Temperley's discussion of twelve aspects that make a section chorus-like is exemplary (2018,158–66).

The distinction between a hook and chorus is useful not only for capturing salient musical differences but also for the sake of avoiding whitewashing hip-hop. Calling a hook section in a hip-hop song a chorus threatens to gloss over the uniqueness of the artistic decision-making that went into the production of the song and the aesthetic preferences rooted in African-American culture underpinning such decisions. A hook is not a hip-hop artist's musically lacking attempt at a chorus. To that end, let us consider some musical characteristics of hip-hop hooks.

*General Characteristics of Hooks*

Example 1.13 shows textural features as well as several musical layers of the first verse and hook of De La Soul's "Me Myself and I." The verse ends with the title lyric, which serves as a verse-ending refrain. Then within the eight-measure hook, the verse-ending refrain is repeated three times with minimal rhythmic variation. Virtually all of the beat's layers present during the verse carry over into the hook: the drums, bass, handclaps, and piano chords all continue to loop. The only part of the verse texture not heard during the hook is a melodic guitar riff that is replaced by the hook's prominent synthesizer layer. Two melodic layers are added to the beat upon the arrival of the hook as well: an infectious synth riff sampled from Funkadelic's "(Not Just) Knee Deep" (1979)—the song that provides most of the beat's source material throughout "Me Myself and I"—first heard during the song's introduction and an additional melodic layer delivered by sampled voices. A great deal of space is left between each statement of the refrain, making lyrical density fairly low in the hook. The effect is a sense of lyrical relief, which is aided by the simplicity of the lyrics (repeating

**Example 1.13:** De La Soul, "Me Myself and I" (1989), first verse and hook (0:10–44)

same words over and over) as if the rapper is taking a break. The general statement "it's just me, myself, and I" also provides a sense of lyrical culmination by summarizing the more specific narrative details as well as the perspective of the rapper given during the verse.[50] Instrumentally, however, it provides a heightened sense of excitement and energy.

"Me Myself and I" is an excellent prototypical example of a hook section and hook function in hip-hop, both in its internal characteristics and in its relationship to the song's verses. As stated above, the characteristic internal feature of a hip-hop hook is a high degree of lyrical repetition. This means that a hook (a section and a function) usually contains a repeated refrain (a short repeated phrase of text, a subsection) that can double as a verse-ending refrain, one of the most common strategies hip-hop artists have employed for tying together verses and hooks.[51] During the last measure of the verse, the onset of the hook is signaled by the dropping out of the pitched layers as well as the anticipatory drum fill. To describe this type of layering, Krims uses the term "upbeat," defined as "one-measure combinations of tracks that directly precede points of formal articulation" (2000, 98). The length of this hook is also typical. Four- or eight-measure hooks are by far the norm in rap music, and whereas we saw that verses demonstrate a great degree of flexibility in length within a song and across rap's entire corpus, hooks are more consistent in length. The added melodic layers in the ninth measure of Example 1.13 also speak to a normal feature of hooks: the repetition of one or more easily memorable melodic riffs. One can imagine someone listening to "Me Myself and I" and having one of two things stuck in their head the rest of the day: either the titular refrain lyric or the minor pentatonic synth riff prominently featured during the hooks. This is one of the reasons I believe that Duinker observes that instrumental sections sometimes "express hook-like qualities" (2021b). If the hook section to "Me Myself and I" did not

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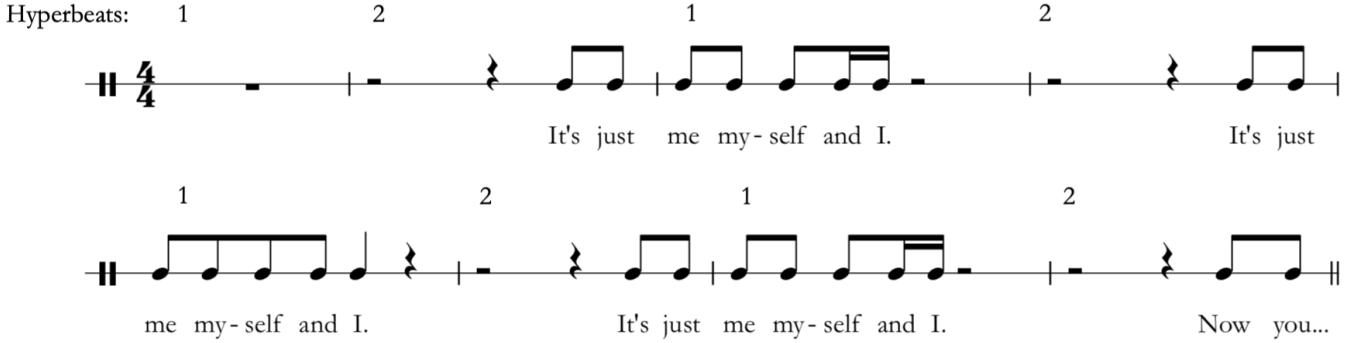
[50] Recorded hook sections may evince the influence of the original roles of an MC, i.e., as hypeman/woman to the DJ. Short vocal exclamations reflect the type of vocal delivery of an MC at a hip-hop block party. In recorded hip-hop, however, a rapping MC has taken the place of a DJ.
[51] Both Jocelyn R. Neal (2007, 45) and Drew Nobile (2020, 59) come close to casting the terms "refrain" and "hook" as synonymous.

contain any lyrics, it would still be hook-like because it retains the function of providing lyrical relief from the verse and contains a highly memorable element, i.e., the infectious synth riff. Here we can see Burns' broad function-based definition of hooks coming into play: Burns would almost surely call the synth riff in hook section of "Me Myself and I" a hook in its own right. This hook section is made all the more hook-like (i.e., its hook function is intensified) because it contains hooks. Finally, because the bulk of the beat carried through from the verse in the hook, there was no harmonic differentiation between the two sections, a regular aspect of hip-hop hooks.

We have observed that hooks are often less lyrically dense than verses, implying that a listener can expect more space in the vocals during the former section. How do rappers use this space? Are there locations we can expect vocals to be heard or not heard within the regular two- and four-bar hypermeasures so regular to rap grooves? In a number of hooks, the lyrics are delivered early in hypermeasures and then followed by a one- to two-measure stretch of silence. Example 1.14

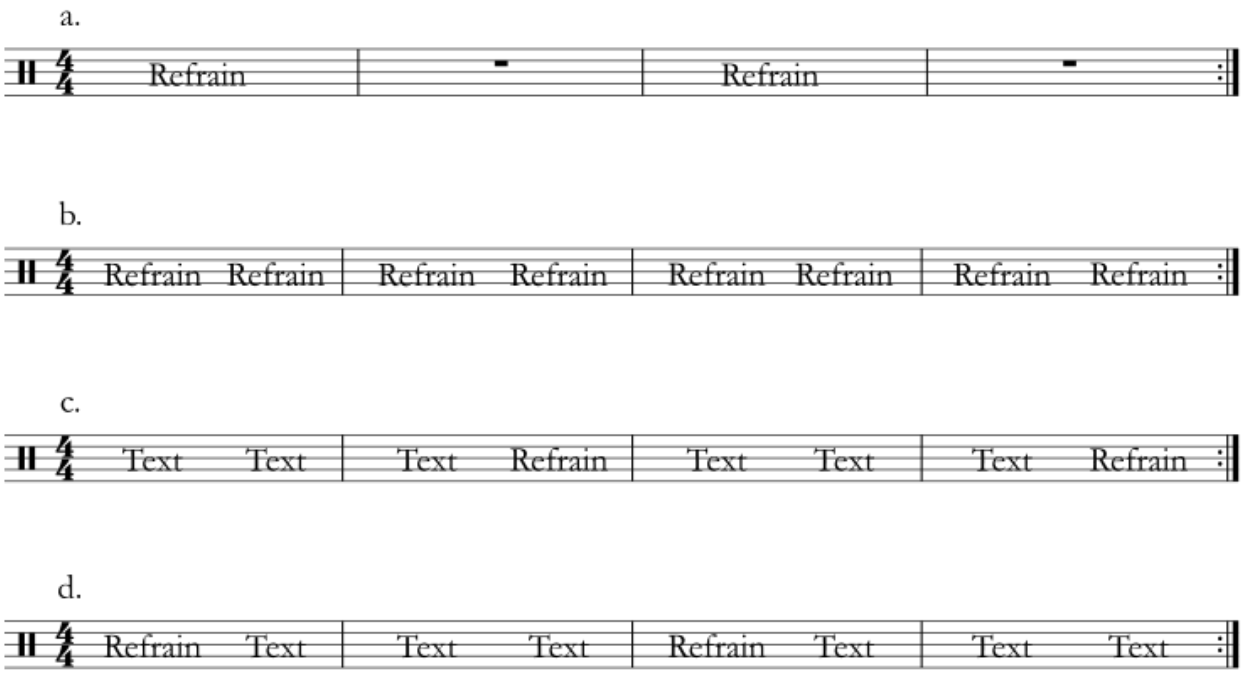
**Example 1.14:** Lyrics and hypermeter in first hook of "Me Myself and I" (0:27–44)




recasts the lyrics of the "Me Myself and I" hook to demonstrate this phenomenon. Each statement of the refrain is contained almost entirely within measures that are hypermetrically strong, i.e., hyperbeat 1s. Even at the level of the measure, the refrain generally aligns with the strong beats because the first accented word of the phrase ("me") coincides with beat one. This metrical placement positions the lyrical focus at the beginning of metrical units, the opposite of the normal

location of lyrical focus during verses. Rhymed words arrive around beat four within measures, and the all-important word that completes a rhymed couplet comes in beat four of the second measure of a two-measure group, a hypermetrically weak position. These rhythmic differences are another musical factor that often provide differentiation between verses and hooks in hip-hop.

**Example 1.15:** Four typical metrical placements and types of lyrics in hooks




The metric placement of the refrain in the hook of "Me Myself and I" is, of course, not the only option, and hip-hop artists have used numerous strategies of phrase rhythm within hooks. Examples 1.15a–d abstract four of the most common formats for lyric-metrical placement within hooks. The first (Example 1.15a) most closely represents the situation in "Me Myself and I." Other examples of this hook format include Public Enemy's "Bring the Noise" (1988) and Clipse's "Grindin'" (2002). Example 1.15b captures a situation in which a refrain (usually a single word) is repeated continuously during the hook. This type of hook takes place in Monie Love's "Monie in the Middle" (1990), A Tribe Called Quest's "Buggin' Out," "Check the Rhime," and "Push It

Along," Souls of Mischief's "93 Til' Infinity" (1993), and most of the hook in Lil' Pump's "Gucci Gang" (2017). Examples 1.15c–d model hooks in which a refrain is present but is not the only text in the section. The refrain either comes at the end (1.15c) or beginning (1.15d) of a pair of lines. A Tribe Called Quest's "Scenario," and Mobb Deep's "Survival of the Fittest" (1995) both reflect 1.15c. Examples of 1.15d include Nas's "Life's a Bitch" feat. AZ and Olu Dara (1994), and Mobb Deep's "Trife Life" (1995).

Another general characteristic of hooks is that they tend to contain more vocal samples, especially samples of full statements of intelligible text, than verses or other sections. An example is Queen Latifah's "Dance For Me" (1989), in which the hook features a vocal sample of the famous title lyric from Sly and The Family Stone's "Dance to the Music" (1968). The topic of the sampled vocals in the hooks is obviously related to the title of the song but does not match the title word for word, a good reminder that refrains (whether they occur in hooks or elsewhere) need not necessarily be the exact title of a song and that songs may contain more than one refrain lyric. As with most sampling in hip-hop, the use of intelligible vocal samples during the hook is an opportunity for artists to participate in the deeply intertextual history of hip-hop and African-American musical culture generally speaking.[52] The use of an R&B anthem following the directive of Queen Latifah's verse-ending refrain ("now dance for me!") adds a cinematic quality to the song by conjuring memories likely held by many listeners of actually dancing in clubs and at block parties to Sly and the Family Stone. The use of sampled vocals in hooks can also allow producers to engage in the African-American tradition of Signifyin(g), Henry Louis Gates Jr.'s (1988) term encapsulating a variety of rhetorical strategies used by black writers and speakers including intertextuality, repetition with variation, irony, wit, and recontextualization, among other techniques.

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[52] For a detailed analysis about how sampling's intertextual nature can take on political significance, see Mark Katz's case study of Public Enemy's "Fight the Power" (2010).

A final musical feature of hooks is that they are the most common section type in rap music where singing (sampled or newly recorded) takes place. Numerous authors including Duinker (2021a, 6) and Berry (2018, 46) have already noted this trait. This aspect of hooks can be cast in both relational and non-relational terms: singing is more common in hooks than in verses, and if we hear singing in a rap song, it is likely we are listening to the hook. To be sure, singing does take place in hip-hop verses, like when Snoop Dogg sings the only statement of the title lyric in his first verse on "Nuthin' But a G Thang." Additionally, Komaniecki (2020) problematizes the notion that vocal pitch (including but not limited to singing) is unimportant to rap music. Komaniecki's analyses all focus on vocal pitch within verses, although his framework could theoretically be applied to any formal section. The vast majority of Komaniecki's musical examples are from the year 2000 or later and Duinker's (2021a) corpus analysis shows that sung hooks have become far more common since the mid-1990s; both of these scholars suggest that singing has generally become a more common feature of rap music (within all formal sections) over time. Yet as a general rule of thumb, it is safe to assume that singing signifies hook function, whether one is listening to 1980s or 2020s hip-hop.

Intros & Outros

*Intros*

The intro in rap music is the formal function whose identity most directly depends on temporal location within the context of an entire song. While a section may contain any number of music features and still be termed an intro, it may *only* be considered as such if it takes place at the beginning of a song. Initial position in a song is then a necessary condition for a span of music to be understood as an intro. Although other sections like verses, hooks, and bridges may have expected locations within the succession of a song's units—e.g., a bridge is extremely unlikely to occur relatively early in a song—temporal ordering is a far less significant factor in identifying them. The only exception to this rule is if a song is divided into two or more large sections that may well be understood as individual songs if the artist hadn't released them as a single track. Examples include

Beastie Boys' "Sounds of Science," Kanye West and Jay-Z's "Ni**as in Paris," and Travis Scott's "Sicko Mode." In such cases, any connecting material between two of the main sections can take on transitional function and also some amount of intro function in that the material introduces the next big part of the song. In both these exceptional cases and in the more normal situation where one and only one section serves as the song's intro, intros are some of the most exciting passages in hip-hop music. Their primary roles are 1) to set up the first verse by heightening anticipation, and 2) to familiarize the listener with what's to come by stating some or all of the musical material that will make up the rest of the song.

Intros are a way of breaking the sonic ice for rappers. They provide MCs with space to clear their throats, hype themselves up (or be hyped up by fellow artists), and familiarize themselves with the beat in improvised settings. Even in strophic songs, which consist of nothing but verses, the very first section of the song is rarely a verse. The time between the onset of a track and the downbeat of a rapper's first verse heightens listeners' sense of anticipation, and the musical activity that takes place during that time is usually structured to intensify that sense. Textural accumulation is the primary compositional technique used to such ends. Mark Spicer (2004) and Robin Attas (2015) have both detailed textural builds at the beginning of songs in the pop-rock repertoire. The accumulative intro is an idea that can be readily applied to hip-hop. Example 1.16 shows the first half-minute of A Tribe Called Quest's "Excursions."[53] The song starts with a syncopated acoustic bass sampled from Art Blakey and the Jazz Messengers' "A Chant for Bu" (1973) accompanied only by the soft bongos present in the source track. Q-Tip begins rapping after four measures, thickening the overall texture and setting up the expectation for further layers to be added. The drums enter at that moment as well, although they are set at an extremely low volume in the mix so as to be virtually inaudible. Finally, we get the full texture with a one-beat pickup to the song's thirteenth

[53] The bass and drum parts are mostly copied from Kyle Adams's transcription of this beat (2020, Example 5a).

**Example 1.16:** Accumulative intro in A Tribe Called Quest, "Excursions" (1991), 0:00–32

measure. Q-Tip's verse has been going for eight measures, and the song itself for an additional four, but the effect of this accumulation is one of marking measure thirteen as the point where the song really starts. The rapper's entrance prior to the presence of the beat's full texture is a common pattern in hip-hop, and one that distinguishes accumulative intros in this genre from those in pop-rock where vocals usually do not enter until most or all layers of an emergent texture have already been presented.

Other than introducing the core beat of a song, intros also often preview content to be featured in sections other than the verses. One way in which hip-hop artists integrate songs into

cohesive wholes is by basing the content of the intro on the hook, which we can refer to as hook-derived intros.[54] In such cases, most of the musical texture of the hooks will be used as the intro, either stated fully from the outset of the song or assembled via accumulation. Crucially, though, one or more of the hook's elements will be missing from the intro—for example a prominent sampled instrumental riff or the hook's refrain lyric. Additionally, a distinction must be made between hook-derived intros and intros that may be described as "the verses minus rapping." Hook-derived intros only refer to situations in which there is a clear musical distinction between the beat of the intro (and hook) and that of the verses, although much may still be shared between them. In "It's a Shame" by Monie Love with True Image (1990), for instance, the second four-bar group of the intro has the exact same beat content as the hooks *except* for two vocal layers: a repeating melody featuring the titular lyric and backing vocals singing "ooh." "It's a Shame" also fulfills the stipulation that the intro/hook beat be notably different than the verse beat: in this case, two guitar layers, one chordal and one riff-based, are heard in the intro and hooks but not the verses. Another way to make a hook-derived intro is to truncate part of the hook, which is precisely what takes place in Jay-Z's "99 Problems." The hook-derived intro is not the default strategy for artists throughout hip-hop's history, but rather an effective and somewhat common way of tying songs together.

Some songs feature intros that are more substantial and may even contain discernible subsections. The intro to Eminem's "Without Me" (2002), for example, can be broken into three sections: 1) a skit in which we hear a brief excerpt from a record by Obie Trice (one of Eminem's protégés) completely unrelated to the rest of the song; 2) Eminem chanting "two trailer park girls go round the outside," an interpolation of similar lyrics from Malcolm McLaren's "Buffalo Gals" (1982); and 3) backup vocalists singing a menacing melody in unison with a saxophone, rhetorically

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[54] This is not meant to imply that hooks are necessarily always created in the production process before intros. Intros are "hook-derived" instead of hooks being "intro-derived" simply because hooks are usually more important formal units. This nomenclature is then based on hierarchy of formal function rather than section order or compositional process.

asking the listeners to "guess who's back." This intro intersects with the "verse minus rapping" intro because the drum beat remains the same as the song leaves the intro and the verse chorus cycles begin; the saxophone is also retained throughout the rest of the song. However, its lyrics and melodic content never return. Additionally, instead of dovetailing into the first core section as in the accumulative intro, this intro ends closed off by virtue of a sustained tonic pitch played by an organ that follows an ascending harmonic minor scale. Despite these unique features, the intro to "Without Me" still serves to prepare the rest of the song. It sets the stage for one of Eminem's most braggadocious tracks by hyping up Slim Shady to a typically absurd degree. The unique grandiosity of this intro fits Eminem's over-the-top aesthetic perfectly.

*Outros*

Outro function is strongly expressed by temporal location within a song, by multiple repetitions of a hook, and by fade-outs. Imagine, for example, a song with a hook that lasts eight measures upon its first two appearances. If, at the third time through the verse-hook cycle, the hook repeats, the expectation that the section will continue to repeat and move to a fade is heightened. Because we never hear the beat stop looping in a vamp-to-fade ending, the impression is created that the song never ends, or, as Drew Nobile puts it, "the party goes on forever" (2020, 121). Hip-hop artists rarely focus on creating a sense of complete closure at the end of songs, an artistic preference once again related to the original live-party format in which keeping the dancing going was the main goal. Of course, many songs do end in a truer sense of the word, most often by simply cutting the entire texture off or "pulling the plug," so to speak. A relatively extreme manifestation of this technique can be heard at the end of DMX's "Fuckin' Wit' D" (1998).

Other Functions and Section Types

*Instrumentals*

Unlike most of the other formal functions identified in this chapter, instrumentals are named primarily based on their sonic characteristics instead of their formal function. Instrumental

sections have the highest degree of flexibility in terms of the functions they can take on in hip-hop songs. Their role in this theoretical framework is that of a malleable catchall to help label and understand the ambiguous and loose sections heard frequently in rap music. As their name implies, instrumental sections are characterized by containing no vocals. The only exception is short (usually sampled) vocals that are either unintelligible or so fragmentary as to mainly function like percussion instruments. Although intros and outros often feature nothing but instruments, they are not referred to as instrumentals because their formal function is so clear. The most common role instrumental sections take on is hook-like/interlude.

Instrumentals and hooks are sometimes difficult to differentiate between, especially if sampled vocals verge on being intelligible or if MCs add conversational vocals over an instrumental section. The overlap between these two section types is caused by the ordering of sections in hip-hop songs: artists tend to structure songs such that verses alternate with hooks or instrumentals. In both a song that alternates verses and hooks and one that alternates verses and instrumentals, the chunks interspersed between verses provide a sense of repose from the intensity and action of the verses. We can refer to these sections as instrumental hooks or, if hook function is for whatever reason not strongly expressed, simply interludes. An example of an instrumental section with a degree of hook-like quality is Ice Cube's "It Was A Good Day" (1992). Instrumental hooks can be further imbued with hook-like function when they have a catchy riff or melody, especially if it is not present in the verse beat. The instrumental hooks of "It Was A Good Day" feature a catchy minor mode guitar riff but because it is present throughout the verses as well, hook function is not expressed quite as strongly as it could be.

*Bridges*

Bridges are somewhat uncommon in rap music, but when they do appear, they are the formal function whose musical properties and role within the larger context of songs can be most easily mapped from the way they are understood in pop-rock music. The single most common term

used in describing bridges is "contrast."[55] Verses, hooks, intros, outros, and instrumentals, of course, already contrast from one another, but the type of contrast provided by bridges is made specifically in relation to the larger cycles of a song, whether that be rotations through verses in strophic form or, more commonly, through verse-hook cycles. Like in pop-rock music, bridges in rap help to underscore the importance of a song's central cycles by taking us away from them momentarily, making their return fresh and relieving. Also like in pop-rock, bridges tend to appear in rap music after two large core cycles. The musical means through which bridges in rap generate contrast, however, are usually quite different from in pop-rock music. In the latter, harmonic contrast via instability, change of mode, avoidance of the tonic, and/or tonicization of new keys are characteristic of bridges. In hip-hop, bridges announce themselves either through singing, especially by a guest artist, or by the appearance of an instrumental section in place of a verse. In Kendrick Lamar's "Money Trees," for instance, two cycles through the song's verse-hook unit are followed by guest artist Anna Wise singing a four-measure set of lyrics twice over the same beat that has been looping throughout the song (see Example 1.17). The hook of "Money Trees" does feature singing by Kendrick, but this does not diminish the contrasting nature of the bridge because singing is not outside the realm of expectations in hooks in the first place and because of the difference in vocal timbre and pitch register of Wise's voice.

Bridges are here treated under the heading "Other Functions and Section Types" because they are somewhat rare in rap music and seem to have not been widely used until rap was mainstreamed in the mid-90s. This observation is supported by Duinker, who writes, "Rapped/sung sections that evade description as verses or hooks are comparatively rare, but have become more common of late. Many of these sections function somewhat similar to bridges in popular music, in that they provide contrast to the verses and hooks" (2021a, n. 28). Duinker also posits that "the core

[55] De Clercq (2012, 26) identifies two authors who describe bridges in this way. Numerous additional examples could be given.

**Example 1.17:** Form chart of "Money Trees" by Kendrick Lamar feat. Jay Rock and Anna Wise (2012)

| Time | Section | Musical Characteristics |
|---|---|---|
| 0:00–27 | Intro | |
| 0:27–1:20 | Verse 1 | Kendrick rapping solo with line-ending lyrics echoed in production |
| 1:20–2:13 | Hook | Two-part hook (1:20–47 and 1:47–2:13); no beat during first part, giving it slight pre-hook function |
| 2:14–3:06 | Verse 2 | |
| 3:07–4:00 | Hook | Beat present during first half of hook this time, recasting the pre-hook section as more properly part of the hook |
| 4:00–27 | Bridge | Sung by guest artist Anna Wise over same beat used throughout most of the song |
| 4:27–5:20 | Verse 3 | Rapped by guest artist Jay Rock |
| 5:20–47 | Hook | Truncated: only first part of previous two-part hooks stated |
| 5:48–6:26 | Skit | |

sequence of a song normally involves verses and hooks, but may also include instrumental or bridge-like sections" (2021a, 4), although he does not use AABA form as a formal paradigm nor do any of the form charts he presents use the section label "bridge"

*Links*

Sometimes in rap music, sections come after a hook and directly precede the subsequent verse. Temperley's idea of a link, a short bridging section that serves to relaunch a verse-chorus cycle, captures the function of these passages quite well (2018, 172–3). A link can be heard in Stetsasonic's "Pen and Paper" (1988). At the end of the song's intro (0:19–28), the texture thins markedly as horn and vocal samples drop out, leaving just drums, bass, and sampled ambient noise for four measures until the start of the first verse. Then after an instrumental hook from 0:53–1:10, the texture thins once again, yielding the same beat heard at the 0:19 mark. This link launches the

second verse by recycling the material from the intro, exactly the scenario Temperley describes as normal. Some links also contain vocals. Kendrick Lamar's "good kid" (2012), for instance, features a link that recycles the material from the song's intro (0:02–24), including lyrics sung by Pharrell Williams. Because links are characterized by launching function (they prepare new verse and verse-hook cycles), some materials at the end of hooks can present traces of link function, even if the section as a whole not a link. Flava Flav's hype vocals that invite Chuck D to start each of his verses in "Bring the Noise" are an excellent example of this phenomenon. Even though Flav's cheering is contained within the segment I would label as the hook, the effect of his vocals is to prepare the listener for a new verse, i.e., to launch the next verse. This is especially true because Flav is heard inviting Chuck to start rapping during the song's intro, directly before the onset of the first verse.[56]

*Skits*

Skits are a section type used in hip-hop more than in any other style of popular music. Prince Paul has posited that the skits added to *3 Feet High and Rising* were the first use of skits, an act that set a widely-used precedent (2019, 1:01:10). Like instrumentals, these formal units are named for sonic content rather than function. Skits are basically non-musical: they rarely include sounds of instruments, singing, or even rapping. They are also unmetered, lacking any pulse streams let alone hierarchical pulse streams, which give rise to meter in musical passages. What differentiates them sonically from other formal units is that they portray real life scenarios—like conversations or news broadcasts—and lack features typically understood as musical—like tempo, harmony, melody, and flow. They can serve a variety of formal roles, but are most often heard outside the time of a song or album. Skits can create a connective thread in between tracks on concept albums like Lauryn Hill's *The Miseducation of Lauryn Hill* (1998), or Kendrick Lamar's *good kid, m.A.A.d. city* (2012) and *To*

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[56] For Duinker, hype vocals are included under the "looser-organized vocal" section type, even though they "usually set up the content of the song or introduce (occasionally self-introduce) the MC or MCs who will rap the verses and/or hooks" (2021a, n. 26). This description is closely related to the function of a link except that it may overstate the extent to which hype vocals occur at the beginning and end of songs.

*Pimp a Butterfly* (2015) or add comedic effect to individual tracks as in the Fugees's "The Beast" (1996). Skits can be very brief, consisting of just a couple of sound effects before a song's intro, or can be quite long, constituting entire tracks as in the first track on Eminem's albums *The Slim Shady LP* (1999) and *The Marshall Mathers LP* (2000), titled "Public Service Announcement" and "Public Service Announcement 2000," respectively. In terms of their relationship to formal functions already discussed in this chapter, skits are most closely tied to intros and outros in that the most common place where skits occur is at the beginning and/or end of songs. Oftentimes, skits and intros or instrumental sections blend, both in the conceptual sense described by de Clercq (2017) and in the literal sense that a musically unaccompanied skit will be wrapping up as instrumental elements are added to usher in the song's intro. The skit at the beginning of N.W.A.'s "Fuck Tha Police," for instance, is also an intro. At thirty seconds into the song, the onset of the track's main beat coincides with the start of Ice Cube's first verse. Prior to this moment, the track consists of an unrelated beat accompanying the famous skit in which the "N.W.A. court is in full effect, Judge Dre presiding, in the case of N.W.A. versus the police department."

Summary

This chapter has identified and described the basic formal functions and sections types used across hip-hop's recorded history. Verses and hooks are the most important sections and formal functions in hip-hop; refrains, a type of sub-section that are mainly understood here in terms of functional quality, are also present in the majority of hip-hop songs. All three have been shown to demonstrate some widely recognizable internal and relational lyrical and musical characteristics, many of which are derived from hip-hop's original live-party format and the general improvised spirit of such settings that has continued in various ways since the 1970s. Hip-hop is a vastly complicated musical tradition and the section types discussed in this chapter cannot be said to be a watertight typology that can explain every second of recorded rap. But this framework, summarized in Example 1.18, provides enough of a theoretical foundation to at least describe the central features

of formal organization in the majority of hip-hop music. Chapter 2 will describe how these basic formal functions and section types combine and order themselves into form types encompassing entire songs.

**Example 1.18:** Summary of formal functions and section types

| Formal function/section type | Key Characteristics |
|---|---|
| Verse | • Expressive locus of rap music<br>• Rhythmically dense and complex<br>• Often end with verse-ending refrain<br>• Light accumulative processes common |
| Hook | • Virtually any aspect of a song can take on hook *function*<br>• Usually just one hook *section* in a song<br>• Rhythmically more diffuse<br>• Most likely section for singing<br>• Vocal samples common<br>• Some textural distinction from verse common |
| Chorus | • Section type from pop-rock music<br>• Present in music of pop-rap artists<br>• Defined as a chorus is in pop-rock scholarship |
| Refrain | • A subsection that may occur in any part of a song<br>• Usually appears in prominent formal locations<br>• Adds cohesion to a song<br>• Most common: head refrain and verse-ending refrain |
| Intro | • Comes first in a song<br>• Often based on same material as hook<br>• Accumulative processes common |
| Outro | • Comes last in a song<br>• Signified by more extended vamp<br>• Vamp to fade most common |
| Instrumental | • Instruments only<br>• Variety of functions, especially hook-like |
| Bridge | • Contrast from core verse or verse-hook cycles<br>• Singing by a guest artist |
| Link | • Usually instrumental<br>• Comes after verse or verse-hook cycle ends<br>• Relaunches next cycle |
| Skit | • Non-musical; exists "outside the time" of the music<br>• Portrays explicit narrative or scene<br>• Ties together concept albums |

# CHAPTER 2: SONG FORMS

Chapter 1 identified and described basic section types and formal functions used in hip-hop. This chapter discusses how these building blocks work together to create full-scale song forms.[1] Common patterns of section succession are used in hip-hop. These patterns are made up of the previously discussed section types and functions but are recognizable as entities unto themselves. The song forms discussed in this chapter are prime-verse form, verse-chorus form, AABA form, and compound song form. Like in the previous chapter, there is a great deal of overlap between hip-hop music's formal patterning and that of pop-rock music. AABA form, for instance, has historical precedent in the music of Tin Pan Alley, the Beatles, and others before the advent of hip-hop in the early 1970s. On the other hand, crucial differences between patterns familiar from pop-rock and those found in hip-hop will be highlighted like, for example, the general use of the same harmonic progression between verse and hook in verse-hook form.[2] The typology in this chapter presents a way of understanding and hearing form in hip-hop at the level of the song and reflects the musical, rhetorical, and and aesthetic preferences specific to this genre.

## Prime-Verse Form

The verse was the first section type discussed in Chapter 2. Its expressive and aesthetic importance will likewise be the focus at the start of this chapter. The relationship between verse and chorus in pop-rock music is normally described such that the verse is subordinate to the chorus. As

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[1] Theorists use different terms to refer to song-length formal patterns. John Covach uses both "formal types" and "formal schemes" (2005, 65); Trevor de Clercq uses "organizational schemes" (2012, 118); and Ben Duinker refers to them as "formal paradigms" (2020, 9). Despite the differences in language, they all refer to ways of classifying form at the level of the song (with the partial exception of de Clercq's terminology, which refers to slightly more abstract schemas than the other authors). I use the term "song forms" because the structures in question are formal at the level of the song.

[2] Covach uses the term "simple verse-chorus form" for songs in which "the harmonic scheme offers no contrast" between the verse and the chorus (2005, 73). While this formal-harmonic design occurs enough in pop-rock music to warrant its own category in Covach's typology, pop-rock songs are statistically more likely to use "contrasting verse-chorus form," which "employs contrasting music for verse and chorus" (72).

de Clercq notes, "a central theme in theoretical descriptions is that a chorus section demands our attention much more strongly than does a verse" (2012, 40). Covach puts it more succinctly when he says, "in a verse-chorus song … the focus is squarely on the chorus" (2005,71). This relationship is reversed in most of hip-hop music, especially in releases from the genre's first couple of decades. Verses are the most important part of the majority of songs from the Golden Age and remain so today in less mainstream pop-rap and underground hip-hop. This unique relationship between verse and hook should have implications for any theory of form in hip-hop. To that end, James Bungert coined the term "prime-verse form" to characterize the normative situation in hip-hop music where verses, rather than hooks or choruses, are focal. Prime-verse form is not a single formal type; instead, "the different kinds of prime-verse form … lie along a spectrum from those altogether lacking lyrical repetition (ballad-verse-forms) up to songs with clear choruses, all of which have in common relatively long verses whose length often varies" (Bungert 2019a, 3). Prime-verse form is the first song form type discussed here because it is the formal strategy found in the earliest days of recorded hip-hop and represents the most obvious departure from song forms in pop-rock music. As evinced by the discussion that follows, my conception of prime-verse form is an adaptation of Bungert's with some important differences.

Bungert's criteria for prime-verse form are summarized in Example 2.1. For a verse to be primary, verses must be long, variable in length, and not overshadowed by the hook or chorus. I view the third criterion as the most essential characteristic of a prime-verse song. On its own it may

**Example 2.1**: Bungert's criteria for prime-verses

1. Length: appreciably longer than pop/rock-industry standard eight measures
2. Variability: verse length changes from verse to verse
3. Chorus: should there be one, cannot be too strong

suggest Bungert's first criterion: a good way for an artist to ensure that the chorus/hook is not too strong is to make it shorter than the verses. Length alone, though, is not the determining factor of the importance of any formal section. A verse-ending refrain, for instance, takes up just a small portion of the verse that it ends, but it could easily be interpreted as the most important part of the verse because it ties the song together thematically and provides closure. Finally, the second criterion is, to me, somewhat extraneous. To be sure, verse length variability is a common feature in early hip-hop and one that sets it apart stylistically from pop-rock,[3] but there are countless songs whose verses are consistent in length and are still more important than choruses/hooks.[4] In sum, Bungert's first two criteria for prime-verse form are often true but not requisite and third is essential.

Given these characteristics, he explicitly describes two subtypes of song forms under the prime-verse umbrella: strophic form and ballad form.[5] The distinction between these two is based on degree of text repetition. Strophic form songs cycle through several verses, each of which ends with a refrain. The example Bungert gives is LL Cool J's "You'll Rock" (1986), which is organized into five verses of varying lengths. A short instrumental appears between each verse, though it hardly competes with the verses as candidates for the most important sections of the song. Each verse of "You'll Rock" ends with a titular verse-ending refrain, lending cohesion between the verses and closure within each verse. Ballad form songs, so named because of "their storytelling nature," have little to no lyrical repetition (3). Bungert offers Sugar Hill Gang's "Rapper's Delight" (1979) and the Beastie Boys' "Paul Revere" (1986) as examples.

While Bungert's theory of form emphasizes lyrics—undoubtedly one of the most important parameters in hip-hop—it downplays non-lyrical segmentation and the ways in which boundaries

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[3] See Chapter 1, pp. 26–8 for more on this point.
[4] One such example is "Basketball" by Kurtis Blow (1984). The song mostly alternates between rapped verses and sung hooks, but Blow raps strictly for eight measures at a time even when his verse is followed by an instrumental.
[5] Bungert mentions that songs with choruses can still be considered prime-verse, although no examples are cited; see quotation above (Bungert, 3).

created by changes in aspects like texture, rhythm, timbre, and harmony influence the organization and perception of form. In neither "Rapper's Delight" nor "Paul Revere," for instance, are the lyrics delivered continuously. The text is broken up in the former by changes in rapper and in the latter by intervening instrumentals. In my adaptation of Bungert's prime-verse form, I combine his emphasis on lyrics with a sensitivity to formal divisions created by musical changes in a song's beat, vocals, or both. I interpret "Rapper's Delight" as strophic because several MCs rap different lyrics over roughly the same music.[6] Despite the breaks between verses of "Paul Revere," I agree with Bungert's classification of it as ballad form because the narrative connection between verses is so strong.[7] The continuity created by the lyrics outweighs the division created by the changes in texture.

Another theorist to discuss strophic form in hip-hop, albeit before the idea of prime-verse form was introduced into the discourse, is Jeffrey Ensign. It is unclear whether Ensign requires a refrain to be present to label a song's form as strophic, but all three of the examples in his dissertation do, including both of the hip-hop tracks: Dr. Dre's "Nuthin' but a 'G' Thang" (1993) and Diddy's "Can't Nobody Hold Me Down" (1997) (2015, 39–44). Ensign interprets fairly substantial spans as refrains. The sections he analyzes as refrains in "Nuthin'" and "Can't Nobody" are both multiple lines in length, and are dynamically bolstered by being delivered by more than one artist. I would interpret these passages as hooks or some other section type unto themselves, likely changing the song form to verse-hook form rather than strophic. This analytical particular aside, Ensign's conception of strophic form is very similar to Bungert's: it is characterized by several cycles through verses with different texts over roughly the same music, usually ending with a refrain. My departure from both Bungert and Ensign is that I don't view a refrain as necessary for a song to be

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[6] Some details of "Rapper's Delight" complicate this interpretation, like the repetition of the famous opening lyrics "a hip-hop, a hippie, a hippie…" and "hotel, motel, Holiday Inn" at various points later in the song. Indeed, the song's disco-based organization may well defy analysis within the present theory of form.

[7] As will become evident below, I ultimately use the term "long-verse" in place of ballad.

considered strophic. In this way, my definition of strophic form aligns fairly well with Covach's simple-verse form in pop-rock music (2005, 73).

One manifestation of strophic form specific to hip-hop is the "posse cut." Posse cuts, as Paul Edwards defines them, are songs "in which numerous rappers (normally more than four or five) all contribute to a single track, usually doing back-to-back verses, in which the next artist starts rapping immediately after the previous MC" (2009, 221). Robert Komaniecki (2017) also discusses posse tracks, although his focus is on relationships between collaborative flow and not on song form. Posse cuts stem from hip-hop's improvisatory, non-recorded origins in group activities like ciphers, which involve several individuals passing off the mic (literally or metaphorically) to one another. The topics of verses in ciphers and posse cuts range from group-oriented (pumping each other up) to competitive (taking on the flavor of a rap battle). Not all posse cuts are in strophic form, but their tendency to feature high-energy verse after high-energy verse makes strophic form a natural description of this song form type.

As a classic example of a posse cut in strophic form, Example 2.2 analyzes the form of "Scenario" (1991). "Scenario" was released on A Tribe Called Quest's *The Low End Theory* although the song is a collaboration between that group and Leaders of the New School. After a brief intro

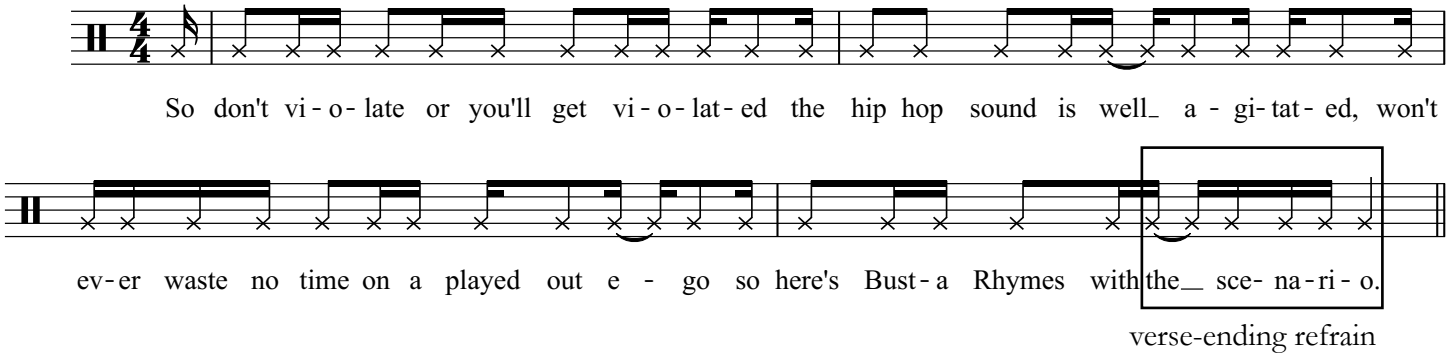
**Example 2.2**: Formal diagram of A Tribe Called Quest, "Scenario"

| Time | Section |
|---|---|
| 0:00–0:08 | Intro |
| 0:09–0:18 | Hook |
| 0:18–1:00 | Verse 1 (Phife Dawg) |
| 1:00–1:48 | Verse 2 (Charlie Brown) |
| 1:48–2:20 | Verse 3 (Dinco D) |
| 2:21–2:58 | Verse 4 (Q-Tip & Busta Rhymes) |
| 2:58–3:50 | Verse 5 (Busta Rhymes) |
| 3:50–4:10 | Hook |

that previews the main elements of the song's beat, the entourage delivers a hook together. The core of the song then consists of five braggadocious and witty verses delivered in direct succession. Only two verses end with what could be called a verse-ending refrain. Examples 2.3a–b transcribe the last two lines rapped by Charlie Brown, whose final words are a direct quote of the hook and song title, and by Q-Tip. Differences between these two moments include the exact words used, the syntactical context of the words, and the metrical placement. But the most important word ("scenario") is

**Example 2.3a**: Verse-ending refrain at the end of the second verse (Charlie Brown) in "Scenario"

**Example 2.3b**: Verse-ending refrain at the end of the fourth verse (Q-Tip) in "Scenario"

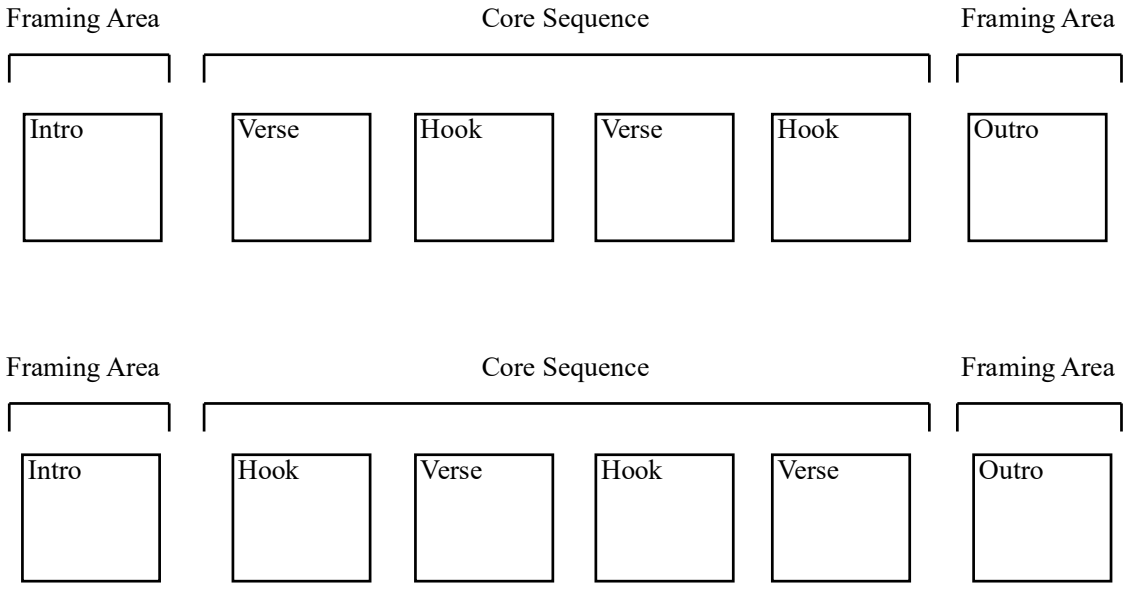



present and is set to analogous rhythms: the first three syllables are set to sixteenth notes beginning on a metrically weak position and end with a the syllable "o" on a longer duration. These factors imbue the end of Charlie Brown and Q-Tip's verses with refrain function that both reference the

opening hook. But, once again, not all the verses in "Scenario" end with refrains. This song is an example of prime-verse form because the verses are primary: the expressive weight of the verses far outweigh that of any other sections, even the memorable hooks. Within the prime-verse umbrella, it represents strophic form because the core of the song cycles through verse after verse delivered by different rappers with different lyrics over roughly the same music.

Strophic form constitutes one extreme of the text repetition continuum in Bungert's formulation of prime-verse form. The presence of verse-ending refrains cause strophic songs to have the most amount of text repetition for prime-verse songs. In the present theory of form, strophic form songs need not contain verse-ending refrains nor do they have the most text repetition in the prime-verse family. That award goes to verse-hook songs. It may seem worthwhile to create a separate typological category for verse-hook songs. This is exactly how Ben Duinker frames verse-hook form. Example 2.4 reproduces his visualization of the verse-hook formal paradigm. As the name implies, "verse-hook songs in hip-hop feature a core sequence of

**Example 2.4:** Duinker's verse-hook formal schema (Example 5 in Duinker [2021a])



alternating verse and hook sections" (Duinker 2021a, 13). Either the verse or the hook can come first. Defining the formal patterning in verse-hook form any further here would be redundant; I fully adopt Duinker's description as indicated by his prose and diagram in Example 2.4. However, I subsume verse-hook form within the larger category of prime-verse form because verses are usually still of primary importance in verse-hook songs. Duinker notes that, despite a somewhat analogous connection between verse-hook form in rap and verse-chorus form in pop-rock, the former has no dependence on a teleological relationship between verse and hook (16). Categorizing verse-hook form within the larger prime-verse type takes this observation one step further; it is not a trivial adjustment of previous scholarship but rather a reconceptualization that embeds the aesthetic preferences of hip-hop artists within a formal theory. Verses typically do not lead towards hooks in hip-hop *and* are typically more important than hooks. The expressive emphasis in pop-rock on choruses over verses is turned in its head in hip-hop music.

As an example of a prime-verse song in verse-hook form, let us return to an example from Chapter 2, De La Soul's "Me Myself and I." As Example 2.5 shows, "Me Myself and I" opens with a short intro and then alternates verses and hooks for the bulk of the song, save for an instrumental section near the halfway point. This regular alternation between verses and hooks is what distinguishes verse-hook form from other types of prime-verse form that may have hooks at the beginning and end as framing sections (see "Scenario" above for such a song with hooks that is not in verse-hook form). The leftmost column in Example 2.5 organizes the verse-hook groups into verse-hook units (VHUs), a term used by Duinker (2021a). Admittedly, there is some competition in "Me Myself and I" between the narrative importance of the verses and the instrumental excitement of the hooks.[8] The prominence in the hooks is further bolstered by their predictability: the fist two verses are a square eight measures in length and all verses end with the verse-ending refrain "me,

[8] See Chapter 2, pp. 43–6 for a detailed description of the elements in each section of this song.

**Example 2.5:** Form of "Me Myself and I"

| Verse-Hook Units | Time | Section | Length in measures |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 0:00–0:10 | Intro | 4 (not counting a dead measure featuring a drum fill) |
| VHU 1 | 0:10–0:26 | Verse 1 | 8 |
| | 0:27–0:43 | Hook | 8 |
| VHU 2 | 0:43–1:00 | Verse 2 | 8 |
| | 1:00–1:17 | Hook | 8 |
| | 1:17–1:34 | Instrumental | 8 |
| VHU 3 | 1:34–1:59 | Verse 3 | 12 |
| | 1:59–2:15 | Hook | 8 |
| VHU 4 | 2:16–2:49 | Verse 4 | 16 |
| | 2:49–3:06 | Hook | 8 |
| | 3:06–3:49 | Instrumental/Outro | 16 |

myself, and I," which signals the onset of the hooks. However, the hooks are ultimately outweighed by the lyrical importance of the verses: the members of De La Soul use the verses to develop a stance of pride in oneself, making them the focus of the song rather than the hooks. The hooks, despite their infectious riffs and repeated lyrics, function as breaks from the action. As the rightmost column in Example 2.5 shows, the verses increase in length as the song progresses, lending them further emphasis.

As an illustration of a rather different manifestation of verse-hook form, Example 2.6 presents a formal overview of The Roots' "Concerto of the Desperado" (1996). Verses alternate regularly with hooks in this song, but it is less clear how the verses and hooks might be organized into verse-hook units because there are more hooks than verses. Does each VHU start with a hook (Verse-Hook Form option 1) or a verse (option 2)? In either interpretation, one of the hooks has to be left out of a VHU. In option 1, the last hook works in conjunction with the outro to make a larger outro-functioning section and in option 2, the first hook does the same but with the intro.

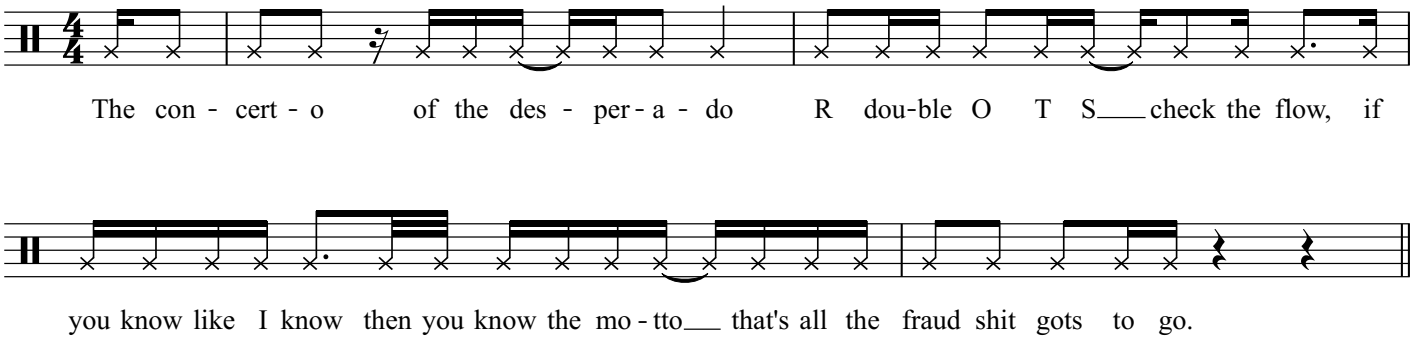
**Example 2.6**: Form of "Concerto of the Desperado"

| Verse-Hook Form option 1 | Verse-Hook Form option 2 | Time | Section | Length in measures |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Intro | Intro | 0:00–0:20 | Intro | 8 |
| VHU 1 | | 0:21–0:30 | Hook | 4 |
| | VHU 1 | 0:31–1:34 | Verse 1 | 24 |
| VHU 2 | | 1:34–1:54 | Hook | 8 |
| | VHU 2 | 1:55–2:58 | Verse 2 | 24 |
| Outro | | 2:58–3:19 | Hook | 8 |
| | Outro | 3:20–3:38 | Outro | 7 (fades) |

The pacing of the sections and the homogeneity of the beat is so even throughout "Concerto" that neither Verse-Hook Form option 1 or 2 stand out as a favorable interpretation. Because of this, I call "Concerto" an example of unpaired verse-hook form. This is in contrast to "Me Myself and I," whose verses and hooks pair clearly into VHUs and thus can be classified as paired verse-hook form.

Other unique aspects of "Concerto" include the durational proportions of the sections, with each verse lasting three times as long as the longest hook. Nothing changes in the texture between the verses and the hooks except for some sporadic vocal doubling of MC Black Thought's (née Tariq Trotter) voice as he delivers the hook lyrics. This slight increase in textural density during the hooks (along with a potential increase in perceived loudness) does little to overshadow the verses, however, making the prime-verse quality of this song fairly strong. An aspect of "Concerto" that the static analysis in Example 2.6 does not capture is the way in which function is conveyed in real time. Most importantly in this regard, it may not be entirely clear upon first hearing that the passage from 0:21 to 0:30 is a hook. Several aspects of this hook (the lyrics of which are transcribed rhythmically in Example 2.7) convey verse function, including its relatively high lyrical density and a lack of internal lyrical repetition. The first verse begins directly after the passage shown in Example 2.7, at which point it becomes much clearer that this nine-second span is at the very least a different section than the verse, and in all likelihood the hook because of the cleaner texture. This suspicion is

**Example 2.7:** "Concerto of the Desperado," first hook (0:21–0:30)




confirmed when the hook returns at 1:34 into the song and not only repeats the lyrics shown here but doubles in length to eight measures via exact internal text repetition. This musical process makes the form of "Concerto" more emergent than readily apparent. The relationship between form and real-time listening will be explored in greater detail in Chapter 5, but for the moment, the point is that verse-hook form can manifest in a variety of ways, both in terms of the ordering of sections and clarity with which the formal functions of the sections present themselves.

The final prime-verse song type form accounts for songs that feature little to no segmentation in their cores. For the most part, these songs feature one long verse. I will adopt Duinker's term "long-verse form" (2021, 17) to refer to this song form type. The closest formal type in Bungert's writing is ballad form, which I refrain from using because it specifically denotes a storytelling quality. Long-verse songs can certainly be of a storytelling nature, but so can a verse-hook or a strophic song. In this way, I once again depart from Bungert by categorizing song forms based on aspects of segmentation just as much as lyrics. That the verses are of primary importance in a long-verse form is self-evident; it is difficult to imagine a song in which the intro or outro outweighs the expressive significance of the central verse, which is usually much longer than an 8- or 16-bar verse one might expect in a strophic or verse-hook song.

Duinker gives several clear examples of long-verse songs, including Roxanne Shante's "Roxanne's Revenge" (1984), Eric B & Rakim's "Paid in Full" (1987), Slick Rick's "Children's Story" (1988), and Ol' Dirty Bastard's "Brooklyn Zoo" (1995). Each of these songs adheres to the long-verse label closely in that they contain a single, continuous verse framed by short, loose-knit introductory and concluding sections. But a song's central verse need not be continuous to fall under the long-verse category. If the *effect* of a single long verse is conveyed, I interpret the song as long-verse—which brings us back to "Paul Revere," Bungert's ballad form example. Example 2.8 summarizes the form of "Paul Revere," with an important difference in section labelling from most other examples in this dissertation: discontiguous verse segments are not labelled numerically (Verse 1, Verse 2, etc.) but rather as "beginning," "continuing," and "concluding." This reflects the effect of the song, which is of a single verse being delivered with interruptions in the form of instrumentals.

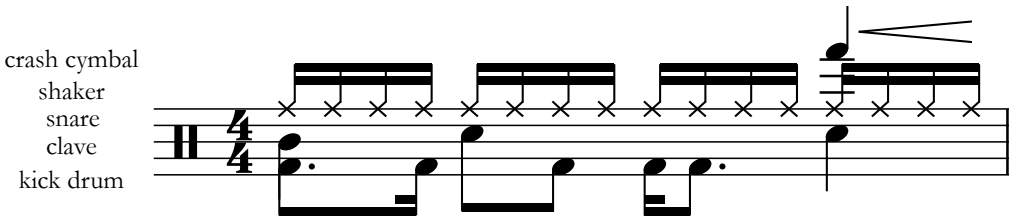
**Example 2.8**: Form of "Paul Revere"

| Time | Section | Length in measures |
|---|---|---|
| 0:00–0:37 | Verse begins | 14 |
| 0:38–0:52 | Instrumental | 6 |
| 0:53–1:29 | Verse continues | 14 |
| 1:30–1:44 | Instrumental | 6 |
| 1:45–3:09 | Verse continues and concludes | 32 |
| 3:09–3:40 | Outro | 12 |

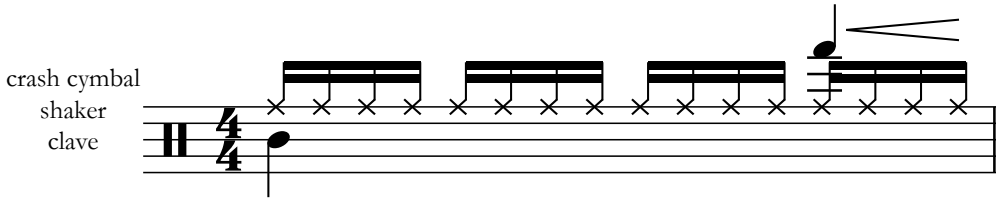
"Paul Revere" gives the impression of a single long verse with interruptions rather than multiple disparate verses because of some important fluctuations in texture, the verse's storyline, and some hypermetrical factors. The beat in "Paul Revere" is fairly minimalist. As Example 2.9a shows, it consists solely of non-pitched percussion elements including a kick drum, shaker, clave, crash cymbal, and modified snare. The active rhythmic profile of the transcription belies the beat's unobtrusiveness. Each element is fairly dry in timbre and short in duration, keeping the beat sonically out of the way of the rapped vocals. At the beginning of each instrumental section, the

beat reduces substantially with only the shaker, clave, and crash cymbal remaining (Example 2.9b). Because this reduced beat lacks the two lowest frequency elements (the kick drum and the snare), it sounds particularly thin. The resulting tentativeness makes it sound as if the instrumental breaks are waiting for the verses to continue in a textural game of "Yes, And!" The instrumentals also builds in texture, adding the kick drum and scratches after several measures of the thinned beat in Example 2.9b. Each instrumental also ends up being more active than the previous one(s), creating a large-scale sense of continuity across the entire song that supports the feeling that "Paul Revere" consists of a single long verse. The verse lyrics further diminish the role of the instrumentals: syntactically, there is nothing at the end of each segment of the verse to indicate a thought has come to an end. The first segment (ending at 0:37) concludes: "Looking for a girl, I ran into a guy / His name was MCA, I said "Howdy," he said "Hi." While this rhyming couplet forms a closed-off syntactical unit at a small scale (i.e., a sentence), it doesn't play a role as an obvious ending point within the larger scope of the verse. The narrator could easily continue the conversation between the "guy" he just ran into immediately, but instead the verse segment ends abruptly. Similarly, the final lines of second

**Example 2.9a:** "Paul Revere," main beat

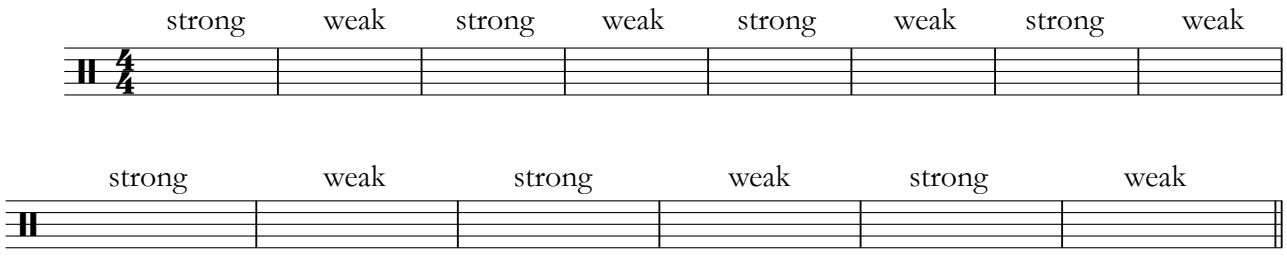



**Example 2.9b:** "Paul Revere," reduced beat at beginning of each instrumental

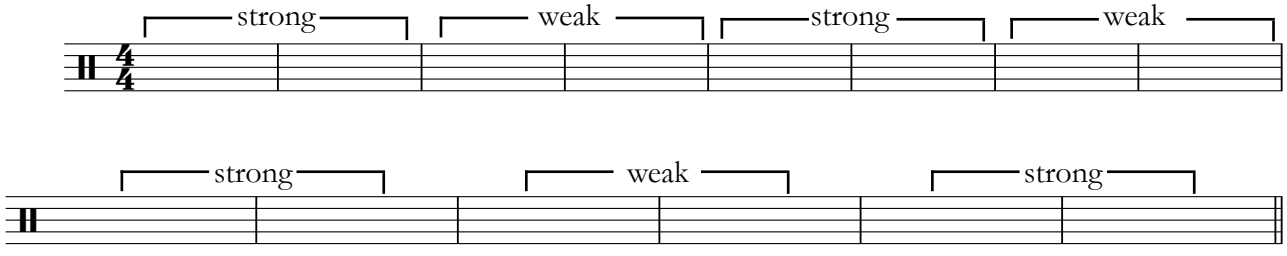


verse segment(ending at 1:29) are: "We stepped into the wind, he had a gun I had a grin / You think this story's over but it's ready to begin." Just as the listener hears that something is going to begin, the verse segment ends. A final parameter that creates a sense of continuity between the verse segments is hypermeter. As the rightmost column in Example 2.8 shows, the first two verse segments are both fourteen measures long. Taking the first measure of each verse segment as a strong measure, each verse segment ends on a hypermetrically weak bar, i.e., at the end of a hypermeasure at the two-measure level (Example 2.10a). At the four-bar level, however (Example 2.10b), they end on a strong hyperbeat, creating incomplete hypermeasures. This incompleteness makes it sound as though the verse segments want to continue, tying together each segment into one large verse even though it is not continuous.

**Example 2.10a:** Two-bar hypermeter in first two verse segments of "Paul Revere"




**Example 2.10b:** Four-bar hypermeter in first two verse segments of "Paul Revere"



Verse-Chorus Form

A recurring theme of conversations in hip-hop's cultural circles is the question of what makes an artist, song, or album authentic. This issue revolves around several dimensions including race, gender, sexuality, age, biography, economics, and, of course, the actual musical product. Mark Spicer summarizes a similar debate surrounding the genre terms "pop" and "rock": "the distinction between 'pop' and 'rock' … has hinged on the idealistic notion that pop music is willfully derivative and carefully calculated to have mass commercial appeal, while rock music is grounded in 'authenticity' and therefore carries with it a seriousness of artistic intent that pop somehow does not" (2011, xii–xiii). Like pop as discussed by Spicer, one subgenre that has long been criticized for its lack of loyalty to "pure" hip-hop is pop-rap. Pop-rap encompasses artists, albums, and songs that combine elements of hip-hop with those of mainstream popular music. A classic (and quite literal) example of pop-rap fusion is Run-D.M.C. and Aerosmith's collaborative cover song "Walk This Way" (1986). Hip-hop has drifted closer to the center of the mainstream since the mid-1980s—specifically due to "Walk This Way"—so the extent to which pop-rap as a label carries meaning is questionable. To the extent that pop-rap is understood to refer to a specific group of artists, releases, and sounds, one musical element common in this subgenre is a chorus.

The chorus was a section type discussed in Chapter 1 in relation to the hook. The hook is framed in this dissertation as the default section type in hip-hop that repeats the same lyrics throughout the course of a song, but using the label hook feels forced in some songs. Verse-chorus form—defined largely as it traditionally is in pop-rock scholarship—is a more appropriate term in these cases. It is difficult to reduce the difference between hooks and choruses to a few axioms, but important features that make a section more chorus-like include the presence of singing, a different harmonic progression than the verse, and a sense of culmination and arrival in relation to the verse. This last aspect is the most important since it distinguishes verse-chorus form from prime-verse form. I do not discount the possibility of interpreting a song prior to 1990 as being in verse-chorus

form, but I will limit the discussion that follows to songs from the mid-1990s and early 2000s because it was around the turn of the former decade that pop-rap rose to prominence.

An early example of a song that sits directly on the dividing line between verse-hook and verse-chorus form is Snoop Dogg's "Gin and Juice" (1993).[9] As the most popular track on Snoop's debut album *Doggy Style*, "Gin and Juice" set the tone for a lighthearted strand of West Coast gangsta rap, one which spoke of partying, money, and women rather than gang violence and politics. As Jeff Chang writes, "on *Doggy Style*, Dre and Snoop largely ditched the inner-city blues for more smoothed-out roughness and gangsta parties, and sold even more records" (2005, 419). The last observation (the commercial success of *Doggy Style*) highlights how Snoop and his close collaborator Dr. Dre discovered something that was embraced by (white) American popular culture. "Gin and Juice" was not only relatable for its subject matter but also because it contains a sung hook that may have been more similar in terms of sonic content to what a wide listener base expected in a popular song.[10]

Example 2.11 transcribes the sung hook and bass line from "Gin and Juice." The hook consists of three lyrical segments broken up among four artists: David Ruffin Jr. and Jewell sing first, then Snoop Dogg states two words that perhaps best encapsulate his personal aura ("laid back"), then Daz Dillinger raps a catchy tongue twister that is also a reference to a 2Pac verse before the whole cycle repeats. Any of these three lyrical segments could have been used to make up a hook on their own, but the inclusion of them all in direct succession helps to portray the setting in which "Gin and Juice" is supposed to be taking place, i.e., at a party where friends are coming together. The sung lyrics at the beginning also reflect some attributes that would be found in a pop

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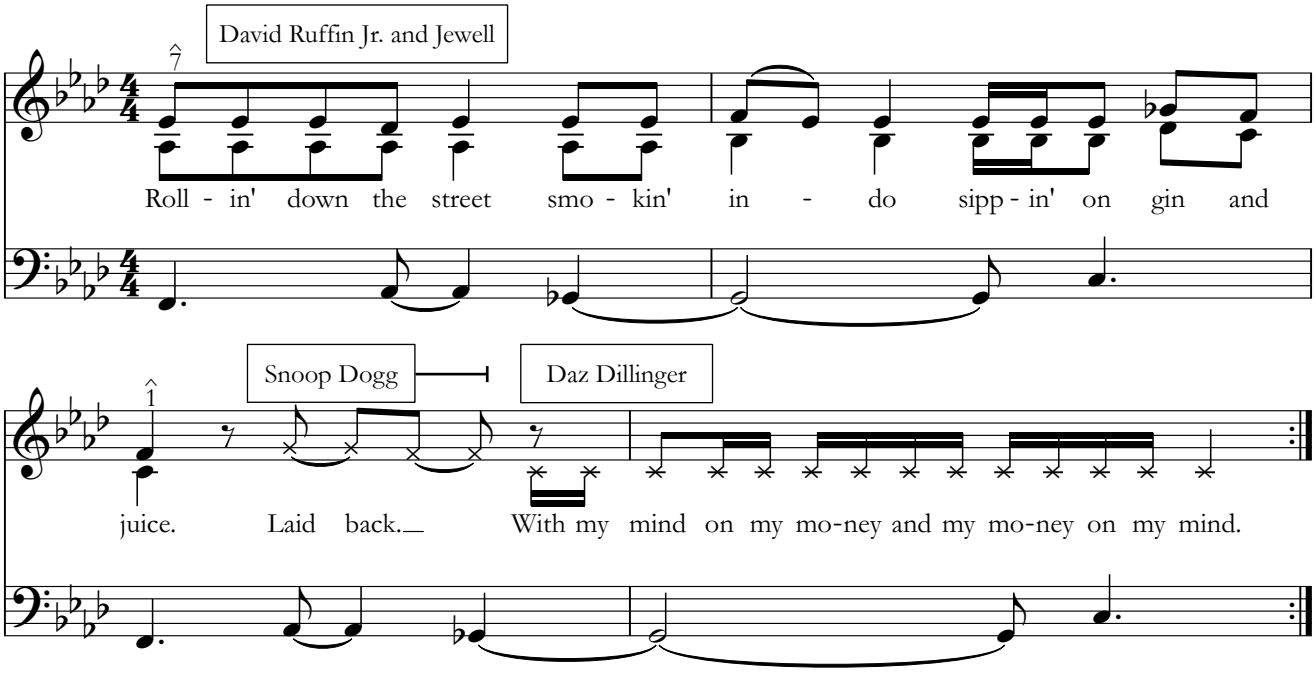
[9] The section in question (transcribed in Example 2.11) could either be labelled as a hook or a chorus within the present theory of form. For simplicity, I will refer to it as a sung hook in this discussion. *Genius.com* labels the section as a chorus in its lyric transcription but refers to it as a hook in the song description (https://genius.com/Snoop-dogg-gin-and-juice-lyrics).

[10] Other songs on *Doggy Style* that feature recurring, sung, chorus-like sections include "Who Am I (Wha's My Name)?," "It Ain't No Fun (If The Homies Can't Have None)," and "Doggy Dogg World."

**Example 2.11:** Sung hook with bass line in "Gin and Juice"




chorus. Other than being unequivocally sung—a marked feature in a hip-hop track in the first place—the duet contains directed tonal motion from a place of instability ($\hat{7}$ over an F in the bass) towards a place of stability in the tonic pitch F. This upper-voice movement is coordinated with the bass's melodic and implied harmonic motion towards tonic, creating a cadential effect commonly found in popular choruses. This passage is also chorus-like because of its use of a higher tessitura than the rapped verse and because of the use of more vocal forces. On the other hand, numerous elements may suggest a reading of this section as a hook: the bass line and harmonic layers of the beat remain the same from the verse, nearly half of the passage is rapped rather than sung, and the verse does not strongly prepare the arrival of the hook. While "Gin and Juice" reflects the increasing influence of mainstream popular music on hip-hop during the 1980s and early 90s, it does not fully crossover, musically speaking.

For an artist who uses full-on pop choruses, we have to fast forward to the turn of the millennium when Eminem erupted in popularity. After five major musical releases, Eminem starred in and wrote the music for the quasi-biographical movie *8 Mile* (2002).[11] One song from the soundtrack would become so successful as to help define the sound of the 2000s: "Lose Yourself." "Lose Yourself" was a hit partially because of the artistic and personal attributes Eminem was already admired for in the early 2000s (a dark sense of humor, extreme confidence, inventive wordplay, and lyrical agility), but it didn't hurt that it was packaged in the most familiar song form of the preceding half-century.[12] "Lose Yourself" is organized into a very tidy verse-chorus form, as Example 2.12 outlines. After a two-part intro, the song alternates verses and choruses that follow predictable 2:1 proportions with the exception of an eight-measure extension of the third verse. A number of musical factors make these sections unequivocally choruses rather than sung hooks,

**Example 2.12**: "Lose Yourself," full song form

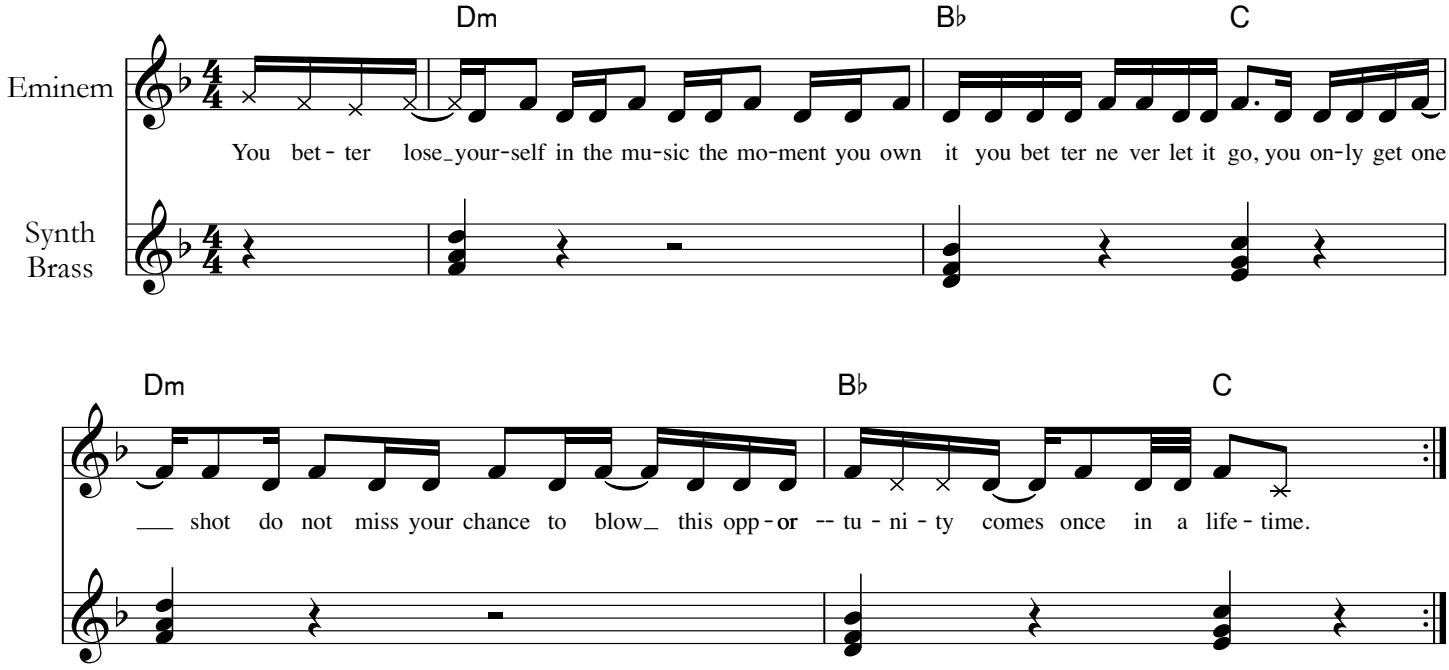
| Verse-Chorus Form | Time | Section | Length in measures |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 0:00–0:30 | Intro Part I | 7 |
| | 0:30–0:53 | Intro Part II | 8 |
| VCU 1 | 0:53–1:37 | Verse 1 | 16 |
| | 1:38–2:00 | Chorus | 8 |
| VCU 2 | 2:00–2:45 | Verse 2 | 16 |
| | 2:45–3:07 | Chorus | 8 |
| VCU 3 | 3:07–4:14 | Verse 3 | 24 |
| | 4:14–4:36 | Chorus | 8 |
| | 4:37–5:20 | Outro | (to fade) |

[11] Before *8 Mile*, Eminem released *Infinite* (1996), *Slim Shady EP* (1997), *The Slim Shady LP* (1999), *The Marshall Mathers LP* (2000), and *The Eminem Show* (2002).

[12] The mashup "Oops!…The Real Slim Shady Did It Again," discussed in Adams (2015), is an example of Eminem's use of the pop chorus. The mashup uses the instrumental from Britney Spears' "Oops!…I Did It Again" and the lyrics from Eminem's "The Real Slim Shady." What is striking about this mashup is how well the formal design of the two songs align: the timing of the chorus in the instrumental layer fits perfectly with the chorus lyrics delivered by Eminem.

including the presence of singing, more fully realized harmonic material than in the verses, and a textural buildup within the first verse leading towards the first chorus. Examples 2.13 shows the chorus melody and lyrics as sung by Eminem as well as an approximation of a brass synth harmonic

**Example 2.13:** Melody, lyrics, and approximation of brass synth layer in chorus of "Lose Yourself"




layer heard only during the chorus. Eminem's singing helps to distinguish the choruses from the verses in which his lyrics are delivered in a typical non-pitched rap manner. The brass synth layer helps create the effect of a chorus because it confidently realizes chords that are hinted at during the verses. The entire chorus occurs over a tonic pedal on the note D (not shown in Example 2.13), which is also present throughout the verses. The brass synth chords are either hinted at or played exactly by synth trombones at various times during the verses, although in a much more subdued dynamic and textural way. Thus there is not a different harmonic progression between the verses and the choruses. But the much more dynamically and timbrally prominent realization of the chords during the choruses gives the impression that there is tonal motion that was lacking in the verses.

Finally, the texture accumulates during the first verse, creating an exciting build up to and strong sense of arrival at the first chorus. Example 2.14 captures the addition of layers to the beat starting with the second part of the intro through the first chorus. The effect is clear upon listening through this passage: the thin pairing of Eminem rapping over a guitar riff gives way in stages to a full texture that leads us to the climactic chorus. This process is so measured that it is not hard to hear the passage immediately preceding the chorus as a prechorus, as noted at the 1:16 mark in Example 2.14. In this reading, 1:16 is a moment of formal articulation because of the entrance of the full drum kit for the first time, greater activity from the synthesized trombones, and a change in Eminem's flow that Mitchell Ohriner describes in great detail (2019, 71–4). The only aspects of

**Example 2.14:** Textural accumulation from the intro through the first chorus in "Lose Yourself" (dotted lines indicated continuation of layer)

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Beat Layers** | Eminem rapping<br><br>Guitar---------- | ----------<br>Violins<br>---------- | ----------<br>Soft trombones<br>----------<br>Kick drum<br>Bass punctuations | ----------<br>----------<br>----------<br>----------<br>Bass pulsing | ----------<br>"snap back to reality…"<br>Trombones more active<br>----------<br>Full drum kit----------<br>---------- | Eminem singing<br>Piano<br>Synth brass<br>----------<br>----------<br>---------- |
| **Time:** | 0:30 | 0:43 | 0:53 | 1:05 | 1:16 | 1:38 |
| **Section:** | Intro Part II | | Verse 1 | | Prechorus? | Chorus |

"Lose Yourself" that prevent the unequivocal inclusion of a prechorus label are the lack of text repetition and textural articulation at analogous moments in the subsequent VCUs. Eminem only raps the famous words "snap back to reality…" during the first VCU and the full beat layer is present through the remaining VCUs. The arrivals of subsequent choruses are signaled in subtler ways, mainly through hypermeter and less substantial textural fluctuations.

A change in harmonic progression from a song's verse to its chorus (Covach's "contrasting verse-chorus form") is one of the key markers of chorus function in popular music, but this situation is exceedingly rare in hip-hop. One song to be discussed below ("Empire State of Mind" by Jay-Z with Alicia Keys) features this type of change, but it is not included in the present discussion of verse-chorus form because the overall form of the song is AABA form.[13] It seems that instead of changing harmonic progressions, hip-hop songs in verse-chorus form bolster the verse's existing harmonic progression by adding pitched layers and riffs as we saw in "Lose Yourself."[14]

AABA Form

AABA is a formal archetype that appears in variety of musical practices, ranging as widely as the classical rounded binary to Tin Pan Alley thirty-two-bar song form. John Covach sketches a history of AABA form as it has been used in rock in three phases. In the first, rock musicians and songwriters were influenced in a fairly direct way by the Tin Pan Alley tradition: "the AABA form is common in 1950s and 1960s rock, and its use generally marks the influence of the Tin Pan Alley professional songwriter pop tradition." In the second phase, "rock music in the mid-1960s tends to move away from AABA forms and towards verse-chorus forms." Finally, full verse-chorus cycles were embedded within the A sections of AABA patterns in "the music of the 1970s, [which] shows a strong tendency toward compound AABA forms" (2005, 71–5). As a groove-based (and, originally, dance-based) music, hip-hop has never relied extensively on AABA form's tightly knit, teleological rhetoric. It is a less-common formal type in hip-hop music, especially from the Golden Age and

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[13] Another rap song in contrasting verse-chorus form is Eminem's "Like Toy Soldiers" (2005). The song's verses are squarely in C# minor while the choruses move to the relative major, E, making it an example of what Cristopher Doll would call a "breakout chorus" that uses "expressive modulation" (2011). This pop-rock technique further demonstrates Eminem's position as an artist who has treaded the pop-rap boundary throughout his career.

[14] Outkast is another artist—whose career peaked around the same time as Eminem's—that often uses choruses along these lines.

earlier. But it has become common enough since hip-hop's mainstreaming in the 1990s to demand a place in a typology of form.

The letters in this formal type's name denote similarity and difference among four musical spans. The As represent three sections that are the same (roughly or identically) and the B represents a section that is different.[15] The order of these sections is part and parcel with the overall narrative arc of AABA form: the first two sections are the same and serve to establish a home base as well as expectations regarding the pacing of repetition and change. The B section—most often referred to as the bridge, although "middle eight" has also been used, especially in thirty-two-bar song form—provides contrast and arrives just when a piece or song may be threatening to be boringly repetitive.[16] The final A is a return to home that relieves the tension created by the contrasting B section. The B section is usually subordinate to the A sections. As important as its function of providing contrast may be, it is a diversion or temporary break from the action rather than the focal point of the song.[17]

A pattern with the same narrative arc as AABA form is termed "Statement–Restatement–Departure–Conclusion" (SRDC) by Walter Everett (1999, 318). SRDC was originally coined to refer to relations at the level of the phrase and subphrase (Everett's term for each letter in SRDC is a "gesture"). For example, Trevor de Clercq analyzes the first verse of the Beatles' "From Me to You" in terms of SRDC; each segment of the pattern is two measure in length (de Clercq's analysis is

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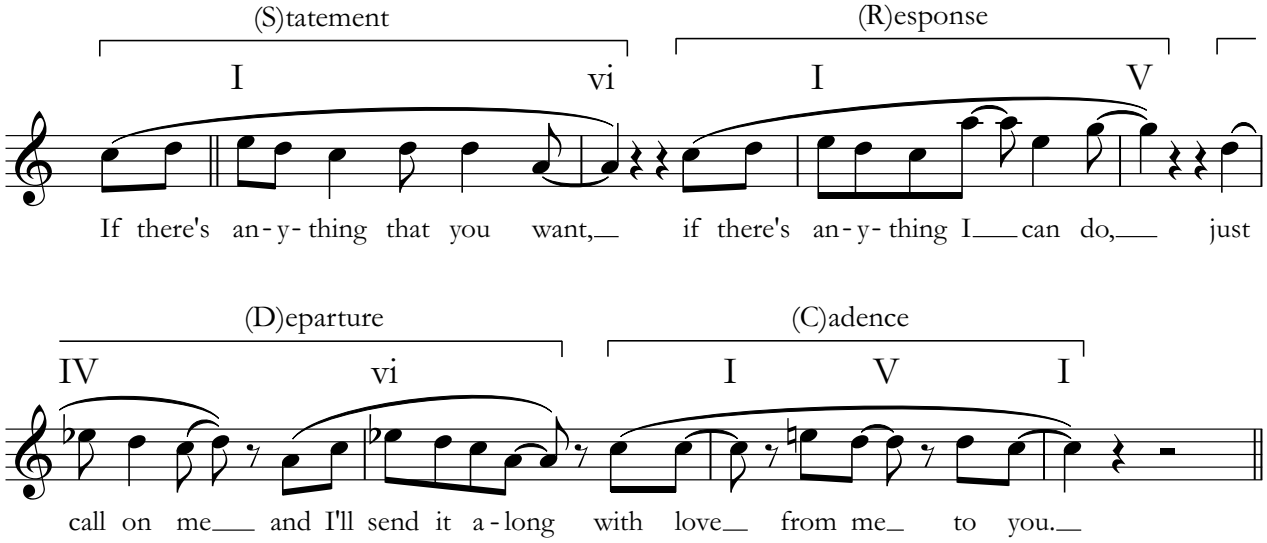
[15] In a classical rounded binary, the repetition of the first section is very often represented by repeat signs, creating exact repetition of that material. In cases without repeat signs, the second A (repeated via a "written out repeat") commonly includes variations. Ken Stephenson even includes "rounded binary" as one of his four popular song form categories. AABA form falls into Stephenson's rounded binary category rather than being its own formal type (2002, 139).

[16] The B section in early AABA forms is more strictly defined than a bridge in the current context: such B sections were almost always eight measures in length and featured contrasting harmonies and new melodic material. In the current context, a bridge may have contrasting melodic and harmonic material but is not necessarily eight measures in length and may achieve contrast in a variety of ways.

[17] Covach discusses an exception to this rule in songs written by Jerry Lieber and Mike Stoller for the Coasters in the 1950s and 60s: "in a dramatic AABA form, the bridge emerges as the narrative climax of the song" (2010, 7).

reproduced in Example 2.15).[18] But SRDC as a concept can be applied at larger scales, up to and including AABA forms spanning entire songs.[19] AABA form and SRDC differ slightly in that the final section of the latter ("Conclusion") does not require a return of previous material, whereas the final A in AABA form implies at least some degree of identity with an earlier section. The final A of an AABA form song still offers concluding function, both because it comes last and because it relieves the tension created by the contrasting bridge. Just as a square is a rectangle but a rectangle is not a square, AABA form may be understood as an SRDC design , but SRDC is not necessarily AABA.

**Example 2.15:** De Clercq's analysis of "From Me to You" (Example 4.3.02 in de Clercq 2012, 156)




The scale of each section in AABA form changes dramatically from genre to genre. In thirty-two-bar song form, the whole is divided evenly into four eight-measure sections. The As and

[18] De Clercq uses "Response" and "Cadence" instead of Everett's "Restatement" and "Conclusion." No discussion of this change in terminology is given in de Clercq's dissertation, perhaps because both versions of the SRDC initialism are so similar in meaning.
[19] An exhaustive discussion of the possible scales of AABA patterns can be found in de Clercq (2012, 143–212).

Bs usually consist of just one phrase. In rock and post-rock genres, the As and Bs can stand for larger sections including full rotations through a verse-refrain or verse-chorus cycle. Covach cites the Beatles' "I Want to Hold Your Hand" (1963), for instance, in which the A sections are twelve measures long and can be segmented into three phrases of four measures each, the last of which contains the song's titular refrain. He later analyzes Boston's "More Than a Feeling" (1976) as an example of compound AABA form, so called because each A section consists of two smaller independent sections: a verse and a chorus (2005, 70–4). The A sections in "More Than a Feeling" not only contain their own rhetorical ebb and flow but are also long and variable in length over of the course of the song. The first is twenty-seven measures long, the second thirty-three, and the third forty-four. A sections in hip-hop routinely consist of more than one independent section (e.g., a verse-hook unit), and the length of these sections is variable (recall from Chapter 2 that verses in hip-hop are particularly wide-ranging in length, both between and within songs). B sections usually consists of one core section (i.e., the bridge). Uncommonly, adjunct sections like links or short instrumentals may surround the bridge section.

A song in AABA form, whether in pop-rock or in hip-hop, rarely consists of just those four sections. Intros and outros commonly frame the central four-part design, as is the case in several of the songs discussed below. Additionally, the As are rarely exact repetitions of each other. Minor changes can be heard in the form of textural variations or additions/subtractions in length. The most common way an A section is modified in hip-hop is to truncate the final A section, especially if it consisted of a verse and a hook during its first two iterations. This final A section usually presents the hook alone (cutting out the verse) as a summarizing and catchy end to the song. Another variant is an extra repetition of one of the A sections, e.g., AAABA. This layout lacks the specific large-scale rhythm of change following one repetition (departure after restatement), but I still consider it to be an AABA form variant because it features contrast created by a bridge over halfway into the song. It is also easily connected to the SRDC pattern as Statement–Restatement–

Restatement of the Restatement–Departure–Conclusion. Examples 2.16a–d summarize AABA form in its standard manifestation and possible variants, all tied together by the SRDC pattern. Another pop-rock variant takes the overall form AABABA. Covach describes this as an "AABAscheme followed by an abbreviated reprise," citing The Beatles' "I Want to Hold Your Hand" as an example (2005, 70). Although AABA BA is a common format in pop-rock, I have only found one example of it in hip-hop: "Twist and Shout" by Salt 'N' Pepa a song analyzed in Chapter 3. AABA BA is scarce in hip-hop possibly because tempos are slower than in pop-rock and because verses can be considerably longer. Both these factors make it less likely to fit the additional sections that result from reprises within the standard three- to five-minute length of pop song.

Musicians employ a variety of strategies to create the all-important contrast typical of bridges. Primary among these in the context of pop-rock music is harmonic contrast. A sections are normally harmonically stable and closed (i.e., ending on tonic) while the bridge is harmonically unstable and open.[20] Since hip-hop is largely based on loops whose harmonic progressions remain the same between sections, harmonic contrast is not a marker of B sections (although one example of a harmonically differentiated hip-hop bridge will be discussed below). Duinker includes bridges as a possible label for sections in the body of hip-hop songs: "The core sequence of a song normally involves verses and hooks, but may also include instrumental or bridge-like sections" (2021a, 3). Duinker's description of the characteristics of bridges in hip-hop is limited to a reference to Ensign's discussion of bridges: "they provide contrast to the verses and hooks" (2015, n. 28). Duinker does not include AABA form as a song form type in his typology, but I contend that enough examples exist in the hip-hop repertoire to reserve space for AABA as a unique song form.

Since harmony is usually not the source of contrast in hip-hop bridges, artists rely on other parameters including timbre, texture, vocal delivery, melody, and rhythm. I propose three types of

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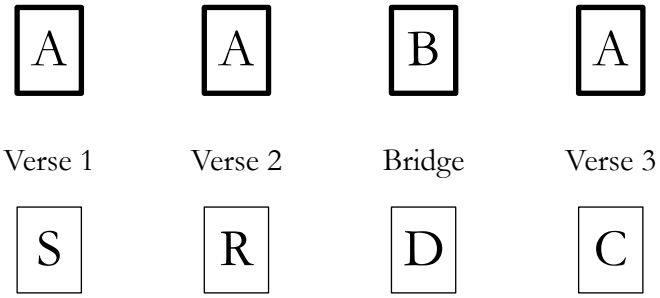
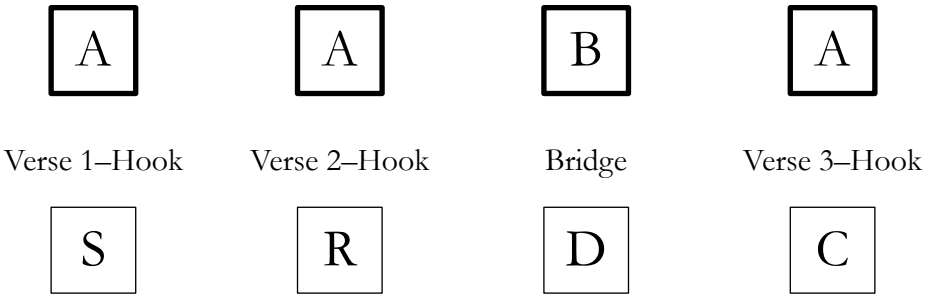
[20] Descriptions along these lines can be found in Everett (1999, 315), Stephenson (2002, 138), Covach (2005, 69–70), Biamonte (2010, n. 26), de Clercq (2012, 71), and many others.

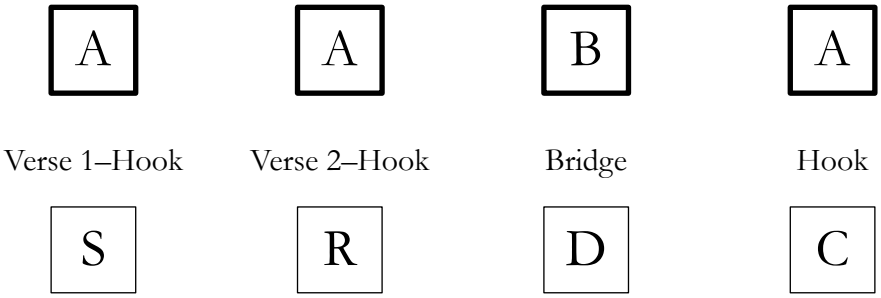
**Example 2.16a**: Standard hip-hop AABA form (As consist of verse only; verse-ending refrains possible)



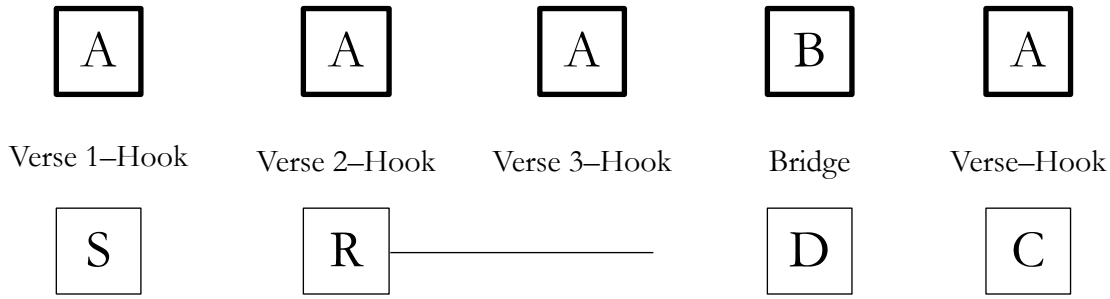

**Example 2.16b**: Standard hip-hop AABA form (As consist of verse and hook; Covach's "Compound AABA")




**Example 2.16c**: Modified AABA form (last A truncated)




**Example 2.16d**: Modified AABA form (extra initial A)



bridges found in AABA song form, each named for the source of contrast: 1) instrumental bridge, 2) sung bridge, and 3) guest verse bridge. An *instrumental bridge* creates contrast primarily through changes in texture and timbre. Whereas the sections preceding an instrumental bridge are formatted in standard hip-hop fashion with a beat layer and a rapped vocal layer, the bridge consists of nothing but instrumental material (this can mean the beat layer alone or a beat layer plus an instrumental solo). As an example, Example 2.17 shows the full form of Monie Love's "Monie in the Middle" (1990). After an intro in which the texture accumulates at regular intervals, the song goes through two verse-hook units. Monie Love raps in the first two verses about being caught between two men: one who is chasing her persistently despite Monie's denials and one that she is interested in who has reciprocated, albeit coolly.[21] Each hook is very typical with an active beat layer, Monie Love repeating the title lyrics, hype vocals within every bar, and response vocals every four bars. After the

**Example 2.17:** Monie Love, "Monie in the Middle," full song form

| AABA form | Time | Section | Texture |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 0:00–0:21 | Intro | Accumulation of beat layers: drums, then bass + organ, then tenor sax |
| A | 0:21–0:54 | Verse 1 | Beat + Monie Love rapping |
| | 0:55–1:11 | Hook | Beat + Monie Love repeating title lyric + response vocals |
| A | 1:12–1:44 | Verse 2 | Beat + Monie Love rapping |
| | 1:45–2:01 | Hook | Beat + Monie Love repeating title lyric + response vocals |
| B | 2:02–2:18 | Bridge | Beat + sax solo |
| A | 2:18–2:35 | Verse 3 | Beat + Monie Love rapping |
| | 2:35–3:44 | Hook | Same as previous hooks (to fade) |

[21] Monie Love (née Simone Johnson) recounts that "Monie in the Middle" was inspired by actual events in her life at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SCqNz3eANtg.

second verse-hook unit, a thinned beat supports a tenor sax solo for the instrumental bridge. The bridge recycles the harmonic content of the verses (a repetitive loop consisting of a C minor chord with non-structural neighboring chords in the guitar and sax layers).[22] Texture and timbre create contrast, rather than harmonic change. The tenor sax has been part of the beat layer for most of the song but during the bridge it is foregrounded dynamically and in terms of melodic and rhythmic content. The verse texture returns after the bridge, laying the foundation for the final A section. Monie Love raps, "Bringing matter to a close and everybody knows / That I'm no longer in the middle / I made my decision, precisely, precision is a must," indicating that the conflict discussed in the first two verses has been resolved. In this way, Monie Love leverages the structure of AABA form by providing a sense of return and narrative resolution in the final A section.[23]

Another type of bridge used in hip-hop is a *sung bridge*. Any extended passage featuring singing stands out in a hip-hop track since singing is not the default vocal delivery style in rap. This is especially true if singing takes place in a section other than the hook/chorus. Singing, therefore, can be a strong source of contrast in most hip-hop songs.[24] Example 2.18 summarizes the form of Eminem's "We Made You" (2009), a song in AABA form that uses a sung bridge. After a brief intro,

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[22] The hooks, however, feature an open oscillating loop that alternates between i and IV in C minor. This "Dorian shuttle" (Spicer 2017, §25) has special relevance to hip-hop because of its common use in funk and disco records including Chic's "Good Times" (1978), the main sample in The Sugar Hill Gang's "Rapper's Delight."

[23] "It's a Shame (My Sister)" is another song from *Down to Earth*—the album on which "Monie in the Middle" appears—that follows a very similar narrative pattern woven into an AABA form. Digable Planets' "Rebirth of Slick (Cool Like Dat)" (1993) is another example of a song in AABA form with an instrumental bridge. Unlike in "Monie in the Middle" and "It's a Shame," the instrumental in "Rebirth of Slick" contains no instrumental solo; it consists of just a stripped-down beat and periodic vocal exclamations.

[24] Singing has become more common over time in all sections of hip-hop songs, especially since Drake's astronomic rise in the 2010s. Drake's use of discreet pitches in most of his verses blur the boundary between R & B and hip-hop. However, Drake's influence has not made singing a default approach to vocal delivery; non- and semi- pitched rapping is still a defining feature of hip-hop. For a thorough investigation of vocal pitch in rap flow, see Komaniecki (2020).

Eminem exclaims, "Jessica Simpson, sing the chorus!"[25] Even if the chorus were not labeled as such by Eminem, it presents elements typical of a chorus (rather than a hook) with its catchy sung melody, chorused response vocals delivered by Eminem, and thick and active texture. Following the initial chorus, "We Made You" goes through two verse-chorus units. The verses feature Eminem rapping over a beat that is slightly thinner the chorus beat (a tambourine and bells are added during the choruses as well as more vocal forces). At the 2:18 mark, after the song's second full verse-chorus unit (i.e., the first two "As" of the AABA form), Eminem sings, creating such contrast that the label bridge is highly appropriate.

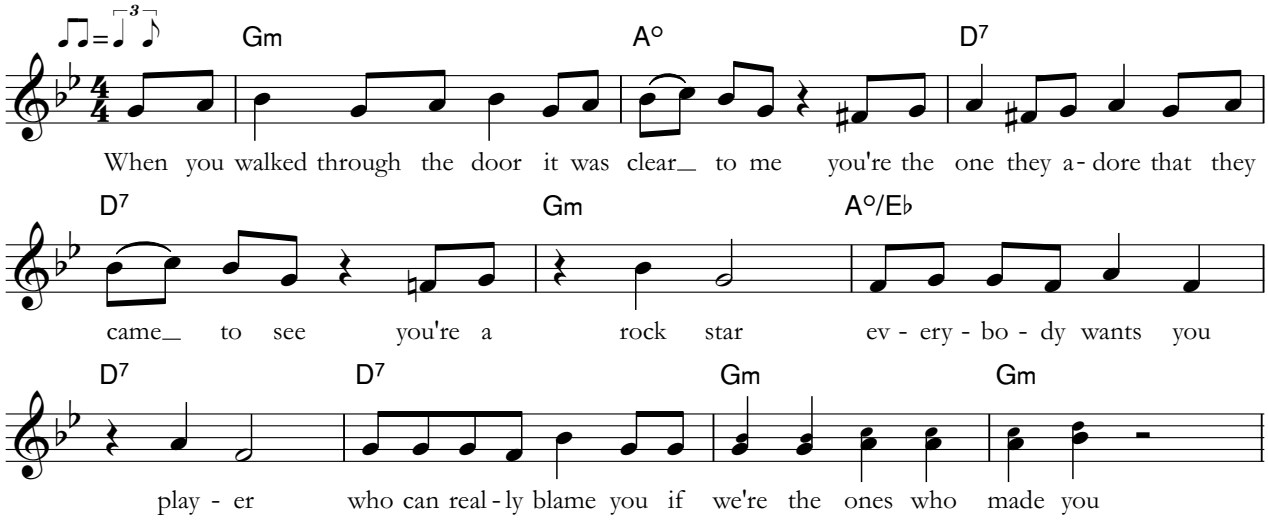
**Example 2.18:** Eminem, "We Made You" full song form

| AABA form | Time | Section | Texture |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 0:00–0:08 | Intro | Partial beat + Eminem speaking |
| | 0:08–0:29 | Chorus | Thick beat + Charmagne Tripp singing |
| A | 0:29–1:02 | Verse 1 | Thinner beat + Eminem rapping |
| | 1:03–1:24 | Chorus | Thick beat + Charmagne Tripp singing |
| A | 1:24–1:57 | Verse 2 | Thinner beat + Eminem rapping |
| | 1:57–2:18 | Chorus | Thick beat + Charmagne Tripp singing |
| B | 2:18–2:35 | Bridge | Thinner beat + Eminem singing |
| A | 2:35–3:09 | Verse 3 | Thinner beat + Eminem rapping |
| | 3:09–3:30 | Chorus | Thick beat + Charmagne Tripp singing |
| | 3:30–4:29 | Outro | Thinner beat + Eminem singing (to fade) |

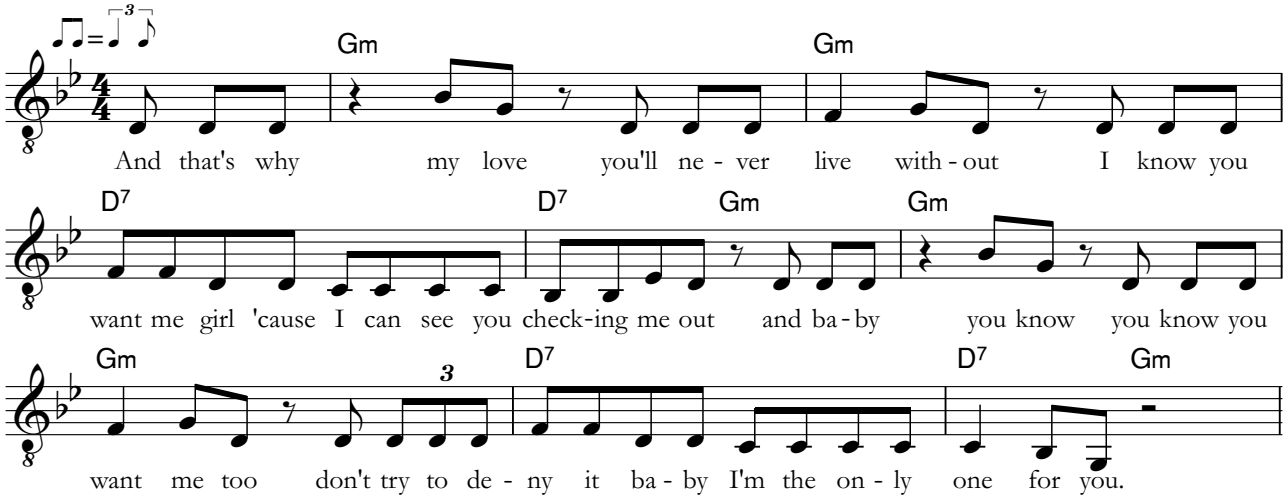
[25] The chorus was actually recorded by Charmagne Tripp. Eminem's reference to her as Jessica Simpson goes along with the concept of the song, which mocks celebrity culture in the U.S. Among the other celebrities mentioned in "We Made You" are Kim Kardashian, Amy Winehouse, Bret Michaels, and Lindsay Lohan. Eminem also explicitly announces the chorus in another song from about ten years before "We Made You": in "Real Slim Shady" (2000), he ends his first verse with the lyrics "sing the chorus and it goes…."

Not only is the timbre of Eminem's singing voice different than anything that has come thus far in the song, his melodic content is new; most significantly, it is a different melody than Tripp sings during the chorus. Examples 2.19a–b compare the melodies sung by Tripp and Eminem in the choruses and the bridge, respectively. The two melodies are almost entirely motivically unrelated, other than being anacrustic. Additionally, the two sections have different chord progressions: while

**Example 2.19a:** Chorus of "We Made You," Tripp's melody and chords




**Example 2.19b:** Bridge of "We Made You," Eminem's melody and chords



the chorus has a wider variety of harmonies including a supertonic diminished chords, the bridge features simple alternation between tonic and dominant, which is the same progression as in the verses. It is worth noting one interesting similarity between the melodies in these two sections. Both Tripp and Eminem use the subtonic scale degree over major dominant chords, creating a dissonance between the pitch classes F and F#.[26] This points to some influence between the two artists in the recording and production process, but certainly does not prevent the bridge from creating clear contrast with the rest of the song.

It is also possible to hear the passage under discussion as what Mark Spicer terms a "postchorus." Eminem's singing excerpt is a "self-contained passage that can be heard as a departure from the chorus and yet does not serve merely as a transition to the next verse" (2011, §9). Indeed, there is nothing open-ended or strongly transitional about Eminem's sung section. Cara Stroud extends Spicer's idea by distinguishing two types of postchoruses: the codetta-type postchorus and the anthem-type postchorus. The former "is identified by its emphasis on closure" (2022, §1.1) and maps well onto "We Made You." Closure is achieved at the end of each of the song's choruses, but the $V^7$–i authentic cadence and brief musical silence after the words "one for you" reaffirm this closure. The postchorus reading not only reflects the musical features and relations in "We Made You," it also aligns with musical practices of post-millennial pop. Aside from a few precedents noted by Spicer in songs from the year 1970, both he and Stroud connect postchoruses with popular releases from the first fifteen years of the twenty-first century. Nonetheless, postchoruses usually occur after every chorus of a song and the bridge/postchorus only appears once in "We Made You" after the second VCU. It is also longer and more lyrically substantive than any of the songs analyzed by Spicer or Stroud, leaving the both the bridge and postchorus interpretations viable.

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[26] This crunchy sonority is related to the common blues practice of mixing minor pentatonic collections in the melodic layer with dominant seventh chords in the harmonic layer. The former includes the subtonic scale degree and the latter the leading tone.

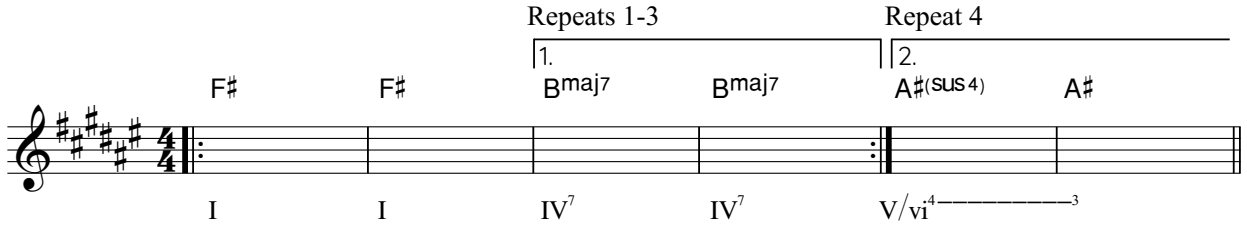
Another example of song with a sung bridge is "Empire State of Mind" (2009). While "We Made You" and "Empire State of Mind" both feature sung bridges (and were released in the same year), the latter's formal layout and musical features within each section are much more typical of pop-rock music. As shown in Example 2.20, "Empire State of Mind" goes through three verse-chorus cycles before moving to a bridge and closing with a chorus, making for a modified AABA form such that there are three initial As rather than two. "Empire State of Mind" has distinct harmonic progressions in the verses and choruses, evincing a fusion of pop and hip-hop sensibilities. Along these lines, the harmonic progression in the bridge is also unique to that section. Examples 2.21a–c show the verse and chorus progressions and compare them with the bridge progression. The effect of the bridge harmonies aligns fairly well with the descriptions of traditional bridges as discussed by Covach, de Clercq, and others cited above: it takes the song away from tonic and prepares a return to a familiar progression near its end. The final chord (a V/vi) is not the typical dominant harmony expected at the end of a Tin Pan Alley bridge, but it prepares the return of the chorus in this song because it is the same chord used before each previous chorus. In the

**Exampe 3.20:** "Empire State of Mind," full song form

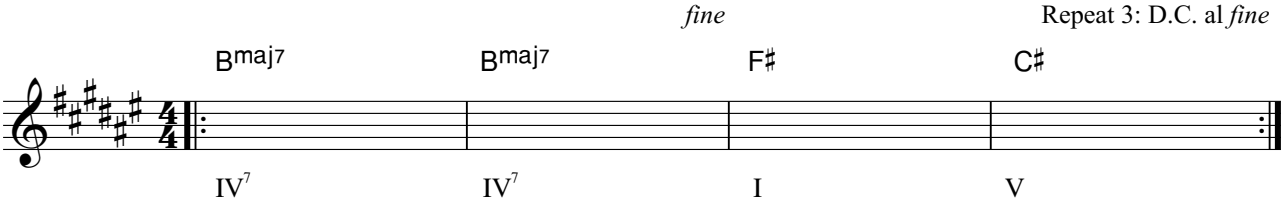
| AABA form | Time | Section | Texture |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 0:00–0:09 | Intro | Drums only |
| A | 0:10–0:54 | Verse 1 | Full beat + Jay-Z rapping |
| | 0:55–1:22 | Chorus | Alicia Keys singing |
| A | 1:22–2:06 | Verse 2 | Jay-Z rapping |
| | 2:07–2:34 | Chorus | Alicia Keys singing |
| A | 2:34–3:19 | Verse 3 | Jay-Z rapping |
| | 3:19–3:46 | Chorus | Alicia Keys singing |
| B | 3:47–4:03 | Bridge | Alicia Keys singing |
| A | 4:03–4:36 | Chorus | Alicia Keys singing |

verses, the V/vi threatens to bring the song away from its happy major-mode landscape towards the relative minor key of D#. This chord resolves deceptively upon the arrival of each chorus, however to a B major seventh chord ($IV^{maj7}$ in the home key of F# major and VI in the relative minor key D# minor). This allows the chorus to recycle the verse progression (essentially an oscillation between I and IV) in retrograde by starting on IV and relaxing to I in the third bar. Because the bridge ends with the same secondary dominant that ends each verse, the truncation of the final A

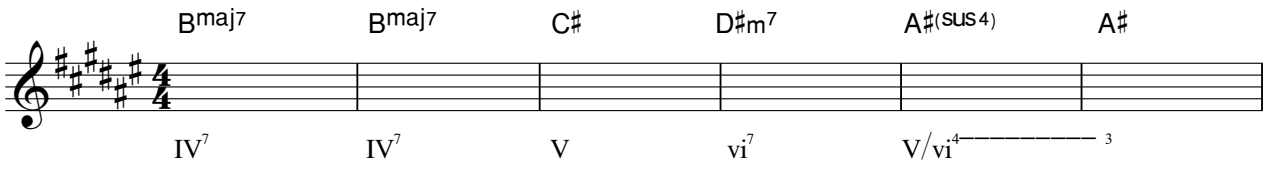
**Example 2.21a:** "Empire State of Mind," verse harmonic progression




**Example 2.21b:** "Empire State of Mind," chorus harmonic progression




**Example 2.21c:** "Empire State of Mind," bridge harmonic progression



section to a chorus without a verse is achieved very naturally.[27] The contrast provided by the harmonies in this bridge is quite noticeable, which is perhaps necessary in the context of "Empire State of Mind" because Alicia Keys has already been heard singing throughout the song.

The final type of bridge used in hip-hop is a *guest appearance bridge*, which occurs when the source of contrast is created by changes in voice heard and, often, flow style. Vocal timbre is a central agent of difference in this type of bridge. The guest appearance bridge is the rarest type of bridge; featured artists usually rap in the second verse slot, meaning that their contrasting vocal timbre and flow would come during the second big section of a song, deflating the large scale statement–restatement–departure–return rhythm of AABA form.[28] The guest appearance bridge is also endemic to music released more recently in hip-hop's history: rap collectives/rap groups were much more the norm during the Golden Age of hip-hop and earlier, making guest appearances both less common and less capable of creating contrast. Individual acts became the industry standard in the late 1990s, which created a context in which a guest artist's vocal timbre and flow had a much stronger ability to create contrast. Juxtaposing a guest artist with several different rappers is less aurally notable than juxtaposing them with one artist who delivers several verses.[29]

As an example of a guest appearance verse, Example 2.22 outlines the form of "a lot" by 21 Savage featuring J. Cole (2018). A number of aspects of this song are interesting, both in terms of and aside from its AABA pattern. The first two hooks are substantially longer than the verses that they are paired with, which is the reserve of the normal situation. The order of the verses and hooks is also reversed between the first two verse-hook cycles. J. Cole's verse (which constitutes the guest appearance bridge) is long enough to outweigh any of the repeated sections like the hooks, links,

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[27] The only time a vi chord (i of the relative minor) is actually used is in the bridge as a deceptive resolution from V of the home key F# major.

[28] Examples of songs in which the guest verse comes in the second position include Eminem's verse on "Forgot About Dre," Raekwon's on "Skew It on the Bar-B," and Lil' Kim's on Mobb Deep's remix of "Quiet Storm."

[29] Robert Komaniecki demonstrates the opposite phenomenon: collaboration between artists yielding "unified flow" (2017, abstract).

and intro/outro. Contrast in the B section thus results from the change to J. Cole's vocal timbre and from the substantial weight of his section.

**Example 2.22:** "a lot," full song form[30]

| AABA form | Time | Section | Texture |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 0:00–0:19 | Intro | Texture builds |
| A | 0:19–0:51 | Hook | Full beat + 21 Savage rapping |
| | 0:52–1:04 | Verse 1 | Full beat + 21 Savage rapping |
| | 1:05–1:18 | Link | Full beat + rhythmic vocal sample |
| A | 1:18–1:44 | Verse 2 | Full beat + 21 Savage rapping |
| | 1:45–2:11 | Hook | Full beat + 21 Savage rapping |
| | 2:11–2:37 | Link | Full beat + vocal sample + J. Cole ad libbing |
| B | 2:37–3:43 | Verse 3 | Texture builds + J. Cole rapping |
| A | 3:43–4:09 | Hook | Full beat + 21 Savage rapping |
| | 4:09–4:48 | Outro | Full beat + vocal sample |

AABA form is far from the default song form used in hip-hop, but the preceding examples show that it occurs enough across the genre's history to be included in a typology of form. There are differences between AABA form in hip-hop and its various manifestations in earlier genres, but the large-scale patterning statement–restatement–departure–return is the common thread that leads me to name it in the same way as Tin Pan Alley songs.

Compound Song Form

The final song form in this typology is compound song form. A song in compound song form sounds as if it is made up of two (or more) separate songs that have been stitched together. I

[30] DJ Dahi, the producer of "a lot," details how he developed the song's beat in an interview with Genius.com: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WwYX6iIodqI&t=346s.

refer to the dividing line between the two constituent songs as the rupture. In most compound songs, there is just one rupture, meaning that two songs have been put together. In some more extreme cases, there are two ruptures, meaning that at least three songs have been Frankensteined into one, creating a compound form.[31] This usually means that—since the sound world of most hip-hop songs is dependent on the beat—an entirely new beat will replace the one that started the song. Often, a new tempo takes over after a rupture as well. The word compound is used here slightly differently than in some other contexts, like Covach's "compound AABA form." Instead of describing a section made up of smaller sections (e.g., an A section within an AABA consisting itself of a verse and a chorus), compound song form describes a song that appears to be made up of more than one song, or at least snippets of more than one song. Each large section on either side of a compound song's rupture need not consist of a verse-hook cycle, or any particular section(s) for that matter. Its compound-ness occurs at the level of the song, not the level of the section (hence the name compound *song* form, rather than just compound form). This unique song form is indicative of the influence of popular dance music, particularly EDM, on hip-hop in the last decade.[32]

Compound song form is a phenomenon found in fairly recent releases, at least within hip-hop, but there is related historical precedent in rock music from decades ago. Ken Stephenson's term for such songs is compound-binary form. I quote Stephenson here at length because his thorough definition of compound-binary form is an instructive starting point for defining its use in hip-hop:

> A song composed in compound-binary form, heard mainly in the 1960s and 1970s, can be divided into two principal parts. In many songs, the two parts are even labeled separately, as in Chicago's "Dialogue (Parts I & II)." In a compound-binary song, the first part, itself as long or longer than a normal song, usually follows one of the forms outlined above. As a result it may be dubbed a "super-

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[31] This is true of the song that has kicked off the most recent interest among hip-hop artists in using compound form, "Sicko Mode" by Travis Scott (2018).
[32] See Adams (2019) for a discussion of the influence of EDM on form in (non-hip-hop) pop music in recent years.

> section": although a principal division of a piece, it in turn is divided into several sections. The second part is generally structured around several repetitions of a single melodic line or chord progression or both. This second division or part as a rule presents previously unheard material; were it otherwise, the passage would not be distinguished as transcendent to the form of the first part (Stephenson 2002, 141–42).

Stephenson cites The Beatles' "Hey Jude" (1968) as an exemplar of compound-binary. Other examples include Derek and the Dominoes' "Layla" (1970), Grand Funk Railroad's "Close to Home/I'm Your Captain" (1970), and Led Zeppelin's "Stairway to Heaven" (1971) (142). In his definition, Stephenson notes the importance of repetitions of "a single melodic line or chord progression." Another aspect of these second parts that perhaps results naturally from the emphasis on single riffs/chord loops is a subordination of lyrics. The second parts of each of the classic rock songs just cited are far less lyrically dense than their first parts. The bulk of the narrative or imagery of the song is carried by the first part while the second part contains a brief turn to optimistic lyrics ("Stairway"), singalong syllables and the title lyric ("Hey Jude" and "I'm Your Captain"), or no lyrics at all ("Layla"). Brad Osborn (2013) discusses related compositional strategies in experimental rock from the late 1990s and early 2000s, which he terms terminally climactic forms (TCFs). There is a great deal of overlap between Osborn's theory and Mark Spicer's cumulative form, though Osborn differentiates himself by defining TFCs as being non-recapitulatory (24). Spicer discusses even earlier examples of "multisongs," "epic tracks in which the multiple shifts of groove and affect sound as if two or more songs have been stitched together" (2018, 126). Spicer agrees with Albin Zak, who points to the Beach Boys' "Good Vibrations" (1966) as a trend-setting song that sounds in multiple distinct parts. The competitive back and forth between the Beach Boys and the Beatles led the latter group to release such multisongs as "A Day in the Life" (1967) and "Happiness is a Warm Gun" (1968). Electric Light Orchestra then released multisongs including "Mr. Blue Sky" and "Wild West Hero" under the influence of the Beatles (113).

The key ingredient shared between these authors' definitions and my own conception of compound form in hip-hop is the autonomy of the large sections of the song. The sections of a compound-binary song are substantial enough in length and content to stand on their own, in some cases as full songs and at least as full sections.[33] Stephenson even notes that "the piece known as 'Layla' came about as a simple concatenation of two pieces: a song by Eric Clapton and an instrumental by the drummer Jim Gordon" (142). Osborn's Terminally Climactic Units (TCUs) are usually autonomous as sections but not songs.[34] The constituent sections of compound songs in hip-hop are autonomous *and* different enough to be standalone songs, or at least cut from the cloth of different songs. Another feature unique to hip-hop is the rupture. In the songs analyzed by Stephenson and Osborn, there is a fairly smooth (if not carefully planned-out) transition between the first part and the second part/TCU. The later two of Osborn's three TCF categories (three-part, and extended) are defined by the presence and significance of bridging or transitional material between the first part of the song and the TCU. The division between sections in hip-hop's compound song forms is more often than not abrupt, seemingly purposefully planned to surprise the listener. Material on either side of the rupture is usually drastically different, connected sometimes just by the common thread of a rapper's voice.

Travis Scott's "Sicko Mode" can be considered a *locus classicus* of compound song form in recent hip-hop. Virtually every review of the song following its release in August of 2018 remark on two aspects: the song's unconventional form and its chart-topping success despite that form. Brendan Klinkenberg of *Rolling Stone* wrote, "instrumentally, 'Sicko Mode' is three songs in one, and Scott's instincts are the reason he can pull it off."[35] The phrase "pull it off" implies that Scott took a

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[33] The first section of a compound-binary form song usually is understood by Stephenson as an autonomous song. He remarks about "Hey Jude," "This [first] part of the composition could have stood as the entire song; it lasts a full three minutes and six seconds" (2002, 142).
[34] A possible exception is the Decembrists's "The Crane Wife I & II," (2006), his first example of an extended TCF, although Osborn does not go so far, claiming "the eleven-minute track is far too unified to be composed of two separate songs" (38).
[35] https://www.rollingstone.com/music/music-news/travis-scott-sicko-mode-song-708140/.

risk releasing a song that stitches together what could have been multiple distinct tracks. A more colorful description from Michael Saponara for *Billboard* reads, "'Sicko Mode' was like watching a mad scientist at work … as the 26-year-old perfectionist concocted the experimental three-part composition."[36] Saponara also observes the unlikeliness of "Sicko Mode" performing so well in the popular sphere, calling it "the most atypical radio hit in recent memory." In a more recent piece discussing formal trends in popular music more generally, Nate Sloan and Charlie Harding write, "in 2018's 'Sicko Mode,' the rapper Travis Scott stretches formal boundaries further, stitching together three disjunct songs—with separate flows, melodies and beats—into one mad-scientist, Frankenstein track."[37]

"Sicko Mode" is indeed unconventional in terms of song form and has been very successful in terms of chart performance and air time.[38] It is also literally a combination of multiple songs.[39] Perhaps it is because of this unusual large-scale organization that there seem to be as many different descriptions of the form as there are authors that have written about it. The simplest may be from Sloan and Harding, who offer the rather agnostic analytical graphic reproduced in Example 2.23.[40] Others refer at time to verses (Saponara 2018, Unterberger 2018[41]), a chorus within the song's third part (*Genius* lyric chart),[42] and the first part being an intro (Klinkenberg 2018). Despite these varied interpretations, the large three-part structure seems fairly easy to agree upon. Example 2.24 details

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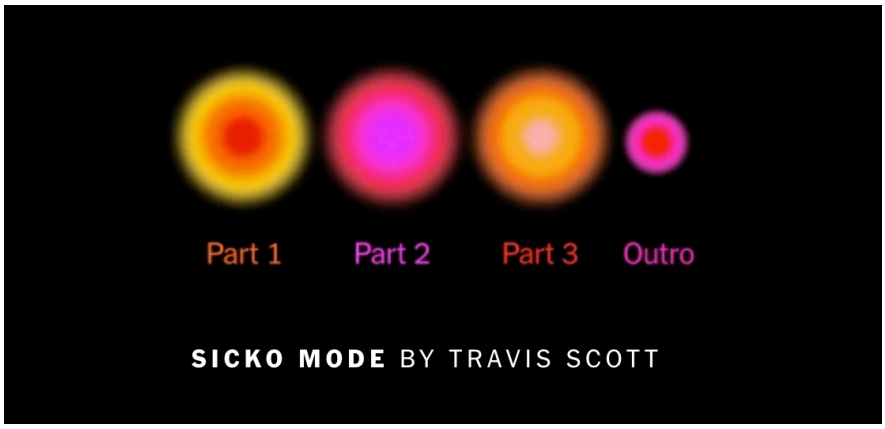
[36] https://www.billboard.com/music/rb-hip-hop/travis-scott-sicko-mode-number-one-hit-8488882/.
[37] https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2021/03/14/opinion/pop-music-songwriting.html.
[38] The song debuted at #4 on the *Billboard* Hot 100 for the week of August 18, 2018 rose to #1 the week of December 8, 2018, and remained in the top five for another ten weeks.
[39] Contributing producer Rogét Chahayed has reported that "a full track between Drake and Travis over the initial ominous beat exists somewhere in the digital world" that ended up as the first minute of the song. https://www.billboard.com/music/rb-hip-hop/travis-scott-sicko-mode-number-one-hit-8488882/.
[40] Sloan and Harding discuss "Sicko Mode" in more detail in episode #95 of their podcast *Switched on Pop*, although formal specifics within each of the three parts are not mentioned.
[41] https://www.billboard.com/pro/travis-scott-sicko-mode-number-one-paul-mccartney-band-on-the-run/.
[42] https://genius.com/Travis-scott-sicko-mode-lyrics and Saponara (2018).

the form of "Sicko Mode," showing the large-scale division into three parts as well as my analysis of the sections comprising each part. The Parts 1, 2, and 3 correspond to those analyzed by Sloan and Harding in Example 2.23. There is only one rupture shown in Example 2.24, but two really exist: the

**Example 2.23**: Form of "Sicko Mode" as presented by Nate Sloan and Charlie Harding




first (occurring right around the one-minute mark) is represented because it has duration, whereas the second (dividing Parts 2 and 3 around 2:55) does not. A single listen through the song will quickly demonstrate the differences between the parts and show why they are easy to hear as three different songs combined into one. The tempo changes between Part 1 to Part 2.[43] The beats themselves are also drastically different. Part 1's beat is characterized by layered organs playing chords steadily that change once per measure. Part 2's beat is much more drum-forward and uses less pitched material with the exception of the synthesized riff shown in Example 2.25. Part 2's hollower beat also makes use of short rhythmic punctuations ranging from synthesized sweep timbres to ad lib and echo vocals, making it sound more chaotic than the other two parts. Part 3's beat is something of a middle ground between that of the first two Parts. As Example 2.26 shows, the beat consists of a minimalistic trap drum pattern, a rumbling and percussive bass part, and

[43] One can entrain fairly easily to two different pulse streams in all three parts. Part 1's tempo can thus be described as 70 or 140 bpm while the tempo in Parts 2 and 3 is 78 or 156.

twominor mode bell-timbre riffs. The high bell riff enters and leaves the texture at various points during Part 3 but is included in the core beat because of its memorability.[44]

**Example 2.24:** Form of "Sicko Mode" with time stamps and significant textural and metrical events events[45]

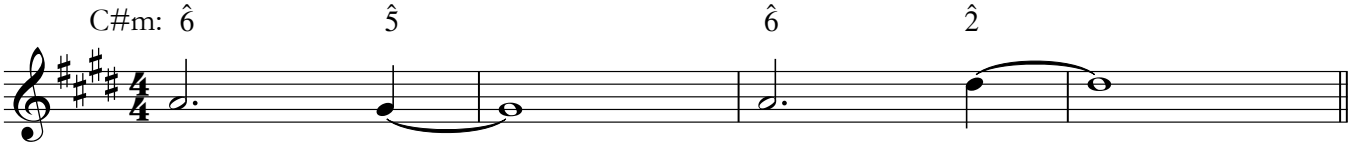
| Part | Time | Section | Texture/Tempo |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 0:00–0:26 | Intro. | Intrumental intro. then Drake sing/ rapping |
| | 0:26–0:54 | Intro./Verse | Drake singing |
| | 0:55–0:58 | Verse | Beat drops, Drake rapping |
| | 0:58–1:00 | Rupture | Reverb from last sounds of part 1 |
| 2 | 1:00–1:40 | Verse | Two-measure upbeat then Scott rapping over active trap beat |
| | 1:40–1:52 | Hook A | Beat drops out, sampled vocals by Big Hawk and new vocals by Swae Lee |
| | 1:52–2:36 | Verse | Scott rapping over active trap beat |
| | 2:36–2:55 | Hook A | Beat drops out, sampled vocals by Big Hawk and new vocals by Swae Lee |
| 3 | 2:56–3:08 | Intro. | Minimalist trap beat with minor bell riff |
| | 3:08–3:24 | Hook B | Drake rapping, drums drops out for most of hook |
| | 3:24–4:10 | Verse | Minimalist trap beat with Drake rapping |
| | 4:10–4:28 | Hook B | Minimalist trap beat with minor bell riff and Drake rapping |
| | 4:29–5:00 | Verse | Minimalist trap beat with Scott rapping |
| | 5:00–5:12 | Outro | Half-time beat |

[44] Gary Burns (whose theory of hooks in popular music was discussed in Chapter 2) may well have called this bell riff a hook.

[45] Details regarding the texture and beat construction of "Sicko Mode" were retrieved from Who Sampled (https://www.whosampled.com/Travis-Scott/SICKO-MODE/).

It is not just the differences in beats between the parts that make "Sicko Mode" so interesting but the way in which the song is stitched together. The ruptures and the moments surrounding them are built to keep listeners on their toes. Part 1 begins with an instrumental intro

**Example 2.25**: "Sicko Mode," Part 2, main pitched riff




**Example 2.26**: "Sicko Mode," Part 3, core beat

featuring a looping two-chord progression played on organ and repeated every two measures.[46] Drake enters with sung lyrics twenty-seven seconds in, at which point it is not immediately obvious whether he is participating in a continuation of the intro or starting a verse because the full beat does not drop. Drake's passage takes on more obvious intro function when he trails off at forty-one seconds, still before the drums have entered. Finally, at forty-eight seconds into the song, a triplet

[46] The organ loop changes at 0:13, starting at a higher pitch level and increasing in length to be an eight measure loop with harmonies still changing once per measure. This detail is not particularly relevant to the present discussion.

snare fill modified with a filter sweep begins, signaling an impending beat drop. Drake plays along by repeating the exclamation "Yeah!," a typical ad lib vocal indicating that a rapper is hyping him or herself up to begin a verse. The beat drops emphatically at 0:55 and Drake starts rapping over a grandiose ("banger") beat. It is the drawn-out lead up to such a satisfying beat drop that makes the rupture that comes three seconds later so surprising. Just as Drake seems to be getting down to business, everything stops. Part 2 takes off with much less effort than Part 1 did: four succinct bass hits are all Travis Scott needs before he launches straight into a verse. The song does not care how surprised its listeners are at the rupture, it's moving on.

I further argue that it is the relatively early location of this rupture within the five-minute song that has made "Sick Mode" stand out from other compound song form songs. Two very famous hip-hop tracks from earlier in the decade are in compound song form: Kanye West and Jay-Z's "N****s In Paris" (2011), and Kendrick Lamar's "m.A.A.d city" (2012).[47] The rupture in Kanye's braggadocious pump-up anthem takes place at the 2:43 mark, over two-thirds of the way into the song. "N****as In Paris" has also already gone through two complete verse-hook cycles before the rupture and second part. The rupture (which, like the first rupture in "Sicko Mode," has duration from 2:43–2:56) also maintains the tempo of the first part of the song, and while the insistent static noise that takes over the texture is certainly surprising, there isn't a strong indication that the song is not going to return to any of its previous material until the other side of the rupture. The rupture in "m.A.A.d. city" similarly takes place after two and a half minutes and a tidy intro–hook–verse–hook–outro structure, constituting a long-verse form. Both "N****s In Paris" and "m.A.A.d city" could ostensibly be heard as consisting of two songs stitched together, but "Sicko Mode" is an extraordinary example of the expressive power of compound song form because the "first song" that makes it up never gets going.

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[47] Another example released after "Sicko Mode" that will not be discussed for the sake of space is "Life Is Good" by Future featuring Drake (2020).

Summary

This chapter has presented a typology of song forms I have found to be most commonly used in hip-hop music, as summarized in Example 2.27. The song forms consist of the section types and formal functions developed in Chapter 2. They can theoretically be applied to hip-hop from any chronological period or style, although certain formal types are more strongly connected with certain eras and subgenres (e.g., strophic form with Golden Age hip-hop and verse-chorus form with pop-rap). The following two chapters use these typologies as theoretical backgrounds for case studies in the use of form in hip-hop.

**Example 2.27**: Summary of song forms

| Song form type | Key characteristics |
|---|---|
| Prime-verse form | • Verses are expressive locus; format of hip-hop's earliest recorded corpus<br>• Encompasses verse-hook form, strophic form, long-verse form (listed from highest degree of text repetition to least) |
| Verse-chorus form | • Representative form of pop-rap stylistic blend<br>• Sections alternating with verses contain singing and often different harmonic progression than verse<br>• Arrival of chorus is predictable in some way |
| AABA form | • Sections succeed in Statement–Restatement–Departure–Conclusion format<br>• Contains a bridge (instrumental, sung, or guest verse) which contrasts with verses/verse-hook units that constitute A sections |
| Compound song form | • Single song that sounds as if it were made up of two or more songs stitched together in succession<br>• Moment of division between parts is a rupture |

# CHAPTER 3: FORM IN SALT-N-PEPA'S RAP VERSIONS

Hip-hop is a music rooted in borrowing. It is unique in the degree to which it relies on refashioning existing sounds, even though recycling of musical material is a practice that long predates hip-hop. Scholars have generated an extensive body of work investigating musical borrowing in hip-hop from various angles, probably because it has been an integral feature of hip-hop since its earliest days. Topics covered by this corpus of scholarship include sampling technology (George 2004), legal issues (Sinnreich 2010; Stoia, Adams, and Drakulich 2018; Sloan and Harding 2020), musical analysis (Ohriner 2019b, Tatar 2019), sampling aesthetics and culture (Schloss 2004, Williams 2013), and ontological inquiry (Adams 2015). One topic that bears further discussion is how musical borrowing and musical form interact, an analytical angle that affords abundant opportunities to better understand conventions of genre, intertextuality, and the perception of form in hip-hop. This chapter demonstrates such affordances by focusing on the intersection of borrowing and form in the music of one of hip-hop's most successful female groups, Salt-N-Pepa. The trio of Salt (Cheryl James), Pepa (Sandra Denton), and DJ Spinderella (Deidre Roper) recorded several rap versions of existing songs across their discography to fair commercial success.[1] This chapter compares Salt-N-Pepa's "Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang (It's Your Thing)" with earlier versions of each song by the Beatles and the Isley Brothers, respectively. In both cases, there is more ambiguity to deal with in interpreting the form of the original song than in Salt-N-Pepa's version. The hip-hop trio's versions are clearer in terms of formal functions and segmentation than the source tracks.

[1] The term "rap versions" is taken from Mark Spicer (who, in turn, borrows it from Tim Hughes [1999]) to describe rap songs "in which a distinctive element of a pre-existing song is lifted out of its original context—typically via digital sampling—and used as the foundation upon which a new song is built" (2009, 347).

Background

Queens, New York natives Cheryl James and Sandra Denton became Salt and Pepa in 1985 after releasing a modestly successful record called "The Showstopper," recorded and produced by Hurby Azor. Azor was their co-worker at Sears at the time and would go on to produce four of the group's five albums, as well as being Salt's boyfriend for the latter half of the 1980s.[2] The group added a third member in Spinderella[3] and rose to international fame less than a year later with their first album, *Hot, Cool, and Vicious* (1986). The album's most successful song was the B-side single "Push It," a song that James and Denton were not enthused about recording because of concerns that the public would pin them as sellouts (Weingarten 2017).[4] Their next album, *A Salt With A Deadly Pepa* (1988), was notable for including three rap versions of existing popular songs. After another album in 1990 (*Blacks' Magic*), 1993's *Most Necessary* featured "Whatta Man," another moderately successful versioned song. Example 3.1 lists each of these versions, aligning them with the original song, artist, and year.

Salt-N-Pepa were not the first group to release rap versions of pop-rock songs. The most well-known and commercially successful example is Run-D.M.C.'s "Walk This Way" with Aerosmith from 1986, a cover of Aerosmith's original song of the same name from 1975. Run-D.M.C.'s producer Rick Rubin had the idea to go beyond simply covering a rock song by bringing in Steven Tyler and Joe Perry of Aerosmith to collaborate on the recording. According to D.M.C. (Darryl

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[2] "The Showstopper" was a class project for the music production program in which Azor was enrolled. It was an ambitious project considering that he produced "The Showstopper" for a grade: the song was an answer record to Doug E. Fresh's "The Show" and it peaked at #46 on the US *Billboard* R&B chart.

[3] Deidre Roper joined the group in 1987 after Salt-N-Pepa's first DJ, Pamela Latoya Greene, left them to get married. Greene was also called DJ Spinderella, but Roper was in the role for a longer period and is more often remembered as *the* DJ Spinderella (Elafros 2007, 201).

[4] This attitude towards a pop-oriented song that ended up being a hit parallels De La Soul's feelings about their most popular record, "Me Myself and I."

**Example 3.1:** Salt-N-Pepa's rap versions

| Original Song | Original Artist | Salt-N-Pepa Version |
|---|---|---|
| "Twist And Shout" (1961/62/63) | The Top Notes/The Isley Brothers/The Beatles | "Twist And Shout" (1988) |
| "It's Your Thing" (1969) | The Isley Brothers | "Shake Your Thang (It's Your Thing)" (1988) |
| "I Gotcha" (1972) | Joe Tex | "I Gotcha" (1988) |
| "What A Man" (1968) | Linda Lyndell | "Whatta Man" (1993) |

McDaniels), he and Run (Joseph Simmons) were hesitant to redo a rock song and were more excited about their originals for *Raising Hell*, the album on which "Walk This Way" ended up appearing.[5] Songs like "My Adidas," "It's Tricky," and "Peter Piper" did become fan favorites, but "Walk This Way" was the shining star. It was the first rap record to be widely played on mainstream pop radio stations in the United States, skyrocketed *Raising Hell's* success exponentially, and ostensibly "established [rap] as a viable pop form" (Light 2004, 140). It is somewhat surprising that there were not more rap-rock collaborations during the Golden Age of hip-hop considering how well Rubin and Run-D.M.C.'s experiment worked.[6] Nonetheless, they created a workable template and Salt-N-Pepa's versions represent a contemporary artist's fusion of rap with pop-rock. Although I am unaware of any reports by or about the group explicitly stating that they were following the Run-D.M.C. mold, Azor's acumen for producing popular records leads me to believe that he saw covers as a path to commercial success.

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[5] McDaniels relays this information and much more about "Walk This Way" in an interview at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5ikJrtxRovI.

[6] Michael Berry notes one other group who participated in the rap cover trend: "The Fat Boys covered songs that the previous generation grew up with, like 'Wipeout,' 'Louie Louie,' and 'The Twist' (which featured Chubby Checker, the artist who popularized the original version of the song)" (2018, 106). Later examples of rap versions include Coolio's "Gangsta's Paradise" (1995) and several tracks by Will Smith—"Just the Two of Us" (1997), "Men in Black," and "Wild Wild West" (1999). Other rap-rock collaborations include Public Enemy's version of "Bring The Noise" with metal band Anthrax and the soundtrack to the movie *Judgment Night*.

Versions, Covers, and Signifyin(g)

Before proceeding to analyses of Salt-N-Pepa's covers, it is worth considering how exactly the terms "version" and "cover" are defined in the present context. The term cover originally had "purely commercial connotations" in the Anglophone popular music world: "In the 1950s and 60s, a cover typically entailed the re-recording of a song, for the purposes of disseminating it among a broader or different section of the record-buying public from that of the original" (Witmer and Marks, 2001). This conception of a cover implies the goal of replicating the original song. Oftentimes, cover versions became more commercially successful than the originals, especially if a white group covered a song originally recorded by a black group. This is true in the case of one of the songs to be discussed below, "Twist and Shout": while the Isley Brothers' version was fairly successful, the Beatles' cover was much more so.[7] Covers can also allow artists to express rather than mimic. Witmer and Marks' example is Tina Turner's cover of The Beatles' "Help," which "changes the melody and harmony so fundamentally that it is scarcely the same song as that written by Lennon and McCartney" (ibid.). Dai Griffiths' terms "rendition" and "transformation" neatly describe the two approaches to covers described here, the former applying to "Twist and Shout" and the latter applying to "Help" (2002, 52).

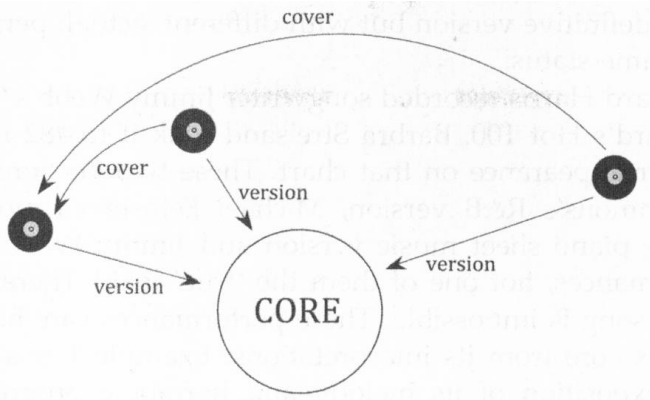
Thomas Robinson's framework for analyzing covers of Jimmy Webb's "Didn't We" separates the concept of covers from that of versions. Example 3.2 reproduces his "scheme of versions, covers, and core." Each small black (vinyl) disc represents a specific recording of a song while the large white circle is what Robinson terms a song's core. Robinson's core is not just a melody-focused concept, it is a melody.[8] The core for "Didn't We," his case study song, is a simplified melody that

[7] Perhaps the most often-cited white artist who made covers of songs originally recorded by black musicians is Pat Boone.

[8] Robinson's core is specifically a vocal melody with lyrics. All six versions of "Didn't We" that he analyzes are sung, despite the existence of purely instrumental versions.

"serves as a background of sorts" (2014, 329) based on the pitches sung by most or all of the artists who have recorded renditions of the song. Every recording of a song is a version of the core and many of the versions are covers of one or more other recordings. A version may also not be a cover at all: "Naturally, performers often create a version of a song unaware of the versions that already exist" (319). This framework emphasizes intentional imitation and/or adaptation, a key characteristic

**Example 3.2:** Robinson's scheme of versions, covers, and core (Figure 1 in [Robinson 2014])




of covers that is at play in Salt-N-Pepa's versions. An artist produces a cover song only if they are modeling their version on a known recording. Each of the covers Robinson analyzes are musically faithful to their originals, making them examples of Griffiths' renditions. We therefore don't have an explicit indication of where a transformation would fit into his framework, but ostensibly they would be a category within the umbrella term of "version." This is a slight difference in terminology between Robinson and Griffiths: Robinson's "version" is synonymous with Griffiths' "cover," Robinson's "cover" is synonymous with Griffiths' "rendition," and there isn't an analogue in Robinson's work for Griffiths' "transformation."

The specific musical materials that constitute Robinson's core are not directly applicable in the current context since hip-hop is not a melody-based genre. But the notion that an abstract core

of a song exists can be extended to hip-hop. What non-melodic components of a song might contribute to its core identity? To what extent do these components have to be kept intact in a new song to consider it a version? Is it possible to draw a line between a cover version and a song that samples liberally? Hip-hop songs—especially from the Golden Age, the period during which Salt-N-Pepa flourished—borrow numerous elements from existing songs, including vocal melodies with lyrics at times. But two factors prevent the typical hip-hop track from being a cover: 1) these samples usually come from disparate sources and 2) the primary lyrics (rapped verses and hooks) usually have little or nothing in common with the lyrics of the original song(s). "Can I Kick It" by A Tribe Called Quest (1990), for example, despite sampling the bass and guitar from Lou Reed's "Walk on the Wild Side," a drum break from Lonnie Smith's "Spinning Wheel," and a slide guitar riff from Dr. Buzzard's Original Savannah Band's "Sunshower," is a far cry from being a cover of any of these songs. It even makes little sense to interpret a song like De La Soul's "Me Myself And I," in which a single sampled song dominates, as a cover. Funkadelic's "(Not Just) Knee Deep" constitutes the bass, explicit beat, and harmonic filler layers of "Me Myself And I," but the members of De La Soul rap completely new lyrics.[9] In most sample-based hip-hop, the whole is greater than the sum of the parts.

Salt-N-Pepa's rap versions are of a different nature than "Can I Kick It" or "Me Myself And I" in the way that they point both backwards to identify with their source songs and towards themselves as not quite the same song. They add new lyrics in the form of rapped verses, but they go beyond traditional sampling by borrowing not just riffs or drum beats but entire sections—memorable choruses at that.[10] Amanda Sewell includes this technique within her category of lyric samples: "In yet another variant of lyric sampling, a producer samples an entire verse or chorus of

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[9] Amanda Sewell calls this type of sample an intact structural sample because it "includes every element from the source material" (2013, 37).

[10] As will be discussed below, the borrowed section from the Beatles' "Twist and Shout" is not quite a chorus, but here I refer to it as one for the sake of simplicity.

one track [and] uses it intact in a new track" (2013, 55). According to Sewell, this is a somewhat rare approach. It is more common for turntablists and producers to scratch shorter lyrical snippets "from a single source or from a variety of sources" (ibid.) into songs. Not only do the Salt-N-Pepa songs analyzed in this chapter borrow choruses from source songs in their entirety, but their production processes are more in line with a typical cover song. Justin Williams borrows Serge Lacasse's terms autosonic and allosonic "to differentiate between sampled and nonsampled quotations, respectively." An "autosonic quotation is a quotation of a recording by digitally sampling it (digital or analog)," while an allosonic quotation "quotes the previous material by way of rerecording or performing it live" (2013, 3). Strictly defined, a cover song uses allosonic quotation throughout. Autosonic quotation, on the other hand, is very strongly associated with hip-hop through the predominance of analog and digital sampling during the Golden Age. Salt-N-Pepa's "Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang" use a combination of autosonic and allosonic quotation, the latter of which is the technique used for their production of choruses. James and Denton recorded the chorus to "Twist and Shout" themselves and the go-go band Experience Unlimited was brought in to record the chorus of "Shake Your Thang."

The exact nature of Salt-N-Pepa's versioned songs lies somewhere at the intersection of replication and creation, of performance and composition. I find Griffiths' "transformation" (a subcategory of cover theorized in opposition to "rendition") most appropriate for understanding these songs. It may be objected that these songs should not be considered covers at all. They are rearranged formally, new sections and formal functions are added along with new lyrics, and some traditional hip-hop sampling (autosonic quotation) is used. But for all their musical differences,

"Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang" demonstrate elements of intentional reconstruction, especially in their recycling of original songs' titles and the allosonic production of their choruses.[11]

Even if "Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang" don't fit neatly into any existing academic categories of musical borrowing, their ontological ambiguity makes them exemplars of the African American tradition of "Signifyin(g)." Signifyin(g) is a concept developed by Henry Louis Gates Jr. in his 1988 book *The Signifying Monkey: A Theory of Afro-American Literary Criticism* to theorize African American literature in terms of the deeply multivalent nature of meaning in much of African American writing and speech. The idea was quickly picked up by sociologists and historians writing about music, and music theorists were not far behind.[12] "Signifyin(g)," writes Gates, "in jazz performance and in the play of black language games is a mode of formal revision, it depends for its effects on troping, it is often characterized by pastiche, and, most crucially, it turns on repetition of formal structures and their differences" (52). Signifyin(g) as a technique draws attention to the signifier just as much as the meaning of their speech or the original source. Salt-N-Pepa's versions Signify on the versioning process itself, implying cover status in some regards while revising the very notion of a cover in others.[13] Their inter-generic pastiche brings rap to a time and place where covering was a *modus operandi* for all levels of popular musicians and yet one where rap

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[11] Kyle Adams comes to a similar conclusion about Danger Mouse's *The Grey Album*, his case study in considering the nature of mashups: "In *The Grey Album* … one part of the composition is fixed from beginning to end; it serves as a referent for anything that Danger Mouse might add to it. The album thus stands or falls as a new interpretation of Jay-Z: it is a cover performance by Danger Mouse, a type of performance unique to configurable culture in the twenty-first century" (2015, 22).
[12] According to Bungert (2019), Krims (2000) and Perry (2004) are among the scholars who have discussed hip-hop through the lens of Signifiyin(g). Bungert frames his own analysis of Kendrick Lamar's "King Kunta" with the concept. More publications can be added to this list including Demers (2003), Schloss (2004), Williams (2013), Adams (2008) and Duinker (2020).
[13] The connection between Salt-N-Pepa's versions and Signifyin(g) is further supported by the music video for "Twist and Shout" (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gsJzMC2EHpE). Dressed in suits and holding traditional rock band instruments, Salt, Pepa, and Spinderella perform the song at what appears to be a high school dance. During the song's second guitar solo (starting at time stamp 3:30 in the video), the camera turns towards the audience to show young men and women fanatically shouting and reaching towards the stage. It is not too much of a stretch to see this as a racial and gendered reversal of the classic image of young female fans at Beatles concerts.

did not yet exist. That the nature of Salt-N-Pepa's versions is so slippery is somewhat ironic because, as will be argued in the analyses that follow, their song forms are conveyed more clearly than in the original songs.

"Twist and Shout"

"Twist and Shout" is a song whose story was full of musical borrowing long before Salt-N-Pepa thought about recording their own version. It was originally written for and recorded by The Top Notes in 1961, but did not become a hit record until the Isley Brothers' cover of it in 1962. The Beatles subsequently covered it again in 1963, producing a recording which surpassed either of the previous versions in popularity. According to Walter Everett, the Beatles had to go one step further than borrowing "Twist and Shout" from the Isley Brothers. During the group's early days as a cover band working in Liverpool and Hamburg, they had to coordinate with other local bands so as to avoid stepping on each other's toes:

> Each competing band was careful to carve out its own niche, and so the different groups would not cover numbers highly identified with other local artists. Thus, many old standards such as "It Ain't Necessarily So" would become part of the mix for Ian & the Zodiacs. Gerry Marsden remembers that groups would "trade" numbers —"If you let me play your 'Jambalaya,' I'll give you my 'Roll Over Beethoven.'" Looking ahead to the early 1960s, the Swinging Blue Jeans were permitted to "have" the Beatles' arrangement of Chan Romero's "Hippy Hippy Shake," and the Beatles in turn are said to have "nicked" their version of the Isley Brothers' "Twist and Shout" from King Size Taylor & the Dominoes. (2001, 39)

Had the Beatles never made this trade with King Size Taylor and the Dominoes, the Isley Brothers' version may have remained be the most well-known, and who knows if it would have been on Salt-N-Pepa's radar as a possible song to cover.[14] Because the Beatles' is likely the version that comes to mind first for most readers, I will compare Salt-N-Pepa's cover only to the their version.

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[14] Even though Everett describes most transactions between bands as trades, he makes it sound as though the Beatles' with King Size Taylor & the Dominoes was a theft.

Both the Beatles' and Salt-N-Pepa's versions of "Twist and Shout" are upbeat, danceable recordings. This is particularly true of the earlier groups' rendition: the Beatles exchange their penchant for syntactically sound if poetic lyrics for narrative-less exclamations. Fueled by John Lennon's slightly strained belting, the energy is high throughout the song with the exception of George Harrison's guitar solo near the middle. For these reasons, "Twist and Shout" made an excellent closer to many early Beatles live shows until 1964 when "it was replaced as their closer with 'Long Tall Sally'" (Everett 2001, 156). The lyrics and unwavering energy level of "Twist and Shout" have implications for interpreting the song's form. The most significant conflicts in this regard are 1) whether choruses alternate with verses or the song is simply strophic, and 2) if it is strophic, whether the verses are eight or sixteen measures long.

To address the first analytical issue, Example 3.3 presents the lyrics of "Twist and Shout," broken into sections labeled as "modules" for the moment to delay assigning formal function. Each module is eight measures in length and pairs with a sibling module (e.g., Modules 1a and 1b are paired). Lines of text are separated by forward slashes. Modules 1a, 2a, and 3a contain nearly

**Example 3.3:** Lyrics of "Twist and Shout" (version by the Beatles)) organized into modules

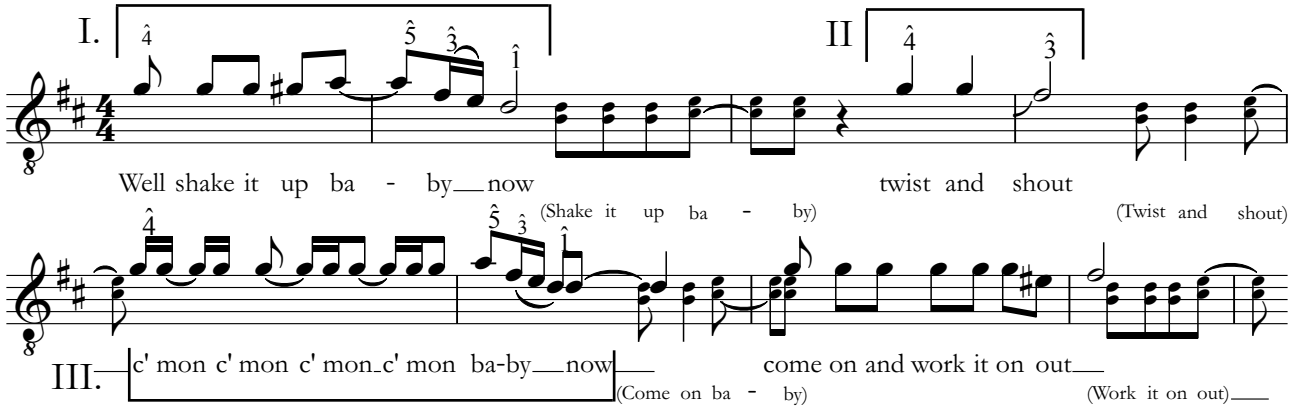
| Module 1a (0:07) | Module 2a (0:37) | Module 3a (1:35) | Module 4 (2:05) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Well shake it up baby now /<br>Twist and shout /<br>C'mon, c'mon, c'mon, c'mon baby now /<br>Come on and work it on out / | Well shake it up baby now /<br>Twist and shout /<br>C'mon, c'mon, c'mon, c'mon baby now /<br>Come on and work it on out / | Baby now /<br>Twist and shout /<br>C'mon, c'mon, c'mon, c'mon baby now /<br>Come on and work it on out / | Well shake it, shake it, shake it baby now (3x) |
| Module 1b (0:22) | Module 2b (0:52) | Module 3b (1:50) | |
| Well work it on out /<br>You know you look so good /<br>You know you got me goin' now /<br>Just like I knew you would / | You know you twist your little girl /<br>You know you twist so fine /<br>Come one and twist a little closer now /<br>And let me know that you're mine / | You know you twist your little girl /<br>You know you twist so fine /<br>Come on and twist a little closer now /<br>And let me know that you're mine / | |

identical text, the only difference being the omission of the initial "well shake it up" in module 3a. This section comes immediately after the song's memorable six-measure vocal arpeggiation of the dominant ninth chord, which Everett calls the "screaming retransition" (2001, 385 n.148). It is possible that the lyrics "well shake it up" are missing because Lennon, the lead vocalist on "Twist and Shout" had to catch his breath after singing the root of the $V^7$ chord for the duration of the build up. Regardless, the text repetition found between these sections implies chorus function, an analysis which is further supported by the presence of the title lyric and some internal text repetition ("c'mon, c'mon, c'mon" and "come on").

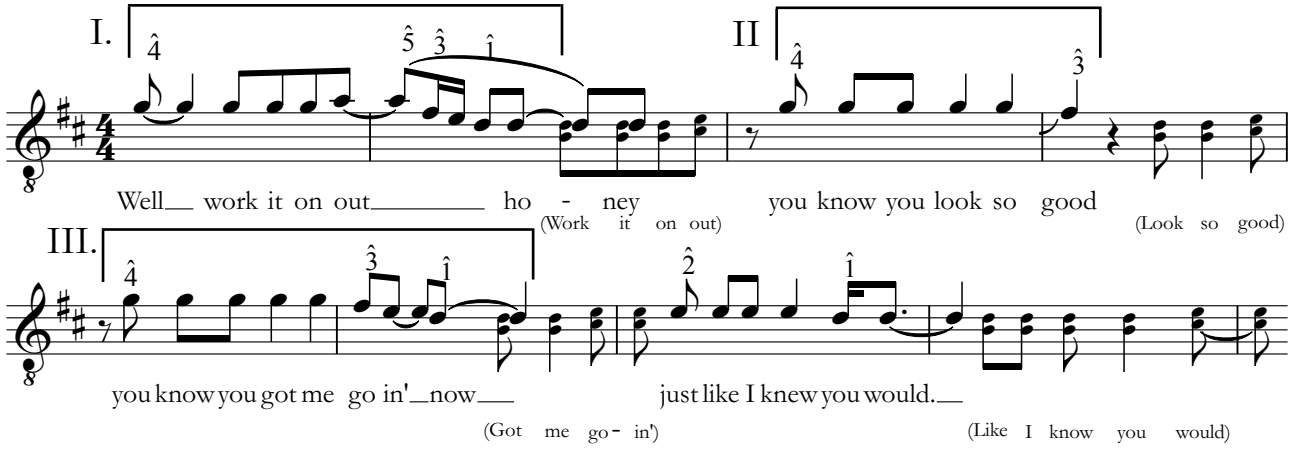
Do the modules paired with these chorus-like sections (Modules 1b, 2b, and 3b) convey verse function? Modules 1b and 2b feature different text than their partners and different text than each other, aligning with expectations for verse lyrics. But the third "verse" (Module 3b) repeats the same text as the second (Module 2b), throwing a wrench into the clean pattern of chorus-like modules paired with verse-like modules. More significant than the lack of different text in each verse is a musical environment that goes unchanged across paired modules. Examples 3.4a–b compare the vocals in Modules 1a and 1b. Despite the difference in text, Lennon's lead melody is largely the same between the two sections. Examples 3.4a–b highlight a parallel melodic skeleton in the modules' first three subphrases using scale-degree numbers. Module 1b departs from Module 1a in by omitting $\hat{5}$ in the third subphrase, but the resolution from an unstable scale degree ($\hat{4}$) to a stable one ($\hat{3}$) is still present. Its melody also reaches a stronger sense of closure by ending with the descending step $\hat{2}$–$\hat{1}$ (this is also the only moment in the passage where John emphasizes $\hat{2}$). John's vocals are anacrustic in both modules, beginning in the middle of measures and leading to downbeats for each snippet of text. Additionally, the response background vocals sung by McCartney and Harrison are present in both sections. This latter similarity is a particularly strong factor in reducing the differentiation in formal function between paired modules. Extra vocal forces are often saved in pop-rock for the

chorus but they appear in all sections of "Twist and Shout," including the sections that have different lyrics each time through.

**Example 3.4a:** Module 1a vocals—John Lennon on lead with stems up, Paul McCartney and George Harrison on response/background vocals with stems down



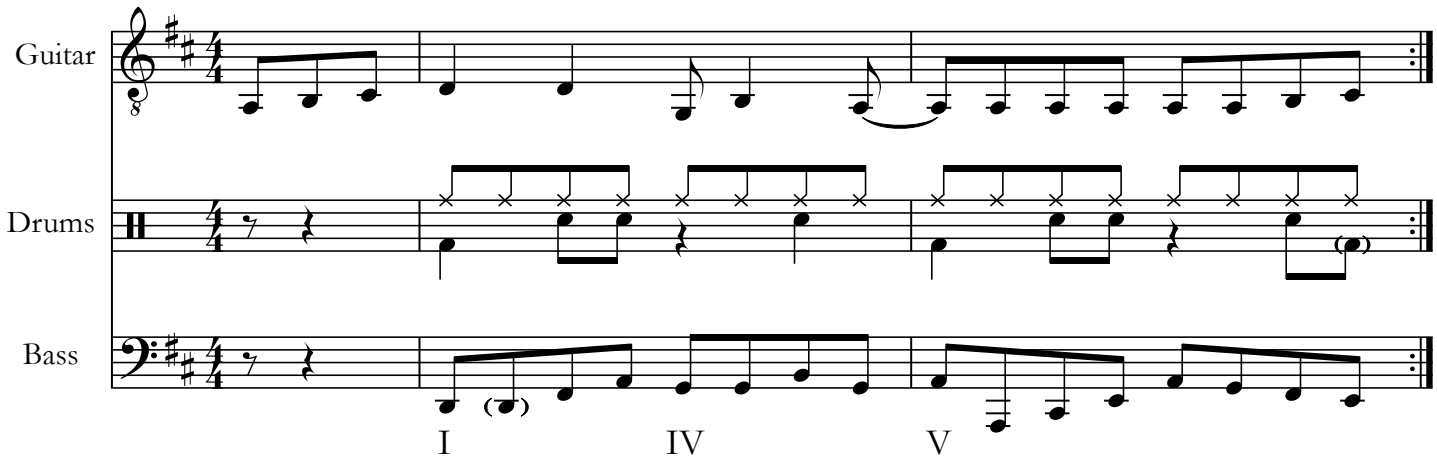

**Example 3.4b:** Module 1b vocals




If the Beatles' vocal layers do little to differentiate modules in "Twist and Shout," their instrumental layers do even less. Ringo Starr's drum beat, Harrison's lead guitar riff, Lennon's rhythm guitar strumming, and McCartney's driving bass guitar all remain essentially the same between paired modules. Only slight variations occur like in Ringo's drum fills at hypermetrical

boundaries and Paul's navigation of the bass line.[15] This tapestry of riffs—minus Lennon's rhythm guitar—is transcribed in Example 3.5.[16] The groove persists throughout each module, allowing for no textural or harmonic change to suggest different formal functions. "Twist and Shout" was recorded by the Beatles ten years before hip-hop was born in the Bronx and nearly twenty years before hip-hop gained international recognition as a new musical genre, but the song shares more

**Example 3.5:** "Twist and Shout," full groove




musically speaking with hip-hop aesthetics than the typical 1960s rock song. Particularly relevant in this regard is the use of a short (two-measure) groove that loops for nearly the duration of the song.

Assigning formal designations to the modules in the Beatles' "Twist and Shout" is not a straightforward matter. Two possibilities stand out as most likely: 1) Modules 1a, 2a, and 3a are

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[15] McCartney's bass line is the instrumental layer that varies the most throughout "Twist and Shout." There are dozens of tutorial videos online offering pedagogical walk-throughs of the song's bass line, and most of them differ by several pitches as well as a rhythm or two. This could be because the bass part is the hardest to hear in most recordings, but it is also likely because the bassists are imitating different recordings or even different passages from the same recording. McCartney used several variants of the bass line shown in Example 3.5, like, for instance, repeating a dominant pedal on the pitch A in the second measure of the looped groove rather than arpeggiating the dominant triad.

[16] "Tapestry of riffs" is a phrase used by Mark Spicer to describe grooves in pop-rock music (2004, 30).

choruses while Modules 1b, 2b and 2b are verses, making "Twist and Shout" a verse-chorus form song; and 2) every module just discussed is a verse, making the song form strophic. The first option is most strongly supported by the 'b' modules' distinct lyrics in relation their paired modules. But the melodic similarities, persistence of the full texture, and unwavering climactic energy strips a verse-chorus reading of its normal ebb and flow. I prefer to hear "Twist and Shout" as strophic in light of the latter considerations. This is not intended to be prescriptive stance, but it is somewhat easier to ignore the repetition of lyrics between Modules 1a, 2a, and 3a and Modules 2b and 3b than it is to ignore the unchanging texture, energy, and response vocals.[17] The large-scale organization of "Twist and Shout" is rooted in a blues sensibility, which privileges repeated cycles through the same harmonic progression often with the set of riffs. This connection is bolstered by a bluesy harmonic pallet: I, IV, and V are the only three chords used in "Twist and Shout." John Covach cites two songs that use an actual 12-bar blues progression and feature some of the same elements of formal blend we have seen in "Twist and Shout": Elvis Presley's "Hound Dog" (1956) and Little Richard's "Lucille" (1957). Despite some repetition of lyrics between formal units in both of these songs—including titular refrains just like in "Twist and Shout"—Covach describes them as examples of consisting of "a succession of twelve-bar verses *without chorus*" (2005, 67–8, emphasis added).

Given a strophic interpretation of "Twist and Shout," we are still left with one salient piece of ambiguity: are the verses eight or sixteen measures in length? Not only is formal function somewhat ambiguous but so is segmentation since little in the musical fabric changes between modules. Example 3.6 compares the song's form based on eight- and sixteen-measure understandings of the verses. The two-measure groove can be heard as repeating four or eight times

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[17] In a passage focusing on Ringo's drumming, Walter Everett indirectly describes "Twist and Shout" as consisting of nothing but verses: "Ringo's joining the group in mid-1962 was good timing for covering the interesting fills in 'Chains' and 'You Really Got a Hold on Me,' both added to the repertoire in early 1963. Among early recordings, Ringo's fills are evident *following every verse of* 'Twist and Shout'" (2001, 121, emphasis added). Listening to the recording of "Twist," one can hear that there are fills every eight bars, meaning that if Everett's prose is to be taken seriously as an interpretation of the form, the song consists of verse after verse and no choruses.

to fit neatly into the former or latter verse length, respectively. Ringo's drum fills punctuate the song every eight measures, with an extra fill in the fourth measure of Module 3a. The cadential function of these fills bolsters the idea to the verses are eight measures in length. Pop-rock norms do as well: eight measures is a very typical length for a verse, especially in simple-verse and verse-chorus popular songs from the 1960s. On the other hand, the restatement of the same lyrics in Modules 1a, 2a, and 3a (separated by sixteen measures) creates a sense that the same type of section is being

**Example 3.6:** Comparison of the Beatles' "Twist and Shout" song form based on eight- and sixteen-measure hearings of verses

| Time | Module | Section (8-measure verses) | Section (16-measure verses) | Sections ending with a drum fill |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 0:00–0:08 | | Intro | Intro | |
| 0:08–0:22 | 1a | Verse 1 | Verse 1 | *** |
| 0:23–0:37 | 1b | Verse 2 | | *** |
| 0:38–0:52 | 2a | Verse 3 | Verse 2 | *** |
| 0:53–1:08 | 2b | Verse 4 | | *** |
| 1:08–1:24 | | Guitar Solo | Guitar Solo | |
| 1:24–1:35 | | Retransition/ Bridge? | Retransition/ Bridge? | |
| 1:36–1:51 | 3a | Verse 5 | Verse 3 | *** \| *** (fills at four and eight measures) |
| 1:51–2:06 | 3b | Verse 6 | | *** |
| 2:07–2:35 | 4 | Outro | Outro | |

relaunched each time we hear them. The sixteen-measure verse reading can also help to resolve the question of how the 'a' and 'b' modules relate to each other. If the verses are sixteen measures in length, then the first eight measures of each verse (i.e., Modules 1a, 2a, and 3a) may be heard as long head refrains. I tend to hear the verses in eight-measure chunks because of Ringo's fills and because

sixteen measures is a long time to aurally hold on to the same formal segment. But what is more important than deciding on an interpretation is that the Beatles' version of "Twist and Shout" is open-ended in terms of the formal function and segmentation of its constituent sections.[18]

Leaving the Beatles' version of "Twist and Shout" on the topic of verse length makes an excellent segue to Salt-N-Pepa's.[19] The hip-hop trio offers their own answer to the eight- versus sixteen-measure verse question by borrowing Modules 1a *and* 1b in their entireties (i.e., sixteen measures) to serve at the chorus of their cover version. Example 3.7 summarizes the form of Salt 'N' Pepa's "Twist and Shout. The first section following the intro is an allosonic reproduction of the Beatles' first two verses (Modules 1a and b) left entirely intact save for a few minor lyric variations. This is, in a sense, Salt-N-Pepa's analysis of the song's segmentation: leaving the Beatles' Modules 1a and 1b intact shows that they understood it as a single unit, or at least could bring themselves to understand it in that way such that it felt natural to record it this manner. It is somewhat easier for Salt-N-Pepa to do so because their version is set at a faster tempo. The Beatles' clocks in at 128 beats per minute and Salt-N-Pepa's at a peppy 145. The latter version also excludes drum fills every eight measures that created a sense of articulation in the Beatles' version. Both of these factors make sixteen-measure groupings feel much less strained.

Salt-N-Pepa's version recasts these modules with clearer formal function because of their lead-ins to the choruses, the inclusion of differentiated verses that alternate with the choruses, and

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[18] I have neglected to discuss the retransition in detail for the sake of space, but it further complicates form in "Twist and Shout." It fulfills both essential characteristics of bridge function (contrast and preparation for the return of the verse) but its scale is less substantial than the typical bridge. It condenses both of these characteristics into one event since it consists solely of the building up of a dominant sonority. It also does not make much sense to group the retransition with the preceding guitar solo to form a larger bridge section because the latter section matches the verses in terms of harmony and length.

[19] The question of why artists choose to cover the songs they do is difficult to answer without asking them directly; even then an artist may not know how or why a song inspired them. But the odds of Salt-N-Pepa choosing "Twist and Shout" were probably increased by its reappearance on the *Billboard* Hot 100, where it peaked at #23 in 1986 after being featured in *Ferris Bueller's Day Off*.

**Example 3.7:** Salt-N-Pepa, "Twist and Shout, full song form

| Time | Modules from Beatles' version | Section | Comments |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0:00–0:19 | | Intro | Dominant seventh chord arpeggiation leads into first chorus |
| 0:20–0:46 | 1a + 1b | Chorus | |
| 0:46–1:05 | | Verse 1 | |
| 1:06–1:32 | 1a + 1b | Chorus | |
| 1:32–1:58 | | Verse 2 | |
| 1:59–2:25 | 1a + 1b | Chorus | |
| 2:25–2:31 | | Link | Dominant seventh arpeggiation |
| 2:32–2:45 | | Guitar Solo 1 | Allosonic quotation of Harrison's guitar solo |
| 2:45–3:04 | | Verse 3 | |
| 3:05–3:31 | 1a + 1b | Chorus | |
| 3:31–3:51 | | Guitar Solo 2 | New guitar solo |
| 3:52–4:54 | | Outro | Accumulative vamp to fade |

exact repetition of the chorus across VCUs. The strongest build-up to a chorus is the intro, preceding the first chorus. The first sounds we hear in Salt-N-Pepa's "Twist and Shout" are not sourced from the Beatles' or any other version of the song, but rather from Toni Basil's "Mickey" (1981), itself a transformation cover of "Kitty" (1979) by the British pop group Racey.[20] As the comparison in Examples 3.8 a–b of the original drum pattern and the hip-hop version shows, the rhythm is kept nearly identical. The "Mickey" drum pattern is a one-measure loop whose distinctive features are the lack of a hi-hat and a syncopated kick drum. Salt-N-Pepa's version maintains these aspects and extends the loops to two measures in length via an extra articulation on beat three in the

[20] "Mickey" also influenced hip-hop duo Run-D.M.C.: the lyrical cadence and syllabic patterning in their "It's Tricky" (1986) is based on that of the opening lyrics to "Mickey."

**Example 3.8a:** Toni Basil, "Mickey," drum pattern

**Example 3.8b:** Salt-N-Pepa, "Twist and Shout," drum pattern (allosonic quotation)

kick drum.[21] The beats' timbres are slightly different as well: the "Mickey" kick drum is a clustered stomp attack and its snare is drenched with reverb while the "Twist and Shout" loop is drier, sounding as if it was created with a drum machine. The opening solitary drum beat in both tracks begs for an accumulative process to lead us toward the songs' cores. Example 3.9 transcribes the entire intro of "Twist and Shout," showing that such an accumulation takes place with the addition of semi-pitched vocal exclamations at measure 5 then a bass line and two layers of pitched vocals at m. 9. The accumulation gives the intro a sense of forward direction that makes the arrival of the chorus in m. 13 (not shown in Example 3.9) feel like a point of arrival.

There is also an accumulation within the accumulation: from m. 9 to m. 13, Salt and Pepa sing the hook-functioning arpeggiation of the dominant triad (Everett's "screaming retransition") on the same syllable used by the Beatles—"Ah".[22] The Beatles' screaming retransition is, of course, an actual retransition in their version since it steers the song from a guitar solo back toward already-

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[21] As can be seen below in Example 3.9, the kick drum omits this extra articulation at times, making the "Twist and Shout" drum beat rhythmically identical to that of "Mickey."

[22] The vocal arpeggio is certainly inspired by the Beatles, but, interestingly, there is a similar dominant arpeggio at the end of the intro to "Mickey" played on organ. Salt-N-Papa's "Twist and Shout" is also in the same key as "Mickey" (E major, a whole step above the Beatles' "Twist"), so the dominant arpeggio involves the same pitch classes in the two songs.

**Example 3.9:** Salt-N-Pepa, "Twist and Shout," intro

heard material. Salt-N-Pepa simplify the arpeggio by shortening it from six to four measures in length and eliminating the seventh and the ninth from the chord.[23] This truncation keeps the song's established four-bar hypermeter regular, making the arrival of the chorus conform with its expected beginning. Within a section that has already undergone a build up in terms of texture, Salt-N-Pepa literally build up the dominant triad, an unstable harmony that points forward toward its resolution.

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[23] In the album version of "Twist and Shout" (the last track on *Please Please Me*), the ninth is not clearly audible in the quartet's singing but comes through in the rhythm guitar. Paul can be heard and seen singing the ninth in the group's performance of "Twist and Shout" on the Ed Sullivan Show in February of 1964 (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=b-VAxGJdJeQ).

All these factors make the intro a strongly directional lead-in to the first chorus that ultimately helps to make that section's function obvious.[24] Subsequent choruses are not as strongly prepared, but their arrivals are predictable relative to some hip-hop hook/choruses. The "chorus signal" drum fill highlighted in Example 3.9 precedes each of the remaining choruses. Additionally, Salt and Pepa rap command lyrics in the final measure before each chorus telling their partner to dance: "do what the record say," "don't wait too long," and "go hit the floor."

The preparation of the choruses just described helps to clarify their formal role as choruses to a great extent. What makes their function even clearer is the verses Salt and Pepa add in alternation with the choruses. The verses are differentiated from the choruses most notably by Salt and Pepa's rapping in a typical non-pitched fashion, contrasting their singing in the choruses. The texture is also reduced in the verses: while the choruses feature bass guitar, drums, rhythm guitar, lead vocals, and response vocals, the verses are thinner with only drums, bass, and Salt and Pepa's rapping. Texture is homogeneous across nearly all sections in the Beatles' version, making lyrics the primary cue to convey different function. In Salt-N-Pepa's version of "Twist and Shout," not only is lyrical repetition reserved for the chorus sections, the texture and timbre of the choruses is very chorus-like while the texture and timbre of the verses is very verse-like, and the choruses are preceded by lead-ins in various strengths. While formal function and segmentation was fairly ambiguous in the Beatles' version, these aspects are conveyed with clarity relative to hip-hop norms in Salt-N-Pepa's cover.

One final question remains with regard to interpreting form in "Twist and Shout": to what extent does AABA form fit the two versions in question as the overall song form? Since the Beatles and Salt-N-Pepa operated in different generic environments, the criteria for tackling this issue should

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[24] The Beatles' apparently also found their screaming retransition to make a good intro: according Walter Everett, "a truncated version of 'Twist and Shout' *beginning*" with the vocal arpeggio opened many of the Beatles' live shows after it was replaced as their closer with "Long Tall Sally" in 1964 (2001, 156, emphasis added).

be different for each group. A bridge for a rock group like the Beatles will not necessarily demonstrate the same musical characteristics or types of contrast as a bridge for a hip-hop group like Salt-N-Pepa. If we are to find a bridge in the Beatles' "Twist and Shout," it will have to contain lyrical and harmonic contrast. No such section exists in their version, so AABA form does not fit well as an interpretation. George Harrison's guitar solo contrasts the preceding verse cycles timbrally and motivically but within pop-rock norms it does not fulfill bridge function in the context of an AABA reading.[25] Additionally, I argued above for eight-measure rather than sixteen-measure verses. Taking this as the length of the verses, there would be *four* verses before the hypothetical bridge, i.e., AAAABA form, a severe stretch of the basic AABA pattern. To my ears, the Beatles' "Twist and Shout" is best understood as strophic with an intervening instrumental solo.[26]

AABA form in hip-hop, as I have defined it, does not require harmonic contrast in the B section, a framework which upholds the possibility of bridge function for the guitar solo in Salt-N-Pepa's "Twist and Shout." This interpretation is made even more appealing by because Salt-N-Pepa's version cycles through only two-and-a-half verse-chorus cycles (i.e., A's) before the guitar solo, rather than the Beatles' four. The first chorus can even be heard as blending with intro function, simplifying the number of initial verse-chorus cycles to the prototypical two. An interpretation of the song form of Salt-N-Pepa's "Twist" as AABA is complicated only slightly by an additional guitar solo after the final VCU. The first guitar solo, i.e., the bridge, sounds like an autosonic sample of George Harrison's solo. The second guitar solo uses a different timbre and is newly performed without any motivic relation to Harrison's playing, complicating a hearing in which the second guitar solo sounds like a return of the bridge. Following the second guitar solo is the final section of the song, labeled as an outro in Example 3.7. It is long enough and reprises enough of the chorus

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[25] The harmonic progression I–IV–V remains the same while Harrison solos. There is some harmonic contrast provided by the screaming retransition, more from a slow down of harmonic rhythm than the actual introduction of a new harmony.

[26] All this being said, the Beatles' version still follows a large-scale SRDC pattern.

material (response vocals and fragmented "shake it baby" lyrics) to be heard as A-like. As mentioned in Chapter 2, a common pop-rock variant of AABA form is AABA BA form, ending in Covach's "abbreviated reprise" (2005, 70). As long as one can hear through the differences between the two guitar solos, this design models Salt-N-Pepa's "Twist" well.

"Shake Your Thang (It's Your Thing)"

"Shake Your Thang (It's your Thing)" is another song from *A Salt With A Deadly Pepa* that was conceived as a version of an existing pop-rock record. In this case, Salt, Pepa, DJ Spinderella, and their producer Hurby Azor chose to cover "It's Your Thing" by the Isley Brothers (1969), the group's breakout hit after taking the risk of leaving Motown Records in 1968. With their original version, the Isley Brothers struck a chord with the listening public as social views on dating and female agency in relationships became more liberal in the 1960s. The message of "It's Your Thing" could be taken to mean what listeners wanted it to mean. It manifested the feeling of letting go of bitter work situations like the Isley Brothers' experienced in their conflict with Berry Gordy at Motown just as it declared that love and relationships don't have to be all or nothing.

Little did the Isley Brothers know that the song's expression of personal empowerment—especially as it was directed toward women—would ideally fit an all-female rap trio's platform two decades later. Indeed, James and Denton have spoken frequently in interviews about the importance to them of sharing their own strong sense of self-esteem through music. Songs like "Tramp," "Let's Talk About Sex," "Shoop," and "None Of Your Business" stood out in the late 1980s and early 90s as rare instances (especially in the hip-hop world) of women MCs flipping the hegemonic male script. "Shake Your Thang" deserves a spot on this list as well, as Athena Elafros contends:

> One of the key tracks from [*A Salt With A Deadly Pepa*] is Salt-N-Pepa's rap duet with the band E.U., "Shake your Thang." Salt-N-Pepa offers a verbal display of black women's sexual resistance (Rose 124). This song serves as a confirmation and assertion that black female bodies and black female sexuality are beautiful. Salt-N-Pepa sing about the freedom of dancing and enjoying your body, and specifically of showing no shame in this enjoyment since it is your

> body and you are able to do with it as you please. In the song, they also specifically emphasize their butts—better known as "thangs"—which they can shake in whichever way they feel. This could be seen as a way of challenging the beauty bias that renders the black female body sexually unattractive (Rose 125). Once again, Salt-N-Pepa support a positive body image for black women while simultaneously expressing their own sexuality. (2007, 201–02)[27]

The rapped verses added by Salt and Pepa in their version of "Shake Your Thang" allow them to make the song their own, to make it their thing. Not only does this open space for them to express themselves lyrically, it alters the form of the song. Just as we saw with their version of "Twist and Shout," Salt-N-Pepa rework "It's Your Thing" such that the formal functions are more easily distinguished than in the Isley Brothers' original. Whereas the Beatles' "Twist and Shout" was formally challenging because of an extreme steadiness of texture, harmony, and energy, the Isley Brothers' song reverses the musical characteristics prototypical of pop choruses and verses.

Example 3.10 transcribes the lyrics of the Isley Brothers' "It's Your Thing" in the same fashion as they were presented for the Beatles' "Twist and Shout." Modules 1a, 2a, 3a, and 4 contain the same lyrics while their paired modules contain contrasting lyrics with the exception of Module 2b, which is an instrumental section. The pairing of unchanging lyrics with changing lyrics suggests choruses in "a" modules and verses in "b" modules. Preliminarily speaking, then, there is a chorus-like section in Modules 1a, 1b, and 1c, and throughout Module 4 where the same lyrics are repeated with slight variation ("It's my thing…" instead of "it's your thing"). The repetition of the hypothetical chorus lyrics in the second half of Module 4 does not thwart this reading: the last section functions as an outro, in which it would make little sense to present new lyrics as one would in a lyrically unique verse. Ronald Isley's melodic setting of the text helps solidify the contrast between 'a' and 'b' modules. As Example 3.11 shows, the melody shares some similarities between Module 1a and 1b but contrasts enough to support different formal functions. Both melodies

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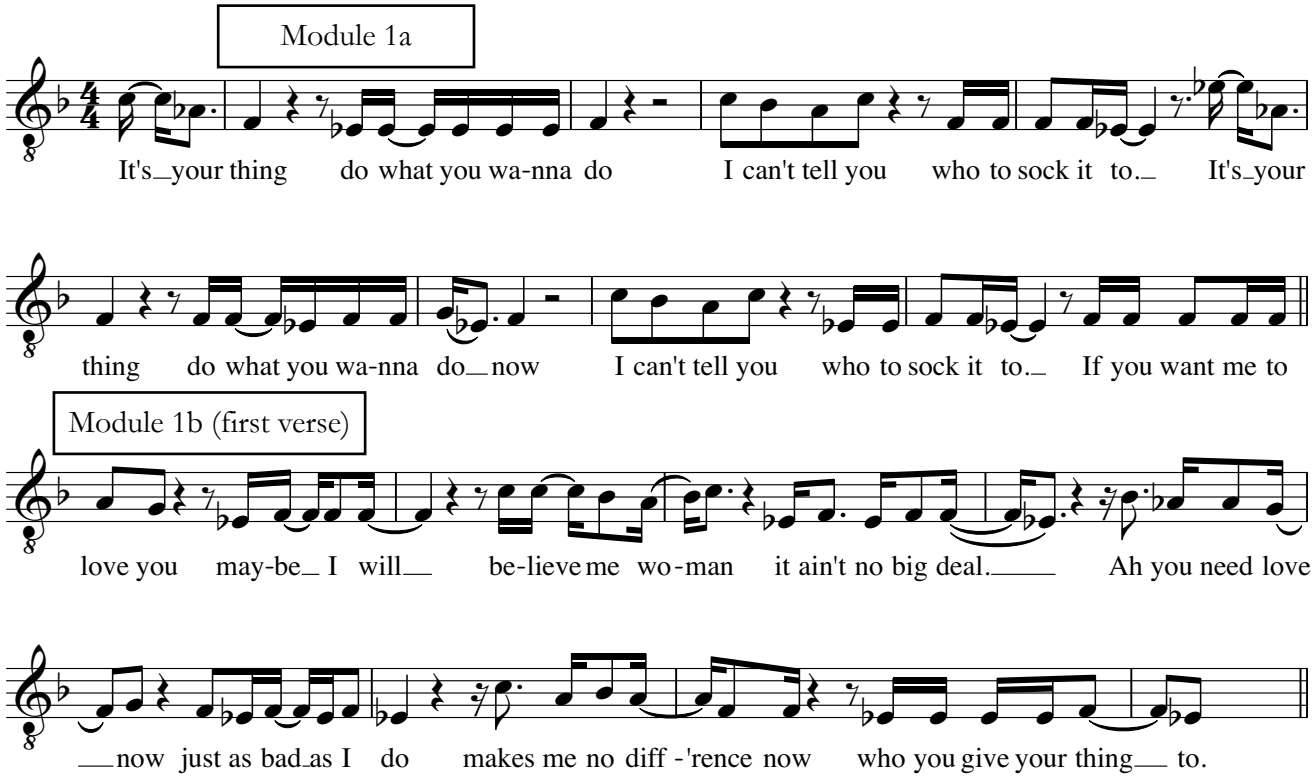
[27] As Elafros notes, Salt-N-Pepa's collaborating artist on "Shake Your Thang" was E.U., a.k.a. Experience Unlimited, a Washington D.C.-based go-go band.

**Example 3.10:** Lyrics of "It's Your Thing" organized into modules

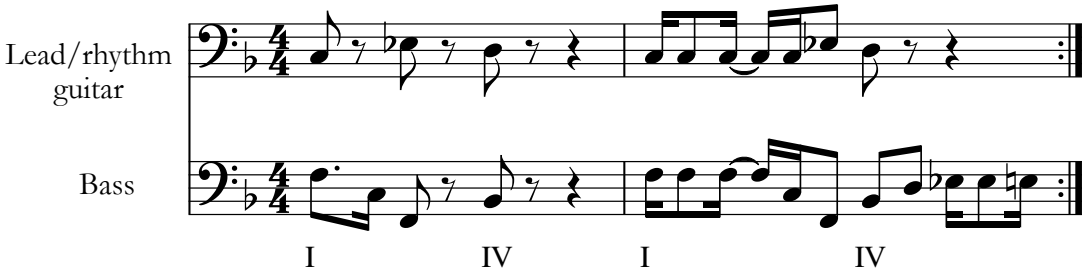
| Module 1a (0:09) | Module 2a (0:51) | Module 3a (1:33) | Module 4 (2:14) |
|---|---|---|---|
| It's your thing do what you wanna do /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to /<br>It's your thing do what you wanna do now /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to / | It's your thing do what you wanna do /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to /<br>It's your thing do what you wanna do /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to / | It's your thing do what you wanna do /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to /<br>It's your thing do what you wanna do /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to / | It's your thing do what you wanna do /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to /<br>It's your thing do what you wanna do /<br>Don't let me tell you who to sock it to /<br>Let me here you say it's my thing do what I wanna do /<br>I can't tell you who to sock it to /<br><br>(Fade) |
| Module 1b (0:30) | Module 2b (1:11) | Module 3b (1:53) | |
| If you want me to love you maybe I will /<br>Believe me woman it ain't no big deal /<br>Oh you need love now just as bad as I do /<br>Makes me no difference now who you give your thing to / | (Instrumental) | I'm not trying to run your life /<br>I know you wanna do what's right /<br>Give your love girl to whoever you choose /<br>How can you lose with the stuff you use / | |

**Example 3.11:** "It's your Thing," melody from Modules 1a to b

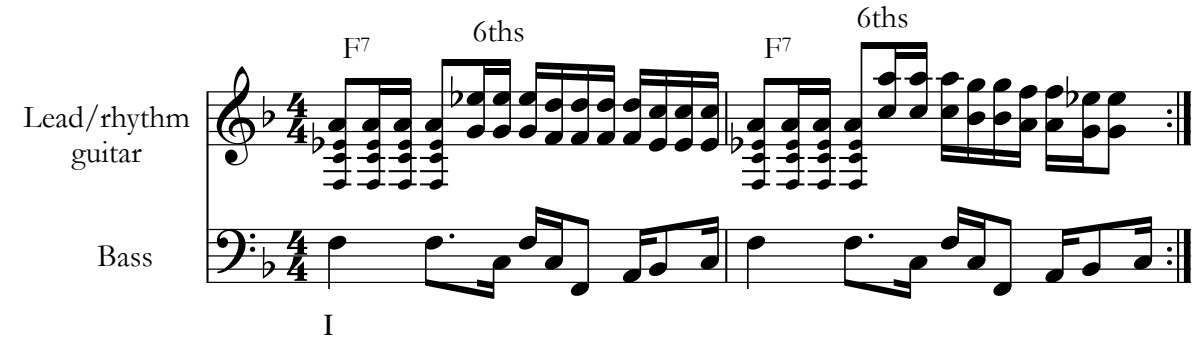


alternate each text snippet between high and low tessituras. In Module 1a, "It's your thing," and "I can't tell you" emphasize $\hat{5}$ while "do what you wanna do" and "who to sock it to" hover around $\hat{1}$. Similarly, in Module 1b, "If you want me to love you," "believe me woman," "Ah you need love," and "makes me no difference now" all begin and/or end entirely above tonic while the remaining text segments remain glued to F. But the pitch settings for "If you want me to love you" (a subphrase that stands out as the opening of the verse) and "Ah you need love now" contrast motivically from anything heard in Module 1a. The former, for instance, lands squarely on the first downbeat of Module 1b with an A-natural, a note that contrasts the blues-derived A-flat heard prominently before. The melodies in these sections are also different rhythmically: despite some funk-influenced syncopation in Module 1a, Module 1b is

**Example 3.12a:** Bass and guitar, Module 1a (chorus)




**Example 3.12b:** Bass and guitar, Module 1b (verse)



almost entirely syncopated. It is also worth noting that there is internal text repetition in the 'a' modules—a characteristic of choruses—while there is none in the 'b' modules—a characteristic of verses.

Harmony is another factor that differentiates the chorus modules from the verse modules. Examples 3.12a–b compares the main instrumental layers that convey harmony in these sections, the bass and lead/rhythm guitars. An oscillating harmonic progression between I and IV is expressed in Module 1a by the bass's statement of each harmony's root in counterpoint with the lead guitar's simple bluesy riff. Other pitched material is present during this section, including the hook-like piano riff that descends stepwise from the the subtonic to the dominant in imitation of the lead guitar riff. Additionally, horns (trumpet, alto, and tenor sax) interject during Ronald Isley's pauses. These parts of the texture are omitted from my analysis of the harmony because they seem to be divorced from the coordinated bass and guitar layers.[28] During Module 1b, the bass is more rhythmically active and does not suggest any harmony other than tonic. The syncopated $\hat{3}$–$\hat{4}$–$\hat{5}$ motion that ends each measure could potentially imply a new chord or two (like a first inversion tonic chord and/or a dominant chord), but such a change is not implied by any other pitched layers. The bass in the last beat of each measure functions more to drive the groove rhythmically toward the next downbeat than to establish a new chord. The lead guitar, meanwhile, takes on more of a rhythm guitar role. It begins each measure on a bluesy tonic major-minor seventh chord then retraces its own riff from Module 1a in 6ths. This all amounts to a highly rhythmatized and

[28] Temperley (2007) and Nobile (2015) theorize the "melodic-harmonic divorce" in rock, in which melodic and harmonic layers are stratified such that they operate independently of each other. De Clercq (2019) extends this notion to a divorce between the bass and the harmonic filler layer, which he dubs the "harmonic-bass divorce." The horns in "It's Your Thing" evince a melodic-harmonic divorce, but the question of whether the piano is involved in a melodic-harmonic divorce or a harmonic-bass divorce is complicated. The piano's top line is distinguishable as a melody (or at least a riff) unto itself, but there are, of course, inner voices played with the remaining fingers of the pianist's right hand.

embellished tonic major-minor seventh chord—not an unstable seventh since the harmonic language of this song is blues-based—for the duration of Module 1b.

Lyrics, melody, and harmony all differentiate the chorus-like sections from the verse-like sections, but upon listening to "It's Your Thing," these functions do not sound like they are expressed in the order that they should be. Lyrically, the choruses come first and the verses second, but the climactic nature of choruses is reserved for the verses. During the verses (Modules 1b and 3b), textural and overall rhythmic activity increases dramatically, causing these sections to overshadow the lyrically consistent choruses in terms of energy. Example 3.12b captures some of this increase in activity: both the bass and guitar are more rhythmically active and the guitar occupies a higher register while also strumming full (and therefore louder) chords. At the same time, the drums open up from a tight to a loose hi-hat, adding to the noisier profile of the verses. Following the first and third choruses, the horns are somewhat more subdued in the texture but they sustain chords beginning on the downbeat of each measure. They strongly outshine the second chorus, however, during a section that corresponds temporally with the other verses but is purely instrumental.

Listening through each chorus-verse cycle, it sounds as though the former leads to the latter. The relationship between the verses and the choruses in the Isley Brothers' is the reverse of the normal situation in pop-rock. As Drew Nobile writes: "choruses usually have a thicker texture than their corresponding verses, most commonly through the addition of backing vocals to ride cymbal in the drumbeat, and/or a general increase in the 'loudness'" (2020, 71).[29] Did the Isley brothers organize the form of "It's Your Thing" to reflect the message of the song itself? In all likelihood, not intentionally. Hearing it this way, however, enriches one's experience of the song: just like we can "do what we wanna do," artists can do what they wanna do with the formal construction of songs,

[29] Nobile cites numerous authors who "have discussed chorus markers in similar terms, including Ken Stephenson (2002, chapter 6), Lori Burns (2005, 138), Jocelyn Neal (2007), Anna Stephenson-Robinson (2009, 93–97), Walter Everett (2009, 145), and Brad Osborn (2013, 26–29)" (2020, 71).

and following convention does not necessarily lead to popularity or commercial success. The 'a' modules in "It's Your Thing" can still certainly be interpreted as choruses and the 'b' modules as verses. But this song is made unique because these sections demonstrate considerable degrees of "blend," a term adapted by Trevor de Clercq for the analysis of form in pop-rock music "from the field of linguistics to refer to those situations in which aspects of two (or more) section roles appear to exist within the same passage)" (2017, §3.8). In this case, the choruses blend with verse traits and the verses blend with chorus traits to the extent that it sounds as though the lyrics are in the wrong locations. At the same, it is hard to imagine "It's Your Thing" beginning with any lyrics other than the titular ones. Such a strong statement up front aligns beautifully with the song's message—self-confidence does not need to be prepared by a verse.

Salt-N-Pepa's version, "Shake Your Thang," begins by assembling the same groove as the Isley Brothers' original. As shown in Example 3.13, the song's intro undergoes an accumulative process beginning with the piano hook plus fragments of the bass and guitar parts transposed up a whole step from the original version to G major. The bass and guitar layers crystalize after the first four bars. A few other elements not heard in the Isley Brothers' version are also present: vocal exclamations from guest artist E.U., a wah-wah guitar, and a rhythmic instrument with a shaker-like timbre. The drum beat is different in that it is present from the start of the track and is sampled from James Brown's "Funky President (People It's Bad)" (1974), also the source of the wah-wah guitar. The shaker, not added until the third measure, adds to the light accumulative effect in the intro.

Salt and Pepa deliver a shared verse after the inrto in which they recontextualize the message of the Isley Brothers' chorus. The first verse sets the scene at a dance where Salt and Pepa are having fun getting down but some attendees don't like their moves (Example 3.14). A fight nearly breaks out but stolid DJ Spinderella breaks it up, convincing Salt and Pepa to turn their

**Example 3.13:** "Shake Your Thang," intro, bass, guitar, and piano

**Example 3.14:** Salt-N-Pepa, "Shake Your Thang," lyrics, first VCU

| | |
|---|---|
| Verse 1 (Salt and Pepa) | We was on a dance floor shakin' our thing<br>To a funky beat with a go-go swing<br>Everyone was watching, they stared in shock<br>Amazed at how Salt and Pepa was rock-<br>in' the place with a smile on my face<br>Some got upset and then tried to base<br>They called us nasty, said we danced dirty<br>Claimed we were freaks, cheap, even flirty<br>Pepa got pissed and pulled out a pump<br>I was all set not to jet but to jump<br>Spin broke it up and asked not to break<br>Said, "They don't understand the way you" |
| Chorus (E.U.) | Shake your thang, do what you wanna do<br>I can't tell you how to catch a groove<br>It's your thang, do what you wanna go<br>I won't tell you who to sock it to |

confrontational energy into positivity. Spinderella's explanation of how their detractors "don't understand" Salt and Pepa ushers in the chorus via a lyrical elision: "shake your thang" forms both the end of her exhortation and the beginning of the chorus. It is at this juncture that E.U. takes over and begins singing, creating timbral contrast to Salt and Pepa's rapped delivery. E.U. tweaks the lyrics of the Isley Brothers' chorus slightly by replacing the "who to sock it to" with "how to catch a groove" in the second line. This alteration situates the chorus in the specific context of the dance hall Salt and Pepa describe in their verse. E.U.'s recording of the chorus (Example 3.15) features octave doubling, moments of harmonization, and response vocals not heard in the Isley Brothers' but other than that is largely true to the original; the horn interjections are retained as well.

**Example 3.15:** Salt-N-Pepa, "Shake Your Thang," chorus

A number of factors make the expression of formal functions more prototypical in Salt-N-Pepa's version than in the original. First among these is the order of verse-chorus pairs: verses precede their paired choruses throughout "Shake Your Thang," following a statistically normal pattern. Second, the choruses are climactic points within each verse-chorus cycle. The texture during

Salt-N-Pepa's verses is subdued, at times reducing to just the rapped lyrics and percussion. The choruses, meanwhile, feature the singing transcribed above accompanied by the full instrumental forces of the beat. The choruses are also anticipated by drum fills, solidifying the teleological relationship between the verses and choruses. This, in a sense, corrects the verse-chorus relationship in the Isley Brothers' version. The harmonic loop is the same between the two core sections in Salt-N-Pepa's version. Instead of using a the I–IV shuttle in the chorus and a tonic pedal in the verse, Salt-N-Pepa repeat the former for the duration of each VCU. This non-change does little to complicate the differentiation between the two sections because of the abundance of other changes just cited.

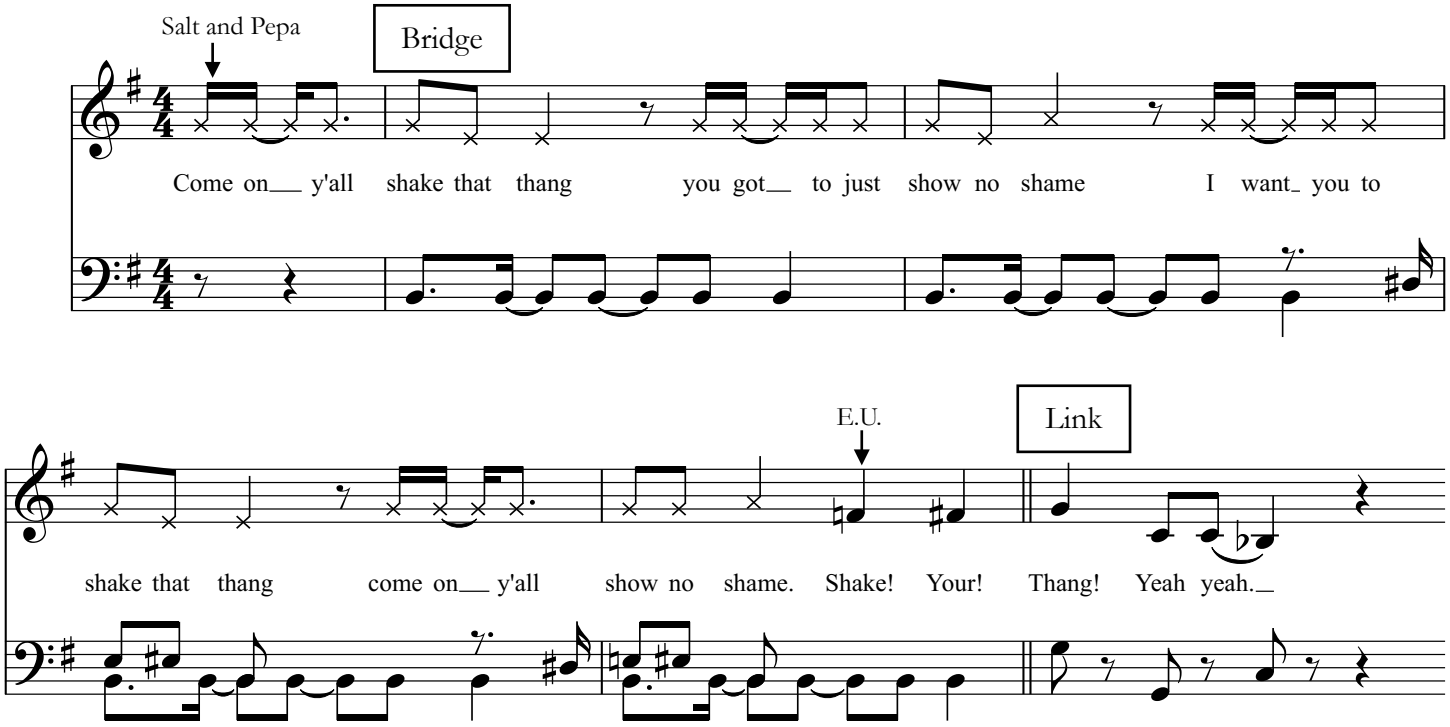
We are now in a good position to take a broader view of "Shake Your Thang" and consider additional formal sections not present in original version; Example 3.16 summarizes the form of the

**Example 3.16:** "Shake Your Thang," full song form

| AABA form | Time | Modules from Isley Brothers'version | Section |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 0:00–0:19 | | Intro |
| A | 0:19–0:46 | | Verse 1 |
| | 0:47–1:05 | 1a/2a/3a/4 | Chorus |
| A | 1:06–1:28 | | Verse 2 |
| | 1:29–1:47 | 1a/2a/3a/4 | Chorus |
| B | 1:48–1:56 | | Bridge |
| | 1:57–2:06 | | Link |
| A | 2:07–2:34 | | Verse 3 |
| | 2:34–2:52 | 1a/2a/3a/4 | Chorus |
| | 2:53–3:25 | | Verse 4 |
| | 3:25–3:44 | 1a/2a/3a/4 | Chorus |
| | 3:45–4:01 | | Outro |

entire song. Two verse-chorus cycles are followed by a bridge that was apparently newly composed for Salt-N-Papa's version, creating an overall song form of AABA. This bridge is quite unique in that its sources of change include not only timbre, rhythm, texture, and lyrics, but also harmony. As the transcription in Example 3.17 shows, Salt and Pepa chant lyrics that, if there wasn't already a chorus, would serve well as hook lyrics. The bass guitar introduces rhythm unique to the bridge section; the horn parts not shown in the example are roughly homorhythmic with the bass. The bass and horns state a 3-2 son clave, a rhythm strongly associated with Afro-Cuban dance music. This is fitting given the topic of the song and Salt and Pepa's imperatives in the bridge. Whereas the verses seem to talk about dancing, the bridge's lyrics and overt reference to dance through rhythm take us to a scene unfolding on the dance floor itself.[30] The bridge's lone harmony is a B major chord, the

**Example 3.17:** "Shake Your Thang," bridge, vocals and bass




[30] This reading is supported by the song's music video (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aYtY7VaF85s). There are some shots of Salt and Pepa dancing in a group during the verses, but they mostly take place in a police interrogation room. During the bridge, however, the camera does not stray from capturing them dance.

major mediant in the song's home key of G. Its tonal status is debatable: it could be heard in a hierarchical relationship to the overall tonic or as a temporary tonic of its own. In the former reading, G major is still the tonic during the bridge and the B major chord serves an unstable harmony that leads back to tonic at the start of the link. In the latter reading, the bridge actually changes keys from G to B major. Alternatively, both situations are true at the same time. At the beginning of the bridge, it sounds as if the song has changed keys because of the emphatic restatement of a new major chord, but at the end of the bridge, the very same harmony has new meaning in light of E.U.'s ascending, tonic-directed melody that leads to the G major chord at the start of the link. Either way, harmonic contrast is achieved. The passage that follows (the link) sounds at first as though it may be the chorus because it presents some of that section's lyrics ("I won't tell you how to catch a groove"). But E.U.'s full vocal forces are missing as are the horn licks heard in the choruses. The role this section plays is to relaunch the following verse, which is why I label it as a link. Finally, we hear two more VCUs before an outro with just the instrumental groove. The final 'A' section is expanded from a prototypical AABA form with the second VCU.

Conclusion

Salt-N-Pepa's rap versions transform numerous aspects of their source tracks, including musical form. In "Twist and Shout," the rap trio differentiates sections that were homogeneous in the Beatles' original and reserves lyrical repetition for the choruses only, making the overall form less ambiguous. Their version of "It's Your Thing" presents formal functions with characteristics that are more typical based on the pop and hip-hop norms outlined in this dissertation. The song's rapped verses contrast timbrally, lyrically, and energetically with its sung choruses. Even the new section added by Salt-N-Pepa, the bridge, has a relatively clear role: whereas harmony is rarely a source of contrast in hip-hop bridges, its use in this case may resonate with the acculturated pop-rock listener. In both cases, Salt-N-Pepa's versions resolve conflicts of formal design present in the original.

Are there any explanations as to why this trend exists? One possibility has to do with the generic crossover at play in Salt-N-Pepa's versioned songs. The mere act of transporting pop-rock songs into the realm of hip-hop inherently introduces a new source of contrast because of the difference between singing and rapping. A large source of the differentiation between the verses and choruses in "Twist and Shout" comes from the difference between the rapping in the verses and singing in the choruses. The difference between the rapping and singing in "Shake Your Thang" highlights the chorus's climactic nature, especially because Salt and Pepa's rapping is fairly easygoing.[31] Another reason that applies to "Shake Your Thang" is the collaboration with E.U. Guest artists on hip-hop songs commonly do one of two things: rap a guest verse or sing the hook/chorus. E.U. was not a rap act, so their role was always going to be to provide some sort of sung component. The clear division of labor (Salt and Pepa rap and E.U. sings) manifests in the form of the song: Salt and Pepa stay out of the choruses and E.U. stays out of the verses. Finally, Salt-N-Papa's cover style is influenced, if not controlled, by their producer, Hurby Azor. As mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, Azor seems to have had a strong intuitive sense for successful songwriting. The formal designs of "Twist and Shout" and (especially) "Shake Your Thang" provide evidence to suggest that he was following the Run-D.M.C. model of hip-hop covering. In "Walk This Way," Run-D.M.C. rap verses while Steven Tyler sings the choruses (the ordering—verse first—is also the same in comparison to "Shake Your Thang"). Aerosmith's original does not present any major challenges of formal interpretation, but besides this, Azor and Salt-N-Pepa's projects are packaged similarly to Run-D.M.C. and Aerosmith's.

This chapter has taken the foundation of formal functions, section types, and song forms laid in Chapter 1 and 2 and applied them to two hip-hop cover songs by Salt-N-Pepa. I hope to have provided a rich historical snapshot of two unique instances of musical borrowing through the lens

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[31] Krims's "sung style" of flow, the simplest of his three categories, describes the rapping in "Shake Your Thang."

of form. Salt-N-Pepa are part of the first wave of hip-hop acts in the Golden Age. Since the late 1980s, popular music, including hip-hop, has gone through many trends. Whereas this chapter investigates an early rap group as a case study, Chapter 4 unpacks the impact of some of these trends in modern hip-hop, specifically with regard to how it has been influenced by trap music.

# CHAPTER 4: INTER-ROTATIONAL FORM IN TRAP-INFLUENCED HIP-HOP

I have focused thus far on repertoire from the so-called Golden Age of hip-hop, with just a few mentions of artists whose careers blossomed after the new millennium. This chapter investigates formal procedures in a subgenre of hip-hop that is relatively new, especially to the mainstream of popular music listeners. Trap music developed as a stylistic niche in Atlanta during the 1990s as a synthesis of classic East and West coast hip-hop, Miami bass music, and crunk, another Southern specialty. Around the turn of the millennium, producers like Shawty Redd began to saturate their Roland TR-808-made beats with fast hi-hats and deep rumbling bass kicks, sounds that continue to characterize trap today.[1] Memphis's Three 6 Mafia are also recognized as being important predecessors to the modern trap sound, despite having been based in Memphis.[2] Regional subject matter also distinguished trap music during its early years: Atlanta-based artists like Goodie Mob and Outkast began using the word "trap" in their verses to refer to the "trap" or "trap house."[3] The trap can denote a literal house where drug deals take place or allude to a more general sense of living in an environment stricken with poverty, drugs, and gun violence.[4] Trap was not well known beyond Georgia's capital city until the mid-2000s when T.I. and Gucci Mane rose to international popularity.

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[1] Released by Roland in 1980, the TR-808 Rhythm Composer one of the first widely available drum machines that allowed users to program their own rhythms on a sixteen-key grid using various preset sounds. Whereas some more expensive competing products used samples of real instruments, the TR-808 produced sounds through analog synthesis. The resulting unrealistic quality of the 808's presets was initially seen as a disadvantage, but enough artists were drawn to its affordability and distinctive booming bass sound that it became one of the most important sonic resources in hip-hop's history. Artists rarely use actual TR-808 synthesizers in music production today, but most Digital Audio Workstations feature 808 sounds or simulators.

[2] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nmjqQy6DzGM; https://www.nme.com/features/music-interviews/three-6-mafia-we-changed-beatles-juicy-j-rupp-arena-lexington-2831942.

[3] According to A.R. Shaw (2020, 61–2), the first songs to use the words "trap" were Goodie Mob's "Thought Process" (1995), OutKast's "Wheelz of Steel" (1996). An earlier example is Kilo Ali's "Keep on Rollin" (1991), which contains the lyrics "quarter to three before I hit the trap" (https://www.okayplayer.com/music/who-invented-trap-music.html).

[4] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zKicD86F7KA.

T.I.'s 2003 album *Trap Muzik* (which debuted at #4 on the *Billboard* Hot 200) and Gucci Mane's albums *Trap House* (2005) and *Trap-A-Thon* (2007) exposed a much wider audience to the name, meaning, and musical style of trap.[5] By about 2010, the trap sound was one of the most prevalent in North American popular music. In 2013, Atlanta-based group Migos struck gold when their single "Versace" caught Drake's ear. The iconic Canadian rapper added a verse to the remix of "Versace," and with that the trap sound (along with Migos's distinctive triplet flow) was firmly cemented as the new sound of hip-hop in the ears of the public.

Musically speaking, trap is characterized first and foremost by a sizzling closed hi-hat sound foregrounded in the explicit beat layer. If one entrains to the snare backbeat falling on beats two and four of a 4/4 measure, than the tempo of trap songs tends to be relatively slow. Trap also very often features a booming, low bass layer that does more work as an atmospheric body-shaking element of the texture than as a pitched one.[6] Ashley Pointer's description of trap corroborates these stylistic essentials: "Trap is characterized by busy hi-hats, heavy sub-bass, gritty, and super rhythmic snares, and deep 808 kick drums."[7] Each of these musical elements is evident in Fetty Wap's 2015 trap anthem "Trap Queen," an excerpt of which is transcribed in Example 4.1. The metallic timbre of the hi-hat cuts through the texture with articulations as fast as sixteenth-note triplets. The explicit beat layer in most trap music embraces the precise, electronic timbre of sound patches offered by synthesizers and DAWs. The result is that the hi-hat is striking not only because of its speed but also because each articulation is identical, giving beats in this genre a tight and snappy quality. The bass in

[5] https://www.billboard.com/artist/t.i./chart-history/tlp/. T.I. and Gucci Mane make up two-thirds of the "trap trinity," with Jeezy (formerly Young Jeezy) completing the triad.
[6] Producers of trap beats often double the articulations of the bass with a kick drum, as can be seen in this instructional video made by Chuki Beats: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QogifYzOh34. "Sidechaining" is a production technique developed to avoid too much frequency overlap between bass and kick drum and is especially useful because their rhythms are commonly identical.
[7] https://online.berklee.edu/takenote/trap-music-where-it-came-from-and-where-its-going/.

"Trap Queen" is not particularly low and rumbly,[8] but it is atmospheric in the sense that its durations are mostly long. It is an idiomatic bass line, in other words, because the actual pitches are

**Example 4.1:** Fetty Wap, "Trap Queen," hook, first half (0:54–1:08)

[8] Listen to "Bad and Boujee" (2017) by Migos for a floor-shaking bass part.

less important than the percussive effect it has on the sound of the song. As the vertical lines starting in the third measure of Example 4.1 indicate, many of the bass's articulations are in sync with the kick drum, contributing to the former's role as a percussive reinforcement just as much as a pitch-based entity. Some metric features of "Trap Queen" are representative of trap more broadly speaking as well. The song's hook is transcribed in Example 4.1 at quarter note = 148, but this is not the only pulse one could entrain to. As the Arabic numerals between the bottom two staves of the first two measures show, the snare hits on notated beat three of each measure can also be understood as a backbeat for a tempo half as fast, i.e., 74 bpm. The point here is not to argue for one tempo as the true or correct one, but rather to highlight how trap songs usually broadcast two viable streams of metric entrainment.[9]

One last common characteristic of trap music has to do with how rappers deliver lyrics: words are very often set to highly repetitive diatonic melodic motives surrounded by pauses. Example 4.2 shows an excerpt from the first hook and verse of Lil Uzi Vert's "X" (2017) to demonstrate this point. The hook begins with a two-beat pickup with a descending stepwise melodic contour outlining $\hat{3}-\hat{2}-\hat{1}$ in E♭ major. Each note sets one syllable of text for a total of five syllables including the downbeat of the hook. This basic motive is repeated with slight variations for every line of the hook. It continues to form the basic text-setting device during the verse despite Uzi's addition of some tonic pitches preceding the descending motive near the end of the passage. As we will see in numerous examples below, the approach to text setting used in "X" is common throughout the trap repertoire. Simple, diatonic motives are repeated exactly or with slight variation in the same metrical location from line to line and are usually framed by rests. One implication of

[9] De Clercq reports that various theorists posit "ideal" tempos in popular music between 70 and 125 bpm. De Clercq's own ideal tempo of 120 is only slightly faster than the midway point (111) between the two pulse streams of 74 and 148 in "Trap Queen" (2016, §2.4–8).

this characteristic for the study of form in trap is that change within the lyric layer is marked; it is attention-grabbing because any change feels all the more important amid a sea of sameness.

**Example 4.2:** First hook and beginning of the first verse in Lil Uzi Vert's "X"

Form in trap music is a topic that is so far underexplored in the scholarly literature. This chapter seeks to add another musical characteristic that differentiates trap from other subgenres of hip-hop vis-à-vis precisely this parameter. My argument is that a great deal of trap is characterized by a unique formal procedure that I call inter-rotational form. Inter-rotational songs resist categorization of their constituent segments and formal functions within individual formal units or within a single cycle through the core verse-hook cycle. Even when formal segmentation and

function are clearly differentiated by some parameters, trap songs usually feature other cues that suggest a conflicting scheme or schemes of segmentation, function, or both. Trap is a fairly wide-ranging subgenre and many trap songs are best interpreted as intra-rotational, i.e., their formal segments and functions are relatively clear within individual verse-hook cycles. However, inter-rotational form is common enough and seemingly endemic to trap, making it a stylistic marker.

Intra- and Inter-Rotational Form: An Overview

*Inter*-rotational form is part of an interpretive lens for analyzing, hearing, and understanding, trap music. It is construed in opposition to *intra*-rotational form. Rotations in the present context refer to cycles through a song's central formal unit. Musics from a wide variety of historical periods and styles feature such cycles. Countless German lieder, for instance, are strophic, meaning the same music is repeated while verses of text change. Each complete pass through the musical material of a strophic song amounts to a rotation. Many blues songs also operate under this pattern: the 12-bar harmonic pattern |I |I |I |I |IV |IV |I |I |V |IV |I |I | repeats while a singer delivers lyrics that change each time through. Each rotation consists of one essential formal unit in many strophic lieder and virtually all 12-bar blues songs, although several less substantial segments like phrases and sub-phrases exist within those cycles. Rotations may also consist of more than one essential formal unit. James Hepokoski uses the term "rotation" to refer to "the architectural propensity within the [classical] style to recycle arrays of thematic material in relatively the same order" (2002, 110). Hepokoski's focus is on pieces in dialogue with sonata form, a formal process that typically contains at least three and often more sections (e.g., first theme, transition, second theme) within each rotation. In pop-rock music, the pairing of verses with choruses is so common that David Temperley uses the term "verse-chorus unit" instead of having to repeatedly use a more cumbersome phrase like "the span of music beginning with the verse and ending with a chorus." Similarly, Drew Nobile develops a typology of harmony and voice-leading schemes across verse-

chorus units in several chapters of his book *Form as Harmony in Rock Music* (2020). Just as pop-rock songs are frequently organized via several rotations through a core verse-chorus pair, hip-hop songs often cycle through core verse-hook rotations.

In intra-rotational songs, the segmentation and function of formal units is generally interpretable *within* rotations of the core cycle. Some generic norms—like those explored at length in Chapter 1 and summarized in Example 1.18—often allow for the identification of formal function of a unit without having to hear the entire rotation. Example 4.3 summarizes the musical attributes

**Example 4.3:** Characteristics differentiating verse and chorus in "Trap Queen"

| Verse 1 (1:21–1:47) | Chorus 2 (1:47–2:12) |
|---|---|
| • Half-sung/half-spoken lyrics<br>• No internal lyrical repetition<br>• Thin texture | • Sung lyrics<br>• Internal lyrical repetition<br>• Same lyrics as first chorus (0:55–1:20)<br>• Thick texture (first half) |

that make "Trap Queen" intra-rotational.[10] Example 4.3 presents the first verse and second chorus because "Trap Queen" *begins* with a pre-chorus–chorus succession. To my ears, the second chorus is the end of a larger unit, not the beginning of a new one. Some musical elements remain the same between the verse and the chorus: both sections are built on the oscillating harmonic progression |i | v | in A minor with a similar supporting bass line, have the same exact snare pattern, and contain the same synth hits stated in a quasi-clave rhythm throughout. Despite these similarities, enough musical elements change between the verse and chorus to generate a clear formal boundary and strongly suggest different formal functions. Fetty Wap virtually shouts the lyrics in the verse but sings a repetitive and easily notated melody during the chorus. The lyrics within the verse feature no

[10] That "Trap Queen" is intra-rotational, of course, makes it an exception to this chapter's main rule, i.e., that trap music is stylistically unique for its prevalent use of inter-rotational form.

internal repetition but are highly repetitive in the chorus, both from line to line (the words "my baby" end each line) and across larger chunks (the final four lines of the chorus are an exact repetition of the first four). Finally, the chorus's texture—at least for the first half—is made notably thicker than the verse's by a sonorous bass with longer durations and additional synth layers.

One important aspect of these musical changes is that they are in phase with each other and with the change in formal section. The downbeat of the chorus aligns precisely with the start of Fetty Wap's singing, a new set of repetitive lyrics, and the thickening of the texture. Trap music is often inter-rotational not for a lack of changes in musical parameters but rather because of misalignments between the timing of these changes. Many trap songs are inter-rotational because various changes in musical parameters are out of phase with each other.[11] "Trap Queen" is intra-rotational because the music projects a relatively clear formal boundary between sections with different and recognizable formal functions. In theory, a listener familiar with Anglo-American popular music would comprehend the sections' roles within the span of this verse-chorus unit, i.e., within a single core rotation. Awareness of some tendencies of popular music—like for verses to be lyrically dense—would probably allow a listener to recognize what section is being played without having to hear the entire verse-chorus unit.

Inter-rotational songs, on the other hand, generally require two or more rotations through the core formal cycle in order to clarify the location of section boundaries and functions of the sections. As an introductory example, the flow and several textural events in the first verse-hook unit of Migos's "Narcos" (2018) are transcribed in Example 4.4. Offset begins with non-pitched lyrics set to an anacrustic rhythm beginning on the sixth eighth note of every measure except the initial pickup. Quavo then enters with quarter-note triplets that serve as pickups to the eighth

[11] Ken Stephenson cites the degree of alignment between various musical parameters (for Stephenson, "text, instrumentation, rhythm, and harmony") as creating either "clear form" or "ambiguity" (2002, 122).

measure of the excerpt. Quavo's flow is quite different than Offset's because it features a fully pitched melody, compound subdivisions of the beat, and a new end rhyme that departs from the "oh" syllable used by Offset. Already, the change in rapper and difference in their flows may suggest

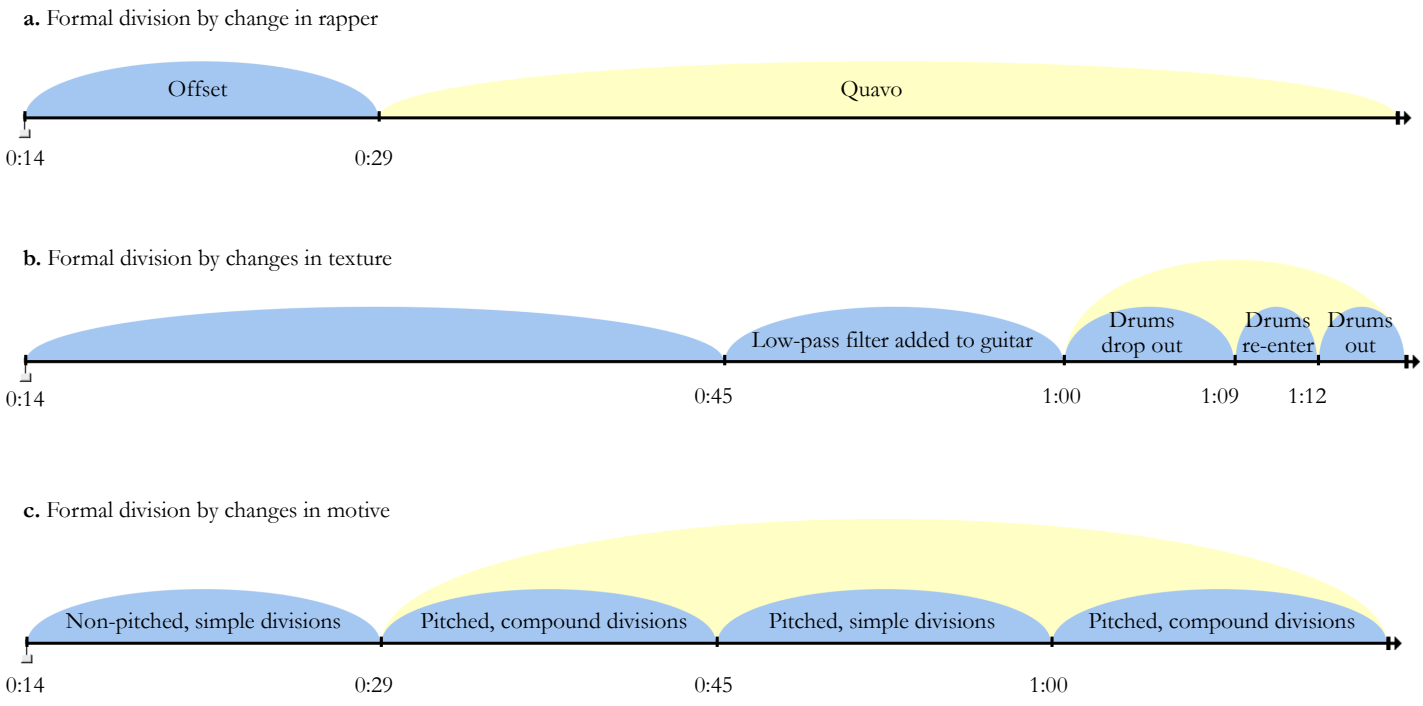
**Example 4.4:** Flow, rapper changes, textural changes, and motives across the first verse-hook unit in Migos's "Narcos"

a formal boundary. Given that Offset raps without pitches and had slightly higher rhythmic density while Quavo sings and repeats lyrics ("straight out the jungle"), it would be reasonable to identify Offset's passage as a verse and Quavo's as a hook. Eight measures later, Quavo's flow changes: it is still completely pitched but occupies a lower tessitura and uses simple divisions of the beat. At this same moment, a low-pass filter is added to the guitar part. The combination of these two changes again presents the possibility of hearing a formal boundary. However, this interpretation is quickly complicated when Quavo returns to a motive used at the end of the previous hypothetical division. As Example 4.4 highlights in orange, the rapper returns not only to the lyrics "straight out the jungle," but also to the same melodic motive with which he first sung them. After four more measures of the simple division flow, the drums drop out and Quavo once again sings the higher "jungle" motive, this time with different lyrics—"we picked up the hundos." He then finishes his stint on the mic with a return to his opening melodic motive (quarter note triplets in a lower range) while the drums enter and drop out again in two-measure intervals. These last changes in texture do not strongly suggest new formal units because they are fairly short-lived. The motivic activity, however, supports the interpretation of Quavo's excerpt as a single formal unit in that they create a bookending effect, as the green boxes in Example 4.4 point out.

The musical cues in this excerpt highlight the complicated situation in terms of formal division and function in "Narcos." Is there a change of section when Quavo starts rapping? If so, what is the formal function of each section? Does Quavo himself rap over one section, two, or more? What are the functions of these sections? Examples 4.5a–c present three interpretations of formal division, each based on one of the conflicting musical parameters: change in rapper, change in texture, and motive. Note that none of these examples says anything about *function* (i.e., where the verse are hook are, if they are present at all). They simply capture several paths for hearing formal *division*. Example 4.5a divides the excerpt at the moment when Quavo takes over the mic from

Offset. Formal articulations are highlighted based on changes in texture in Example 4.5b. The two major changes are the addition of the low-pass filter at 0:45 and the drums dropping out at 1:00; the last two changes at 1:09 and 1:12 are noted in Example 4.5b, but are grouped together at a slightly higher level because they take place too quickly to establish stable divisions. Example 4.5c shows divisions based on changes in motive: the same large-scale segmentation as in Example 4.5a takes place, but lower-level divisions are also prominent because of Quavo's use of different rhythmic and melodic patterning.

**Examples 4.5a–c:** Various paths of segmentation, first verse-hook unit of "Narcos"

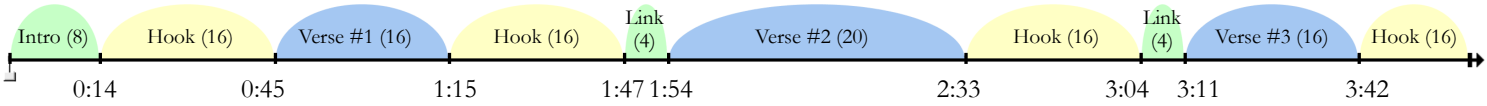



The multiple segmentation schemes available in the first verse-hook unit of "Narcos" are demonstrative of the normal situation in inter-rotational songs. Within one pass through a song's core formal cycle, it is neither clear where the most important formal divisions are nor what formal functions are at play within any perceived sections. Both the beat layer and the lyrical layer influence

our perception of segmentation and function. In songs in which the beat layer changes very little over long spans of time, the lyrical layer is more important in creating segments. In songs in which the beat layer fluctuates more prominently and/or frequently, the influences of the beat layer and lyric layer on the perception of form are more evenly distributed. "Narcos" falls into the latter category: changes in both the flow layer and the beat layer are somewhat pronounced and frequent. No single change is strong enough and no changes coincide between the two layers so as to project an obvious formal scheme.

Despite all this, inter-rotational songs do express formal divisions and functions, and trap artists do organize their songs in ways that overlap with well-known formal patterns from pop-rock and hip-hop music. If we continue past the first verse-hook cycle of "Narcos," for example, we hear an exact repetition of the first sixteen measures of Example 4.4, starting with the opening line "Trapping like the narco." One of the central distinctions between hook (or chorus) and verse function long identified by theorists and artists is that the former section type has the same lyrics while the latter has different lyrics each time through. This is the single most reliable way to interpret form in inter-rotational songs. Additionally, the subtle textural change of the low-pass filter added to the guitar coincides with the start of the verse. Even if form is blurry or complicated within core cycles, lyrical repetition in each pass of the hook/chorus generally does take place and therefore clarifies the segmentation and function of the rotation. "Narcos" is an exemplar of the challenges presented for the real-time interpretive process that takes place in inter-rotational songs. Within the first rotation through the verse-hook cycle, it is difficult to discern where formal divisions occur (if they do occur at all) and what the formal functions within any of those sections might be. But upon the second and subsequent rotations through the core cycle, the repetition of previously heard lyrics provides a familiar musical cue and clarifies division and function: Offset and Quavo share a sixteen-measure hook (Example 4.6).

**Example 4.6:** Full formal diagram of "Narcos"




The inter-/intra-rotational framework most directly applies to real-time and first-time processing of form. If one has heard all of "Narcos" once, for instance, the song can only be said to be inter-rotational in the sense that during the *first* time through, they could not tell where formal divisions were. The more one listens to the same song over again, the more the sense that there was ever a doubt about the formal division or function diminishes. A rehearsed hearing of a song relieves us of the uncertainty that comes with a first-time listening, especially to a song that is inter-rotational. We only get one chance to listen to a song for the first time, but just because we know what is coming during subsequent listens does not mean we should ignore or forget the experience of the first hearing. The inter-rotational quality of a song is most prominent during the first listen and remains a part of the identity of a song, even if we do not need to hear multiple rotations of the core cycle to identify formal segmentation and function upon later hearings.

Before proceeding to more extensive analyses of inter-rotational songs, it is worth considering "the grey area": ambiguity of formal function and how it conceptually informs intra-/inter-rotational form. The intra- and inter-rotational schemas are conceptualized in binary opposition to one another, but their application to real music is often quite complicated. No matter how clearly an intra-rotational song presents its formal boundaries and functions, one will still feel more confident in their interpretation after hearing the song in its entirety; multiple listens tend to sure up an interpretation. Formal labeling in some songs is not clear at all, no matter how many listens one gets. De Clercq (2017) places this conundrum under the microscope, highlighting various disagreements among theorists in the interpretation of form in pop-rock music. Because such

analytical disagreements are so common, de Clercq argues that theorists should "embrace ambiguity in the analysis of form in pop/rock music" and that it is "often preferable to adopt a 'both/and' approach to section labels rather than the mutually exclusive 'either/or' approach that pervades extant published analyses" (§1.6). Adams extends the idea of ambiguity to post-millennial EDM-influenced pop music by arguing "formal units" in this repertoire "are inherently unstable" (2019, abstract).

In light of this, it is important to note that just because a song is intra-rotational does not mean that its form is necessarily unequivocal or easy to analyze. Furthermore, different listeners will not necessarily agree on whether a song is inter- or intra-rotational. While one listener might feel uncertain as to the segmentation and formal functions in the first verse-hook unit of "Narcos," another listener may hear the same passage and have a clear idea of where they think the verse and the hook are. (Whether they have correctly heard these sections and functions is a separate question, but it is certainly possible to revise what was initially a confident reading of the form upon hearing further rotations.) Exhaustively accounting for such differences in the perception of form is beyond the scope of this dissertation, but familiarity with the artist and genre is highly influential in this regard. If, for instance, one listener knows the title of the song "Narcos" before they listen to it, they may be more likely to assign hook function to the excerpt containing the first line of the song ("Trapping like the *narco*"). Another listener might be aware that trap artists (especially Quavo of Migos) are just as likely to sing their verse lyrics as they are to sing during hooks, and therefore that when Quavo starts singing at forty-five seconds into the song, it doesn't necessarily indicate a change from verse to hook.

Finally, an important distinction between de Clercq and Adams's work and my own must be made: for the most part, interpretive issues in their analyses arise from conflicting cues within sections with clear boundaries. This is particularly true in the case of the EDM-infused pop explored

by Adams, who writes, "the boundaries of formal sections are uncontroversial" (2019, 34). The first of de Clercq's three most common types of ambiguity, "verse ambiguity," results from "weak differentiation between the verse material itself and the material that follows" (2017, §3.1). But his last two types of ambiguity (chorus ambiguity and bridge ambiguity) are caused by mixed cues within clearly articulated spans. In the trap music I discuss in this chapter, interpretive challenges are caused by unclear segmentation just as often as unclear function. In the discussion that follows, I posit two sources of ambiguity found in inter-rotational trap songs (homogeneity and out-of-phase changes) and one specific formal scheme related to inter-rotational form (two viable hook segmentations). The musical reality of each topic is substantiated with detailed analyses of songs from the trap repertoire.

Homogeneity

In order for a song to be inter-rotational, there must be substantial ambiguity as to the segmentation, function, or both segmentation and function of large spans of a song. One way in which such ambiguity is created is via a highly homogeneous musical fabric—like, for instance, the rapper's flow and the texture of the beat remaining the same over a long period of time. It is difficult to break a song up into sections if there is very little change for an extended interval. This type of ambiguity in trap is very closely related to what de Clercq calls "verse ambiguity" in pop-rock music in which "it is not clear whether a passage should be considered one long span of verse or a verse plus some other section" (2017 §3.1). In the analyses that follow, homogeneity within verse-hook cycles creates a need to hear multiple rotations in order to clarify segmentation and function. Function is sometimes ambiguous, but more importantly it has a propensity to change between rotations. Since it is stylistically normative in hip-hop for verses to be long, hearing one long span with the same texture and fairly similar flow suggests verse function. But it is often the case that a hook has been delivered without making itself obvious. During the second and subsequent

rotations, a passage that may have originally presented verse function changes to having hook function, or vice versa.

Jack Harlow's "Whats Poppin" (2020) is a braggadocious track that displays the young rapper's humorous (if, at times, lewd) wordplay, bouncy rhythmic sensibility, and crafty rhyme schemes. Debuting at a modest #96 on the *Billboard* Hot 100 the week of February 22, 2020, the track rose as high as #8 the week of July 4th, while a remix featuring Tory Lanez, Lil Wayne, and Da Baby reached #2. "Whats Poppin" has become one of Harlow's staples at live shows: according to concertarchives.org, the song has been a show-ender at most of his concerts since mid-2020, implying that it is a song his fans love hearing and that sends them off into the night in a good mood.[12] Both the flow and beat in "Whats Poppin" are highly homogeneous over time, making the interpretation of formal segmentation and function something of a guessing game within the first rotation through the verse-hook unit. It is a prime example of a song whose initial formal ambiguity and inter-rotational nature are caused by minimal musical change over a long period of time.

In the original version of the song, a non-intrusive beat consisting of a typical trap drum pattern, a simple minor-mode piano riff that repeats every two measures, and a sporadic punchy bass part accompanies Harlow's rapping. The beat layer undergoes very few changes throughout the song, as Example 4.7 shows. The changes that do exist are fairly subtle and do not strongly suggest formal segmentation. The most prominent textural change in the song comes within the first ten seconds. For four measures, we here only the piano riff, then at the 0:06 mark, the full beat drops. But this moment does not sound like a new formal unit because the preceding passage was so short and because Harlow's flow (including his rhyme scheme) follows a similar pattern before and after

[12] https://www.concertarchives.org/bands/jack-harlow?page=1#concert-table.

**Example 4.7:** All textural changes throughout Jack Harlow, "Whats Poppin" (2020)

| **Time** | **0:06** | **0:33** | **0:45** | **1:37** | **1:45** | **1:52** | **1:54** | **2:04** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Changes** | full beat enters | beat brief pauses and bass drops out | beat brief pauses and bass re-enters | brief pause and bass drops out | brief pause | brief pause and bass re-enters | brief pause | brief pause |

the beat drop.[13] The remaining changes in the beat layer are either too short-lived or too subtle to strongly suggest new sections or formal functions on their own. The pauses in the beat at 0:33, 1:36, 1:45, 1:52, 1:54, and 2:04 are at most measure in length. Such pauses are also just as likely to occur periodically within verses to add variety as they are to occur at formal junctures. The bass's low pitch range and subdued volume in the mix make the more extended changes (the dropping-out and reentry of the bass) subtle, something a listener might not even notice. Given all this, the beat layer can be described as highly homogeneous across time in "Whats Poppin."

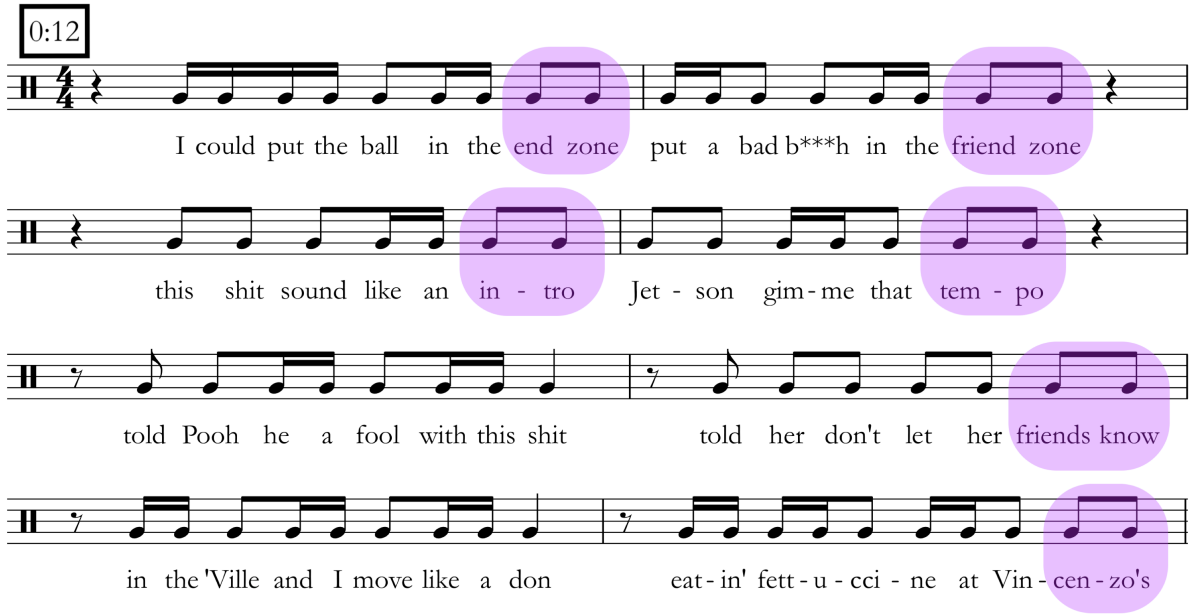
Harlow's flow is also homogeneous enough across the entire song to fall short of presenting obvious segmentation or functional schemes, though it does change more often and substantially than the beat. The first four couplets of the song are transcribed in Example 4.8. Each line of this excerpt begins after the downbeat and places the rhyming syllables on the last two eighths of the measure. Harlow's flow over the next eight measures is motivically quite similar to this opening passage. The lyrics in six of them begin after the downbeat; the end rhyme in six of them is two syllables long set to two eighth notes; and in four of them, the lyrics begin after the downbeat and

[13] Additionally, having the full beat enter near the beginning of a song that begins without drums is so normative in hip-hop as to be almost an expected occurrence. In some songs it aligns with the formal division between the intro and the first verse or hook, but when an artist raps steadily over this textural change (as Harlow does here), the whole passage is usually understood as part of the same section.

place the two-syllable end rhyme on the last two eighths of the bar (Example 4.9). Although the motivic specifics are different as the song progresses, Harlow continues with his approach of sticking to one rhyme and a similar rhythmic setting for relatively long spans. His pitch range is also

**Example 4.8:** "Whats Poppin," first four couplets

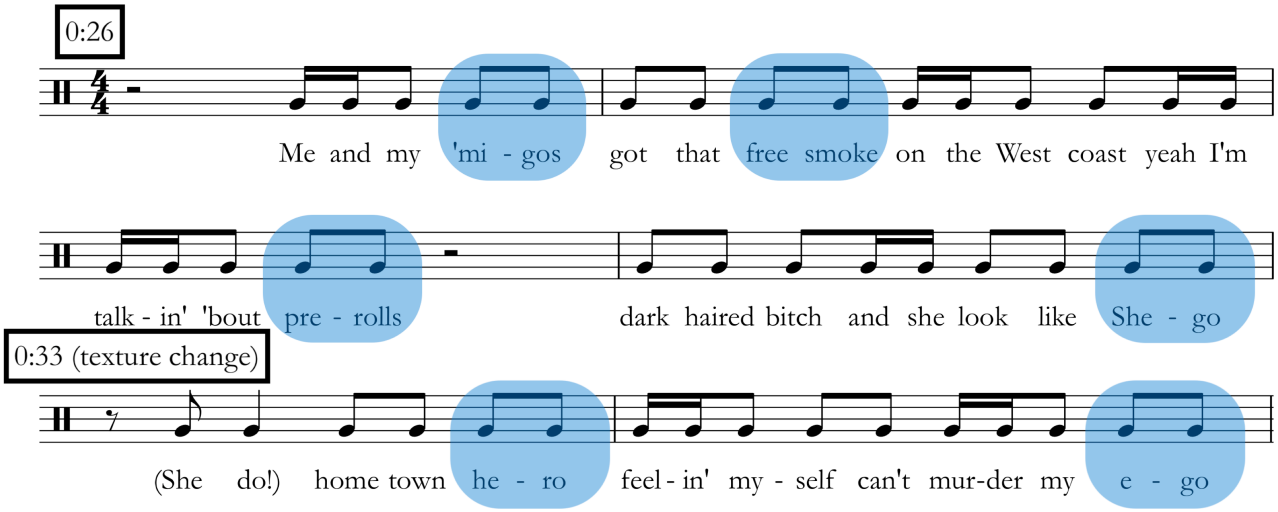
**Example 4.9:** Flow starting after first four couplets



very consistent for the entirety of the track, only moving up slightly from 0:56–1:52. Importantly, he also never sings—every word is delivered in a fairly neutral spoken rapping tone.

"Whats Poppin" is inter-rotational because there are very few musical changes for a long time in both the beat and lyrical layers. The changes that do exist are understated and occur at unpredictable intervals. Even where we might hear a cue that suggests a new segmentation, the two layers do not work together to confirm a change of section. For example, Harlow glides over the

**Example 4.10:** Continuation of same rhyme over textural change at 0:33 in "Whats Poppin"




potential section marker caused by the pause and bass drop out at 0:33 by using the same rhyme before and after that point (Example 4.10). The entirety of "Whats Poppin" might sound like a single continuous unit if it were not for a restatement of what turns out to be the hook lyrics ("What's poppin'? Brand new whip just hopped in…") at 1:52. Unless one is familiar with the title of the song, there is virtually no musical information up to this point that articulates spans or differentiates functions within perceived spans. Even recognition of the title lyric is not a steadfast cue: the song's title appears in verses and hooks in hip-hop without an unequivocal degree of

predictability.[14] Note also that the hook has changed functions between rotations. At first, it presents characteristics that most closely resemble verse function (no singing, no internal lyrical repetition, rhythmically dense), and is therefore likely to be heard as at least verse-like if not as simply part of the verse. The hook becomes a hook when its lyrics are repeated after the first full rotation of the song.[15]

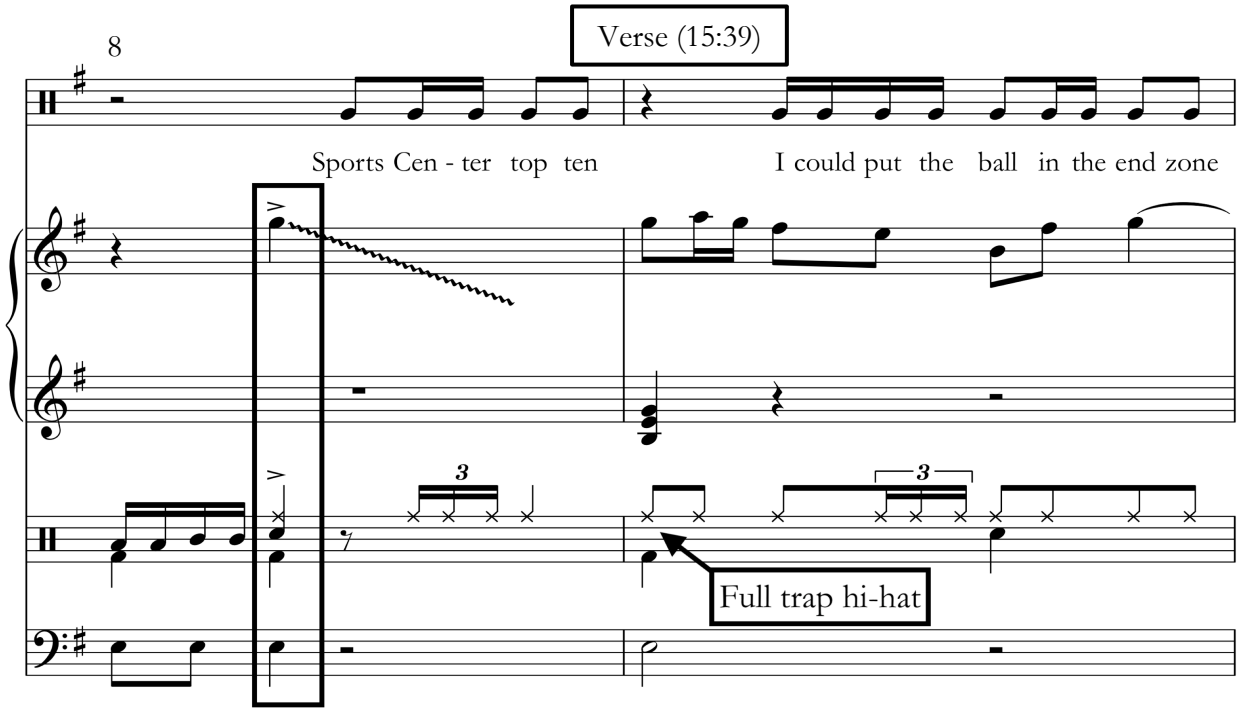
The hook's change in function between rotations is musically highlighted in a live performance Harlow gave of "Whats Poppin" as the last song of an NPR Tiny Desk Concert set in March of 2021.[16] Unlike the album version, the Tiny Desk performance features a full live band (keyboard, bass, drums, and guitar) and three backup singers. Unsurprisingly, the live musicians in the Tiny Desk version add slight variations to the beat—including new drum fills, a more active bass, and doubling of the song's main melodic riff on guitar—that are heard in the album version. There are also more substantive changes that directly shape the form of the song in ways not heard in the album version.[17] First, the band brings out the formal division between the initial hook and the verse (Example 4.11, m. 9). Even their musical changes do not highlight this change unequivocally given that Harlow's flow is very similar in both sections, but there is certainly a potential sense of segmentation that does not occur in the album version. This is especially true because of the coordinated ensemble hits and drum fill in mm. 7–8 of the passage, which announce the end of a section and create contrast with the less energetic material that follows. Drummer Rico

[14] In DJ Mustard's "Interstate 10" (feat. Future)—another inter-rotational song to be discussed below—the title lyric is stated twice, neither time during the hook.
[15] "Whats Poppin" is in an overall ABA form (hook–verse–hook), and therefore only has one full rotation of the verse-hook unit. It might even be more appropriate to say that the song consists of nothing but one large rotation in the form of an ABA ternary group. Yet it is still inter-rotational in the sense that segmentation and function are not obvious until a substantial unit is repeated.
[16] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GNrerhak_pY.
[17] Information as to who decided on these changes (Harlow, the backing musicians, someone else involved in the performance, or a combination of these parties) is unavailable, but the changes are undoubtedly planned.

Nichols also uses a different drum pattern during the hook than in the verse of the Tiny Desk Concert, whereas in the album version, the drum layer is the same in both sections (Example 4.12).

**Example 4.11:** Jack Harlow, "Whats Poppin," NPR Tiny Desk Concert performance, opening

**Example 4.11 continued**

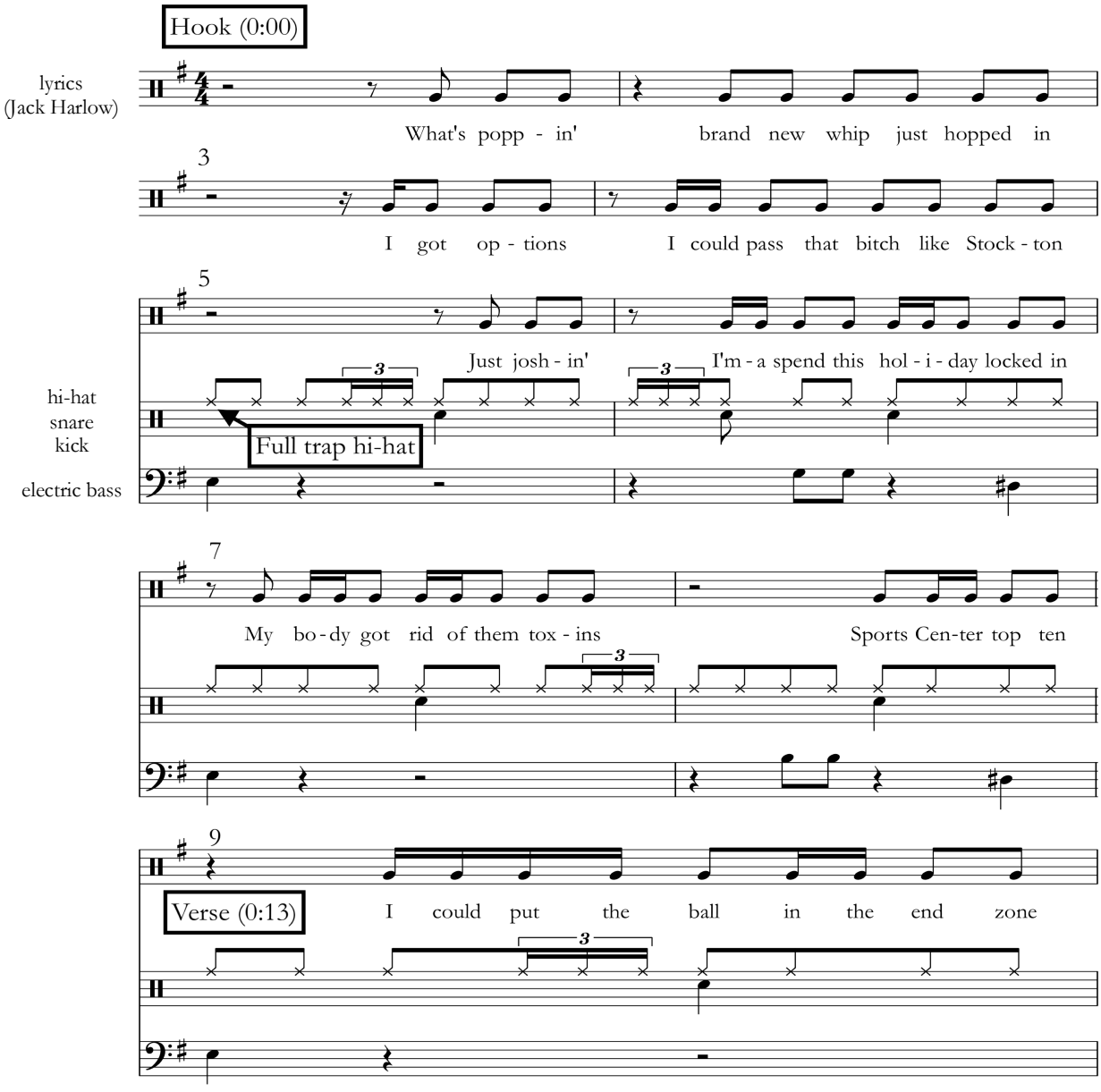



Nichols starts a drum beat in m. 5, the same measure that the beat drops in the album version, but the live drummer refrains from playing the fast trap hi-hat until the verse starts in m. 9.

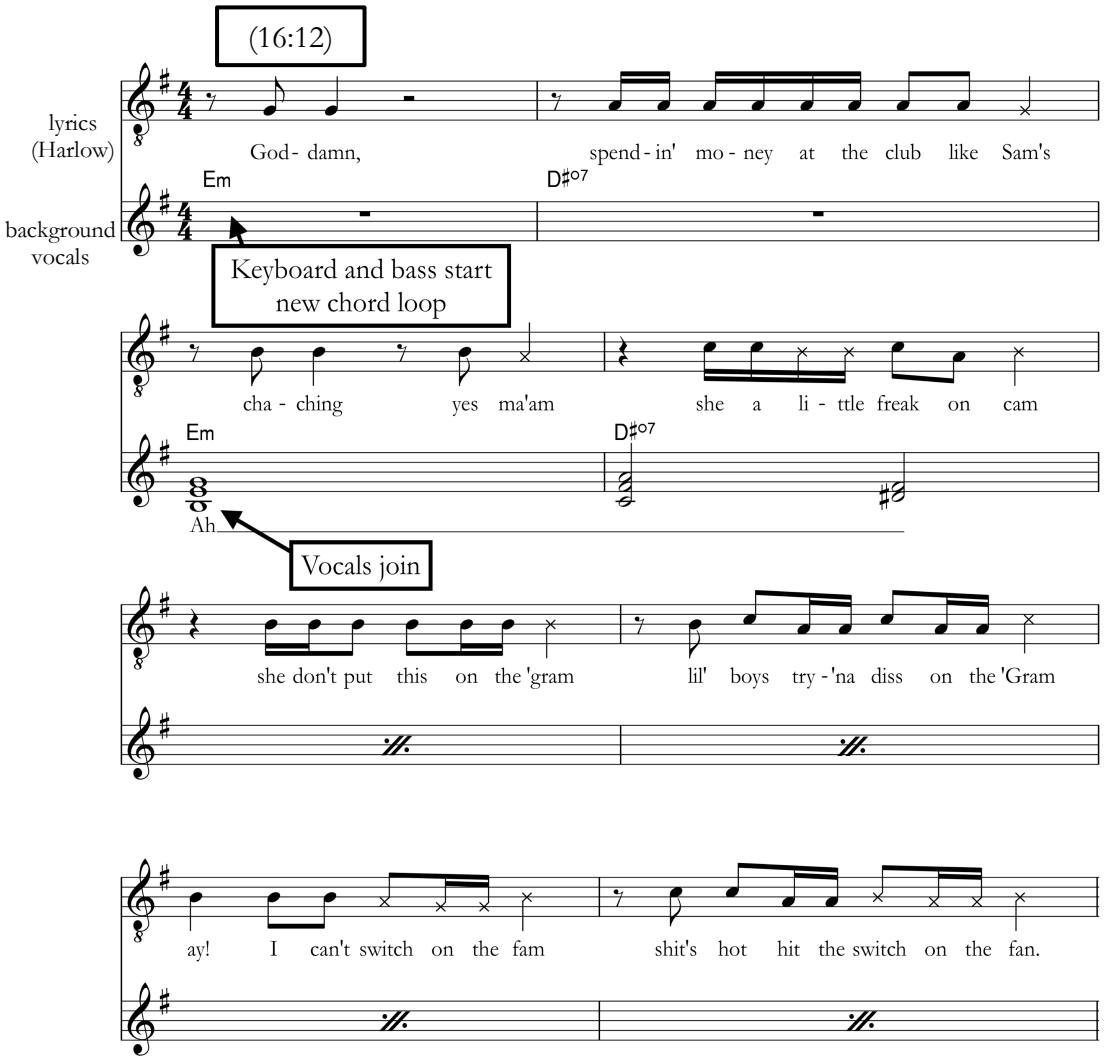
The more striking details of the Tiny Desk performance as it continues have to do with texture and harmony. Despite the differences between Examples 4.11 and 4.12, the harmonic content in both amount to an E minor tonic pedal. This minor tonic chord remains in effect throughout the entirety of the album version, making it fall into Adams's (2020) repetitive beat category. In the Tiny Desk performance, the beat's harmonies go through several changes, the first of which occurs about a quarter of the way into Harlow's verse. Example 4.13a transcribes the backing vocals here along with Harlow's lyrics, which he starts partially *singing*, ostensibly to match with the harmonic change and addition of the vocalists. The harmonic progression consists of an oscillation between the tonic, E minor, and a dominant-functioning D#º7 chord. Harlow begins singing on a G ($\hat{3}$) and ascends by step to A ($\hat{4}$) then B ($\hat{5}$) in coordination with the voice-leading

of the harmonies. He then hovers around the note B by using upper and lower neighbor notes C and A, staying in sync with the harmonic rhythm. The half-step upper neighbor motion between C and B (scale degrees $\hat{6}$ and $\hat{5}$) is a particularly dramatic and expressive feature of this passage, as is the step of an augmented second between C and D# sung by the lowest voice part within each iteration of the D#º7 chord.

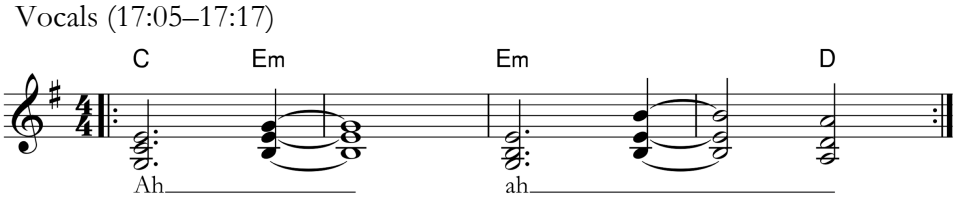
**Example 4.12:** "Whats Poppin," album version, opening lyrics and drum pattern only



**Example 4.13a:** Partially sung lyrics and background vocals partway through verse




**Example 4.13b:** Backup vocalists, final eight measures of the verse




After this brief release of heightened energy, the ensemble returns to a barebones texture with just Harlow's rapping and the drums, setting up a gradual accumulation of the other instruments leading to the repetition of the hook (more on this accumulative aspect shortly). The

vocalists re-enter in the final eight measures of the verse, this time with a different harmonic progression as shown in Example 4.13b. In addition to this harmonic variety, the instrumentalists are notably more active as the hook approaches. Nichols colors the drum beat with frequent cymbal crashes and keyboardist O'Neil Palmer plays sustained chords and adds a brass synth timbre midway through the passage. Finally the hook arrives: Harlow repeats the lyrics from the opening of the song that are now evidently not verse material in spite of their initial guise. The vocalists drop out when the hook starts, yet the instrumentalists are at their highest energy level of the whole song: Nichols plays mostly sixteenth notes on his array of cymbals and the remaining three musicians nail coordinated backing riffs. Neither these riffs nor the improvisatory drum part are used in the album version. In the Tiny Desk performance, the musical differences between the initial statement of the hook and its return at the end of the song are bold and reflect the transformation in function that the section undergoes between rotations of the verse-hook cycle.

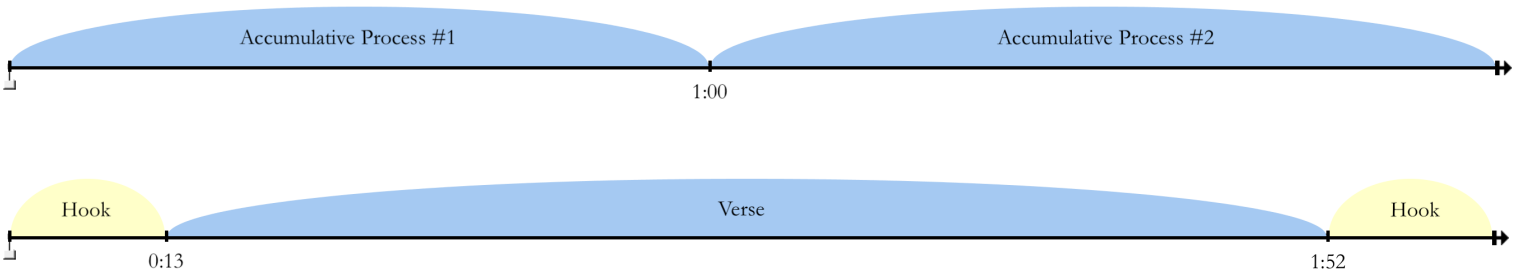
The second hook in the NPR Tiny Desk version of "Whats Poppin" is a climax resulting from an accretion of textural layers and musical energy that started in the middle of Harlow's verse. This live performance, then, makes use of a pair of compositional strategies that Mark Spicer (2004) terms cumulative and accumulative forms.[18] Cumulative form is a general concept describing the sense in which a composition is "somehow always aiming towards a certain moment of culmination" (30), while accumulative processes are typically more localized and characterized specifically by a gradual building up of the texture.[19] The steady addition of layers starting at about

[18] The repertoire addressed by Spicer all falls within various styles and genres of pop-rock, "from progressive rock to post-punk, to techno" (abstract), but the concept of accumulative form is evidently applicable to any number of styles of popular music.

[19] As Spicer details, beginnings are perhaps the most common section for small-scale accumulative processes to take place in pop-rock. This holds true in hip-hop—we even see a basic example of accumulative intro in the album version of "Whats Poppin" with the aforementioned addition of the drum beat six seconds into the song. Spicer also analyzes The Police's "Voices Inside My Head" and Yes's "I've Seen All Good People," Part I as instances where the entire song's structure is an

the halfway point of "Whats Poppin" creates a sense that the song is building towards something. When the second hook arrives, we know that it is the moment that has been the goal for sometime, both because of the repetition of previously heard lyrics and because of the musicians' exciting playing. The (ac)cumulative form in "Whats Poppin" also underscores one of the most important affordances of the approach discussed by Spicer: "the use of such forms can be seen as perhaps the primary means by which pop-rock composers have been able to transcend the predictable boundaries of simple verse-chorus patterns" (61). Indeed, the accumulative process in "Whats Poppin" cuts across its own more standard verse-hook structure, as Example 4.14 shows. The song simultaneously conveys two distinct formal patterns, one relying on verses and hook sections and the other relying on textural and energetic accumulation. The final hook's coordination with the accumulative process's highest point is what makes the use of these forms so musically effective. Jack Harlow's Tiny Desk performance of "Whats Poppin" leans slightly more towards being intra-rotational because there is somewhat more pronounced differentiation between the sections than in the album version. The musicians backing him in the live performance also bring out the experiential difference between the first and second hooks in the album version by treating the second hook as a climax, far removed energetically and texturally from the first hook.

**Example 4.14:** Stratification of conventional song form and accumulative processes in NPR Tiny Desk Concert version of "Whats Poppin"




accumulative process. In these latter, less-common cases, the songs' large-scale cumulative form their large-scale accumulative process are one in the same.

Returning to the topic of musical homogeneity and form, DJ Mustard's "Interstate 10" (2019) featuring Future suppresses formal articulation and functional difference in similar ways to the album version of "Whats Poppin." Example 4.15 transcribes the beat of the song, which remains virtually constant throughout.[20] It is an eight-measure loop consisting of a bass, two

**Example 4.15:** DJ Mustard and Future, "Interstate 10," beat

[20] The outro of "Interstate 10" (from time stamp 2:30 through the end) features a markedly different tempo and texture than the rest of the track. It is so different from the rest of the song that it can be said to occur "after the end" and is thus not addressed in my analysis.

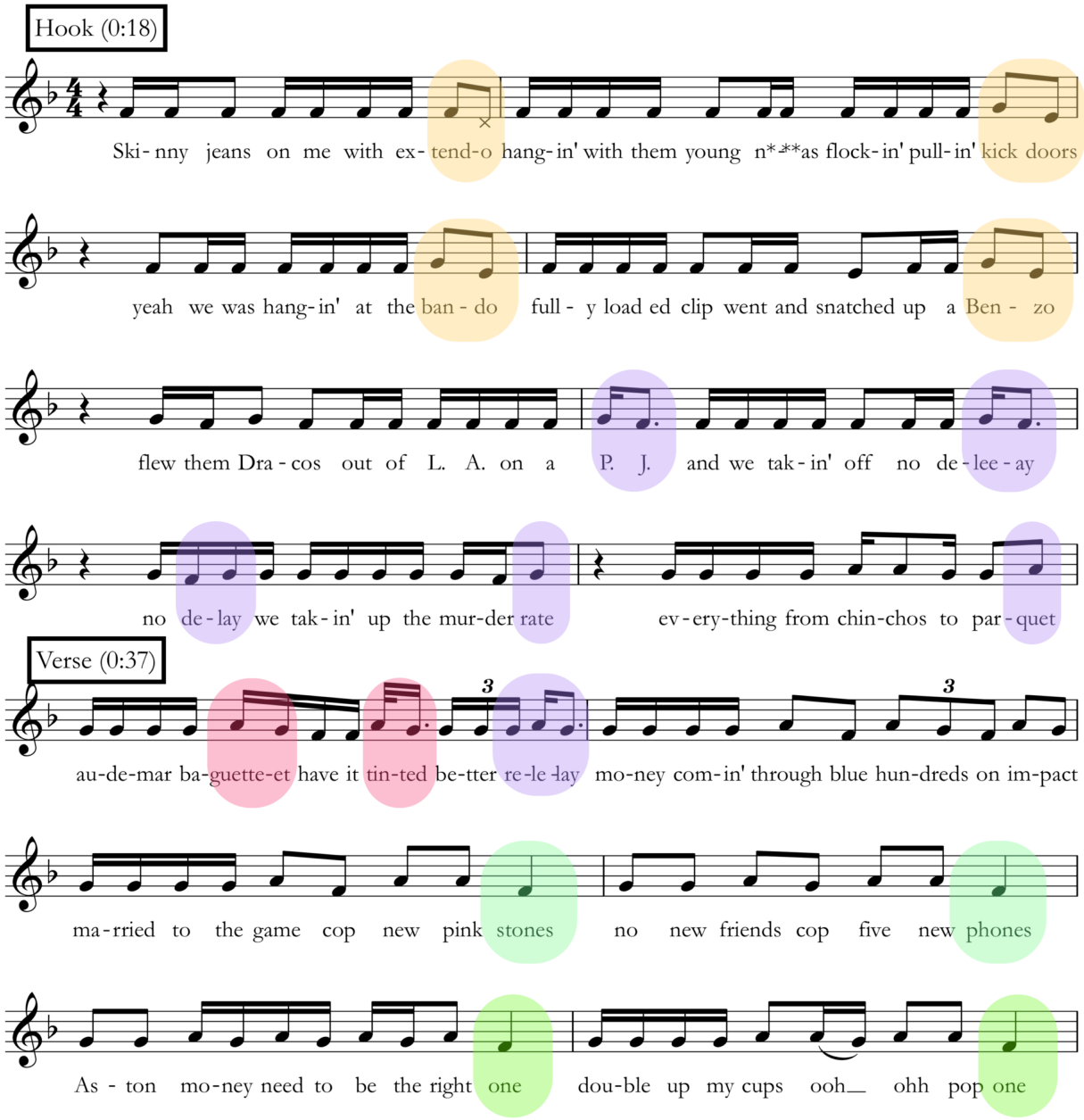
different hi-hat sounds, off beat claps, and an acoustic guitar layer.[21] The texture remains steady through most of "Interstate 10," as Example 4.16 shows. After the full beat enters about eighteen seconds into the song, the beat's essential elements (the drums, guitar, and bass) play tutti for all but roughly seven seconds. The drum pattern does not deviate from its two-measure long pattern. Since it is the loudest element of the mix except for Future's rapping, it gives the effect of the texture remaining constant throughout the song. The changes that do occur in "Interstate 10" are either subtle or short-lived, just as we saw in "Whats Poppin." The soft echo effect, for instance, is hard to notice upon a cursory listen and is made even subtler by because a small amount of reverb remains in effect on Future's voice even during the passages when the long echo drops out. Finally, Future's first line at the beginning of his first verse continues the rhyme scheme from the end of the hook: "murder rate" and "parquet" at the end of the hook rhyme with "re-le-lay" at the beginning of what turns out to be the verse (Example 4.17). Note also in Example 4.17 that the motivic content of Future's flow is similar between the last two measures of the hook and the first verse. Whereas for most of the hook Future intones on the pitch F, he hovers around G near the end of the hook,

**Example 4.16:** Textural changes over the entirety of "Interstate 10"

| **Time** | **0:18** | **0:37** | **0:49** | **1:04** | **1:15** | **1:33** | **2:04** | **2:11** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Changes** | full beat enters | soft echo effect drops out | brief pause in the beat | drums and bass briefly drop out | soft echo enters | soft echo effect drops out | brief pause | soft echo enters |

[21] The bass in Example 4.15 is the lowest voice of the guitar part. There is an additional deep bass in the texture but its pitches are difficult to discern and is therefore only represented rhythmically below the guitar's bass line.

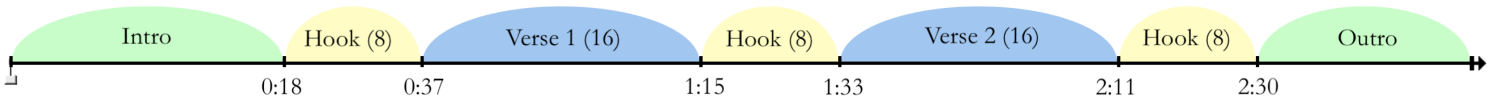
**Example 4.17:** Flow during verse hook and beginning of first verse in "Interstate 10"




often with the use of an upper neighbor A. This pitch content holds over to the first two measures of the verse. Rhythmically Future starts many measures in the hook and the beginning of the verse with faster durations before ending with slower rhythms like eighth notes.

As in "Whats Poppin," formal segmentation and function become evident upon the second and subsequent rotations through the verse-hook cycle of "Interstate 10." Future repeats the hook lyrics ("Skinny jeans on me with extendo…") starting at 1:15 and 2:11, at which point the passage changes identity from verse-like to hook material. "Interstate 10" features multiple cycles through the core verse-hook rotation as displayed in Example 4.18. This allows for the hook to come into its own, so to speak. If the song were to only state the hook twice (as was the case in "Whats Poppin"), a listener may barely have the chance to hear the hook for its true function, i.e., as a hook. By the time the second iteration of the hook is over, it has only just become evident that it was the hook, but a listener would be denied the satisfaction of hearing it again with full recognition of its function from beginning to end if that were its last statement. During the second verse of "Interstate 10," the hook has already been stated twice and its return is therefore expected. Its arrival at 2:11 is both the clearest in terms of function from the outset and also the most gratifying because it was easy to anticipate.

**Example 4.18:** Full formal diagram of "Interstate 10"




Out-of-Phase Changes

Another way in which trap songs create ambiguity of segmentation and function is through out-of-phase changes in the lyric and beat layers. In such songs, there are prominent or at least notable changes in one or both of the layers. Examples include changes between sung and rapped lyrics, between thick and thin beat textures, between different harmonic loops, and so on. One or more of these changes may align with the onset of a new formal unit, but ambiguity of form (and

hence inter-rotational form) is caused because these changes are uncoordinated between the lyrics and the beat layers. The clearest sense of segmentation and change in formal function is usually caused by lyrical and textural changes that occur simultaneously. When changes occur out of phase with each other, formal interpretation can quickly become unclear, especially in repetitive groove-based musics like trap and hip-hop. We already saw an example of this type of song in "Narcos" at the beginning of the chapter and I will now turn to one further example: "We Not Humping" (2021) by Monaleo.

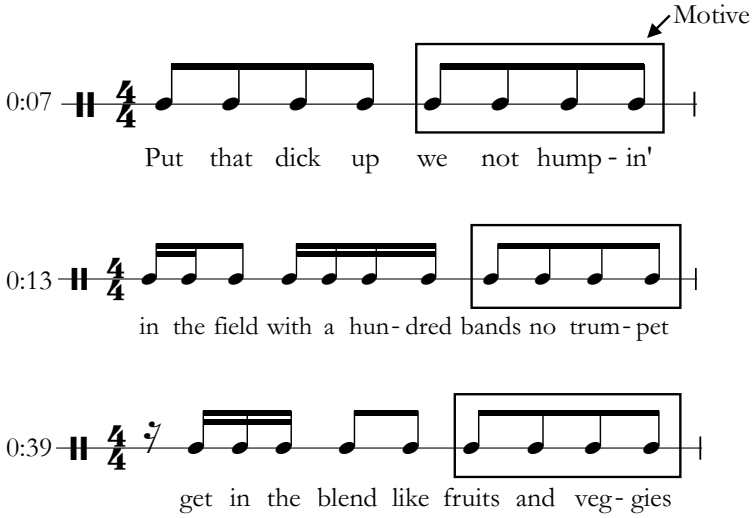
**Example 4.19:** Monaleo, "We Not Humping," lyrics and rhyme scheme from first verse-hook unit

Put that dick up we not humpin'
Sky Zone bitch my block jumpin'
Jump out the black truck we start dumpin'
in the field with a hundred bands no trumpet
Main n***a just cut me off fuck it
N***a stop talkin' just come suck it
When it's smoke bet the opps gon' duck it
We kick smoke up they kick buckets
Put a bag on your head 'cause it's in my budget
All I gotta do is push a button
I'm on the heads like a goddamn mullet
Spent ten bands at the sneaker summit
I got the hood on my back like it's rainin'
He a head monster I'm not complainin'
He don't like my ways but I'm not changin'
I don't text him back 'cause that shit drainin'
Get in the blend like fruits and veggies
Do what I want 'cause my n***as let me
I keep lead case a bitch wanna test me
Smoke on the 'net but in person I'm her bestie

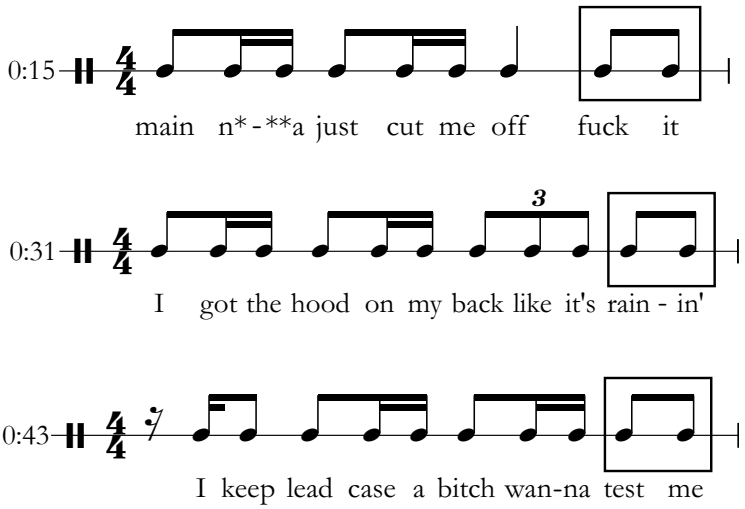
Example 4.19 transcribes the lyrics from the first verse-hook unit of "We Not Humping," highlighting rhyming words with matching colors. Monaleo raps with a very regular

end-rhyme pattern that changes twice across this excerpt: once after six couplets that rhyme with "humpin'" and once after two couplets that rhyme with "rainin'." As the brackets on the right side of Example 4.19 show, the rhymes alone break up the passage into three segments. It's very likely that a listener would also group the two latter segments together (from "rainin'" to "bestie") because it consists of two fairly short spans. Rhyme scheme is by no means the only source of segmentation in rap or trap, but in "We Not Humping," it is a particularly prominent feature because of the

**Example 4.20a:** Four eighth note motive from first verse-hook cycle of "We Not Humpin'"




**Example 4.20b:** Subset of four eight note motive



homogeneity of Monaleo's flow and extended use of a single rhyme. All the lines are motivically similar in that they either end with four eighth notes or two eighth notes, the latter of which can be understood as a shortened version of the former. Examples 4.20a and b transcribe several instances of each of these. Of the twenty lines that make up this passage, thirteen end with the four eighth notes motive and seven end with the two eighth notes motive. Within the first verse-hook cycle of "We Not Humpin," Monaleo's rhyme scheme suggests two sections broken up as lines 1–12 and lines 13–20 of Example 4.19.

The beat, on the other hand, has a different segmentation scheme. Example 4.21 shows the textural changes in the beat across the first verse-hook unit. The two-dimensional chart belies how some changes may be heard as more pronounced than others, therefore having a stronger impact on the of form. Dotted outlines indicate unmarked textural changes while bold outlines around certain boxes indicate those changes that are the most significant. The subtraction of the hi-hat at the start of Monaleo's fifth line, for instance, is marked because of the distinct timbre of that element of the texture.[22] This removal of the hi-hat also coincides with two other textural changes: a less active bass

**Example 4.21:** Textural changes within first verse-hook cycle of "We Not Humpin"

| **"humpin'"–"trumpet"** | **"fuck it"–"buckets"** | **"budget"–summit"** | **"rainin'"–"drainin'"** | **"veggies"–"bestie"** |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| whiny voice | — | — | — | — |
| — | soft response vocals | — | soft response vocals | soft response vocals |
| clave | clave | clave | — | — |
| hi-hat | — | hi-hat | hi-hat | — |
| snare | snare | snare | snare | snare |
| kick | kick | — | kick | kick |
| active bass | less active bass | less active bass | active bass | active bass |

[22] The addition of the hi-hat four lines later feels less prominent because gradual accumulations of texture during verses are highly normative in hip-hop. This textural change is therefore not boxed in bold.

and a subtraction of a "whiny" rhythmic vocal layer. We are only four measures into Monaleo's lyrics, but the coincidence of all these changes suggests a segmentation point. A prominent textural change does not take place again until the last four lines of the passage: the hi-hat is once again removed when Monaleo switches to the "veggies/let me/test me/bestie" rhymes. A whooshing synth sound not shown in Example 4.21 also marks the first downbeat of the last four lines. The lyric and beat layers *are* in sync with each other at that moment, possibly suggesting another formal boundary. Aside from the rhyme scheme, however, there is no change in Monaleo's flow style. She doesn't, for instance, move to sung lyrics or use a high degree of text repetition as we might expect if the new section were a hook. The potential for the "veggies" line to be a new section is then neutralized four measures later when the hook lyrics are repeated at the start of the second verse-hook rotation.

Within the first verse-hook rotation, the lyrics and beat suggest two different segmentation schemes because the changes they undergo are out of phase with each other. Given Monaleo's homogeneous flow, the main indicator of new sections in her lyrics are rhymes. The rhyme schemes break up the passage into three low-level sections and two mid-range sections. The beat suggests two main sections as well, with the possibility of a third in the last four measures of the rotation. The first formal boundary provided by the beat is in the middle of Monaleo's first (the long string of rhymes matching with "humpin'") and the second aligns with the start of her third low-level section ("veggies"). It is not until the hook lyrics are repeated at the beginning of the song's second rotation that it becomes abundantly evident where the sections are and what function they have within each rotation: as it turns out, the lines from "humpin'" all the way through "buckets" constitute this song's hook.

Significantly, in the second verse-hook cycle, Monaleo changes her flow and rhyme scheme in fairly obvious ways so as to highlight the formal boundary between the hook and the verse.

Example 4.22 transcribes the second hook and the beginning of the second verse. As soon as the hook lyrics end, Monaleo switches to a new motive. Each line except the last in this passage begins

**Example 4.22:** Flow from second hook to beginning of second verse in "We Not Humping"

with a longer duration on the downbeat of the measure: "Damn!," "Oh," and "Aww" are either a quarter note or a dotted eighth in length. These are also new in the sense that they are each an exclamation. The end-rhyme rhythms are the same as we've seen for most of the song (either four eighth notes or two eighth notes), but the motivic difference at the beginning of each line is notable

enough to constitute a change in flow from the hook. The rhymes themselves are also different from in the hook, which is a source of formal clarity that was missing from the first verse-hook unit. Finally, the beat does less work in this passage to suggest formal boundaries. Whereas it changed notably with the subtraction of the hi-hat during the middle of Monaleo's first hook, here the beat stays steady. There are no changes in the beat except for drum fills at expected hypermetric positions (including just before the downbeat of the second verse). In the second rotation of "We Not Humpin,'" it is as if Monaleo's rapping takes advantage of the way that the beat is doing minimal work to delineate form and guides us as listener through the form with relative clarity.

Two Viable Hook Segmentations

The last formal phenomenon in trap music I will discuss is not so much a source of ambiguity as a specific formal scheme that evinces a degree of flexibility baked into the creative process in this genre. In a number of songs, there are two perfectly viable ways to segment the hook section. In the two cases to be examined below (Future and Drake's "Life Is Good" and Megan Thee Stallion's "All of It"), the beginning of the first verse is so musically and lyrically similar to the preceding hook that it is entirely reasonable to interpret the first hook as longer than subsequent hooks. From this perspective, it is as if the artists have truncated the second and following hooks. On the other hand, one can interpret the first hook as being the same length as subsequent hooks, in which case the material of the first verse is highly similar to the end of the hook. I view this latter interpretation as more forced, and it certainly requires a rehearsed hearing. This formal type relates to inter-rotational form in that, even though formal segmentation and function may be clear within the first verse-hook cycle, the whole story is not told over that span. The status of the hook is problematized in rotations after the first, making the two viable segmentations scheme the inverse of the types of ambiguity already discussed: the *more* rotations one listens to, the more the uncertainty.

"Life Is Good" was released on January 10th, 2020 as the third single off Atlanta-born trap artist Future's eighth studio album *High Off Life*. It is one of over a dozen musical collaborations from the last decade between Future and Canadian rapper and pop culture icon Drake. The song remains one of Future's most popular releases, having spent eight weeks in the #2 spot on the *Billboard* Hot 100 starting the week of its release and having been certified diamond on November 22, 2021.[23] Example 4.23 presents the overall form of "Life Is Good." It is divided cleanly into two halves by a full halt in the music and intervening skit. The halves are so musically different they could easily be said to be two different songs, very much in the same vein as Travis Scott's "Sicko Mode" (another collaboration with Drake) discussed in Chapter 2. The present analysis will address just the first half of the song, Drake's half.

**Example 4.23:** Overall form of "Life Is Good"

| Part | Time | Section |
|---|---|---|
| 1 (Drake's half) | 0:00–0:11 | Intro |
| | 0:12–0:35 or 0:46 | Hook |
| | 0:35 or 0:47–1:10 | Verse |
| | 1:10–1:34 | Hook |
| Interlude | 1:34–1:42 | Skit |
| 2 (Future's half) | 1:42–1:55 | Hook |
| | 1:55–2:49 | Verse1 |
| | 2:50–3:03 | Hook |
| | 3:03–3:30 | Verse 2 |
| | 3:30–3:44 | Hook |
| | 3:44–3:57 | Outro |

The first half of the song has a similar formal design to Jack Harlow's "Whats Poppin": an overall ABA pattern where the As are hooks and the B is a verse. Drake's flow is typical for trap within the hooks: he repeats a simple, stepwise, diatonic motive for each line of text for the entire

[23] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Life_Is_Good_(song).

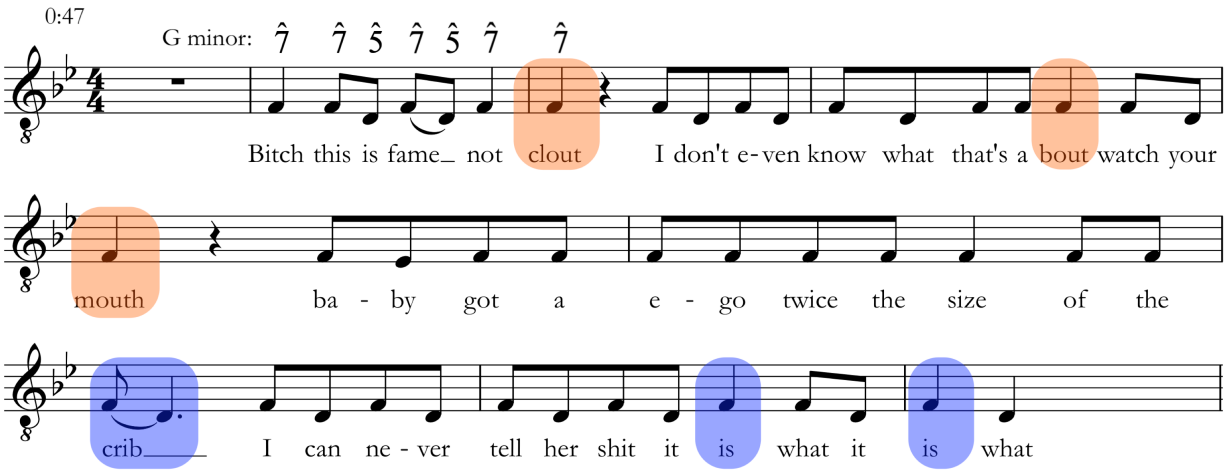
section with some slight variations (Example 4.24). The motive slides down and up through scale degrees $\hat{5}$, $\hat{4}$, and $\hat{3}$ of G minor, the key suggested by the harmonies, bass guitar, and 808 bass parts, making it particularly sing-songy and memorable. Drake's vocal delivery at the opening is supported by a beat that accumulates layers over the first twenty-three seconds of the song. After eight measures of a solo synthesized chord progression, Drake enters along with the guitar part transcribed in Example 4.24. It becomes evident that the beat is an eight-measure loop because the bass guitar aligns harmonically with the opening chords and both parts repeat in eight-measure intervals. The texture further fills out eight bars after Drake and the bass guitar's entrance with a trap drum beat and deep 808 bass part. The bass guitar is subtracted from the texture at this point but re-enters after *another* eight-measure interval. Although not shown in Example 4.24, Drake continues with his sing-songy text setting for twelve measures past the passage just described. Two factors make it difficult up to this point to decide whether any formal boundaries exist: the regularity of the textural changes' timing and quality, and Drake's repetitive, homogeneous flow.

Finally, after the guitar has been in for another eight-bar loop, we get a substantial change coordinated between the rapper and the beat. Drake moves into a higher register hovering around $\hat{7}$ in G minor and uses a new rhythmic motive that aims toward rhyming syllables located on the first and third beats of several measures (Example 4.25). The beat thins with the removal of the guitar in coordination with Drake's change in flow. If anything represents section boundary and change in formal function to this point in the song, this is it. Drake changes his flow for the first time after thirty-six seconds of rapping and aligns this switch with a change in the beat. The subsequent bars are also the first to *not* contain a textural change after eight measures. The song goes through two full loops of the beat (equaling sixteen measures) with the same texture. The steady beat layer over a long period suggests verse function, especially after a small accumulative form at the beginning and

**Example 4.24:** Flow and primary beat elements at Drake's entrance in "Life is Good"

several other texture changes shortly thereafter. If this new section is ostensibly the verse, then the section heard just prior was in all likelihood the hook. This suspicion is confirmed at1:10 into the song where Drake repeats the lyrics he stated at the beginning: "Workin' on a weekend like

**Example 4.25:** Drake's new flow after a long period with the same motive in "Life Is Good"

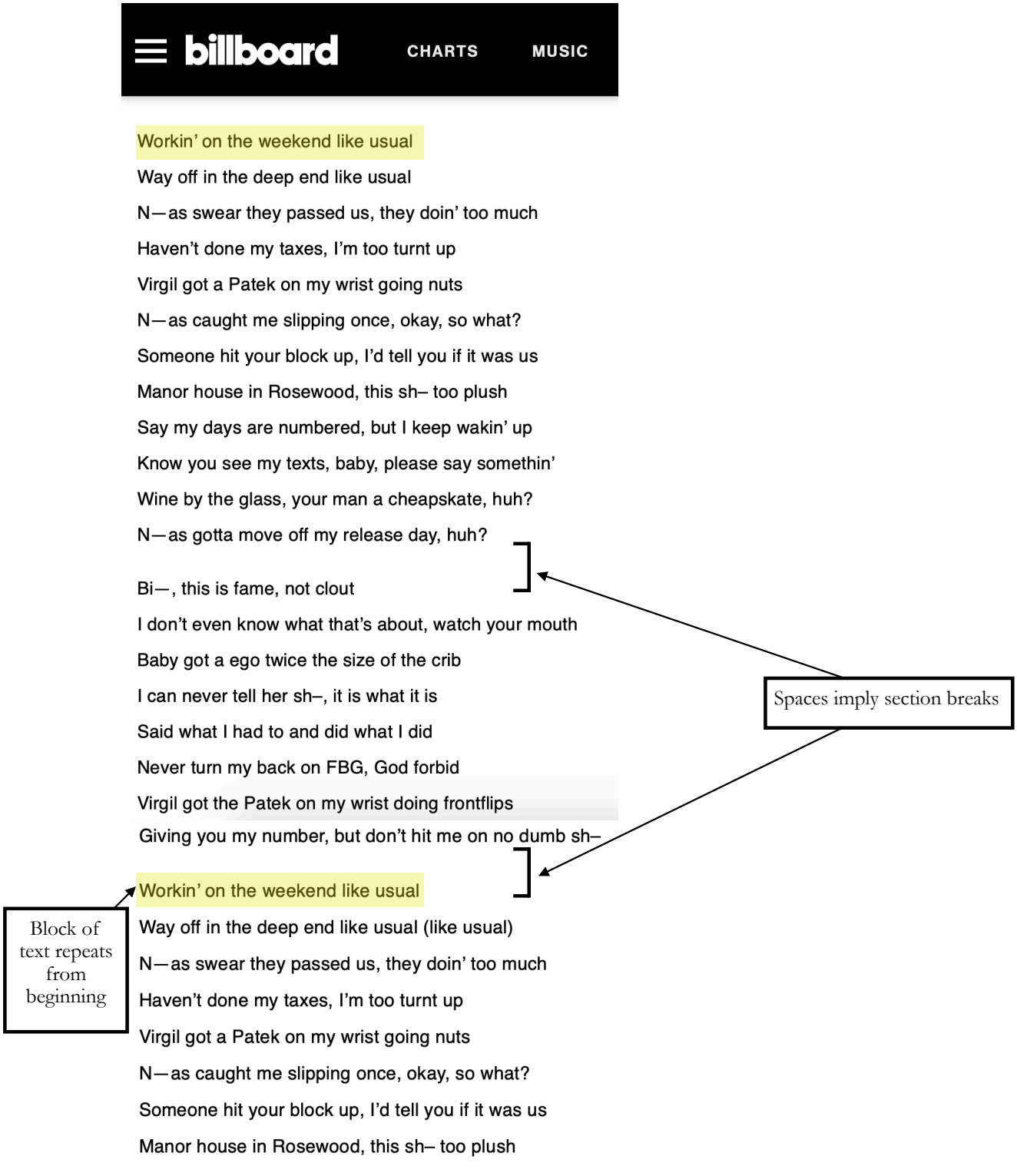



usual…." This passage now firmly sounds like a hook. The texture even returns to the exact same makeup as when these lyrics were first stated. What is different this time around,however, is that Drake does not recite all the lyrics up to the change in flow we heard during the first rotation. The first supposed hook ended with "N***s gotta move off my release date day, huh?" but here Drake is cut off a full four lines early by a total stop of the beat after "Manor house in Rosewood, this shit too plush."

Which section counts as the hook in "Life Is Good"? Is it the longer passage we heard during the first rotation or the shorter section heard after the verse? Until we hear the entire song—or, in this case, Drake's half of the song—there are no cues to suggest that Drake changed from hook to verse (or vice versa) after "Rosewood this shit too plush" during the first rotation. Yet strictly speaking, hooks are those passages that have the same lyrics each time through. The lyrics website Genius.com analyzes the shorter version as the hook both times, following the stricter conception that encompasses only those lyrics that are repeated exactly.[24] *Billboard's* website offers a different segmentation of the form. As the screenshot in Example 4.26 shows, *Billboard* identifies

[24] https://genius.com/Future-life-is-good-lyrics.

**Example 4.26:** Lyrics to "Life Is Good" as published (and segmented) by *Billboard*



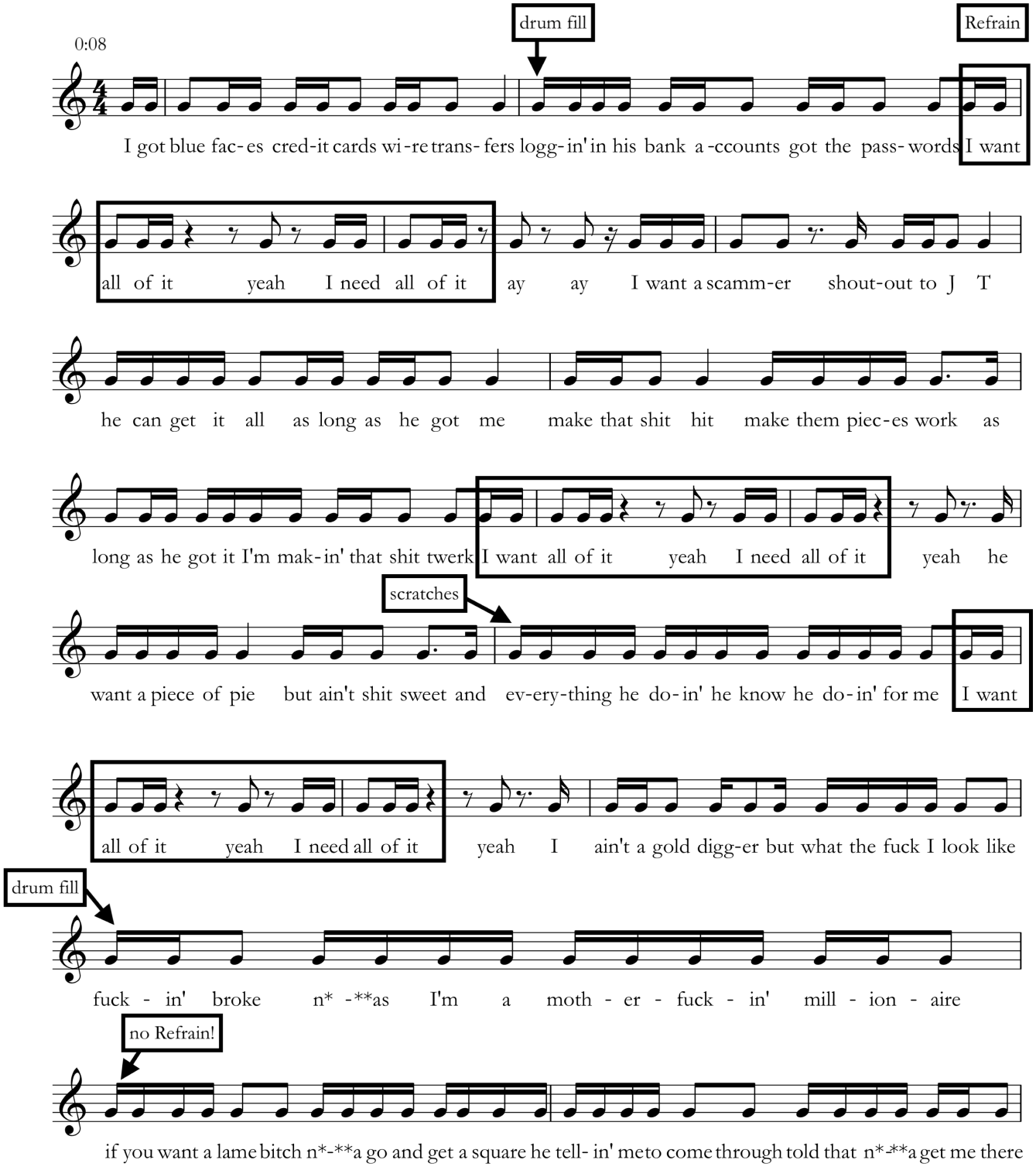
section boundaries via spaces between blocks of text.[25] The lyrical transcription says nothing of function explicitly (i.e., which section is verse, hook, or other), but it does clearly break up the song into sections such that the part beginning with the lyrics "Working on a weekend like usual" is a different length each time. Genius.com's interpretation privileges a rehearsed hearing in which one knows the words of the second hook. *Billboard's* highlights the experience of a first-time listener, or one who hears the second hook as truncated and the first hook as longer because of the melodic similarity up to "N***as gotta move off my release date day, huh?"

Different ears have heard and represented the form of this song differently, which is a conflict that need not necessarily be resolved. Instead, as Trevor de Clercq (2017) has argued in the context of pop-rock music, the multiple formal interpretations invited by "Life Is Good" are part of the identity of the song. What the continuous nature of Drake's flow does for him is make the lyrics more memorable. With formal differentiation somewhat diminished and the melody simple and diatonic, fans are encouraged to sing along with everything at a live show, not just the hooks.

In "Life Is Good," it almost made perfect sense that Drake's second verse would be cut short because Future immediately takes over for his half of the song. It creates an effect of the latter rapper telling Drake to step aside; his turn on the mic is over. A song that has no such narrative explanation for its two viable hook segmentations is "All Of It" by Megan Thee Stallion. Unlike most of the examples discussed in this chapter, formal function in "All Of It" is almost immediately evident. After a four-bar intro, Megan enters with rapped lyrics that alternate with a refrain as transcribed in Example 4.27. This sounds hook-like because of the internal lyrical repetition, use of the title lyric, and rhythmic spacing of the refrain words. Following the first two statements of the refrain, there is a third. Both this third statement and the first are prepared with fills in the beat layer:

[25] https://www.billboard.com/music/lyrics/future-life-is-good-lyrics-drake-8548755/. *Billboard* sourced the lyrics from LyricFind, a lyrics display and licensing company. It is unclear whether LyricFind or *Billboard* separated the text as shown in Example 4.26.

**Example 4.27:** Megan Thee Stallion, "All Of It," first hook and beginning of verse



the first is preceded by a drum fill and the third by rhythmic scratching. The first refrain comes after two measures of rapping, the second after four, and the third after another two-measure interval, which sets up a fairly strong expectation that the refrain recurs every two measures. Two measures after the third refrain statement, we hear another drum fill (the same drum fill that preceded the first refrain). This time, however, the refrain does not occur and Megan keeps rapping, providing evidence that we are in solidly in the verse. To this point, it seems that the hook encompassed the first three refrains and following that, Megan entered the verse even if the drum fill harkened back to the sonic fabric of the hook.

Megan's verse wraps up just over a minute into the song and the hook reprises as she raps the same lyrics from the opening of the song ("I got blue faces, credit cards, wire transfers…"). The beat also returns to its opening texture, including the drum fill that prepares the refrain "I want all of it, I need all of it." But just as we saw in "Life Is Good," the hook is slightly different this time around: Megan delivers the first two refrains and their preceding lyrics, then stops as the song cuts to an outro. One repetition of the refrain plus two measures of lyrics are seemingly missing from the second hook. We are once again left with an interpretive challenge regarding the segmentation of the hook. Is the hook a different length in each rotation or is the beginning of Megan's verse highly similar to the hook? Although both options are perfectly viable, I am inclined toward the former, especially because of Megan's use of a refrain. The refrain is so notably absent the first time it does not occur that it creates a relatively strong sense of segmentation. The refrain also helps to differentiate function because it adds internal text repetition, a hallmark of hooks. Hearing the verse start after just the first two refrains feels forced, even if it does make the lyrics of the hook match precisely each time through.

Both "Life Is Good" and "All Of It" bring up questions about the nature of hooks in trap and trap-influenced hip-hop. The hook section is an integral part of both songs because it frames

the central verses, engendering a sense of cohesion and organization. In this way, the function of the hooks is familiar from more traditionally organized hip-hop songs. They are memorable sections that alternate with verses and provide relief from the lyrically and narratively dense content of the verses. But they depart from typical hooks in terms of segmentation. There are two different boundary lines that could be drawn between the end of the hook and the beginning of the verse, and we only learn that this is the case when we listen to multiple rotations through the hook. Claims about the creative process and intentions of artists are limited because this is not an ethnographic study, but the above observations about hooks suggest that Drake and Megan Thee Stallion took a relatively flexible approach to formal organization. The hook does not need to repeat in its entirety the second time around because as long as a substantial chunk of it is stated, its function is fulfilled. The above observations also suggest a lyrically oriented approach to crafting songs, ostensibly rooted in freestyle. It almost sounds, for instance, like Drake simply grabbed the mic, recorded some ideas for a verse he had, stopped when he fell off the beat, then decided to copy and paste the first part as a closing hook. Regardless of the in-studio process, these songs and the ones analyzed earlier in this chapter demonstrate unique formal properties as they unfold across multiple rotations of the core cycle. Inter-rotational form provides a way of describing the formal phenomena that stylistically distinguish recent trap and trap-influenced hip-hop.

## Conclusion

The method of formal analysis outlined in the first two chapters of this dissertation was applied in two historical case studies that constitute the last two chapters. Salt-N-Pepa took part in a late-1980s trend by releasing covers of pop-rock songs from the preceding decades. Chapter 3 argued that their songs "Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang" present form in a less ambiguous way than the original versions. Chapter 4 analyses songs from the last decade in an effort to show that trap-influenced hip-hop has rewritten the rules of formal organization in mainstream

hip-hop. Many trap-influenced songs make their formal divisions and functions clear only upon multiple rotations through a core formal unit, either because their beat and lyrical layers are highly homogeneous or because the changes in either or both of these layers are out of phase.

These case studies both show the utility of the method outlined in the first half of this dissertation and problematize it. My typology of section types and formal functions assumes that recorded hip-hop songs consist of sections and that some sections have enough in common with others to create categories associated with predictable musical characteristics. Chapter 2 posits that these section types and formal function are ordered, grouped together, and set in relation to one another in a limited number of ways. The analyses in Chapter 3 show that these typologies model songs from the hip-hop repertoire at various scales. One limitation of my method brought out by the songs studied in Chapter 3 is the way that intertextuality may influence a listener's engagement with songs like Salt-N-Pepa's "Twist and Shout" and "Shake Your Thang." Since these songs go beyond the typical Golden Age practice of sampling by covering well-known pop-rock songs, their constituent formal sections have the potential to take on special meaning. For example, not only is the "screaming retransition" borrowed from the Beatles' "Twist and Shout" in Salt-N-Pepa's version, it is also used in a different part of the song: the beginning. For anyone familiar with the Beatles' version, this stands out because the Beatles use this vocal effect about two-thirds of the way into the song. It's effect in their version is to usher in the third and final verse at the highest energy level of the song. This intertextual residue effects the nature of this passage's use in Salt-N-Pepa's introduction: it doesn't just help to build into the song, it may remind listeners of a specific formal juncture in previous song.

Chapter 4's investigation of recent trends in mainstream hip-hop shows that form is a historically contingent phenomenon. While some contemporary songs still operate in the aesthetic vein that my formal method is best suited for, trends have changed and will certainly continue to

change. More than anything, the sections and song types described in Chapters 1 and 2 serve as a foil for the way form unfolds in the songs discussed in Chapter 4. This last chapter also brings up the issue of "when" an analysis captures the form of a song, a topic not addressed in detail in the first half of this dissertation. The idea of inter-rotational form depends to a large degree on the experience of a first-time listener. If one is already familiar with a song, they do not have to deal with the uncertainty of formal interpretation created by homogeneous musical textures or out of phase changes. They will have already made associations with different parts of the song, related those parts to similar parts in other songs they know, and be able to predict what's coming next while listening. I do not think this dependence discounts the inter-rotational label as one that captures something stylistically specific about trap-influenced hip-hop. The first hearing of a song is an experience that remains with someone and, to varying degrees, impacts their understanding and even experience of future listens. Additionally, there are many songs that listeners will only ever hear once, maybe because they heard it on the radio and did not seek it out later. Inter-rotational form applies directly to this situation. Even in inter-rotational songs, some of the characteristics observed in Chapter 1 remain true. Lyrical invariance, for instance, remains a hallmark of hooks, even if it is difficult to know something is a hook the first time through.

Readers may experience some discomfort with the way that I have framed my theory of form. Chapters 1 and 2 basically outline several boxes, describing what belongs in those boxes and what does not. Chapters 3 and 4 are occupied with deciding whether songs can fit inside the boxes and if so, which ones. I also felt some discomfort at as I have reread these pages, especially at the implication that there is a correct way to hear the songs discussed herein. To be clear: I do not believe there is a correct or incorrect way to hear these songs or any pieces of music, for that matter. But what this dissertation offers is a particular way of hearing hip-hop that brings together pop-rock scholarship and musicians, hip-hop scholarship and musicians, and a perspective that values hip-

hop's historical origins as a non-recorded, party-oriented culture. Scholarship on hip-hop is officially here to stay within the academic world. If this is the case, then may this work serve as a resource that invites future work to listen to hip-hop closely and try to understand it on its own terms.

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